
THE SONG OF SALT & SHADOW
SEREN ROSE

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First edition, 2026

For the girls still searching for
their own silver thread of light.

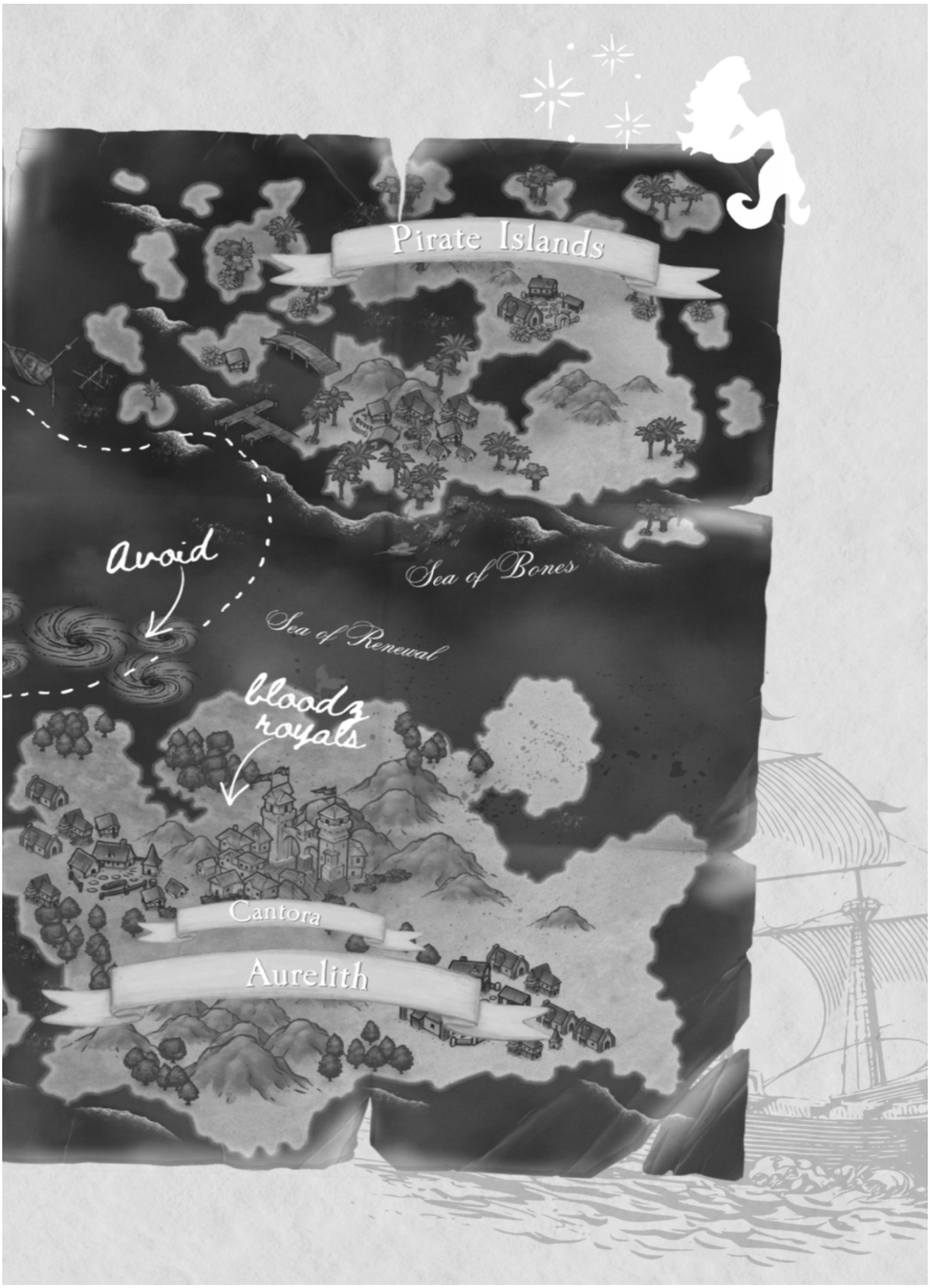
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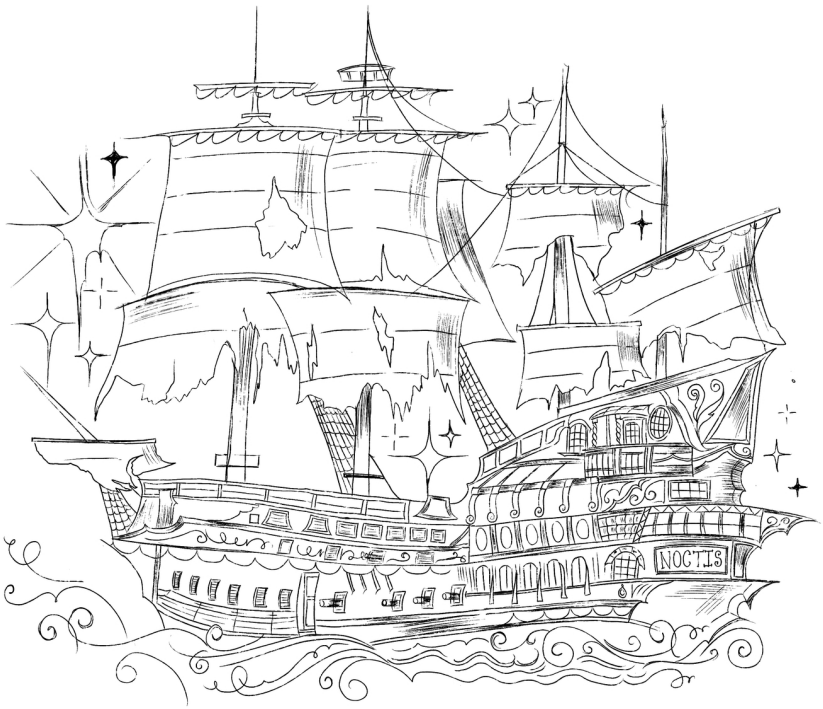
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The Noctis

Main Deck
The primary working deck of the ship, where most daily tasks are carried out.

Quarterdeck
A raised deck at the stern, used by the captain to command the ship and give orders.

Captain’s Cabin
A private space at the stern where the captain sleeps, works, and keeps charts and documents.

Hold
The lowest storage area of the ship, used for cargo, supplies, and provisions.

Orlop Deck

A deck below the waterline, used for storage and housing essential equipment.

Galley

The ship’s kitchen, where food is prepared for the crew.

Bow

The front of the ship, which cuts through the water as it moves.

Bowsprit

A spar extending from the bow, used to support sails and rigging.

Crow’s Nest

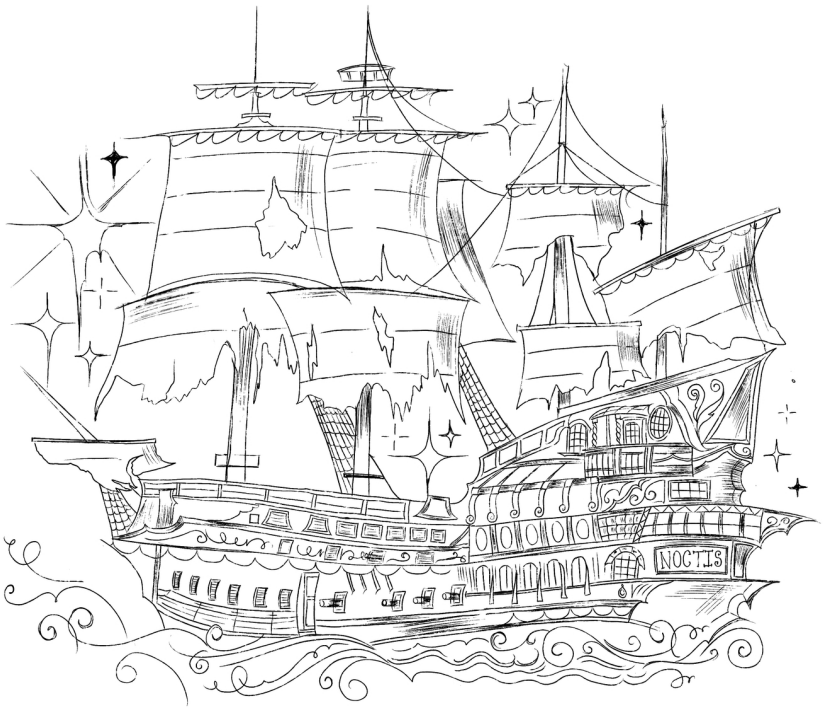
A platform high on the mast where the lookout watches for land, ships, or danger.

Main Mast

The central and tallest mast, carrying the ship’s main sails.

Helm

The steering position of the ship, where the wheel or tiller is used to control direction.



The Crew

Captain – Sable

The one who commands the ship, makes the final call in battle, and carries every life on board in his hands.

First Mate – Grim

The captain's counterweight, keeping order among the crew, settling disputes, and ensuring every share is earned and fair.

Carpenter – Saint

The one who keeps the ship from falling apart, sealing leaks and mending wood so the sea does not claim them.

***Bonesetter* – Harrow**

The one who tends to wounds and broken bodies, setting bone and stitching flesh when survival comes at a cost.

***Cabin Boy* – Lark**

A young hand who runs errands and serves the officers, learning the ways of the ship with every task.

***Lookout* – Nightglass**

The eyes of the ship, watching from the crow’s nest for land, storms, or danger rising on the horizon.

***Powder Monkey* – Match**

A quick and fearless runner who carries gunpowder to the cannons in battle, where one mistake can cost everything.

***Gunner* – Rat**

The one who commands the cannons, turning the ship into a weapon when battle calls.

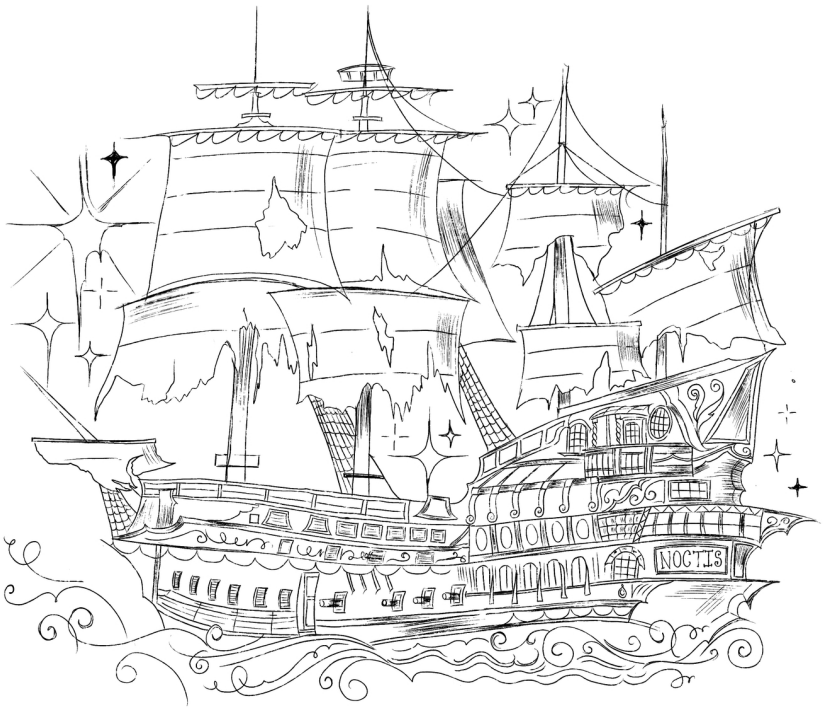
***Bosun* – Unnamed**

The voice of the deck, driving the crew to work and keeping sails, ropes, and rigging in line.

***Helmsman* – Unnamed**

The one at the wheel, guiding the ship through wind and wave with steady hands.


"Resisting you is like telling the moon to stop pulling the tide."


NOCTIS

Chapter One

THE STORM SWALLOWS THE sky whole, and I let the sea swallow me. Ten feet down, I hold myself still and try to remember how to breathe like a daughter of the sea.

I close my eyes and picture it the way it should be, the split at my throat where gills should open, the lengthening of bone, the blessing of scales that should protect me like armor. The body I was promised.

But nothing happens. Water presses against my lips, and I open my mouth, taking it in as if it were air. The familiar taste of salt floods my tongue, my throat, my lungs, until my chest heats from the inside out. A convulsion tears through me, and I clutch my ribs, as if I can force them to widen, as if I can pull the sea into a set of gills that do not exist. Like a stone dropped into water, I sink.

Rushing fills my ears, like voices whispering, warning, though it may be nothing more than my own blood. *Breathe*, the sea seems to say. *Go on, little half thing, show me your trick.* When I cannot oblige, and my vision slowly fades, the sea seems to laugh. It laughs by pressing harder, by leaning its cold weight over my face with the force of a hand. *Drown, little siren.*

Beneath the waves has always been the closest I have come to her, my mother. She said different things to me when I was small. She stroked my hair and told me I was a miracle of two worlds. She promised the sea would claim me in its own time, that I would sing someday and the currents would

turn and the fish would lift their silver faces to listen. She said all the right words a mother says to her child.

Then she left.

I was seven the last time I saw her shoulders vanish below a white edge of foam. She drew a line in the sand and told me to wait on the safe side, that my father would come and get me. I waited until the tide erased the line, then until the night crept in, until I realized that no one would come for me. He never did, because only a few days later, the Royal Navy had a rope tied around his neck and let the crowd watch him die for piracy. He could not fulfill his promise.

With the image of my father on my mind, I give up – give in – to my body's relentless need for air and kick for the surface. Ten feet becomes nine and then eight. Pitch black becomes a dark blue. Seven. Six. The roar above me is the storm. Five. Four. The water grips my hair and drags it back like kelp. Three. Two.

I break into the rain, and moments later, air tears through my throat. I roll onto my back and float, arms spread to keep myself from sinking again. The rain needles my cheeks as the heavy weight of failure once again settles deep inside my chest. It should be different by now. I should be different. I have tried countless times in this cursed sea that surrounds the damned island I have been stuck on for sixteen years now. Storms like tonight's give me something to hide inside, their noise and violence swallowing my presence. Becoming invisible is the only way to survive for someone who cannot afford the risk of being seen.

Thunder roars across the sky, and the light that follows turns the night to day for a brief moment. In those flashes, the cliffs and the crooked path of rocks that leads from the water up to the docks become visible. The harbor is closer than I thought. I let the water carry me that way, as it is easier than admitting that my arms are tired and my ribs hurt.

The harbor of Cantora is one of many on Aurelith. The sirens used to call it Thief Island, as humans of the worst kind reside here, stealing magic, coins, and possessions of the sea that don't belong to them from the surrounding islands. It is also the island where the so-called royal family holds its court.

On the left side of the harbor, the faint light of a lantern appears. Another follows, and then a third. Confusion furrows my brows. Humans avoid the shore whenever the weather is foul. I lower myself into the water to stay

hidden, only letting my eyes remain above the surface. I keep still until I am sure they haven’t seen me. My eyesight is better than theirs, at least I believe so, especially in the dark. I roll onto my stomach and swim as quietly as I can, keeping to the shadows of the cliffs. Thanks to the seas, the storm is louder than me.

The line of the docks comes into focus, right when the sea rocks me hard as if to say move faster. With a pounding heart, I slip toward the dark space beneath the docks. I should remain hidden, but my muscles start to feel numb from my useless attempts to force my shift. Frowning, I grab one of the wooden beams above, trying to conserve some energy. One throw of a net and I am as good as dead. The harbor is enclosed by the cliffs, and there is only one path of steep stairs that leads to the town above. Escaping through the water is not an option, so I swim to the end of the harbor, as far away as possible from the humans. Although I don't have a tail, I am still a good swimmer. It is in my blood after all.

A low ledge rises from the surge, and I reach it. I haul myself out of the water, scraping my hands and knees on the rough rocks in the process. My gown clings to me, the fabric soaked through and clinging to me like a second skin. I shiver as the wind blows its cold breath. The instant I am free of the water, the sea is calling me again. The sea, and the salt. *Come back*, it whispers without mercy. *Come back and try again*.

I could, and I know I will try again. Just not today. The voices of the humans grow clearer through the storm. One of them, a man, mentions a siren without a tail. And by the way he spits it like an insult, I know who I am dealing with. I take the ends of my gown and wring out some of the water with more force than necessary. It’s Grimsbane and his crew, though I just call them the Rats. The hunters have been shadowing me around Aurelith since my fifteenth summer, when I was foolish enough to trade one of my fallen scales for a loaf of bread after going days without eating. They have known what I am ever since.

The rock path leads to the docks. I climb, my palms holding on to the cold rock, until I feel the first plank of the dock under my feet. I wrinkle my nose at the smell of tar and rotten fish. Keeping low, I slip through the narrow lane between a net shed and a stack of empty crates, pausing when a lantern sweeps the boards so close I can see the grain glow. They must’ve seen me.

With a pounding heart, I slide deeper into the shadow, my shoulder pressed to the rough side of the shed. Some are checking the ladders of the docks, while others guard the steps carved into the cliff. Eryse, *think*. I bite my lip and let my thoughts spiral. They have blocked all escape routes. It is only a matter of time until they find me here, crouched in a corner, and I end up strung up on the markets. They sell whatever is desired there, and sirens are desired the most. Falling into their hands is equal to a death sentence. I cannot risk staying here.

A boot scuffs the plank, somewhere close. I freeze.

The lantern light shifts again, then steadies. A shadow stretches long across the boards, until it reaches the narrow path that leads directly to my hiding spot.

“Well now,” a voice drawls. “What did I tell you?”

The light dips closer, and finally, finds the tip of my bare foot. For a moment, neither of us moves. Rain pours down, loud enough to swallow my heavy breathing. Grimsbane stands at the mouth of the lane, his coat plastered to his frame. He is tall and drawn thin, his long face cut with a hooked nose and a mouth that seems to stretch too wide. In the shadow of his tricorn hat, a grin begins to form. Thin and sharp, he is visibly delighted to see my shaking body. Behind him, two more figures shift, cutting off the path towards the stairs.

“Go get the rope,” he orders. “This one’s a good catch.”

I do not wait for them to close in. Instead, I gather all my courage and lunge at him with my full weight. My shoulder slams into Grimsbane before he can react, catching him off balance. He curses and grabs for my arm, sharp fingernails digging into my skin. As he pulls me closer, the smell of stale rum floods my senses.

“Violent little thing,” he snarls as he tightens his grip on me, so hard that I’m sure it will bruise.

“Let me go,” I wince through the pain. “I barely have any scales.”

“Your blood will do,” he spits and yanks me towards him again.

Anger rises in me, with so much fervor that it pushes the fear aside. That siren in me stirs beneath my skin, eager to surface. This time, I let her. I twist within his hold and sink my sharp canines into the exposed flesh of his wrist.

The Rat howls. Blood floods my mouth, metallic and hot, and he jerks back violently, releasing me to clamp down on the wound. I shove him

away with both hands, the surprise of it sending him stumbling into the crates.

“Get the bloody net!” he screams at the other two. A second man lunges, arms wide, and this time I am able to duck beneath him, sliding across the boards on my knees. Wood splinters into my skin, but I do not stop. Not even when someone catches the hem of my gown, and the fabric rips as I pull away.

I kick with my legs, blinded by pure rage, and connect with something solid. A grunt follows, and as I glance back, one of them is holding a hand clasped over his throat.

Good. I hit him hard.

I take the opportunity to bolt as shouts erupt behind me.

“Cut her off!”

The planks are slick beneath my feet, but it does nothing to slow me down. I nearly crash into a stack of lobster creels as another man emerges from the left, forcing me to run back towards the docks. The waves crash against the posts beneath as if urging me on, the voice of the sea no longer mocking, but insisting. I run faster, lungs burning, down the narrow path that leads towards the anchored ships, and when I pass another stack of barrels—I see it.

At the far edge of the harbor, where the docks meet the deeper water, a ship looms. The sound of the net being shaken open snaps through the rain behind me, and I do not turn to look. I am already moving, my feet carrying me towards it, like sand dragged back by the undertow.

There is nowhere else to go.

The ship is huge and black, her hull a wall that drinks in the lantern light and gives nothing back. Torn sails hang from the yards like wet banners, the ladder drawn high out of reach. There are no nets drying, no baskets, no tidy piles of catch. It must be here for repair and not occupied. I do not know what kind of ship she is, only that she does not belong to hunters, and that is as safe as it gets for me.

The vessel is secured by several heavy mooring lines, stretching from the harbor to the ship‘s hull. I squint my eyes at the rope that hangs the lowest. I only have a few moments to estimate if it is thick enough to hold me.

Boots drum behind, coming closer. My time is up. I wrap my arms and legs around it and start to haul myself forward. I’m used to going where I shouldn’t, scaling walls for a safe sleep or a quick exit after stealing food.

Shells and stones stick to the thick line, scraping my arms and legs, yet I can’t afford to care, and continue moving.

But the storm has grown teeth. The waves swing the ship on her ropes, making the line lift and drop. My fingers slip half an inch before I clamp down again, stopping myself from falling. My muscles scream in protest as I hook my ankle around the line and pull myself back onto it. Beneath me, open water never looked more perilous.

“Shake the line!” Grimsbane roars, and the line shudders. They‘ve grabbed it from the dockside, and now heave it from side to side, in an attempt to shake me off. I wrap both legs tighter around the rope, forcing my forearms to hold. Rain pools in my vision as I look up, where the railing comes closer.

“By the seas, cut it!” someone shouts. "It cannot be that hard!”

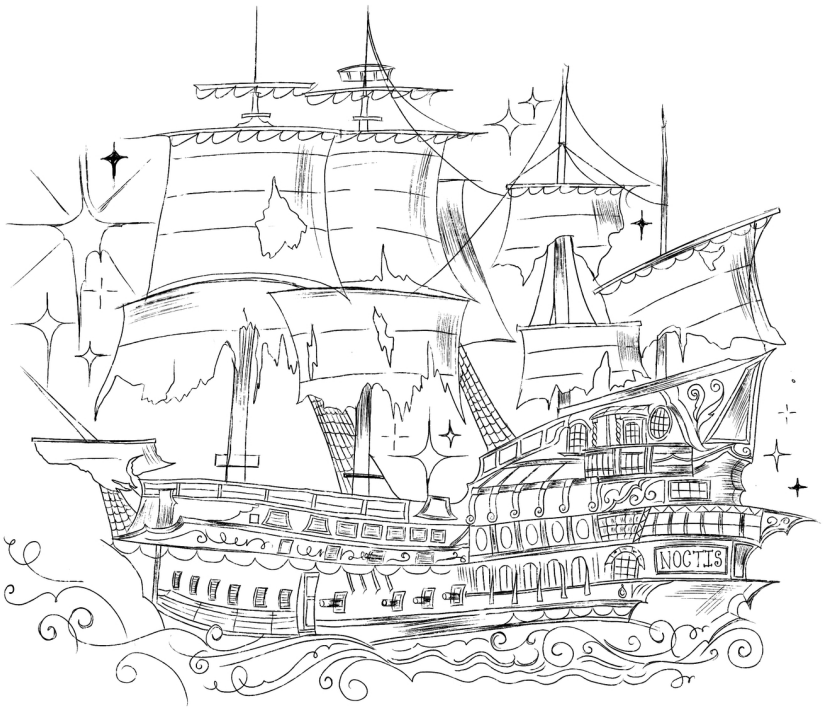
The vibration of the blade working against the rope makes me climb faster. Fibers snap one by one beneath me, until—

The line drops. I hold on for dear life as my body slams against the side of the hull, and for one sickening moment, it feels as though I am falling. The impact knocks the air from my lungs. The rope dangles uselessly now, no longer secured, swaying with the movement of the ship.

I almost reached the railing. I force one hand from the line and grope upward, until my fingers catch the edge of the rail. My arms tremble as I haul myself upward, until the railing digs into my stomach.

I draw myself up and over and fold to the deck, cheek to wet wood, my heartbeat thumping madly in my chest, my ears, my throat.

I’m finally out of their reach.


NOCTIS

Chapter Two

I AM ON THE MAIN deck of the ship. Barrels and buckets are scattered across the slick boards, and coils of thick rope lie piled beside the mast. It is mostly dark up here, only a few lanterns glow from the cabins beneath the quarterdeck, their light spilling through small fogged-up windows. Even that light does not travel far, most of the deck lies swallowed by shadow. I remember being on my father's ship when I was little, though I never got to spend a lot of time with him and the crew– my mother didn't trust the other pirates around me.

I push my weight up by my palms, wincing as the ache in my arms reminds me of the climb. As my eyes adjust, the shapes along the bulwark, the wooden barrier lining the deck, sharpen. Dark iron mouths stare back at me from the gunports. Canons. A soft gasp slips from my lips as realization settles in. I only know two kinds of ships that carry cannons, those from the Royal Navy…and pirates. I pray for the first. Humans fear sirens, but pirates hate us to death. Honestly, the feeling is mutual. Besides my father and parts of his crew, every pirate I have ever encountered has been cruel. Lifting my gaze to the mast, I search for the royal colors, red and blue, but the rigging disappears into the dark. And where's the guard? The Royal Navy would never leave a ship at dock without a watch. My stomach tightens, a creeping unease settling in, though I force the thought away.

Through the thunder that continues to roll through the night, the angry voices of the Rats drift up from the docks below. The storm swallows the clarity of their words, but I can tell from the sheer volume that they are

arguing. If my past run-ins with the Rats have taught me anything, it is that they will not give up easily. Their kind never does. Once they have caught a scent, they hound it to the very end, no matter the cost. No, staying aboard this ship is the only chance at survival, especially seeing as they've probably already sent for nets for my capture. I must remain hidden, even just until the morning. I can jump off the ship in the morning and swim to the shore.

The wind makes the mast creak just as laughter bursts across the deck. A palm slaps against wood, followed by the muffled scrape of a chair. Then the cabin door swings open. A young lad stumbles out with a grunt, rubbing his eyes as he steps onto the deck.

"Lad, cast off the shore lines! And wake the watch!" a voice calls from inside.

The door swings closed again with a dull thud, leaving only the wind and the restless groan of the ship. I press myself lower and hold my breath as if stillness could fold me into the shadows. The boy stands perhaps fifty feet away. With an exasperated sigh, he strides toward the nearest mooring line and begins to work the knot loose, glancing downwards to the dark water below. He is casting off the line. Are they leaving? In this wretched storm? Surely they are not this suicidal. If they truly make for departure, I lose the last path back to the shore. There will be no escaping in the morning once we have reached deeper waters.

The boy's eyes lift to me. His hand stills, the rope goes slack, and his mouth falls slightly agape. For a moment, we just stare at each other, chests heaving and eyes wide, neither of us knowing exactly what to do. I must look feral in my white, ripped gown and scale-sprinkled skin. I swallow and go through my options, but deep down, I know I'm screwed. If he calls for help, I am dragged back to the harbor, or worse. If I jump, I'll fall into the hunter's hands. Only one choice offers any chance of survival at all.

I must use my song. Or whatever broken piece of it I can master.

He draws breath to shout. I, too, draw breath and let a sound rise. It is not a full song, only a hum. A quiet, gentle release of a melody. That is all I am capable of. It curls around my tongue, soft enough to not affect the men below, but clear enough to compel the boy in front of me. I loosen a single thread of it, enough to tug at, but not enough to drive him to drowning. It is bitter on my tongue, a sharp reminder that the magic I am using comes at a cost.

I rise and carry the hum with me as I cross the deck, the water still dripping from my gown, tracing my calves before falling away in a thin line. Confusion tightens his face, then fear. He looks way younger up close. A cabin boy, if I have to guess, maybe around twelve years old. I stop a step away and wait until his pupils widen and the stiffness leaves his jaw. The line in his hand drops and swings between us.

“Be not afraid,” I whisper, keeping the hum steady in my throat. “I do not want to hurt you.” His gaze drifts down my torn gown and back up again, before leaning toward me, as if the tide is pulling at his weight.

“Are you a witch?” he stammers, and a soft smile finds my mouth. I have been mistaken for a sea witch many times in my life before. Humans simply cannot help themselves. They see something that is out of the ordinary and must put a label on it immediately.

“Not quite,” I answer, which makes his shoulders sag with relief. He is easy to compel, being young and clearly having had no close encounters with a siren. A prick of guilt jabs at the flesh beneath my ribs. The boy will get a beating or worse if I force him to comply, and the crew finds out he helped me. I keep humming anyway, because after all, I want to live. And to be fair, so far I haven‘t lived at all.

Perhaps it is my softness that keeps me from becoming what I truly am meant to be. My kind lure men to their deaths, pirates being their most preferred victims. In the deepest waters, the blackwater sirens even consume pieces of their prey to strengthen their magic. My swarm never kept those rites. Instead, we give the sea a man. A soul to keep in return for what we needed most from the sea. The crueler the man, the greater the reward, and so pirates became our quarry. I feel the same instinct, like a subtle hunger, yet I cannot act on it. And truthfully, I am not sure I would want to, even if I could.

“What kind of magic do you wield then?” he asks, forcing the words out as he struggles against the pull whispering in his ears.

“That is not important,” I whisper gently. “What matters is that you show me where to hide on this ship. I am no threat to you or your crew, I swear it by the Six Seas.”

Water drips from the hem of my gown as I roll the fabric between my fingers. The rain has passed, yet thunder still cracks across the sky, flashes of lightning briefly spilling white light across the deck. One wrong glance from the cabin windows and everything will be over. My song does not

hold enough power to compel a whole crew. When the boy hesitates, I deepen the hum to coax his tongue and step closer.

“The hold,” he blurts. “The lower part of the ship. We keep the loot there.”

The word is familiar, though ships have been rare in my life these past years. After my mother abandoned me and it became clear she would never return, I climbed aboard the first vessel I could reach. Kind fishermen carried me along the coast and eventually set me ashore near Aurelith. Since then, I have been trapped on that island. After I encountered the Rats, I came to realize how foolish it was to trust any passing crew, and I did not make that mistake again. Tonight, my fate seems to choose otherwise.

The hold will make a good hiding place, especially with sailors soon crowding the deck to ready the ship. Not that there‘s any other option.

“Please show me the way. And make sure that no one sees us.”

He moves, and I follow, our bare feet quiet on the wet boards. I keep the hum close to his ear to steady him. We pass the gunports and head toward the mainmast, where a hatch leads down into the hold. He lifts the iron ring, and the lid comes up with a soft pull. A steep run of steps drops into black.

“Quick,” he urges, glancing over his shoulder.

Carefully, I lower myself onto the ladder and descend. Twice, my foot slips on the damp wood, nearly sending me tumbling. Thick air gathers below, heavy with the scent of tar, rope, and something sweet that might be stolen fruit. The lad comes after me and pulls the hatch close, leaving a thin seam of light above us before the dark settles.

We reach the orlop, where rows of hammocks swing softly with the motion of the ship. Another ladder takes us further, into the hold. The smell grows heavier down here. Crates marked with chalk stack to my shoulder and higher. Water hushes against the hull, close and steady, as if the sea has pressed its ear to the wood to listen.

“Here,” he says, and guides me behind a tower of caskets. A torn sail is draped over a beam to form a kind of makeshift tent. This could work. Anyone passing by would have to look very carefully to notice someone hiding there.

“Thank you, “ I whisper, offering him another quick smile. “I don’t think anyone saw us.“

“I hope not,” he answers with a weak smile, though his voice trembles.

I let the hum warm again and change the melody, shaping it into something small that fits in his head. “You did not see me,” I tell him. “If anyone asks, the deck was empty. You were never here.”

His throat bobs as he swallows. “The deck was empty,” he repeats. “I was never here.”

“Now go,” I say, choosing my words wisely. “Do not come back unless you must.”

He nods, though his eyes cling to me for one moment longer, as if he’s fighting the magic. Then he turns and climbs, and the seam of light widens and closes before disappearing entirely as the hatch clicks.

I am alone with the sound of the ship’s heart, the timbers creaking in uneven beats, each dull thud carrying through the hull.

Crouching beneath the sail, I draw my knees close to my chest. The hum fades until it is no more than the ghost of a breath. Salt lingers on my tongue, and a dull, throbbing ache begins to swell behind my eyes. My mother never taught me more than this — a note to coax and a note to calm. No lessons on the deeper songs that invoke an answer from the sea, or songs that drive men to drive from cliffsides. Unfortunate, I know.

Before I can close my eyes for sleep, boots begin to drum on the deck. The men start talking to each other as though in a hurry, all while the storm that the Sea of Crowns is known for is still rumbling in the distance around the island. Slowly, I sit up again, trying to listen to what they are saying.

“All hands,” a voice calls above. The voice is rough and sends a shiver down my spine. Only someone with command could give an order like that. It‘s either the captain or the First Mate. “Single up.”

“All single,” a mate answers near the rail.

“Let go bow,” he says, his voice coming closer.

“Bow gone.”

“Let go stern.”

“Stern gone, Captain.”

“Ease the forward spring.”

“Easing.”

“Hold there,” the captain says, quieter now. The crew falls silent, waiting.

“Let go springs.”

“Springs away.”

Lines slap the water, and a heavy rope groans under strain. The hull eases from the pilings, and the ship slowly shifts under me. I brace my palms on

the wet planks. My heart quickens as my thoughts knot.

I was right. They're actually leaving the harbor. In this storm. In the middle of the night. Are they truly mad? And yet, if they're bound for another island— or another sea—it could be my chance. Anything is better than Aurelith. This could be an escape. Or it could be death, if they find me.

"Double-reef topsails. Let fall. Sheet home," the voice barks above. His heavy footsteps stop right over my head. I do not know what the commands mean, only that the crew moves fast to answer them.

There is a sudden tug as the sails take and fill. Caskets shift, one thumps to the deck, and the whole ship creaks as she begins to move.

"Hands aloft," the captain bites. "Make her fly. Follow the Glim."

"Aye, Captain," the crew shouts, settling into their work. We are actually leaving the harbor of Cantora. I swallow, panic rising within me. I hear the water crashing against the hull in a steady rhythm, and for a moment I think I'm imagining the tune that starts low at the bow. But then another voice joins it, then a third, until the boards carry it through the ribs of the ship. They're– singing?

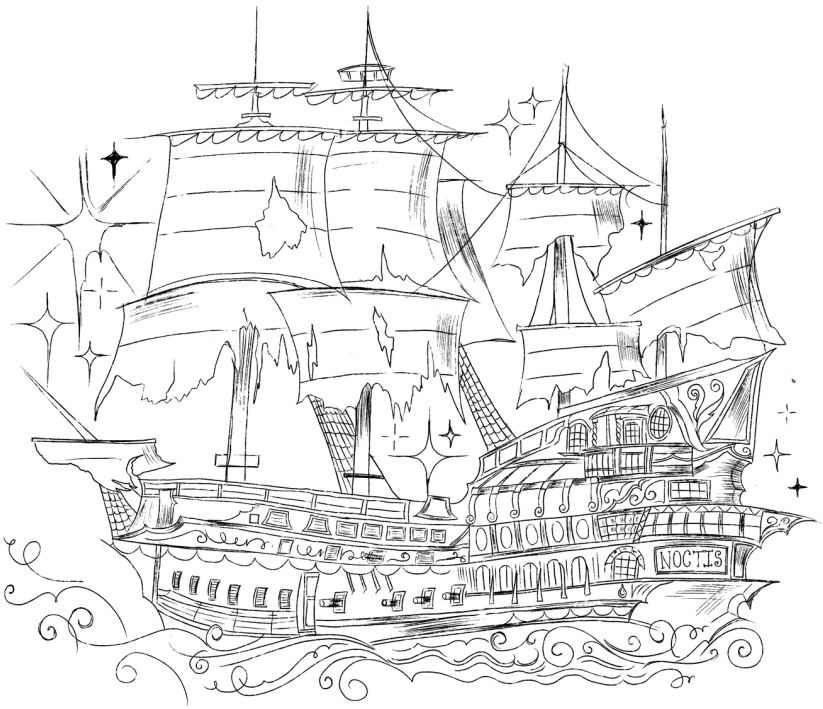
Heave ho, boys, clear the quay
Heave ho, she won't sail free
Heave ho, and don't look back
There's more than wind in the black
Brace and haul and mind the gale
When the sun is gone, shadows sail
Heave ho—keep her tight
Count by hands, not shapes in night

The harmony thickens until it rattles in my teeth. A low voice enters on the last line, the kind that does not need to be loud to be obeyed. It slips under the others and turns the chord darker. I know it is the captain without seeing him. I also know that only men called by the sea raise black flags. My earlier suspicions have proven to be true.

Pirates.

As the deck falls silent again, speed builds and water runs fast along the skin of the ship. I pull the sail closer to my body, hoping it will warm me a little. I am too tired, too cold to think about where we are going, or what the so-called Glim is that they are following. Morning will not be a quiet quay.

Morning will be open water, pirates overhead, and nowhere to go.


NOCTIS

Chapter Three

I DO NOT CLOSE MY eyes all night.

After they set the sails, the crew falls silent again, likely returning to their cabins. According to the snoring sounds, some even sleep in the orlop above me. Now and then, I hear one man murmur to another, likely when they change shifts, or laughter drifting from above. The night lasts forever, so I am relieved when a blade of light slips through the orlop above. I spent the night curled on the hard planks beneath the draped sail, shifting again and again as every position presses into my bones, leaving no way to rest without pain. And by the seas, the smell is awful. I do not know what they store down here, but it smells rotten.

My stomach twists at the memory of my last meal. The last thing I ate was a fig I stole from a market stand yesterday morning. I scrunch my nose whilst I debate risking searching for something edible. At some point, I have to leave my hiding place. I could have told the lad to bring me food now and then, but that would've put me at risk. I am not even sure if my hum was enough to make him keep my secret, or if it will fade. I can't help but wonder what it must feel like to come back to yourself and realize your will was never your own, and something inside me tightens at the thought.

Desperate for something to quieten my hunger, I rise and peer around the caskets. I brace my palms on the planks and tiptoe toward the barrels. I squint, trying to make sense of the swirls of letters on the wood, but then give up. Shame pricks at me for not being able to read, though it is not my fault. My mother taught me a little before the swarm abandoned me, but a

few words are not much help now. I sigh, opting to use my nose to choose a barrel. The air surrounding the first one smells like nothing, so I try my luck. I glance at the steps after every movement and hold my breath to be sure no one hears, then I ease the barrel head free and look inside.

Water.

I whisper a quick thanks to the sea and drink a few mouthfuls from my cupped hands. The cool water slips down my throat, easing the dryness with every swallow. I am about to drink more when footsteps thud above me and come to a halt.

“Nightglass,” a voice calls above, cutting through the boards. Boots strike the deck as the crewmember he called for hurries over.

“Captain.”

“Can we sail...-” The rest is swallowed by the wood. “..intermaria… storm..”

The timbers creak above me. I press myself against the barrel, trying to hide, heart hammering.

“...currents…against us,” Nightglass answers, his words carrying in broken pieces. “The sea…tear us apart.”

Silence follows.

“Captain…orders?” another voice asks, letting the title linger so that I catch it.

The pause is long enough to make my chest tighten. Then the captain speaks, his voice authoritative but calm – controlled. “... follow…the bloody Glim.”

A chill ripples through me. If they choose to sail through the intermaria, the ship is doomed. The Intermaria is where two seas meet, constantly fighting for the upper hand. The result is strong currents and – less commonly but still a very real possibility – maelstroms that swallow ships whole. Only those who live beneath the sea know the safe route through. The thought of being trapped down here while the ship sinks makes my stomach twist with fear.

“You’ll be the death of us, Sable,” the doubter spits, loud enough for me to hear. “The Glim has disappeared. We don't know if it's the right route.”

“It’s Captain to you, Ash,” he replies, the words sharp, though only parts of it reach me. “...what do we have to lose…don’t follow it…sea will claim us…”

The deck groans with their steps. I have to know what they're saying. Before I can stop myself, I move, climbing the ladder as quietly as possible, until I stop just beneath the hatch. Up here, the voices are clearer.

The Captain – Sable – lowers his voice. "If you mean to revolt against my orders, then speak. I would take great pleasure in watching you walk the plank. Until then, obey."

The steps move away at last, fading into silence, and I release a breath I didn't realize I was holding. My muscles ache from keeping still. I climb down as carefully as I can and fumble for my hiding place.

Suddenly, pain spears through my right foot.

I bite down on the scream, teeth grinding together, and hunch over to look at the affected area. A rusty nail pierces through my foot, driven clean through flesh. The acidic sting of nausea rises up my throat, threatening vomit. I have never experienced such searing, violent pain. My hands shake as I grip the wood for balance, every nerve screaming out against the iron intruder.

Tears blur my vision as I force myself to lift my foot free. The sound of my flesh clinging to the metal is wet, and the pain nearly knocks me flat. Blood wells fast, hot against my skin, spilling over my toes and pooling on the boards. I press my palm against the wound, breath stuttering. I count to ten, the way my mother taught me to prepare for when she pulled me under the water.

Slowly, I limp back to my hiding place, my injured foot dragging behind me, leaving a glistening smear of red across the planks in my wake. I clamp my teeth together and scan the hold. I need to stop the bleeding. Fast. Cauterizing the wound is not an option, and I do not have any alcohol on hand to sterilize it either. My only choice here is to apply pressure with whatever fabric I can get my hands on. I catch the loose end of the sail and pull it free, the coarse weave biting my palms, then I tear off a strip with my sharp canines. They are not nearly as sharp as a true siren's, but they cut cloth and skin well enough.

I brace against a casket and wrap the strip around my foot. Once. Twice. I pull it tight until the throb jumps in time with my pulse against the taut fabric, tucking the loose end underneath the binding to hold it in place. Another tear trickles down my cheek as I let my back slide down the stacked caskets, the uneven wood catching on the bumps in my spine. I

keep my hand on the bandage and close my eyes, gathering myself for a moment.

I blink them open again at the evidence I have left, the crimson mark I have made on the dark wooden boards. Should anyone come down here and notice the trail of blood, I am finished. Worse yet, once the pirates realize what I am, I'll be thrown overboard or sold on the markets before dawn. And they do not kill you quickly there. They meticulously pluck the scales, one by one, with a tool they call the flute, then put them in those wretched little cloth bags to sell. I have seen the stains of life on the planks in Cantora, and the buckets of its waste emptied into the sea.

Perhaps they'll take their sweet time, torturing me, killing me slowly, the way they believe most sirens enjoy doing to them. They won't care that I'm not truly one of them. That I've never killed–that I never mean to kill. Every pirate has lost someone to a siren. I know my father certainly did.

But I can't lie to myself. The hunger is there. It courses through my veins and takes shape in my dreams. A version of me I don't recognize, dragging a man beneath the waves, tearing him apart, offering him to the sea. I shiver at the thought of doing something so violent, so unlike me, and apply more pressure to my still-bleeding foot.

I glance at the steps leading to the orlop, weighing up my options, when the hatch is thrown open with a bang, and someone rushes down. Down into the hold, where the iron of my blood hangs heavy in the air. Where I sit, hunched over, desperately trying to make myself smaller. My body stiffens, and I swallow down the bile at the thought of being discovered in my current state.

"Carpenter, you'd best earn your keep! Stitch my ship up before we reach the strong currents!" the captain bellows from above.

I hold my breath, fear washing over me once again as I stare at the threat in front of me. The carpenter strides toward a damaged part of the hull with a sloshing bucket in hand, cursing under his breath, too intent on his work to notice me crouched in the shadows between caskets. He drops beside what looks like a crack in the hull, plunges a hand into the bucket he brought, and begins ramming a coarse, fibrous mass into it. Oakum, if I had to guess. In calmer times, I might marvel at the speed and certainty of his craft. He turns, probably spotting another fracture. I freeze, my breath vanishing from my lungs as his gaze sweeps over my hiding spot. For a

moment, his bushy eyebrows knit together as though a confusing thought has entered his head, and then thankfully, he returns to his task.

He did not see me. But it's only a matter of time before he does.

When I am sure he is fully focused once again on fixing the hull, I gather my skirt in one hand and push myself upright. The world blurs when I put weight on my injured foot, and I swallow the cry that claws up my throat and shift to the other leg, fingers digging into the edge of a nearby crate.

He is only a few paces away, kneeling beside the breach. If he turns fully, if he takes two steps to the left, he will see the blood. The blood of a siren. On the planks between us, the dark smear glistens in the thin light from above. I have to make my escape now.

The steps could lead me upward, away from him. But I must be cautious not to let the sound of my movement give me away. Waves batter the wood of the ship, threatening destruction. If I move with the sound of the waves, there’s a chance their noise might swallow mine. When the next wave rushes against the hull, I move.

The pain that courses through me only propels me forward, each step aligned to the beating of the sea. Wave. Step. Wave. Step. I slip past the edge of the casks, and reach the steps. By the time I reach the top, sweat slicks my palms from the effort. Peering through the opening, I can make out a few lanterns that hang from the beams above, their glow barely fending off the dark. Hammocks sway lazily between them, but no pirates lie in rest. I bunch my skirt and hurry deeper into the belly of the ship, stars flickering at the edges of my vision, exhaustion and pain shadowing my movements. Footsteps echo behind me, but I do not dare to look back. Looking back would only slow me down. It would only provide me with reason to panic.

At the far end of the orlop, I find a ladder leading upward. There’s no telling where it goes, and I can only blindly hope it leads to a place they will not think to search for whoever left their mark on the floor of the hold. At least until we reach the isles of the Sea of Renewal, because if they truly mean to cross the intermaria, there is no other course they could be taking, not with the cliffs hemming in the far edge of the Sea of Crowns, though I have no wish to throw myself overboard there either. Healing my foot would mean giving up another memory, and I am unsure whether I have any I am willing to part with. The Sea of Renewal always takes one in return for a mended wound.

Biting down on my lip, I hone my focus on the present task and start climbing.

What lies at the top of the ladder is not quite what I had expected. It's the galley, the ship's kitchen. I stand as straight as I am able, and cannot help but notice how much easier the movement feels in the warm air of the room. There is an iron stove bolted to the deck, a steady fire crackling inside. A long worktable runs down the center of the narrow room, and from the wear in the wood, I can tell it's been here a long time. Pots and ladles hang from hooks along a beam, and racks fixed to the wooden wall hold onions, citrus, and a net of dried herbs. I would have expected something filthier from a pirates' galley. Whoever works here clearly loves their craft and cares deeply for the space.

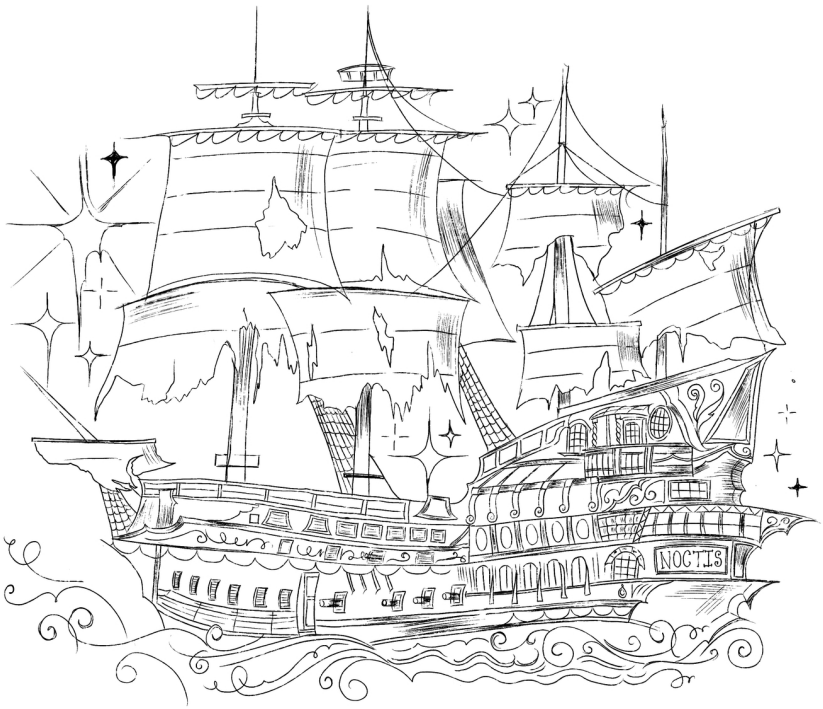
I snuff out the fiery hunger in my stomach and force myself past the food, moving sternward. The door at the end is framed in oak and hangs half open, its glass panes clouded. Salt air slips through, and I inhale deeply, finding comfort in the familiar scent. The thought of clean sea air and a short moment of rest pulls me forward, beckons me out into the open. I press my hand to the cool wood of the door, and step onto a little balcony.

The sea stretches grey and endless, broken only by the churn of white foam trailing behind the ship. In the distance, the cliffs of Aurelith loom, storm light still flashing above them while the waters here lie calmer now. The cold wind bites into my cheeks, stinging the skin red, but for the first time since I fled the hunters, I can breathe. The balcony is a temporary reprieve, but danger still snatches at me behind my back. "There you are."

I flinch as the familiar voice cuts through me. I close my eyes, draw a breath, and turn straight into a solid wall of man.

Into the Captain himself.

Sable.


NOCTIS

Chapter Four

MY BREATHING QUICKENS AS I try to step back, the railing biting into my spine. The man in front of me radiates danger and something I can't quite name. Wet black hair clings to his face, framing kohl-rimmed eyes as grey as the sea surrounding us. By the way those eyes narrow on me, I can tell he would toss me over the rail without hesitation should I try to escape – or fight.

"What, swallowed your tongue?" he taunts.

I open my mouth in anticipation of biting back, but no words come. I clench my fingers into a fist at my side, half out of frustration, half in preparation for throwing a punch. Normally, I can always escape. There's always a little alley I can sneak into, a wall I can climb. But not here, the drop from the balcony is sure to bring me to my end. No, if I wish to be free of him, I am going to have to confront the tall, muscled man before me.

A wicked grin spreads across his face as he closes the door with an eerily calm movement, though I know it only masks the darkness behind it. He knows I am no threat to him, and he knows I cannot escape unless I let the sea take me. Drowning is a miserable way to go, for the sea is as vicious as it is generous. One can never truly know the nature of its intentions.

"How did you find me?" I manage, grabbing the railing behind me.

"Oh, darling. You thought you could hide from me on my ship?" His grin widens. "I thought you might enjoy a little game of hide-and-seek before I lock you up, so I asked Saint to force you from your hiding spot."

He folds his arms in front of his broad chest, pulling the fabric of his shirt taut. “Our cabin boy Lark told me all about you, and what you did to him. Poor boy thinks you’re a sea witch.” His gaze drops to my collarbones and my arms, where scales glint faintly in the weak sunlight that makes it through the dense clouds. “Though I must admit, I’ve never heard of a witch with scales.”

I lift my chin, feigning confidence. Being mistaken for a witch is far safer than the truth of a siren without a tail or a full song.

“Then I dare say you have not seen many sea witches,” I answer. “We can take on the features of any chosen sea creatures if we wish.”

“And you chose to look like a fish?” he mocks with an arched brow, grin fixed in place. It takes all my efforts not to strike that smug grin right off him.

“Yes,” I say through my teeth, holding myself back by frayed threads. By the way he talks and holds himself, I already know he’s the kind of man who provokes just for the fun of it. Losing my temper and baring my canines will be of no help here. I do not exist for his entertainment.

“Mhmm…” he hums, as though he is tasting the lie and deciding whether it pleases him or not.

“You must think me a fool, lass,” he says, stepping closer. The ship rolls beneath us, but he doesn’t shift his weight, secure in his stance. “Sea witches do not compel lads with a hum, and they’re certainly not naive enough to hide on a pirate ship. Especially not mine.”

“And yet,” I say carefully, keeping my gaze on his. “here I am.”

“And yet,” he repeats, his chest rising and falling with excited breath.

The wind snaps between us, tugging at his coat and my hair. The space between us feels smaller with every passing second, and with the certainty of the cold water waiting below, I forget how to breathe.

“If I decide you’re lying,” he continues, voice almost too casual, “I‘ll toss you overboard myself. I don't much like stowaways. I like liars even less.”

Before I can answer, his gaze shifts past my shoulder, eyes widening. I turn to see a faint pulse beneath the waves.

A thread of light.

It blinks once, soft and distant, like a star pulsing in the darkest depths of the water. A shimmer of light, too alive to belong here. Even my deepest imaginings could not conjure up such an image, and for a breathless moment, I stand transfixed with awe. The world narrows to that single line

of light, moving with quiet conviction, stitching a path through the black sea, like a silver ribbon drawn through ink. I narrow my eyes and track it. It threads along the side of the ship, keeping pace with us.

The captain steps closer to the rail beside me, all mockery stripped from him.

“It came back,” he murmurs, more to himself than to me.

The light pulses once more, then slips forward along the hull until the angle of the stern hides it from our view.

“What was that?” I ask and swallow, regretting the question as soon as it meets the air.

He turns his head toward me slowly.

“That," he says, studying my face with a new level of intensity, “is the Glim.”

I remember them talking about it last night, the so-called Glim. That they want to follow it into the intermaria.

“And as a sea witch,” he continues, voice cooling again, “you should know exactly what that is.”

My pulse stutters as I force my features into indifference, raising my chin higher.

“Of course.”

His gaze lingers a little too long. His grey eyes search mine, looking for a crack in the mask I have carefully crafted. A knowing look passes over his face.

“Of course,” he echoes in a low voice, and by now, I am certain he knows I am lying.

The wind rises again, tugging at my gown, and I swallow down the knot that has formed in my throat.

“Well then, little fish. We will talk tomorrow. For now, I have a ship to steady and a crew to tame.” He turns and calls over his shoulder, “Lads, come get the witch.”

The glass door swings open. A broad pirate steps onto the balcony first, carrying chains and cuffs. A wiry one follows, a leather strap already looped in his fist.

“You must understand,” Sable leans closer, his voice low, sending a shiver through me. “We cannot let a sea witch roam free and play her wicked little tricks. Sorry, darling.”

He straightens, the faintest curve returning to his mouth as if this were all a performance staged for his own amusement.

“Take her to the hold,” he orders, his tone shifting into cruelty.

“And find my fucking hat,” he throws over his shoulders as he disappears into the galley, leaving his men to finish the work.

“Don’t you dare put that dirty leath—” My scream cuts off as the wiry one shoves a leather strap between my teeth and yanks it tight. Salt and old tannin flood my tongue. I try to spit it out, but I can only gag. The other pirate grabs for my wrists, but I refuse to give in without a fight. I twist away, nearly lose my footing, then lunge back into him out of spite. I throw a punch that rebounds off his shoulders. I scratch blindly at the air, nails scraping skin or cloth, as anger and fear take control over my actions.

“This one’s feisty,” one of them murmurs, grabs me by my wrists, and secures the cuffs with a metallic clicking sound. Naturally, I test them, tugging at the restraints, but the iron bites into my wrists, sharper than I thought it would.

“Aye, she is. Reminds me of Captain’s sister,” the other one adds with a chuckle.

Hatred burns hot in my eyes, but though they water, not a single tear falls. I will not give them that satisfaction, but the weight of it presses down nonetheless.

Within the span of a single day, my life has been overturned. Fate surely cannot be so cruel. To strip me of my tail and cast me into the hands of pirates. Anger coils sharp in my chest, at the world, at the sea, myself. Mostly myself. I shouldn’t have let it come so far, but I have had little choice in the matter.

They march me into the orlop without a struggle. My limbs drag with the weight of my exhaustion with every step, and I know there is nowhere left to hide, so I give in. The air grows heavy in the ship’s belly. Tar and salt thicken on my tongue until my throat stings. I have not missed that smell. They push me into one of the two cells, chain my ankles, and fasten the iron links to a ring sunk deep in the planks. The younger pirate tugs the chain once to test it. Pity flickers across his face before he looks away and turns the key.

“Match, be a good lad and bring the lady a bucket of fresh water to clean up,” his mate orders.

“Aye,” Match answers. His eyes meet mine for a heartbeat before he hurries off.

“There is a bucket for waste.” The mate jerks his chin toward the corner, where the bucket waits. Wait, how am I supposed to...? With my wrists bound, I cannot lift my gown. He reads the question in my face, and a small smirk shows through his beard.

“Figure it out,” he says with a shrug. He leaves without another word.

Bastard.

I take a deep breath and shuffle towards the wall opposite from the bars, then let myself slide down against it until my butt touches the cold boards. Darkness gathers, and with it comes the sorrow. I close my eyes and listen to the water rushing against the hull, trying to find comfort in it. For a moment, I can almost feel the hum of the swarm, the flick of tails in dark water, my mother’s voice telling me to go to the surface and take air. She had been loving, even when the others whispered that I was wrong, that a siren born without a tail should never have been born at all. They left me anyway. I wonder if it was all for nothing, if I will ever feel a tail behind me, cutting the current the way it should. I refuse to vanish in this belly of wood and iron. I am still here. I will make that mean something.

Through swollen eyes, the cell comes into focus. Salt now clings to my cheeks, and I realize that I must‘ve been crying. There’s no cot in this cell, not even a scatter of straw. Lanterns swing from the beams, their glow soft and uneven, painting the walls in a sickly gold. Chains hang idle, creaking whenever the hull shifts. Above, the main hatch hangs open just enough to spill a thin wash of light across the boards.

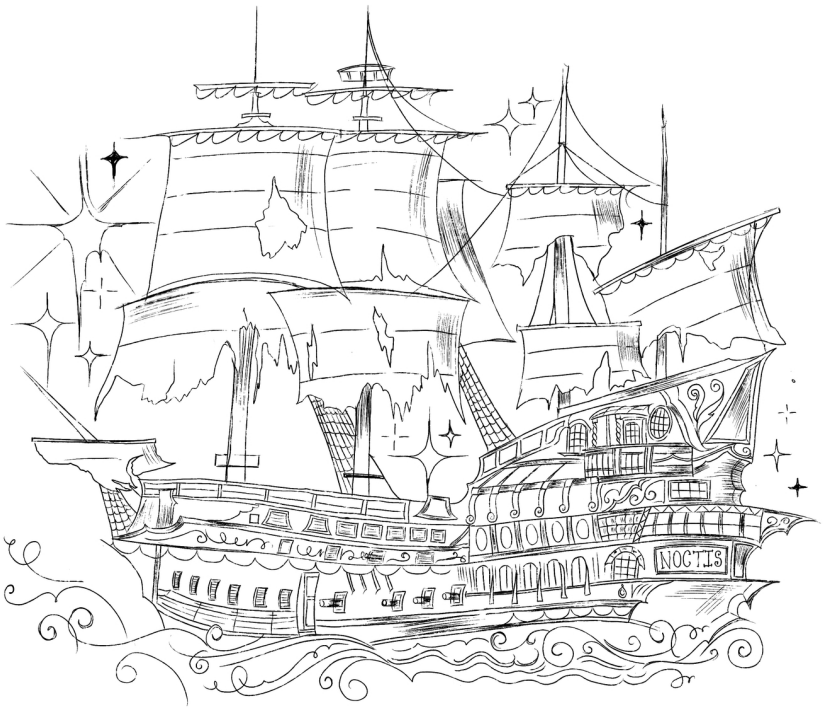
It seems like the crew is still dealing with the aftermath of the storm. Boots thud along the planks, and ropes strain on their pins while voices rise and fall. I pick out the carpenter, Saint, by his steady tone. The captain’s voice does not carry down here, which surprises me, because he enjoys barking orders at his crew.

I focus and sift through the sounds, matching names to the faces I have seen. The carpenter, whose name is Saint. Lark, the cabin boy I compelled, who might have helped me even without the hum. Match, who showed a flicker of mercy, though I do not know how long it will last. His mate, the one who sneered and spat, kept his name from me. For now, I call him Rat, as I call any man who chooses to treat me poorly. Yes, that feels right to me.

And then there’s the captain, Sable. He clearly does not trust me. My hands curl into fists at my sides until the cuffs cut into skin. He finds amusement in hunting me through his ship. And let’s not forget the leather strap that sits between my teeth, making me drool like a sick whelp.

Saint. Lark. Match. Rat. Sable. I say their names in my head and fix them to the faces of each one. Better to remember them all, I think to myself, and a smile tugs at my lips.

The siren in me stirs with excitement.


NOCTIS

Chapter Five

I WAKE UP TO THE cold. The chill sits on my skin and makes it almost impossible to catch a clear thought. When my teeth begin to chatter, I notice that the leather strap is gone. I touch my tongue, disbelieving, then work my jaw to ease the pain. Straining my ears, I listen for shouts or boots drumming the deck, but there's nothing. It must be in the middle of the night.

The wound in my foot still pulses, and with every pulse, pain rushes through me. If the wound gets infected, I am doomed, unless they have a bonesetter. A dark red stain is now visible where the nail pierced my foot. The idea of ripping the makeshift bandage off turns my stomach, but there's no way around it if I want to clean it to avoid an infection. A quick glance at the closed gate of my cell makes me sigh in relief. Match has brought me the bucket while I was sleeping.

I crawl towards it, the chains that bind me rattling as they're dragged across the floor, not wanting anyone to wake and look after me. I know that the men are sleeping in hammocks a few feet away, on the opposite side of the main hatch, their breathing rising and falling like the waves that carry the ship. Leaning against the rusty bars, my face twists in agony as I unbind the piece of sail from my foot. The blood sticks to it, so by removing the fabric, I will tear the wound open again. Better to make it quick than slow. I count to three and rip it off.

The fabric tears free with a wet sound, and pain shoots up my leg so sharply my fingers dig into the boards beneath.

I scoop some of the water up with my hands and start to clean the open flesh. It stings, but I know it’s necessary, so I breathe through it until the shake leaves my hands. After I’ve finished, I make quick work of my nightgown and tear away a few strips using my canines. I take one of them and wrap it around my hurt foot, then carefully clean the other ones in the bucket and hang them on the edge of it to dry.

Sinking back against the wood, exhaustion takes over me again and fuzzes the edges of my vision. My stomach grumbles, telling me something I already know. The sound is small but insistent. If I don’t eat something soon, my strength will fade away even more.

From the corner of my eye, I catch a movement underneath the stairs leading to the deck. I go still, my breath caught halfway. What was that? Cautiously, I lift myself up a bit to get a better look at the narrow space, but there’s no one there. Great, so the stage of hallucinations has begun. I rub my temple with my fingers, trying to get myself back together. If I'm lucky, sleep will find me for a few more hours before sunrise, and I will come back to my senses.

I am about to make my way back to my favored corner of the cell when I catch the dark figure moving again. This time, I can see the silhouette clearly. A pirate leans against one of the wooden beams, looking in my direction. He doesn’t bother to hide it. His head is tilted to the side, as if he were curious, trying to figure me out.

How long has he been watching me? Does he think I will simply accept that I’m being gawked at? Heat rises within me as my nails dig into the palm of my hand.

“Go away.” I spit, maybe a little too harsh for the position I am in. But I couldn’t care less. My back straightens on its own. I will not lose my worth, or my pride, to these men.

The pirate doesn’t move an inch. Instead, he tilts his head to the other side and crosses his legs at the ankles, getting comfortable. I pinch my brows together and clench my jaw tight.

“If you want to harm me, just know that I will fight back.” My voice trembles, and I hate myself for it. I carefully sit back up, getting ready to defend myself with all I have left. My gaze fixes on his throat. Will my canines be sharp enough to rip it open? Probably.

“You got yourself in a pretty inconvenient situation.” His voice is calm and quiet, like the sea when the sun rises on a beautiful day. But there’s

something unnatural about it that I cannot explain. It sounds like a whisper that echoes through the ship, and though he stands a few feet away from me, it is as if he is whispering directly into my ear. I fight the urge to cover it with my hand.

That man is not human—he cannot be. I am about to ask him who and what he is when he steps closer to my cell with his hands tucked neatly behind his back. His posture is straight and proud as he makes his way over to me in long steps, though the boards do not creak under his weight. Maybe I am hallucinating after all.

I blink hard, once, twice.

"You fear me?" he asks, as if offended by my reaction, now almost standing directly in front of my cell.

Fear me?

Fear me?

Fear me?

His voice surrounds me and multiplies itself over and over again. I clench my jaw, my whole body going rigid as I keep my eyes fixed on the stranger. I can only see his silhouette, the darkness takes everything else, and the moonlight doesn't help much. My pulse hammers in my ears, blending with his voice.

"Yes," I manage to mutter through clenched teeth.

There's no point in lying. I am terrified.

He steps closer to the bars, likely glancing down at me, though it is hard to tell with the way his features flicker and blur at the edges. I wonder what I must look like to him. My torn gown, the dirt, the bruises, the blood. I barely recognize myself. In Aurelith I was poor, but I had clean clothes and food, even if it was stolen. It wasn't a good life, but it was mine. My throat tightens at the thought of what I have left behind.

"Fear me not. I am no threat to you. Never will be. But they are. You have to tell him the truth." He crouches in front of the bars, one hand wrapping loosely around the iron. I follow the shape of his face, only to find his eyes unnaturally dark, black, and empty. The outline of his hands flickers faintly, surrounded by a dim silver light. Something in him draws me in despite the fear crawling under my skin.

"Who?"

"The Captain."

"What truth?"

His gaze lingers on the scales scattered along my collarbone. “You know what truth.”

I pull in a slow breath and let it out through my teeth, careful not to let him hear the tremor. How can he know the truth about me? They think I am a witch. I have given them no reason to believe otherwise. I turn my face away, pretending to study the floor, though my skin prickles under his stare.

“Don’t play dumb now, lass.” His voice shifts, a quiet warning. “I saw you humming for the cabin boy. Beautiful sound, by the way. I was impressed and can admit that even I was almost drawn to it.”

My jaw tightens as I look back at him, unwilling to give him the satisfaction of seeing my fear. The faintest twitch touches the corner of his mouth, and I can’t tell if it’s amusement or cruelty. Perhaps it’s the latter. If I tell the captain the truth, as he proposes, I will die a death they will write songs about.

“Why should I tell him the truth? He will toss me overboard."

He tilts his head, thinking. His other hand wraps around the second closest iron bar. The light from above glints faintly over his knuckles, making them vanish. I shift, the chain at my ankle scraping against the floor.

“Maybe. But he hates one thing more than sirens, and that’s a liar.”

Liar.

Liar.

Liar.

The word lingers in the air, making my stomach churn.

“You seem to know the captain well,” I murmur, lifting my head again, trying to locate where his voice comes from, but it seems to come from everywhere. From the hull behind me, from the steps leading to the deck, from every crowded corner.

“Vaguely.”

Footsteps echo across the orlop. We both look toward the far side and fall silent. My heart stops for a beat, then rushes back into motion, pumping blood. When the sound fades, he turns back to me and lowers his voice.

“One more thing. Make sure the Glim doesn’t disappear again.” He glances down, his gaze lingering on my frame. “And ask for a new dress. They have plenty from their last raid, and I think the emerald one would look exquisite on you.”

My brows lift before I can stop them. Is he toying with me? I don’t even acknowledge his attempt to flirt with me. What intrigues me, though, is him mentioning the Glim, the silver light the pirates follow.

“What makes you think I can prevent the Glim from disappearing?”

“The Glim appeared when you set foot on the Noctis,” he says, as if it’s obvious.

I’m about to ask him more about the Glim when the sound of boots returns. I freeze and glance toward the steps, then back, but he’s gone. The space he occupied feels colder now, empty. It’s like he vanished into the shadows.

A lantern sways toward me, light spilling across the floorboards.

“What’s all that noise about?” the pirate in front of me murmurs slowly, as if he just woke up. “Who removed the leather strap?”

I freeze, heartbeat stuttering. I almost mention the ghost I just encountered, but decide against it.

He didn’t want to be caught, and I doubt they would believe me anyway.

“I don’t know. I woke up, and it was gone.” Luckily, lying has never been an issue for me. I do it without hesitation—probably a leftover siren trait.

The pirate sighs and rubs his temple with his other hand, clearly not convinced. His eyes briefly flick toward the chains, then back to me.

“I have to put it back on. The captain won’t like it if someone has disobeyed him.” He places the lantern on the floor outside my cell, the light reflecting in his honey brown eyes. They look kind, I realize, but they also hold pity in them.

“And drink, lass. You don’t look too good.” He adds and clears his throat.

I crawl to the bucket and cup water into my hands, drinking until my throat stops burning. The cool liquid steadies me a little. He unlocks the cell and steps inside, picking up the leather strap from where I slept. His boots creak against the boards as he crouches in front of me.

“Thank you,” I manage, hoping he hears the honesty in my voice. My fingers twitch in my lap. “What’s your name?”

He studies me for a moment, then quickly glances to the side before looking at me again. “Grim.”

He motions for me to turn. I hesitate only a second before obeying. He gathers my hair and places the leather on my tongue, pulling it tight behind my head to make a knot. The uncomfortable feeling makes my eyes water immediately.

I glance back in his direction and take a moment to look at my captor. In the lantern light, I can see his hair is red, and a short beard frames his face. He doesn’t look as young as the cabin boys, and several scars mark his face. He must be in his thirties. His nose is crooked, as if it has been broken many times. But he doesn’t look cruel. He looks like a boy raised by the sea, and the sea is unforgiving.

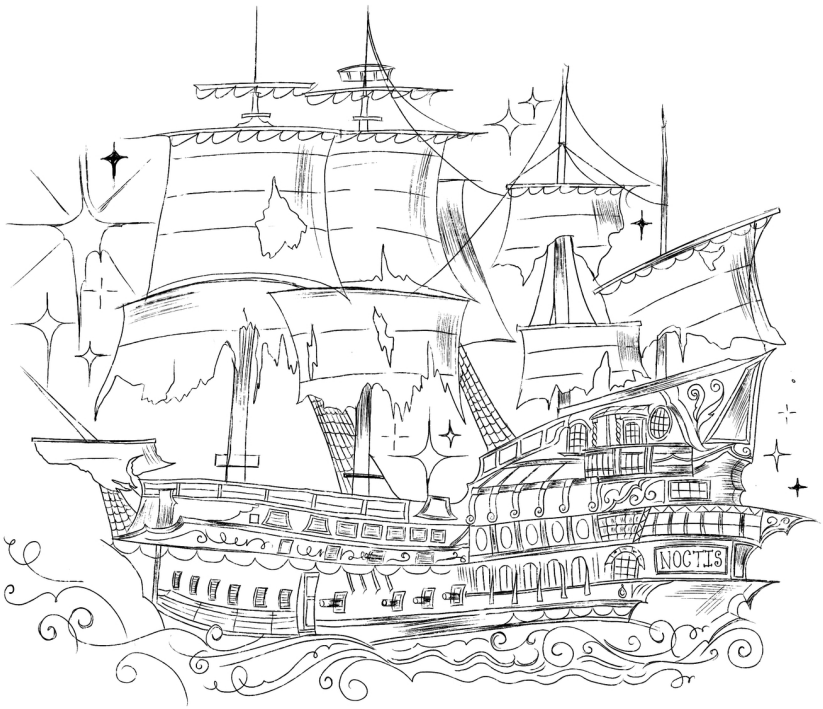
He gets up and steps out, locking the door again. The sound of the key turning echoes through the orlop.

“Oh, and lass,” he adds, turning slightly, “stop talking to yourself in the middle of the night. They’ll think you’re mad.”

He leaves the lantern by the cell and disappears into the dark.

Only then do I realize he never asked for my name. I stay still, staring at the faint glow on the floor. My heart hasn’t quite settled. The air feels too quiet, as if the ship itself is listening.

The ghost does not visit me again.


NOCTIS

Chapter Six

"LADY," A VOICE URGES. I fight to open my heavy eyelids. My whole body aches from sleeping on the hard and uneven floor. Not that I slept much after my encounter with the ghost.

When my vision clears, the cabin boy, Lark, peers through the bars. The night has finally passed, and soft light floods the orlop, giving it a faint golden touch.

The chains bite into my skin as I push up and try to answer him, but the leather strap still muzzles me and instead, spit catches in my throat. His brows draw together, and fear glints behind his wide eyes. The last thing I want is for the young lad to be scared of me. I try to give him a smile, but fail miserably.

"I have breakfast for you." He points to a plate of hardtack, a biscuit made from flour and water, and salt fish, which he must have slipped into my cage while I slept.

Just at the sight of the food, my stomach growls. If I weren't already drooling from the leather between my teeth, I would start now.

"Orders from the captain," he adds quickly. "But I should tell you that it's likely to be your last meal." He stammers. "Unless you, uh…"

I tilt my head at him. Unless I what? Unless I follow his ridiculous orders? Unless I succumb to their every whim as a prisoner? I can think of many reasons as to why this might be my last meal. Every meal has felt like my last meal in this unforgiving life. His feet shift from side to side, his jaw tense, giving away his nervousness. Did he forget? His eyes go wider than

before, his eyes scanning his surroundings as though in search of the answer. So he did forget. And he already knows that asking his captain for the message again will bring consequences for the pirate-in-training.

“Unless you’re good,” he snaps, trying to sound rough by mimicking his captain’s bark. I bet that’s not exactly what the Captain told him. His fingers curl into fists at his sides, though I know he’s bound to be more angry with himself than with me.

“Now eat.”

I point to the strap still in my mouth. He sighs and nods, then jogs up the steep steps to the main deck. Seconds later, he returns with a key in his hand. The crew clearly doesn’t trust him with one after he helped me the first night. The lock clicks before the door to my cell is pushed open. He eyes me carefully, as if I were a dangerous animal about to snap, then steps around me and unties the leather. As it falls off, I groan in relief and work my jaw in all the directions I couldn’t before.

“Do not use your magic on me, witch.”

Lark backs out of the cell and locks the door. He sighs, obviously relieved to be out of my reach. Despite his attempts to act tough, I know he’s frightened, and that doesn’t sit right with me, so I finally manage a small smile.

“Lark, please know that I do not mean any harm to you. I only used my magic as a precaution. I couldn’t risk you shouting for the rest of the crew. And even you must admit that my fear of them is justified, given the situation I’m in now that they’ve caught me.”

Lark glances aside, as if checking whether someone might overhear. He steps closer to the cell again and lowers his voice. “So you really are a witch?”

“Something like that, yes,” I answer with a smile.

“Can you help us, then?” he asks, his voice low, his eyes searching mine as if he already expects the answer to hurt.

“Help…you?” I ask.

Is he talking about that thread of light again, the Glim? He opens his mouth to answer, but Grim comes down the steps from the deck.

“That’s enough, lad, ” he orders. “Go help Saint with the holes in the hold.”

While Lark hurries away, I grab the plate like a wildling and start shoving the food into my mouth. I pay no attention to how I must look. The hardtack

is – well –hard, as expected, but not moldy, which is a pleasant surprise. The fish is surprisingly good. Naturally, I love fish. It was all I ate until my seventh year. My mother insisted, though my father wasn't pleased with it. I don't remember why exactly, but I assume he wanted me to know a life beyond that of a siren. We eat it raw, not cooked as humans prefer, and the head is the most delicious part of all. I swallow the whole thing with hardly any chewing.

Grim chuckles and leans against the bars.

"I will bring you more later. We have plenty. The crew will first eat the fresh food we organized in Cantora."

"Organized?"

"Stole." He answers with a shrug and holds back a smile.

I lift my gaze to meet his hazel eyes.

"Thank you," I murmur, surprised by how weak the words sound.

"We leave the Sea of Crowns in a few days, and we expect heavy currents when passing the Intermaria. I believe the captain wants to speak to you before that. But I must warn you, lass, his mood is foul."

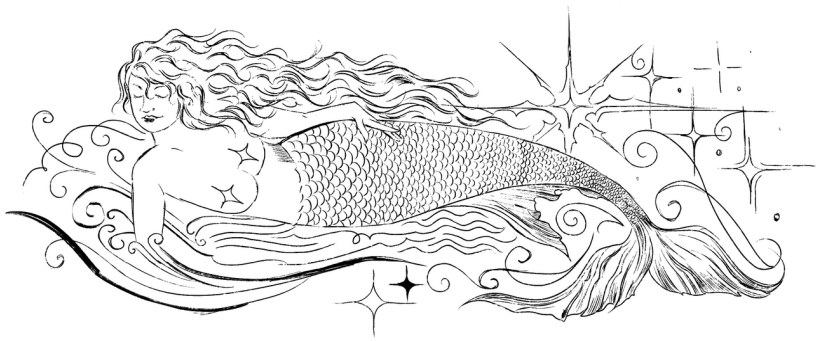
"Is he ever in a good mood?" I challenge him, and regret it in an instant.

He straightens and glares at me as if I've insulted him personally, instead of his captain. For a heartbeat, he seems angry, until his eyes soften. Blinking, he turns his gaze away from me, his posture relaxing. When he meets my eyes again, a faint smile tugs at his mouth. I release a quiet sigh of relief.

"Sometimes, lass. I hope you get to see that someday."

I nod and watch his back as he leaves, then spot the leather strap at my feet. He didn't put it back on. I consider using my hum, but it wouldn't get me far. We are in the middle of the Sea of Crowns, and if he is right and we are near the Intermaria, there's no island in sight.

So I sit and wait, as an obedient prisoner would.



Bored out of my mind, I count the ship’s frames. “Sixty-five,” I murmur as I lie flat on my back. Hours must have passed since Lark brought me the food, and I have resorted to desperate measures to keep myself alert.

“Bored already, little fish?”

Damn it. That’s not the voice I want to hear. His voice. The Captain. Sable. I sit up and turn toward him, standing in front of my moldy cell. My pulse jumps, the air catching in my throat. By the Seas, this man has a talent for scaring me. He wears a black coat, and a tricorn hat sits on his head now, casting his face in shadows. His white linen shirt hangs loose, giving me a glimpse of his broad chest, and I hate the way my breath stumbles at the sight. Charms that look like they’ve been carved out of bone dangle from necklaces layered around his neck. There are dark circles under his eyes, a deep purple, as though he didn’t get much sleep last night. His dark, messy curls rest atop his head like a crown. If he weren’t a pirate or my captor, I might consider him handsome. Unfortunately, he is both. And the sight of him sets me alight with pure ire.

“There is very little to keep a prisoner entertained in this disgusting cell, I’m sure even you understand that.” My voice wavers, but I keep my chin high. “There is no need to keep me caged like an animal. I mean no harm, and I will leave your ship as soon as it is possible to do so.”

I rise slowly to get somewhere near eye level, but he’s still so, so much taller than me, so I tip my head back to look at him and give him my best glare.

“What makes you think we will make for a port again?” he asks, a grin spreading across his face. There it is again, the teasing tone that makes my skin crawl.

I narrow my eyes even more, but he doesn’t look away, not even for a second. Heat creeps up my neck, but I don’t blink first. I can’t resist the challenge flickering in his eyes.

“What makes you think I need a harbor? I will gladly walk the planks once the shore is in sight.”

My response surprises him; his eyes widen for only a heartbeat before he snaps back to the same stern expression.

“I do not negotiate with my captives,” he says. “But you will answer my questions when I bloody ask them.”

He turns to grab a nearby stool and pulls it toward the cell, but instead of sitting immediately, he studies me first, as if something about me does not sit right with him. His gaze traces my white hair, my scales, before lingering on my wounded foot. If he notices the blood-stained makeshift bandage, he does not comment on it. Only then does he lower himself onto the stool, elbows on his knees, fingers loosely clasped. He looks composed, but there is tension in the line of his shoulders that tells me he is not.

“Who cut the mooring line?” he asks, leaning forward slightly.

“I don‘t know what you mean,” I answer with care. If I tell him who cut it, it will only raise even more questions.

His jaw tightens.

“You were on that dock,” he continues. “My ship doesn’t drift free by accident. Someone cut her loose.” His eyes narrow slightly. “I saw you running away from a few men through the window in my cabin.”

Unwanted memories creep into my mind, of their voices, their boots drumming the deck behind me to the rapid beating of my heart.

“I wasn’t with them,” I say, avoiding his stare.

“That‘s not what I asked,” he says as his gaze drifts toward the back of my cell, unfocused for a heartbeat, before snapping back to my face. He stands abruptly, the stool scraping across the planks.

“Who,” he takes a deep breath through his nose, then exhales just as slowly, “were those men?”

Biting my lip, I scramble for a plausible explanation he’d buy, but nothing comes to mind.

“Hunters.”

His gaze sharpens.

“Hunting what exactly?”

My breath catches in my throat. At my hesitation, his mouth curves, as if he already got a hold on the mask of lies I've carefully crafted and only has to rip it off my face whenever he feels like it.

"What are they hunting?" he presses, stepping closer to the bars.

The ship gives a sudden rise and then drops abruptly, and for the first time, he stumbles on his feet. His eyes flick to the side again, to the empty space near the ladder, searching for something.

"They hunt…various things," I say and furrow my brows, searching the spot he is staring at.

"Not a good enough answer," he drawls. He curls his fingers around the iron, as though he needs anchoring.

"You compelled Lark with a humming trick. You have scales scattering that pretty, pale skin of yours. You dare lie to me about being a witch." His voice lowers. "What? You thought I wouldn't notice?"

Anger flickers in his eyes before they darken.

"You're not telling me the truth," he says, his voice tight.

"I can't," I whisper, and even to my own ears it sounds thin.

His mouth presses into a thin line. I can tell he is losing his patience. When he reaches for the lock, I step back, trying to create distance between us. The door opens with a low groan, and he steps inside the cell. My fingers curl at my sides as I measure the space behind me, the wall already too close. There's only one reason for him to open that door, and that is to drag the truth out of me.

"You truly expect me to believe that?" he says and begins circling me in slow, calculated steps. "That you're just some harmless witch with a fondness for scales? Surely you're aware of how ridiculous that sounds."

I don't dare to move. Don't even dare to breathe. Of course, he doesn't believe me. I don't even believe the lie myself. My teeth press into my tongue as I force my mouth to stay shut, even though every instinct in me screams to run, to bare my teeth, to do something.

"You see, my sister is a sea witch," he continues, his words a little quieter now. He stops his pacing behind my back, his presence making me shiver. "So I know a whole damn lot about them, and I know for sure they cannot choose their appearance to their liking. My sister would've chosen beautiful, glistening scales if she could. But instead she's stuck in the form of a living reef."

He continues to circle me.

“So try again,” he says, and comes to a halt.

My heart beats so loudly, I am certain he must hear it, considering how close he is standing in front of me.

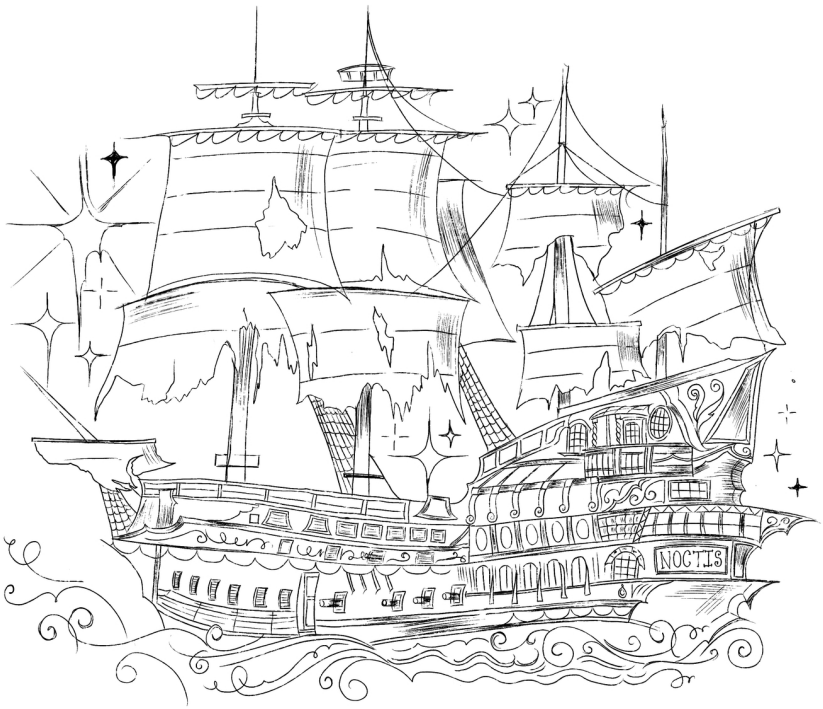
“What are you?” he asks and narrows his eyes until they are almost slits. “The code demands a tribunal. But I do not tolerate liars, and I cannot risk having you on board if I don’t know who or what you are. So I suggest you stop lying to me, if you do not wish me to cut off your tongue and feed it to the fish.”

My breathing grows heavy. A pirate tribunal. My father once told me about those things. A crew member once made a mistake, I was not told what it was, and they all voted to decide his fate. He was abandoned on a little island in the middle of the sea. Grim wasn’t lying when he said the captain isn’t in a good mood. I remember the words of the ghost— that I should tell him the truth. Despite this, I consider lying again, of inventing something else, making something new up to further hide the truth. But I know he would pull away every thread of my lie, until the fabric came apart in his hands.

“I am—“ My throat closes around the word.

He waits and widens his stance, like a man bracing for impact. He already knows what I am. I can see it in the way he watches me with intent, like he’s only waiting for me to confirm. If I say it, there’s no taking back. No pretending. My tongue feels heavy in my mouth, as speaking it out loud might be the moment the ground gives way beneath my feet.

“I am a siren.”


NOCTIS

Chapter Seven

MY CONFESSION IS A mere whisper, but still loud enough for him to hear. A tear slips from the brimming pool of my eye, wetting my cheek.

"At least I think I am," my voice breaks.

Within a heartbeat, he draws a dagger from his belt, yanks my back against his chest, and presses the cold blade to my throat. My whole body goes rigid. My lower lip trembles as I fight back tears. I couldn't coax a hum from my tongue even if I wanted to. Even if I could, it wouldn't be strong enough to soothe him anyway. He is like the storm that thunders above the Sea of Crowns. Destructive and unforgiving.

"Never in my twenty-nine years have I heard of a siren without a tail," he spits into my ear, pressing the dagger as deep as it can go without breaking skin, his arm locking me in place like a cage.

"I am telling the truth," I breathe, knees shaking. As stupid as I may be for admitting my secret to him, only a fool would tell a pirate they are a siren without actually being one. Even he must recognize that through his anger.

He goes still, weighing whether he should believe me or not. Then, ever so slowly, he lifts the dagger.

"So my nickname for you is not so wrong after all, little fish," he finally says, and lets the tip of the dagger travel down the side of my throat, until it slides over the scales covering my collarbone.

“I bet you know that such scales are worth a heavy penny?” he says into my ear. “Maybe I should count these up and see if it’s worth my while to cut them from your flesh.”

He gathers my hair and pulls it over my shoulder, as if to check for more scales on the other side, and I hate the way my body reacts to the closeness, a shiver running through me in response. Salt and spice slings to him, as if he carries the sea with him, whether it wants him or not. He lingers there, his breath brushing faintly against my neck, and I curl my fingers into fists, forcing myself not to react.

Both of us jump out of our skin as the hatch above slams open, cracking through the thick silence. Light bursts into the orlop.

“Sable.” Grim’s voice cuts through between us.

Sable’s body goes rigid behind me, and my mind goes blank. I count the time that passes with my heartbeat. One. Two. Three. Four. Finally, his grip slackens, and he lowers the knife. My knees buckle as air rushes back into my lungs, and he holds me upright with a trembling hand against my waist. I continue to pull in air in desperation, as I do after breaking through the surface of the waves after my failed attempts to shift.

I stumble forward, creating distance between us. When I turn back, he is already looking at Grim, anger twitching the muscles in his cheeks.

“She is a siren,” he says. His voice is steady, but it lacks the bite it had before. “Though a broken one, it seems.”

Broken. The word bites at me like salt in an open wound. I watch him carefully, like prey anticipating its predator’s strike. He pulls a key from the pocket of his breeches and crouches in front of me to unlock the shackles around my ankles. The cuffs spring free as he glances up at me, the anger vanishing from his features.

I furrow my brows at him, trying to understand what has sparked the sudden change of heart, but come up blank. I don’t know what inner demons he fights, but that’s no excuse for threatening me. When he straightens and walks out of the cell, he avoids my gaze.

"That explains a lot," Grim says, eyeing me up carefully. I do not like the way he looks at me now, like I am a risk to be evaluated with the utmost care and precision. Pressing his lips into a thin line, his harsher stare lingers on my legs.

"But it also raises many more questions." His eyes find mine again, and I hold his gaze, bracing myself for the one I know is coming– why I have

legs instead of a tail, one I cannot really answer. I force myself to stay still under his gaze, even as everything in me strains to look away. If I give him even an inch of fear, he'll take it. Finally, Grim breaks the tension and looks at his captain.

"What are the orders, Cap?"

Sable rubs a hand across his mouth, thinking, still avoiding my gaze.

"Take her below the quarterdeck," he says at last. "She's injured. She cannot remain here if the sea breaks through the hull. She'll lose too much."

He turns and climbs the ladder without so much as another word. Grim exhales through his nose and gestures for me to step out.

"You'll have to see the bonesetter," he says. "You're bleeding, and the ship isn't fully patched. Do you really want to be in here if the water comes flooding in, taking memory after memory until there is nothing left to give?"

I clench my jaw so tightly that I fear my teeth will splinter under the pressure. I am stubborn, and sometimes I make poorly thought-out decisions. I can admit as much, given the situation I am in. I wonder if this is some kind of trick, and why they would care if I lose my memory. Trick or not, I need to see a mender, so I decide to accept the small mercy offered to me and walk out of the cell on unsteady feet.

Grim helps me up the stairs and onto the main deck, as the handcuffs still bind me. The bright blue of the cloudless sky blinds me, and I squint against it, trying to adjust my eyes. The sails flap lazily as they catch the wind, wood creaking as ropes are pulled tight. The sharp fragrance of salt floods the air.

I don't think word has spread about my siren identity yet, judging by the curious, but not fearful, glances of the crew. At the corner of the main deck, Lark scrubs the planks with a holystone, and I give him a slow smile. It seems the boy got his punishment for forgetting his message for me. As usual, his eyes widen for a heartbeat, but to my surprise, he gives me a shy smile in return. I cross his name off my list of people seeking revenge.

"Come on, we don't have much time. This way." He points to the stern of the deck, and I limp awkwardly in front of him, each step sending a fresh wave of pain up my leg. We enter the heavy door to the quarterdeck and move down a narrow hallway. Rooms line both sides, I count six dark doors. At the end, a wooden door decorated with stained glass comes into view. It must lead to the captain's quarters. Grim walks me down the

hallway and fishes a key from his breeches as we stop at the last room on the right. He makes quick work of my handcuffs and removes them without another word.

Grim leans over to push open the door to a small, dimly lit room. The sharp smell of rum and herbs fills my nose, and I recognize the smell instantly. One of the few things I remember vividly from the short time I spent on my father's ship was that one time when I climbed the rigging and fell, spraining my ankle. My father took me to the bonesetter, and the room smelled just like this one. He is called "surgeon" on most ships. He sets bones, tends wounds, and performs amputations if necessary. Luckily, my ankle just needed a bandage.

An older man sits at a large wooden table, and from the stains of red in the grain, I can tell what it's used for. The wall is covered with built-in shelves and makeshift racks that hold jars and bottles. Iron tools hang from nails, and by the Seas, I hope none of them will ever be used on me.

My eyes wander back to the pirate, who is now looking at me. He furrows his gray brows. His skin looks leathered and worn, probably from spending countless years at sea in foul weather. His eyes look tired but hold wisdom and warmth. He does not frighten me nearly as much as most men, and the coiling dread in my stomach eases at the thought.

"Mm," he says at last, breaking the tension. "Come sit here, lass. Let me see what I'm working with."

When I don't move, Grim taps my back and gently shoves me toward the surgeon. The door closes behind me with a drawn-out squeak. I sit on the wooden table as I was asked.

"The captain already suspected you were a daughter of the sea, but he wanted to hear it from you. Though he isn't quite himself today and—"

"I don't want to hear it," I interrupt. My voice comes out louder than I intended. "I'm sorry. It's just that I don't think his behavior can be excused, sir."

A smile tugs at his lips. "I haven't been called sir in a very, very long time. You can call me Harrow."

I give him a wry smile and fidget with the hem of my gown while my feet dangle off the table.

"Eryse."

"Eryse. An unusual name for a siren, don't you think?" He tilts his head and waits for a reaction, but when I give him none, he gets to work. When

he lifts my foot to inspect it, he doesn’t even grimace, only lifts one gray eyebrow. He has probably seen much worse.

“How did this happen?”

“A nail,” I say simply. “When I was hiding in the hold. I wasn’t careful enough.”

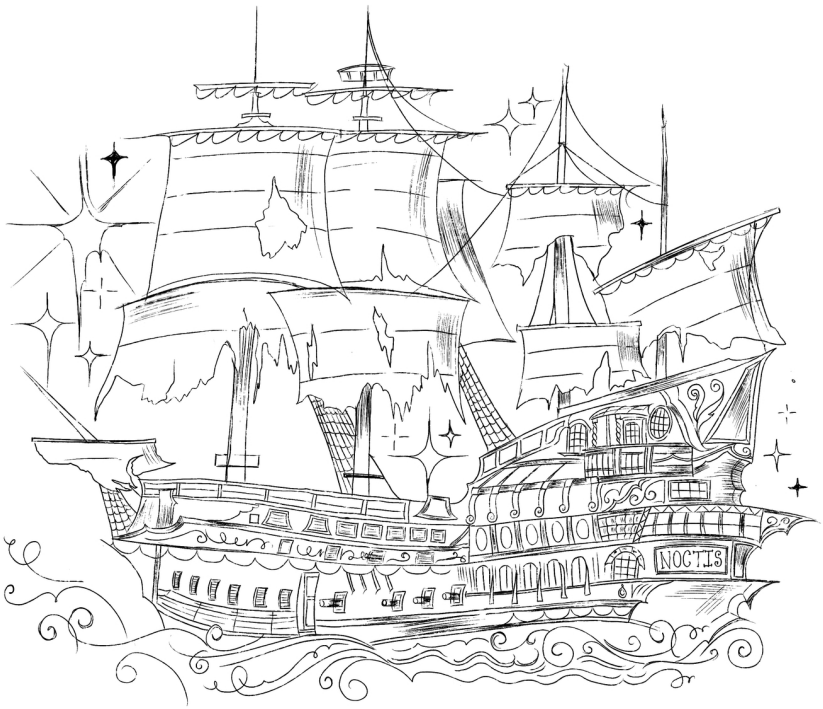
He uses a cloth and water to clean my wound, then flushes it with rum and seals it with a sticky substance that smells like tar and honey.

“We must clean and change this daily to avoid infection,” he explains, and I haven’t felt this taken care of in a long time.

He gives me some privacy to wash with the remaining water, the door squeaking again as he leaves the room. I reach for my dirty gown, but a knock at the door stops me. It seems surprising to me that pirates would engage in something as civilized and considerate as knocking. Confused, I pad over to the door and press my ear against the wood, trying to figure out who’s on the other side. Hesitating, I open the door just enough to peek through. No one’s there.

Something pulls my gaze downward. Neatly folded at my feet lies the most beautiful dress I have ever seen.

The fabric is a deep emerald.


NOCTIS

Chapter Eight

I FURROW MY BROWS, GLANCING down the hallway again, making sure no one is watching me. The way the dress is folded makes it seem like it was placed for me to take. With shaking hands, I reach for it and take it. A smile tugs at my lips as I close the door and hold the gown against my body, staring down at it in awe. The deep emerald leaves little room for doubt. The ghost told me it would suit me. It cannot be a coincidence, no, it must be from him.

I do not care how foolish I may look, that something as simple as a pretty gown can make me smile despite the fact that I am being held captive. It feels like one small defiance against my situation, that I can choose to find a small spark of happiness in the mysterious offering of a dress. That I will not crack no matter how much pressure is placed upon me.

I relish the feeling of the fabric as it glides over my body, pulling it up and tugging the strings of the corset as tight as I can on my own. I run a hand over the material, smooth and shining, and I cannot help but liken it to my mother's scales. The way it seems to shift from darkness to a rich emerald when I move, how it echoes the way her onyx scales would turn that same deep shade of green when the sun hits it right. The kind of green that hides in shadows and glows only when you're close enough to see it.

The bodice clings perfectly to my frame, scattered with dark stones, each one glinting in the light like stars at midnight. The soft off-shoulder sleeves cascade down my arms, showing skin without revealing too much. The skirt

flows in long, smooth lines of satin, the fabric pooling at the ground in a way that feels effortless, as if it were meant to move freely with the wind.

The door squeaks again as Harrow enters.

“Well, I dare say you look much better, lass.” A warm smile spreads across his face, and it is only now that I notice a couple of golden teeth.

I nod and try to return the smile. “I do feel better. It seems you have a very generous ghost lurking amongst you.”

The old man’s smile fades as soon as he hears the word ghost, and he quickly shakes his head.

“Better not to talk to any of them, Eryse. That only keeps them from where they should be,” he says in a lowered, more serious voice.

I shoot him a quizzical look and cross my arms behind my back.

“And where should they be?”

“At peace. Talking to them and recognizing them as actual beings makes them restless.”

I inhale in preparation for my next question, but before I can ask it, someone standing in the doorframe clears his throat. I glance behind Harrow to find Grim standing there, with his arms crossed over his wide chest.

“Enough ghost stories, old man,” he commands, and I sigh in disappointment. Of course, he would show up when things just got interesting. I roll my eyes at him, my first hint of attitude toward these men. The only reaction I get from him is a slightly raised brow and a clenched jaw. “Aye, right you are, Grim. Don’t want to scare you, lass,” Harrow says as he walks past me into the room. He is not too steady on his feet, I realize, his steps a little uneven as he passes.

Grim holds my cuffs in his hands, clearly intending to put them back on, but I don’t want to leave before thanking Harrow again, so I turn toward him once more.

“Thank you for stitching me up.”

He laughs at that, a deep, honest laugh that deepens the lines in his face. “That’s what I’m here for, Eryse.”

I lay my wrists in the openings of the cuffs, not wanting to anger him, and Grim locks them instantly. I catch him quickly glancing down at my gown with a deep frown, but he doesn’t comment on it. He gives the cuffs a quick tug before leading me down the hallway. Doors line both sides, until the corridor narrows toward a single door at the end– the captain’s quarters.

Just before we reach it, a nook cuts into the wall on the right, sealed off with iron bars. Lanterns are lit inside it, far too many for the narrow space. Grim stops pulling me as soon as we are in front of it. There are multiple hissed voices coming from inside the cabin of the captain, one of them Sable’s, his tone as serious and commanding as ever. The other voices I don’t recognize, but many insults are being thrown about. They seem to be arguing.

With my brows furrowed, I glance back at the cell. I relax my tired body in relief as I spot the cot in the corner of the cell. My heart stumbles as I take in the iron bars, bolted into the ship to hold the captive in there. To hold me there. At this moment, I crave the sea. The feeling of being underwater, the coarseness of it on my skin, the salt of it on my tongue. The freedom of a wide, open sea. But the pain and exhaustion prevail over that want, for the need of rest. If it granted me the chance to sleep, I would gladly walk into that cell right now. The thought makes me question why I haven’t been thrown in there already. Confusion twisting on my face, I glance over my shoulder to look at the brooding pirate standing behind me. He studies me for a few seconds, contemplation glistening in his eyes.

Grim steps around me, blocking my view of the cell. “Do you know something about this intermaria? About how to make it safely through?”

“Why? Don’t tell me you suddenly need my help.” I raise my brow at him and try to keep my mocking tone low. Not too low, however. Grim has been kind to me, unlike his captain, but I must not forget that I am still his captive. “You don't know how to make it through, do you?”

He crosses his arms over his chest and widens his stance in defense. “We have sailed through other intermarias before. But not this one. Every sailor knows the route can be deadly.”

While I have never swum in the intermaria that separates the Sea of Crowns and the Sea of Renewal myself, I do know how to make it through. While humans learn how to walk, how to avoid falling by holding on to something for support, sirens learn how to swim using the current.

A smile tugs at my lips. I have just been given something I can bargain with.

“I do know how to make it through. And I will help you. But….” I start carefully, putting my head back to look at him properly.

Grim raises a brow at me in a silent challenge, seemingly teasing me for having the audacity to open negotiations. The way he shakes his head tells

me what’s coming.

“… I want better treatment. A pillow, a blanket, food, water—”

“Don’t push your luck, lass,” he says through gritted teeth, but I continue nonetheless.

“I want to be allowed to use the privy in privacy, no chains in my cell, and for that matter, I shouldn't even be kept in a cell at—”

“Careful,” he says in a warning tone and takes one step forward, crowding me against the iron bars of the cell.

I swallow hard, a knot starting to form in my stomach. I might be pushing my luck here, but if I’m lucky, my plan will work out.

“…and I get your vote in the tribunal.”

His mouth opens once, then closes again. Silence stretches between us as he turns my last request over in his mind, the muscles in his face taut, his eyelid twitching. “Who told you about the tribunal?”

“The Captain,” I say, feigning indifference. I let my back rest against the iron bars, trying to act nonchalant. If he looked at me closely, he’d see the quickening of my breath and the unsteadiness of my legs.

Grim finally looks away and sighs before finding my eyes again. “You cannot buy my vote. The tribunal is part of the code, and we live by the code. But if you prove useful in getting us through the intermaria, I will consider giving you my vote as thanks.”

I exhale sharply before straightening my posture, making the metal of the cuffs clink. I narrow my gaze on him. “You know that’s not enough for me.”

“It must be enough,” he snarls and jabs a finger at my chest. “You are not in a position to demand anything from me. If you don’t help us, you will only drown as we will, considering your very human legs. Do not test the limits of my generosity, siren.”

My breathing grows heavy at the threat, the knot in my stomach binding further into a mess that will take forever to untwist. I, of course, knew that he wasn’t a friend, but I hadn’t thought he was fully an enemy either. By the way he looks at me now, I realize how foolish I have been to expect anything more from a pirate, let alone that I could convince him to speak in my favor.

“Fine. Then consider voting for me, Grim. But I demand better treatment. I am a woman. I will not sacrifice my dignity and pee in a bucket.” My chin

is held high, clearly stating my insistence. I will not soon back down. He'll see.

He lowers his finger and steps away, giving me more space. He lets out an elongated breath, followed by a slow nod. "I'll see what I can do. After we pass the intermaria."

"Fine." I glare at him. If I could cross my arms, I would. Deep down, I know the solidity of our bargain. I can get us through the intermaria, and he will be forced to give me what I am owed.

Another nod from him. "Fine. We have a deal."

Without another word, he opens the heavy-looking door to the captain's cabin and pushes me forward. The sudden movement makes me stumble into the room, but I am able to prevent myself from falling by widening my stance, the chains from my cuffs clinking by my sides. Two pairs of angry eyes land on me, their discussion cut short by my unexpected entrance. The room is larger than I expected. A broad wooden desk sits in the center, its surface scratched and used, while a narrower table stands before the fogged-up window, scattered with letters held in place by a dagger driven through the wood. To the left, there's a shelf crammed with worn books, chests stacked beside it as if there is never enough space to hold everything this man owns. On the opposite side, a massive bed is bolted to the wall, his dark coat thrown carelessly across it.

"What is that wench doing in the captain's cabin?" the other pirate to Sable's left spits, and I recognize him as the thick-necked one who brought me into the hold. Rat. I try not to roll my eyes at him.

"She can help us to pass the intermaria. She's done it before, so she can do it again," Grim argues in my favor, and I nod in agreement with him. Proving my usefulness and worth is crucial if I want to make it out of here alive.

"I know the sea." The words come out of me in a low voice, sadness flooding through me as they leave my tongue. While I know the sea, the sea sometimes doesn't seem to know me. Without wanting to, without even knowing why I do it, I look to Sable. Whether a plea for mercy, for compassion, I cannot tell. Sable's eyes find mine. And for whatever reason, he looks at me like he understands my sorrow. My breath catches in my chest.

Averting his eyes, he clears his throat and points to a map that is pinned to the desk. "We will reach the intermaria in about ten days. According to

the map, it stretches around 130 leagues, though the worst maelstroms will be in the center.”

Grim pushes me forward again until I am standing in front of the worn table. Two open bottles of liquor sit above the map, with a tiny ship carved out of wood resting between them.

I follow the fingers of the captain, as they trail from the Sea of Crowns to the Sea of Renewal and then tap on the area between them, indicating it to be the intermaria.

I sigh and lean forward slightly to get a better look at it. While he is right about the dangers of the intermaria, he misunderstands the concept of it.

“The intermaria is never in the same place. The seas do not stay within the lines of a map just because that is how they’ve been painted by a man. We could reach it in one day, or in ten. There’s no way to be certain.”

“If you think you can give us any lessons on how to read a map, then get back into your cell, girl,” the Rat snaps. His captain lifts one hand, silencing him. Then he gives me a short nod so that I can continue, a smile tugging at his lips. There are no signs of the man who threatened me with a dagger in his face, no darkness clouding his eyes. It’s as though it's an entirely different version of the Captain that stares at me now with expectation. A softer version. Less severe.

“The whirl does not spin forever. It pauses for breath. It rests. Where the foam stops curling tight, and the fast water meets the slow, that’s where we sail. And then gain speed to cut across.” I take the beautifully carved ship into my hands and move it along the lines of a drawn maelstrom, following the edges of it, then place it down, struggling a little as the chains hanging from my arms catch on the table’s splintered edge. The clinking metal is a heavy, inconvenient reminder of my place on this ship, that what I am currently doing might be considered overstepping.

“It is risky,” Grim points out, and stares at the map as if the solution to the risk lies between the dried ink. His sudden presence at my side startles me. “If the sails catch the wrong wind and we fall off the edge, even the sea wouldn’t be able to help us.”

“Nor would it venture to,” I stare into the whirling ink, near hypnotized. “The sea doesn’t want to help you. It wants you very, very dead.”

“Aye,” Sable says, our eyes meeting once again, though this time I successfully hold back the urge to glare at him. I give him a look that tells him I haven’t forgotten the knife he pressed against my throat.

He swallows and turns toward Rat. “Is the Glim still following the same route?”

“Aye, Cap’n. Nightglass has an eye on it. But it is fainter.” Amber eyes find mine, and I turn toward him, raising one brow in challenge, daring him to speak his mind. “Perhaps the filthy witch is manipulating it.”

I make a step forward with a hiss, ready to throw myself at him, but Grim is quicker, holding me back by a fistful of my skirts. Slightly embarrassed by my sudden lapse in composure, I calm myself with steady breaths and smooth out my dress with a gentle hand.

Sable clears his throat and I return my attention to him, as the pirates do. I expect him to comment on my outburst, but he doesn’t. Instead, he straightens and puts his hands behind his back, a move he seems to make whenever he’s about to bark commands.

“When it disappears again, tell me immediately. We must sail toward the intermaria unless the Glim decides to show us a different route. I don’t want to see a single wounded man on deck tonight. That is an order,” He plucks the wooden ship from the table, throws it up in the air once, and then catches it. He brushes his thumb over the tiny ship's carved sails. “The Noctis will not go down.”

“And if it does, we shall drown with it,” Grim and Rat say in unison, as though this is a mantra they have repeated time and time again. The sound of it makes my skin crawl. These men must have been sailing together for a long time. Rat pushes himself to his feet, his chair scraping against the floor, and storms out of the cabin. The door slams behind him.

My gown sweeps over the boards of the cabin as I make my way around the table to Sable. Grim is not holding me back, but by the creaking of the wood, I know he tails me in anticipation of another outburst. He turns his body to face me as I reach his side. Face expressionless. Standing in front of the Captain of the Noctis, I clear my throat.

“You cannot read the water properly without me. I must be on deck.”

Sable carefully sets the ship back on the table before looking at me. “You will be out on that deck with me when the time is right, little fish. I cannot risk you losing a memory until the tribunal.”

Taking a deep breath, I try to steady my rising temper and contain the siren clawing at my insides. I clench my fist at my side.

“My. Name. Is. Eryse.”

“Hmm.” His eyes scan my body, from my bare feet to the scooping neckline of my dress, to the scales that litter the skin of my collarbones. He tilts his head, as though debating from looking at me whether my name fits me or not. Or whether it's even worth remembering at all. He smirks.“ Nope, Little Fish suits you well enough.”

I snap forward and bare my teeth at him, hissing and aiming for his throat. The siren in me wants to see blood – to taste it –and she wants it now. Another pull on my dress yanks me backward. Sable doesn’t even blink. He just looks at me, unfazed, amusement tugging at his features. “I think I must correct myself. It is a *feisty* little fish.”

My skin heats, and I see red. Blood red.

“Fuck you!” I spit out, anger coursing through me in harsh waves. Grim chuckling behind me only makes it worse.

“I will bring her into her cell until we reach the intermaria, Cap’n.” Another tug pulls my back flat against his chest.

Sable nods and closes the gap between us in one heavy-booted step. I raise my chin in a silent challenge, my breathing heavy and growing more and more laborious as my anger gives way to fear. I grow dizzy with the lack of oxygen as my siren-fogged brain comes to the realization that I am very much wedged between two pirates. And I essentially just told them to go fuck themselves.

“Careful, little fish. My goodwill is not to be taken for granted.”

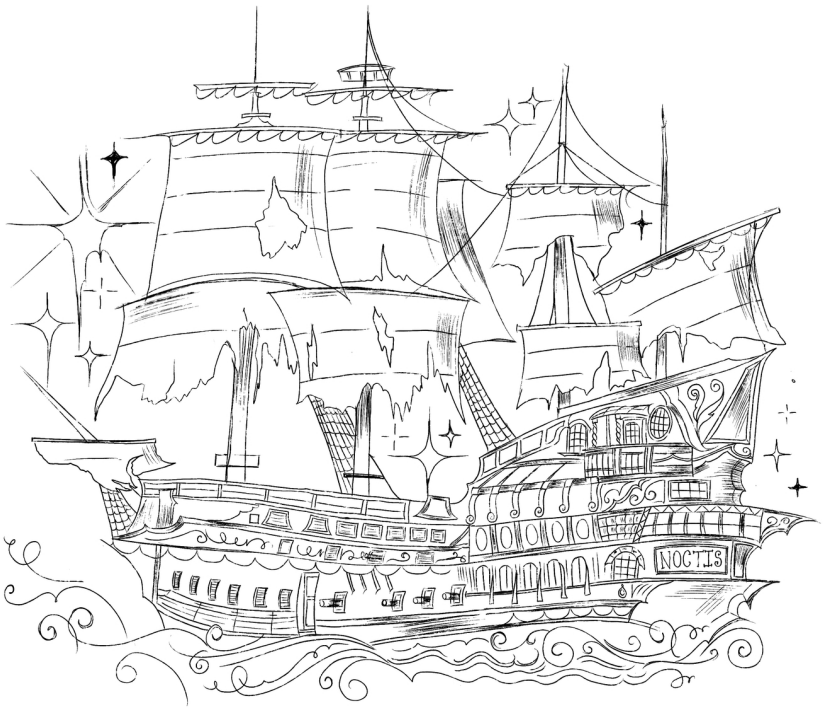
Holding his stare, I plant my feet on the ground and ignore the blood that continues to rush into my head. Sable’s eyes shift from a light, foggy gray to a black as dark as ink. The light behind him seems to flicker, but I do not break my gaze from him as Grim slowly pulls me away, until I have no choice but to turn to avoid stumbling backwards.

He does not let up on his shoving until I am out of the cabin and on the other side of the cell door. I lower myself onto the cot as the lock clicks shut. If Grim says something before he leaves, I do not hear it.

My thoughts are spiraling, thinking about the consequences of my bargain. If I am right, the crew might show mercy at the tribunal. If I am wrong, well, we are all doomed anyway. At least Sable seems to recognize that I am their only hope to make it through the intermaria. Something about him is otherworldly. The color of his eyes, how he gives nothing away. He reminds me of the sea, and how flat and black it can look from above. From a distance. Yet, there beneath that quiet surface, whole forests

of kelp sway, currents cross and collide, and creatures with teeth like knives glide unseen. He is dark. Clouded. His morality murky, his temper short.

And yet, I believe he is made of such depths.


NOCTIS

Chapter Nine

THE SCREAMS COMING FROM the deck shake me to the core. We have reached the intermaria much quicker than estimated, as only a few days have passed since Grim locked me in my cell. Everything between then and now is a blur of eating and sleeping and staring at the ceiling. My thoughts have been restless about Sable and the approaching tribunal. How I must hold up my end of the bargain, and how Sable seems unwilling to let me be free to do so. How my fate lies in the hands of pirates. By the seas, my chances of leaving this ship are narrowing with every thought. My tiredness slips from me as soon as Lark comes rushing to my cell, dripping wet, the cursed water sticking his clothes to his body.

My feet carry me to the bars of the cell as though with a mind of their own, and I wrap my hands around the iron. My heart pounds as I eagerly wait for him to speak. Usually, he approaches me with the kind of daring confidence only a child can have. But not today. He tries to get the keys out of the pocket of his breeches, but his shaking hands won't seem to let him pull them free.

"Lark." My gaze meets his, pure panic writhing across his face.

"The maelstroms. They are…." he drifts off, swallowing, fidgeting with the fabric of his trousers. More shouts erupt from the deck. Sable's voice carries through them all, trying to calm the crew.

"Look at me. Breathe, slowly." I instruct him, drawing in a slow breath. He mirrors it, taking one long inhale.

“Now, try to take out the keys again. Everything’s fine.” I say, my voice sure and steady. “We’ll be fine, Lark. I promise.”

He glances at me before reaching into his pocket, his hands still shaking as he pulls the key free.

“Good,” I reassure him, “Now unlock the door. Just focus on that.”

The keys rattle against the lock as his fingers fumble, refusing to steady. A frustrated grunt escapes him, and his eyes begin to shine.

“It’s okay,” I press my lips together, forcing myself to think. I could hum for him, but I don’t want to take away his will again. He asked me not to use my power on him again, and I will not betray his trust. “Take another breath and try again. You can do this. You’re a pirate, aye? A pirate never gives up.”

His gaze snaps back to mine, and I offer him an encouraging smile. He hesitates, then nods, his throat bobbing as he swallows. This time, his hands are steady enough to guide the key into the lock. The door clicks open, and he moves on to my cuffs, releasing me. I rub the sore point on my wrists where the cuffs have bit into my skin to ease the pain. I hope that Lark has not lost too much. A few drops of the cursed water will not do any harm, but it looks like an entire wave has crashed over him, and that is sure to have cost him a memory. I curse the crew for sending the poor boy out there in the first place.

“Stay under deck, Lark. It is not safe out there.”

A quick nod is all I need for confirmation before I run down the small hallway in the quarterdeck. The door slams against the wall as I stumble out into the open air, wind tearing at my hair, salt stinging in my eyes.

The two seas collide in a violent embrace. One dark blue, the other shimmering pale and ghostlike, the water where they meet twisting into spirals wide enough to swallow a full fleet of ships. The Sea of Renewal glows faintly, and it pulls at my chest already, whispering promises of mending me. The Sea of Crowns fights back against its force, and the waves of the two seas clash against each other like swords.

There is no doubting it. We have entered the intermaria.

Above me, on the raised quarterdeck, Sable stands at the helm, feet planted wide as the ship heaves beneath him. His shirt clings to him, soaked through, his hair plastered to his brow. One hand grips the wheel, the other raised as he shouts orders into the chaos.

“Grim, hold her steady! Tie down the foremast! Bosun, the sails now!”

Grim is already there, braced against the helm beside him, muscles straining as the ship lurches. His eyes are narrowed slits of determination as the wheel continues to jerk. The ship drifts to the right, closer to the first maelstrom awaiting us. The Bosun scrambles up the rigging, a knife between his teeth, before cutting loose a tangled rope, before the sail can tear itself apart.

Another wave surges over the gunwale. It hits me like a wall and steals the breath from my lungs, the familiar cold drilling into my bones. Sable shouts, but it's too late. The deck tilts, and I go with it, sliding, then catching myself on a cleat. Between my hands, the water sheens bright with the light of Renewal inside it. It searches for hurt, for anything to mend, as though it is as curious as a living thing. I pull back with a hiss and whisper a plea to the sea. Please don't take any more from me; you already took too much.

I haul myself upright, salt burning in my eyes, and force a breath into my chest. Beneath the next wave, the Sea of Renewal gleams like molten glass, its glow curling around the Noctis in ribbons of silver.

The ship groans, her timbers crying out in protest.

"By the seas," I say. "She'll be torn apart."

Sable's eyes find mine through the chaos, his storm-gray eyes meeting mine. There's no sign of fear in him. Only an impossible, reckless determination that could make the seas themselves obey him. If the seas obeyed anyone, that is.

"Not while I breathe," he shouts over the crashing of waves, and the ship dives towards the maelstrom.

Brave, I think to myself, and remember how my mother constantly whispered that word into my ear. She could sing a song that would calm the waters and create a passage through the impossibly strong current. My mother may not be here, but I am. And I'll be damned if I die on a bloody pirate ship.

So I curl my hands into a fist and make my way up to the helm. Five massive maelstroms are spreading out in front of us, and by the looks of it, the crew is trying to navigate through them, completely ignoring my advice. Stubborn, reckless pirates.

"You have to follow the edge of it! Look, where the waves break." I point at it, and Grim and Sable exchange a look, still clinging onto the wheel for dear life.

“The currents are too strong. We can barely hold the ship as it is!”

“You will *lose* the ship if you try to bypass them, Captain!” I shout right back at him, every muscle in my body tense. “Trust me. You have to sail along the edges and follow the current instead of fighting against it.”

“You haven’t earned my trust.” He spits, and for a brief moment, it feels like he stares directly into my soul before he focuses on the dangers ahead of us again.

“Sable. Look.” Grim points toward the sea ahead of us. In that exact moment, the sails catch a strong wind, and he loses his grip on the wheel. It spins and spins as if it has a mind of its own, hitting Grim in the stomach. He crashes to the floor. I hear shouting, cursing –and for the first time– panic, in their voices.

The ship makes an abrupt turn. I grab the nearest rail to avoid tripping and falling overboard. A quick glance at the sea makes my heart almost fall out of my ass. No. Please let my eyes be deceiving me. Someone tell me we’re not sailing directly into one of the giant mouths of the sea. The thunder roaring above us now feels like the sea celebrating its victory. Not yet. I am not ready to die. I have things I must do first.

But the captain doesn’t hesitate. He grabs the wheel and yanks it in the other direction with unbelievable force. Where he finds that strength, I do not know. But the ship obeys and batters against the waves to follow a new course.

Then I see it. The familiar thread of silver trailing its way through the cursed water. Because of the foam and the waves, it’s barely visible. But I see it anyway, and I know that Grim and Sable see it too.

“The Glim,” I murmur, more to myself than to Sable, but he hears me anyway. My chest tightens, and my hands grip the railing a little tighter. I don’t know exactly what the Glim is, but the magic radiating from it is like the waves hitting the Noctis in an unsteady rhythm. Powerful and unyielding.

“Aye.” Grunting, Sable tries to keep the ship steady. Determination is written all over his face, but so is the pain of giving everything to his ship and his crew twisting at his features. His muscles must be completely torn at this point. I know mine are.

“I got you.” His first mate pulls himself up again and grabs the wheel, supporting the captain by using his body weight. They exchange looks, then nod.

“Nightglass!” Sable shouts to the man above in the crow’s nest. He immediately turns to look in his direction.

“You see the Glim? Do not lose track of it.”

The command is accepted with a sharp nod. I know for certain that we will not lose track of it now. Nightglass locks in and focuses completely on the water below.

“All hands! This will be rough, but we’ve seen worse! We follow the bloody Glim, my ship will not go under!”

“Aye!” the crew shouts back in unison, and they start working faster at his command. Most of the men are dripping wet. The cursed water clings to their bodies as if it doesn’t want to let them go. Tonight will be rough. I know exactly how it feels to lose a memory and not know what has been taken from you. The violation of it still presses down on me.

“Eryse.” I turn my head over my shoulder to look at Sable, my name sounding foreign in his mouth. Like an ancient warning I am yet to heed. He gives me a wry look that makes me leave my spot at the railing and walk toward him on unsteady feet.

“It follows the edges of the maelstrom. If you are right about this, you’re sleeping in a cabin tonight.” A smile tugs at his lips, but I don’t return the favor. Not when he only found value in my input when the Glim appeared to back it up. Another pair of eyes lands on me. Grim raises one brow and tilts his head slightly, as if to tell me: See, he has his good moments.

“I am right,” I say while turning toward the open sea ahead of us, curling my hands into the fabric of my dress. We have passed two of the maelstroms already by following the edges of it. My plan is working. I am going to have the best sleep of my life tonight. Before I let myself indulge in the thought of a proper bed, the ship must turn again to follow the current of the next whirl. Sable barks commands, and moments later, the ship lifts and drops harshly, crushes through the waves, and gets back on track. The moment the current is in our favor again, we gain speed. So much speed that the wind picks up and makes my hair whip across my face. I don’t mind the sting of it on my skin. It is refreshing to feel something so familiar after being locked away in this ship.

The fourth maelstrom ahead of us looms closer and closer. We have to leave this whirl now and aim for the next one, or the sea will swallow us whole. I’m about to shout, but Sable already maneuvers the ship to cut across the current.

“That’s it, lads!” he roars with no fear in his voice, “full bore and into the abyss!”

The Noctis groans and tilts, first abruptly to the left, then to the right. I clamp both hands around one of the nearest masts, so I don’t slide across the deck again.

Then the world goes numb.

Water–so much water– crashes down on me. I hold on to the mast for dear life. I cannot afford to slip even slightly. The rushing in my ears is so loud I can’t hear anything else. No shouts. No heartbeat. Nothing.

It goes as quickly as it came. A wave crashed over me.

When my surroundings come back into focus, the ship is steady beneath my feet. We must’ve already cleared the maelstrom. I double over, coughing up pure water, clamping my hands over my ribcage. There it is again, the burning in my lungs that reminds me of how broken I am.

Wait.

My muscles tense as realization washes over me. Besides the discomfort in my lungs. I don’t feel any pain. Anywhere. Not from the wound, not from my foot. The sea healed me, and I have no idea what memory it took in return. I swallow down the knot forming in my throat, along with the tears that sting in my eyes more than any salted water could. I must not dwell on it. There is no use in mourning what I do not know I’ve lost.

I piece myself back together, like I always do. My knees shake beneath me, but I get back up and face the captain. Storm-gray eyes meet mine, and that glint of sorrow in them is there again. Swirled with the murkiness of pity too this time. I will not stand for it. Not after he was so quick to dismiss my efforts to help them make safe passage back in the cabin.

“I will go check on the boy you let wander the deck,” I say, my voice a knife’s edge. If looks could kill, he’d certainly be a dead man now. “Someone needs to check if he remembers anything at all, considering he was soaked to the bone.” Lark is too young, too innocent to be out here in such a storm. If he were wounded, it’s too late anyway, as it is too late for me. But maybe I can give him a little comfort. The seas know he’ll be in desperate need of it.

“Lark made the decision on his own.” He imparts through gritted teeth. And that is all he seems willing to say. He waves a hand as if to dismiss me. Pirates and their ridiculous traditions. Lark is not old enough to understand the consequences of his actions. Surely they can go against his decisions

when they are life-threatening. Surely no one wants that boy's death on their hands.

Cursing, I make my way back to the quarters. My once-beautiful gown is now soaking wet and freezing as the wind batters into me, causing my whole body to shiver. Relieved to finally escape the elements, I open the door to the quarters and close it behind me.

“Lark?” I carefully make my way down the narrow corridor, leaving a wet trail behind me. The boards creak under my bare feet, each sound feeling too loud in the quiet after the storm. He’s in none of the smaller cabins, nor is he in Harrow’s room. There’s only one hiding spot left.

I find him sitting underneath the wooden table in the captain’s quarters. He’s pressed as far back as he can go, knees drawn up tight to his chest. His arms are wrapped around his shaking body, fingers clutching at the fabric of his sleeves as if he’s afraid to let go.

For a moment, I don’t speak. I lower myself slowly, careful not to scrape the floor or startle him. His breathing comes fast and uneven, shallow gasps that hitch in his throat when he notices me move.

“It’s me, Eryse.” Not wanting to scare the boy, I carefully crouch down next to him, then crawl underneath the table to sit with him. I make sure to keep a small distance between us, close enough to be there, far enough away so that he does not feel crowded.

His gaze flicks to my hands, then back to my face. My chest tightens at the sight of him.

“I thought it would be only fair to give you my name, as you have given me yours.” I begin, keeping my voice low and steady, so as not to startle him. He doesn’t stop shaking despite my attempts at comfort.

“I am not a sea witch, you know.” I look ahead of me, watching him from the corner of my eye. He perks up a little. “But I think witches are pretty cool. The captain’s sister is a sea witch, did you know that?”

Lark furrows his brows and tilts his head, as if turning the thought over in his mind. After a second, he gives me a quick nod, some of the tension in his shoulders easing.

“I like her. She’s very nice, unlike…”

“Unlike her brother?” I ask, a smile tugging at my lips, careful not to push it too far.

He blushes and quickly shakes his head. Of course, he would never insult his captain. Pirate loyalty and all that. “No, that’s not what I wanted to say.

She’s just so soft, while he’s …not. Not anymore.”

I nod my head in understanding and shift my weight until I’m sitting more comfortably on the floor. The table leg presses awkwardly into my back, and I cannot sit fully upright, but I don’t mind.

“Well, he’s a pirate.” I counter with a shrug, teasing him in the hopes of distracting him from what just happened.

“Hey! I’m a pirate too, you know.” He straightens his back at once and points a finger at me. “Pirates are good. We’re one big family.” He shakes his head, as though it’s pointless even saying it to me. “You wouldn’t understand. You’re a girl.”

A laugh bubbles from my throat before I can stop it.

“And you think girls can’t be pirates?”

“I have never seen a lass on one of our ships.”

With that, he crawls from his hiding spot and picks up a small cutlass he must’ve dropped earlier. He hesitates for just a heartbeat, then shoves it into the mount at his waist. I lift the hem of my dress and follow him out. His chest puffs with pride as he gets to his feet, standing taller than before. A soft swelling of relief appears in my chest at the sight of his reappearing confidence. He’s young, but it seems like he’s already learned the values that guide him, the rules that keep him standing even when fear tries to drag him down. I can only admire that in him.

“I was chosen for this when I was eight. The girls back home were very impressed.”

Home? I don’t know why, but I've never paid much thought to the fact that pirates would actually have somewhere they consider home. My father certainly didn’t tell me about this. I thought they considered the sea their home and their ship. My heart begins to ache at the thought of this boy having a mother and leaving her behind at such a young age. The reverse of my own childhood.

“I am sure they were.” I smile softly at him, then gently check his arms and shoulders for wounds by running my fingers over the skin there, my touch light and careful. “Do we have to see Harrow? Or are you okay?”

“I am okay. The Sea made sure I am.” He says, smiling as though it's nothing to be afraid of or worried about.

So he was wounded. The Sea of Renewal has cured him. With a smaller bank of memories, he is more at risk of losing something valuable. I hope the sea showed mercy and took an unimportant one.

His head swings to the side as the door to the cabin opens. The planks squeak as Nightglass enters the cabin and lets out a breath he's clearly been holding for a while.

"There you are, kid. Come here."

Lark doesn't hesitate. He runs straight into his open arms, and Nightglass hugs him tight, one hand cradling the back of his head as if to make sure he's safe. He seems to inspect the boy for wounds just as I did mere moments ago.

"I'm okay, Dad. You can stop," he says, eyeing me through the side of his vision, his head firmly pressed to Nightglass's chest. "You're embarrassing me."

Hold on a second. Do my ears deceive me? Dad?

Father and son. By the seas, of course they are. Now that I know it, I can see the similarities in their features. The same ash-blond hair, the same freckles peppering their cheeks. At the sight of them, something stings my heart, like a small needle tearing open a wound I try to keep closed. I, too, had a father who worried about me. Once upon a time.

"Of course, how could I be so thoughtless?" He lets go of him but scans his body one more time with a smile on his face that doesn't reach his eyes. A mask placed meticulously over his worry. He has to be concerned about which memory his son has lost.

Nightglass pats Lark on his shoulder. "You're needed out on deck. The captain's counting hands."

Lark nods and quickly hurries away, boots thudding down the corridor with renewed confidence, leaving me alone with his father, who eyes me up, scrutinizing every inch of me.

"I appreciate you checking on him, lass. But I don't want you near him." He sees my brows as they lift in confusion. "Grim told me what you are."

Swallowing, I slowly shake my head.

"Sirens never hurt kids. We're not interested in the innocent. Besides, you are pirates. I think it is I who should be more afraid. But I understand your concern, and I will respect your wish."

He nods slowly, jaw tightening as if he's weighing every word. He seems to let it slip, his worry for his son overpowering any anger my words have sparked.

"You don't know what he lost? Did he seem… confused to you?"

“No.” I offer him a reassuring smile. “He remembers his home, his family, and that he’s a true pirate at heart.”

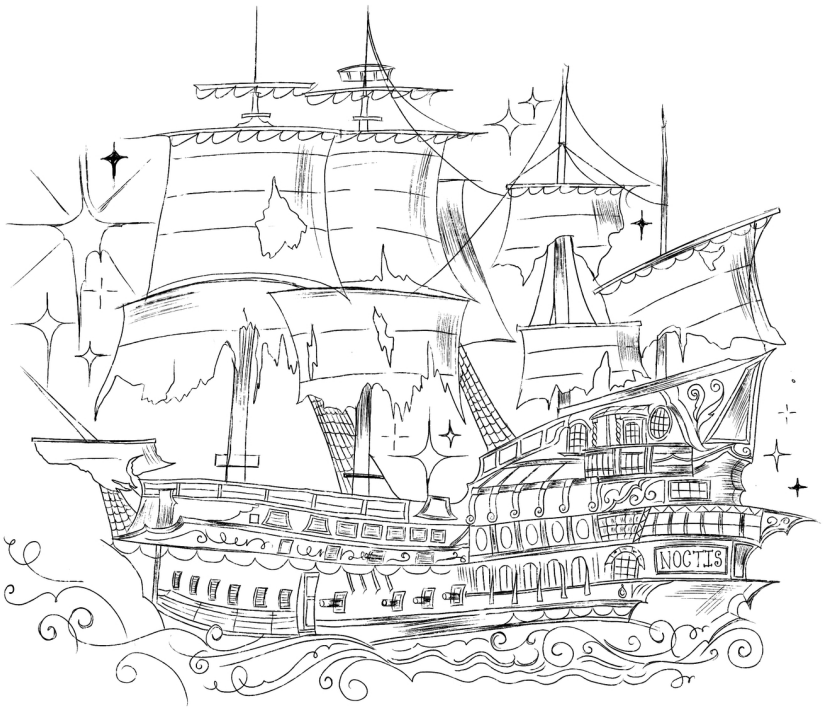
A smile tugs at his lips. “Good. That must be enough.”

Nightglass turns toward the door again but stops and looks back at me.

“I’ll lock you in here until the crew has settled and the captain is ready to see you. Go change and rest. I’m sure he has some clothes in there.” He nods toward a chest at the end of the bed.

Metal clicks. When I turn back around, the door is already closed.

I don’t even bother trying it. I know it’s locked.


NOCTIS

Chapter Ten

APPARENTLY, I CHANGED INTO a simple gown I found in the chest and completely crashed out on the soft bed in the captain's quarters. Otherwise, there's no way of explaining the stern-faced captain staring down at me with his dark eyebrows pulled into a frown.

I half expect rough planks beneath my back, the stink of the hold, iron at my ankles. It takes effort to register the softness of the mattress, the unfamiliar weight of blankets, the quiet creak of the ship instead of the roar of the sea.

The last thing I remember is exhaustion so deep it felt like drowning. For a moment, I just lie there, trying to understand what I'm seeing. I rub my eyes, my vision still blurry from sleeping, and prop myself up on my elbows.

"Had a good nap in my bed, little fish?" He asks me in a mocking tone, raising a dark brow. A playful smirk tugs at the corner of his mouth. He's clearly amused, and that alone bothers me.

He's so close to me that I can feel the warmth coming off his body. It's a little too intimate for my liking, him hovering over me like that, so I give his chest a slight push, forcing him to give me more space. The skin underneath his damp shirt is hot against mine, the strong curve of his muscles resisting the pressure of my hand. I linger a little too long, my eyes stuck on his chest and his tattoos there, before quickly pulling my hand back, annoyed with myself for briefly falling prey to thoughts of how muscular he is.

“I won’t apologize to you if that’s what you’re after.” I point my chin high. “I was locked in here, after all.”

“Mhm.” The corner of his lips lifts into an almost-smile as I get up to sit on the bed cross-legged. His bed. What was I thinking? Allowing my guard down long enough to fall asleep on the captain’s bed was a big mistake. Without wanting to, heat rushes into my cheeks. I shouldn’t have lain down here, not with the lack of sleep I had in the last few days. I was bound to crash. My head still feels heavy, my thoughts slow to catch up.

Sable straightens his posture and leans against one of the wooden bedposts with his arms crossed. He looks comfortable, a little pleased with himself, like this is all working out exactly how he wants it.

“You were right about the Intermaria. You tried to save the ship and the crew. That doesn’t go unnoticed.”

My eyebrows shoot up in surprise. Is he trying to thank me? Of all the things I was expecting him to say, that was not at the top of my list. I allow myself to indulge in a faint smile as I realize I have fulfilled my end of the bargain, and it is now Sable’s turn to fulfill his.

“Are you saying I get to sleep in a cabin tonight?”

He shrugs and nods toward me. “You’ve already slept in one. Mine, to be specific. I think the debt is paid.”

I quickly glance out of one of the foggy round windows across the room. It looks like the sun is about to set. Time has crept on despite my brief break from the world. “The night hasn’t even begun yet!”

A grin spreads across his face, dimples forming in his cheeks. “So you want to stay in my bed, little siren?"

A gasp escapes me, the heat creeping into my cheeks again. He thinks just because this is his cabin, that he can waltz in here and flirt with me. Well, he is sorely mistaken. After what he has done to me, hunting me across the ship just for the fun of it. Locking me up in a damp and miserable cell, only to come back and torture me later.

Clenching my jaw, I gather my gown and get to my feet, my movements sharper than I intend.

“No, thank you. I’d sooner take the cell than share a bed with my captor.” I curl my hands into fists at my sides until nails dig into my palms, threatening blood.

He doesn’t even flinch. He just looks at me, all calm and unbothered, like my anger barely registers.

“That looked different to me moments ago. But of course, you can change your mind,” he pauses, something registering in his eyes. “I see you took one of my treasures too.”

His eyes are on my gown, so I quickly smooth the folds of it using my hands in a defensive manner, suddenly aware of how thin the fabric is.

“Nightglass told me to take it. Mine was wet.”

“Right. About that other dress of yours,” his lips press into a line. “Who gave it to you?” Finally, he unfolds his arms and steps away from the bedpost. He walks toward the table with the pinned map on it and scans it, as if asking this question doesn’t sit right with him. His fingers tap once against the wood before going still. At least he seems less comfortable than usual.

I hesitate for a moment. I can’t blame any man of his crew, and it has become clear to me how much he hates dishonesty. I don’t want to provoke him again. My throat dries up. The truth it is then.

“The ghost,” I murmur and swallow hard.

His head snaps in my direction, his chest now rising and falling faster than before. His jaw is set tight, a muscle ticking beneath his skin, his mouth drawn into a thin line as if he’s forcing something down. I carefully watch his eyes, but they remain grey. That doesn’t keep my muscles from tensing, though. I brace myself without knowing why.

“A ghost?”

“I was visited by someone. There was nothing human about him. He came to see me last night and told me to ask for a new dress. Then the emerald one appeared outside the door when I was visiting Harrow.”

Sable curses under his breath and keeps his voice low. Then, he takes a bottle of rum from the table and opens it. He tilts his head back and swallows down a good amount of it. I can’t blame him. It’s been a long day, and he almost lost his crew to the sea.

“Don’t talk to him again. If he insists, tell him to leave you alone. Send him away. Loud and clear. You hear me?” His voice is serious and steady as he steps closer toward me again, the bottle of rum still in his hand.

It’s right next to where his knife is sheathed on his breeches. My stomach tightens. I swallow hard and peel my eyes off it to look at him again.

Our eyes meet.

“You hear me?” He repeats, his voice low.

Swallowing, I nod my head in agreement, though my pulse is loud in my ears.

“No, I want to hear you say it, little fish.”

“I won’t talk to the ghost again.”

“Good.”

He turns on his heel and walks toward another chest in the room, then begins digging through it with determination. Wood creaks and fabric rustles as he moves.

“You can have all the dresses. I don’t need them.” He throws a dress behind him, then another one. The fabric lands in a soft heap at my feet.

“My sister never likes what I pick for her, and her corals tear the fabric apart anyway.”

A pile of gowns starts to build up quickly. White gowns, pink gowns, and a lot of green and blue. Colors I haven’t worn in a long time. Then he grabs the pile and staggers over to me. With one swift movement, he thrusts the pile of clothes into my chest,

“Take it.”

I hesitate, my brows knitting together. This has to be a trick. Why else would he give me all of these clothes? Perhaps to make sure I don’t dig through his stuff again. But it could be what is becoming all the more apparent to me by the second. He is actually serious, and he wants to stop that ghost from offering me a dress again. Either way, it still catches me off guard.

He shoves the pile of dresses against me once more, urging me to take them. The weight of it surprises me. So much so that I have to lean back to avoid falling forward. I bet he stole them from fine ladies he met on his travels, maybe even princesses.

I am not sure what to say to him. I do not have much practice showing gratitude, considering the cards I’ve been dealt in life. “Thank… you?”

“Don’t thank me yet.” He says, then takes the emerald colored gown and throws it over the pile in my arms too. “If the crew decides to throw you overboard tomorrow, the dresses stay here.”

Of course, his kindness does not extend further than clearing out his inventory of dresses for me. But now that we have left the Intermaria and my wounds are healed, I could actually jump overboard. The thought sneaks in uninvited. Maybe the sea would actually mend my wrongness now that there are no further wounds to heal, giving me all I have waited

for my whole life. My thoughts start to spin, my pulse thumping in my ears. I could leave this ship tomorrow, but I unfortunately have no idea how far away we are from Aurelith. If there's no other island nearby, I would be doomed.

"Understood. The dresses remain dry on deck, in the event that I don't. So you give them to me because…?"

"That's nothing you should rack your brain over. I have plenty, and I evidently have no need for them. Now," he waves his hand again in dismissal. "You may go to your cell, little fish. The one up here, not in the hold."

I am about to open my mouth to protest, but he quickly moves on.

"Match." Sable barks, opening the cabin door. Match stumbles into the room, almost falling flat on his face.

"As you've been eavesdropping anyway, make yourself useful and lock the lass in her cell."

"Yes, Captain. Sorry, Captain." The young pirate straightens his posture and clears his throat, then looks at me and the pile of clothes in my arms.

Sable places a hand on my back and gently pushes me toward the door. The meaningless touch was a little too intimate, causing a cold shiver to erupt down my spine. I turn to glance over my shoulder once more, but he's already back at the table, studying the map.

I awkwardly follow Match into my cell and throw my dresses on the cot in the small space.

"The tribunal is tomorrow when the sun is at its highest," Match explains as he locks the door. I nod lazily.

"Sable told everyone you're a siren. It's not looking good for you. Most of the men want to sell you to the markets, or throw you overboard."

Fucking wonderful. Of course, the hatred they feel toward our kind makes the decision easy for them. I can't even blame them. If this were the other way around, the sirens in my swarm wouldn't bother with a tribunal to decide a pirate's fate.

"And what do you think?" I make my way over to him and grab the iron bars firmly with both hands, needing something solid to hold on to to cool my skin.

"I think you saved our asses from drowning." He says with a shrug and a smile on his face.

“Fair enough,” I reply and sigh. At least I’ve got his and Lark’s vote. And Grim, if he considers it hard enough. Thinking about it makes my stomach twist with worry.

Match brings me some fish and water before leaving me alone in my cell. The few hours of sleep refueled my energy, but it’s not nearly enough. It’s not just my energy that is drained. It’s my magic too.

I used my siren hum twice already in the last few days. It regenerates itself over time, but it takes a long, long time. And it requires salt. Either that or drowning a man. As neither swimming nor killing someone is an option right now, my magic will most likely remain low for a while yet. It also means that I cannot use my hum again. Not until I’ve taken a good, long swim in salty seawater. Sighing, I let myself fall onto the cot. Because of the dresses that are scattered across it, it is now surprisingly comfortable.

I lie on my back as I stare at the ceiling. Thinking about the tribunal tomorrow makes my stomach knot. I can’t help but run through the possible outcomes. Being sold is the most likely. It’s the most profitable for them. If necessary, I will plead on hands and knees not to sell me to the markets. In my current state, I wouldn’t stand a chance against the dealers. They’d pluck my scales and drain me dry of my blood, and I’d be just another siren corpse to dispose of.

Being thrown overboard would be faster, at least. If I were stronger, if my magic wasn’t drained, I might even welcome the change. But right now, it would be a gamble I likely wouldn‘t survive.

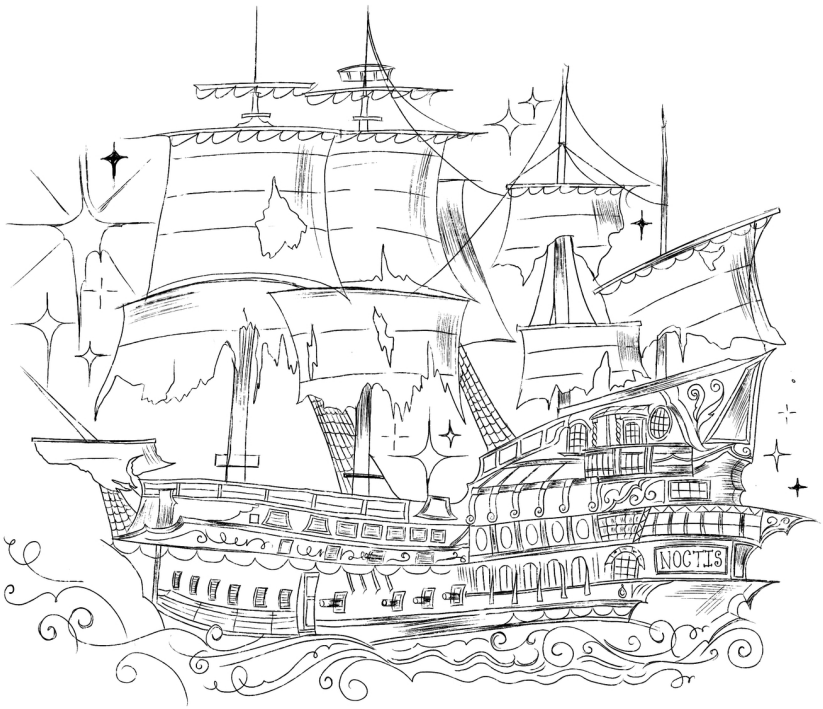
Heat rises within me, so I take a deep breath to calm myself. Well, not necessarily myself, but the siren within me that wants to riot. I’ve noticed that it becomes harder for me to control her temper, especially because being locked up feels so unnatural to me.

Frowning, I start counting the days of my captivity. It feels like it has been forever since…

Wait.

My heart skips, but not in a good way. It cannot be. I swallow hard and sit back up, panic rising within me.

I have no idea how I ended up on this ship.


NOCTIS

Chapter Eleven

EVEN BEFORE THEY COME and fetch me for the tribunal, I sense it is time. The ship falls into a dead silence. There's no laughter, no singing, no boots drumming the deck. No Lark checking on me every so often. Even the sea around us has gone quiet, though that's not unusual for the Sea of Renewal. The silence is heavy with contemplation.

Grim seems to appear in front of my cell with a deep frown line between his hazel eyes. The fact that he seems worried does nothing to ease my anxiety. I have been on edge all night. I didn't sleep a wink last night at all.

Even though Sable told me to avoid the ghost, I've been secretly hoping he'd visit me again. Besides Lark, he's the closest thing I have to a friend on this ship, his generosity not transactional as everyone else's seems to be. I don't mistake Sable for a friend, but he hasn't been as cruel as I expected. When I first told him what I am, I thought he'd toss me overboard without hesitation. Instead, he later trusted me with his ship and his crew, even let me sleep in his cabin. And then there are the dresses.

Then there's Grim. He carefully unlocks the door to my cell while I pick at the hem of my dress. It's the emerald gown the ghost gifted me. It's still a little damp from yesterday, but it reminds me of my mother, and I need a hit of saltwater, so I put it on anyway. If I'm drowning today, at least that gives me a little comfort before the end.

"It's very important that you accept the decision when it's made, Eryse. No matter what it is. The tribunal is not just a meaningless tradition. It's

enforced by the sea.” Grim puts the keys back into his pockets and opens the rusty door to my cell, the metal moving with a low metallic groan.

Taking a deep breath, I straighten my posture and hold my chin up high. A gesture I have repeated countless times to convince myself that I am not afraid. But my fast-beating heart betrays me, and so does the shiver running down my spine.

“I understand,” I finally manage to say through the knot that has formed in my throat.

Without another word, Grim reaches for my elbow, and I follow him out of my cell without a fight. I can’t use my hum. I can’t fight them all without it either. So the last thing I can hope for is that the sea shows mercy at last.

The sun is so bright that I have to squint as he opens the door to the main deck. He leads me toward the mast in the middle of the ship. With every step I take, the space around me seems to close in, the distance to the mast shrinking too quickly. Death looms over me, greedy, ready to take me as its prize. I try to hold onto the thought that I can endure this, that I have endured worse. But I haven’t. I have never been in a situation that feels this…final.

It’s the first time I’ve seen the whole crew gathered together. They’re standing in a half circle around the mast. Looking to my left and right, I search for a way out, for some last chance I have missed. Do something. Run. The closer we get, the louder it becomes – that voice telling me to do anything but step into the place where they will decide my fate. Finally, my survival instinct takes over. My feet slow. If I walk into that circle, I am handing myself over. I can’t. Before fully realizing what I am doing, I plant my feet into the ground and refuse to take another step toward certain death. Strong hands grab me and pull me forward against my will.

Panic hits me like a punch in my guts, rising up my throat until it tears free–

“No!”

My scream fills the otherwise silent air, and Grim instantly covers his ears in reflex. The tone is high and echoes around us on the open sea. As I look around, the rest of the men are grimacing and covering their ears as well. Without intending to, I have used my siren magic on them. The dizziness in my head is undeniable proof.

I regret it as soon as it happens. As the echo of my shrill scream fades, I see the darkness of hatred in their eyes. My eyes snap to the smallest pirate

in the crowd. Lark.

There's fear in his eyes. He stands next to his father with a hand on his little cutlass, ready to draw it to defend himself. My stomach twists and turns, and for a moment, I am scared I might throw up.

The circle closes around me as Grim ties me to the mast. No one speaks a word, and that makes the panic within me rise even further. They seem to be waiting for something. No, not something. Someone.

"Crew of the Noctis."

I look up to find Sable standing on the quarterdeck above, dressed all in black, his black hair peeking out beneath his tricorn hat. He stands proud and sure under the blazing sun as the crew turns to listen to their captain. The authority radiating from him is strong enough to make my knees buckle, and for the first time, I understand why they chose him as their captain.

"We are gathered here today to hold the tribunal. As it is stated in the Black Code of Free Ships, every intruder aboard a ship must face the tribunal. The crew decides their fate by democracy."

Murmurs start around me, some praising the code, some the sea — the entity we all live by.

Sable makes his way down and takes the last spot in the half-circle across from me. His eyes, burning straight through me. I look away. The barrier of denial and confidence I have carefully built and maintained over the last few days crumbles away slowly but surely.

The edges of my vision blur. Sounds bleed together, voices turning distant and warped, as if I'm underwater already. My hands are numb, my chest too tight to draw a proper breath. I know I'm still standing, but it feels like I'm not fully here anymore.

"Eryse." I feel his hand on my cheek, turning my face toward the body suddenly blocking the sun in front of me.

I obey and look into his kohl-rimmed eyes, the tears now threatening to swell. I swallow them down. The decision has not been made, yet here I am, already crying. No wonder the sea doesn‘t want me. I am so weak.

His thumb presses against my skin, just enough to anchor me, preventing me from drifting away further into the panic. My breath stutters once, then again, before evening out. Sable doesn't tear his gaze away and watches me with intent. His brows draw together, as if the sight of me unsettles him. He

stays close, his hand steady against my cheek until the blur at the edges of my vision settles and the world comes back into focus.

“Go on,” I whisper, and he hesitates. Finally, his hand slips away, the tenderness of his touch leaving me.

He takes back his place in the half-circle and clears his throat.

“The siren boarded the ship without permission. She compelled Lark.”

The crew grows uneasy and anxious, spitting insults toward my kind and talking about revenge.

“Quiet!” Sable’s voice carries over them all, sharp and steady, and the crew goes silent in an instant.

I hold my breath.

“We will start the questioning now. Grim?”

Grim hesitates before stepping forward, eyes dropping for a heartbeat before lifting to meet mine.

“Why did you board this ship?”

I shake my head, and my breath stutters to a stop as the question sinks in. I didn‘t know that there’d be a questioning. I thought they would vote and get it over with. I try to remember, but where the memory should be, there is just a hollow, aching blank space. I cannot answer any of their questions. I don’t remember how I ended up on this ship, nor do I remember what I wanted here.

“I don’t know.” My words are nothing more than a whisper. It does not go down well with the crew.

“And what were your intentions in boarding this ship?”

“I don‘t remember, but—“

“This is ridiculous,” someone spits and steps into the circle, breaking the tension. That thick-necked man. Rat. “She didn’t wander aboard. She came for us. To kill us. And you know what bloody sirens bring!”

Others nod in agreement, and murmurs become shouts. Again, Sable raises his voice.

“Silence, you unruly whelps! You forget the bloody sea we’re in. She was on deck yesterday. The sea took from her. I saw it with my own eyes. She boarded the ship because she was running away from siren hunters.”

“Are you defending the wench?” Rat spits and takes another step toward the captain.

“I am making this a fair process, as the code demands it.” Unspoken words pass between the men as they stare at each other. “Now,” he starts,

dragging every word. “Get back in your place.” Silence follows, but in the end, Rat obeys and returns to his place.

I let go of the breath I’ve been holding.

“It’s true,” I manage to say. “I don‘t remember why I’m on this ship. The sea took it from me. I had a wound that was mended, and we all know the price we pay for that. I can assure you of one thing, and that is I don’t mean any harm.”

Tears sting my eyes. One of them slips out of the corner of my eye and wets my cheek.

“I am more human than I am a siren.” It’s more a confession than a statement. “I compelled Lark to survive. That‘s it.”

“She’s right.”

My head snaps toward the young pirate, and a smile tugs at my lips. Lark is speaking in my favor.

“I would’ve done the same in her situation. And yesterday, I was scared of the maelstroms. She could’ve used her tricks on me, but she didn’t.” Lark says quietly, avoiding eye contact and shifting his weight from one foot to the other. His father puts a hand on his shoulder and squeezes it to encourage him to continue. He swallows and does so in an unsteady voice.

“She was nice to me.” He pauses, his face lighting up as though he’s just been struck with a sudden spark of confidence. “And then she went on deck and saved your asses from drowning!”

“Aye!” Multiple men shout in agreement.

Another pirate steps forward, one I haven't seen before. Seeing as he’s covered in tar and ash, it’s safe to assume him to be a man working at the gunports.

“It’s the Glim that showed us the route, not her.”

Now Nightglass moves forward and pushes his son behind him protectively.

“But the Glim has only appeared whenever she is on deck. And it was the night that she boarded the ship when the Glim first appeared to us. It’s why we left Aurelith.”

At that, a gasp escapes my mouth. If what he is saying is true, the Glim could actually be connected to me. I don‘t even know what the meaning behind the Glim is. One thing I know for certain, though, is that it is a creation of sea magic. It has to be.

Twenty pairs of eyes stare at me in anticipation. An invisible string pulls my attention toward the captain. He tilts his head as though trying to read me, his eyes silently questioning if I am behind the Glim. But I don’t have an answer to his question, so I press my lips together and shake my head ever so slightly. It’s a movement subtle enough so the others don’t catch it, but he does.

Sable takes a deep breath before he raises his voice. “Based on the fact that she claims not to remember, I announce the questioning closed. We will cast our votes now. I urge you to think your answer over fully before locking in your decision. Her life is in our hands.” Swallowing, he moves to stand next to me, then looks at every man in his crew.

“The possible options you have chosen in yesterday‘s pre-tribunal vote are the following…” I turn my head to glance in his direction. My whole body goes rigid as he announces the paths my life can possibly take.

Walking the plank.

The Markets.

Captivity.

I must admit that even for my miserable life, my future has looked brighter before. My freedom is not even considered. I let my head fall forward in resignation. There’s nothing left that I could do or say now. It’s up to them. I have no control over my fate. Not that I ever have.

Match collects the votes of each crew member in a small pouch. Each pirate throws in a piece of colored glass, though I don’t know the meaning behind each one, but by the seas, there’s a lot of red.

Then the captain counts the votes and hands the pouch to Grim. He counts them again, and they nod in agreement.

Because of the blood rushing in my ears, I cannot make out what Sable says. The dizziness of my drained magic makes me sway on my feet. Again, my vision blurs. Sable swallows hard, the muscles in his face tight, his forehead carved with deep lines. There’s that clouded sorrow in his eyes again.

The next thing I know, I am moved toward the plank of the ship. So the decision has been made. This will be my fate. I walk it down with unsteady feet, remembering Grim‘s words from earlier. I have to accept my fate. As I reach the end, I glance over my shoulder to find them all gawking at me. Some smile in victory. In the center is Sable, with his arms crossed over his

chest. When I look him in the eyes again, they're darker than before, his hat casting a shadow over his face. His expression gives nothing away.

Then there's Lark. Tears are streaming down his face as Nightglass hugs him tightly against his chest. The sight of him breaks my heart. He's too young to witness death by drowning. Too young for any of this.

"It's okay, Lark. I'm a siren. The sea is my home." I manage a smile, and he gives me a sharp nod. He should know that I'll be at peace.

Turning back around, I step to the very edge. The drop stretches beneath me, and for a moment, my body refuses to follow through. Every instinct claws at me to stay, to fight, to turn back and beg for one more breath. My toes curl against the wood, as if that could keep me here. If the sea does not show mercy now, it will take me and keep me in its depths.

It doesn't matter now.

I close my eyes.

And jump.

The water swallows me whole. I sink fast. Too fast. I don't hold my breath, the weight of my wrong body dragging me under. Useless, human legs that don't belong here. The sea presses its heaviness on my ribs, my mouth, my legs.

Brave.

I hear the voice of my mother surrounding me as the water drags me under. I have done this many times before, but I never had to fear death. My last hope is my shift. Maybe the sea will show me mercy at last. There's no wound to heal, only my legs to correct into a glistening tail. My true form.

So I open my mouth and invite the water in. It rushes into my lungs and steals the last breath away from me as I silently scream.

The sun fractures above me, light splintering into pale ribbons that grow thinner the further I sink. If this is the last thing I see, at least it is something beautiful.

The pressure grows unbearable. My lungs seize, my vision darkens at the edges, and the warmth I felt earlier is gone, replaced by a numb, spreading cold.

Then something shifts.

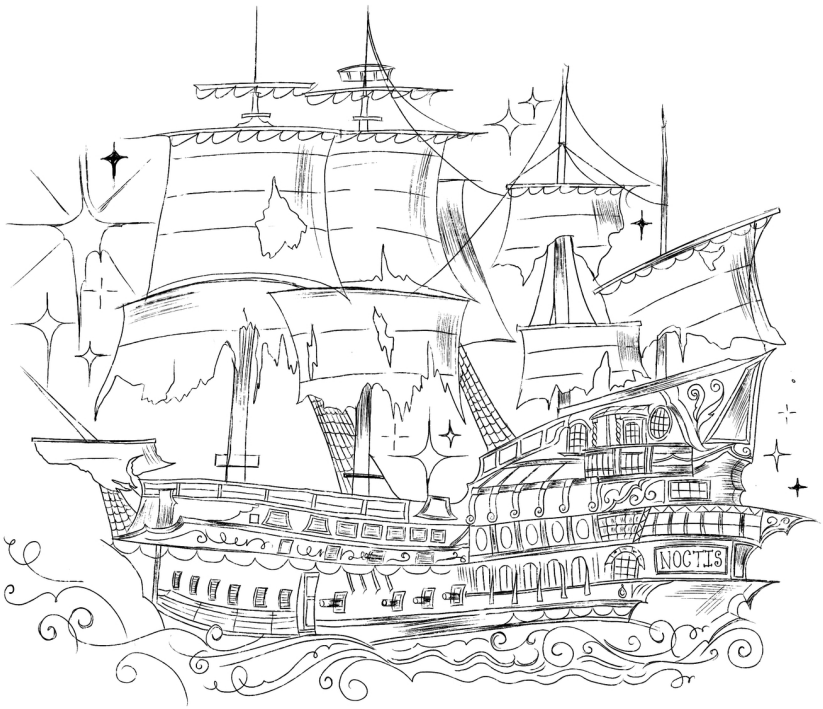
"Little siren, you are drowning." A faint voice whispers into my ear. "Let him help you."

I am pushed upward by an invisible force that curls around my ribs like smoke. Through the haze of salt and fading light, a shadow cuts through the

water above me.

My mind screams as I recognize him.

It’s Sable.


NOCTIS

Chapter Twelve

I FALL IN AND OUT of consciousness as strong hands pull me from the depths. The sea lifts in shades of blue as the pressure on my body lifts with every heartbeat.

We break through the surface. Instead of gasping for air, my chest jerks uselessly, lungs burning as they try to pull in breath and only drag water in instead. I cough so hard my body folds in on itself. Panic crashes back in as I realize I'm still drowning, even with my head above the water, my lungs are full of the sea. My limbs are too numb, too weak – to swim on my own.

Then there's pressure on my ribs, and a warm body behind me. Arms tighten around me as they pull me against a hard chest, causing me to choke. He repeats the motion, and I choke again. Only this time, the water I've been holding bursts out of me. I cough and choke out more and more water until finally, I can pull in air.

"Don't you dare die now, little fish."

The world turns. One arm slides around my waist, while his other hand keeps my head above the surface. Then he draws me back against his chest. Instead of the horizon, there's a cloudless sky. Sable keeps me afloat.

I draw in another long breath. Then exhale, and repeat.

"There you go."

I tell myself that I can float here with him for a little while longer and pretend. Pretend that I was not forced to walk the plank, that I didn't almost drown. That he didn't jump after me. When the coughing finally eases, he loosens his hold slightly, keeping one arm firmly around my waist.

“Slow breaths,” he instructs.

Then he shifts again, guiding me back until my legs find the rhythm of kicking again. I draw in another breath and begin to move, the water beneath me finally making sense again.

I can’t help myself, I glance at the legs beneath the surface. I didn’t expect to see a tail, but the sight still hurts. When I look back up, Sable is in front of me, his storm-grey eyes staring into mine.

“Why?” My words break, the salt in my throat still stinging and making it hard to speak.

“Because if there’s the slightest chance that you can help us, I can’t risk losing you.” He confesses, “And because I wasn’t going to let the sea take you on my watch.”

“Captain!” A voice carries from above, and I look up. The Noctis looms over us, dark and solid against the brightness of the sea. Her hull cuts a sharp line through the turquoise water, like she doesn’t belong in a place this bright.

It is only now that I see it.

The Sea of Renewal glows around us, sunlight breaking into shards as it hits the surface. The water sparkles, almost alive, threads of light swirling and folding into each other.

My gaze drifts back to Sable.

If he was wounded when he jumped in after me…

The thought settles heavily in my chest. Whatever it took from him, it won’t return. He took a risk for me. A real one.

Before I can say anything, something heavy splashes down beside us. A rope hits the water, sending ripples racing outward.

Sable keeps one firm arm around my waist while his other hand catches the line bobbing between us. The rope goes taut as he grips it, anchoring us both.

I hear movement above us, then the scrape of rope against wood. A ladder drops over the side of the ship, slapping against the hull before settling into the water beside us.

He shifts us closer to the ladder, positioning me between himself and it.

“Slow,” he says, then lifts me just enough for me to catch the rope and pull myself onto the first rung.

I climb, shaking, water streaming from my dress, the ladder swaying beneath me with every moment. The narrow planks are slick and tilt under

my feet, forcing me to grip the rope tighter. I drag myself up one rung, then another, my limbs heavy and so awfully slow. My foot misses once, scraping hard against the hull. I take a moment and press my forehead to the thick rope, fighting the dizziness that threatens to take me under again.

I know he'd catch me if I slipped. His presence edges behind me the entire way up. Only when my hands close around the railing do I glance over my shoulder.

There he is, a few feet below me, fully clothed and just as drenched. Further down, on the surface of the cursed water, his beloved tricorn hat drifts, bobbing gently.

"Your hat—"

"I'll organize a new one," he says with a wink, leaving me speechless. This man is something else, unlike anyone I have met before.

A firm grip closes around my upper arm and pulls me over the railing. I land on my knees, crashing against the deck, the impact sending a sharp wave of pain through my body. I brace myself and lean against the hull, my breathing uneven and fast.

Sable is hauled up next, landing on his feet with great ease. Strangely, it's silent around us, the rest of us staring at us in stunned disbelief. Murmurs and protests ripple through the crew. A pirate near the mast lets out a sharp breath, his jaw tightening as his gaze flickers between the captain and me. One of the gunners mutters something under his breath, too quiet to make out, but the man next to him answers with a curse.

No one returns to their work.

"What are y'all gawking at? Get back to your stations, savvy?" Sable barks.

A few men move, but only hesitantly. About half of the crew remains, their eyes fixed on me, and the hatred on them tells me exactly how they voted. The murmurs don't die but rise into restless shouts.

"We did not vote for this!"

"You broke the code!"

"You saved a bloody siren!"

I lower my head, but every word lands anyway. I know this situation could shift into something much worse if Sable doesn't calm them down soon. They are not done with me, not even the slightest. If anything, this has made it worse.

The wood creaks as one of the men steps forward. When I look up, a dark figure looms over me. As expected, it's Rat. His patched-up coat whips around him as he points a finger at Sable, who couldn't look more unbothered.

"You broke the code, Captain," he spits the last word, saliva splattering on Sable's cheek. "Just know that overruling our decision will have consequences, captain or not. Mark my words."

He turns to me, his gaze crawling over my soaked form with open disgust. "Enjoy your prize. She is your responsibility now." A disgusting, rotten-toothed grin cuts across his face. "I'll enjoy watching you climb over that railing under the sea whore's compulsion and throw yourself to your death."

The blow comes without warning.

Sable's fist slams into Rat's jaw, snapping his head to the side and sending him stumbling. Skin splits, and blood spills down his face, trickling over his chin.

The siren inside me smiles. She relishes the sight of his bleeding face. But I'm too stunned to fully grasp what just happened.

Rat wipes the blood away with the back of his hand, then staggers toward the captain again.

"You wanted to say something?" Sable lifts a brow, baring his teeth in a grin.

Rat's hand moves to the mount at his waist, fingers brushing his cutlass—

"Enough."

Grim steps in, grabbing Rat by the front of his shirt and hauling him back. "I don't appreciate the captain's actions either, but it is what it is. You can call for mutiny if that's what you want, however, you know the crew. They're loyal to him. You'd lose everything."

The weight of the words settles in Rat's posture. The tension drains from his body, and he gives a stiff nod. Grim releases him, and a moment later, they both leave the main deck.

Sable helps me to my feet as the crew gets back to work around us. Ropes are pulled tight, and the sails are adjusted to help the ship gain speed again. Moments later, the Noctis groans beneath us as she cuts through the water. The sounds of the ship carry on around me, routine and indifferent, as if no one just watched a man get punched for my sake. As if no one just sent me

off the plank to my death, then watched the captain decide my life was worth saving.

“Wait here,” he instructs, and I furrow my brows as he leaves. He disappears into the cabins beneath the quarterdeck and returns shortly after with one of the wool blankets I saw in his room yesterday.

He drapes it over my shoulders and nods toward the bow. “You owe me a few answers.” And with that, he strides along the main deck in steady steps, expecting me to follow.

My legs are still shaking as I trail closely behind him, each step feeling slightly delayed, until we reach the very end of the ship. Sable leans against the railing, studying me carefully, the sea stretching endlessly behind him and outlining his frame with a subtle golden glow. For a moment, it feels like the rest of the ship falls away, and it is only the two of us.

I pull the blanket tighter around myself, the warmth settling my body a little. My thoughts, on the other hand, are still a tangled mess. I know the reasoning behind his actions, or at least what he told me. I might be useful, so he wanted to keep me. I always knew pirates liked to hoard what they found. If he already decided I was worth saving, he could have stepped in sooner, could have spared me the walk to the plank. Instead, he let it unfold, let them cast their votes, only to ignore them at the end.

None of it makes sense.

“That frown of yours tells me you’re not happy about being saved,” he says. “Or is it simply that you dislike me?”

I exhale quietly and keep my distance, not trusting myself to answer immediately.

“No. I mean, of course I didn’t want to drown, it’s just—”

“It’s just that you sank to the bottom of the ocean like a bloody stone,” he cuts in. “Hell, you didn’t even put up a fight. Are you quite mad?” His chest rises and falls once, measured, like he’s forcing the anger back down. I feel cornered, even though what he’s suggesting isn’t entirely true. I didn’t want to die. But I knew that if I didn’t force my shift, I’d be dead anyway.

“I was hoping for that—”

“I know what you were hoping for,” he interrupts sharply. “Don’t think I didn’t notice how you stared at your legs in disappointment. And the amount of water you must’ve swallowed.”

Heat rushes to my cheeks, and for the first time, I can’t meet his gaze. I stare at my feet as a knot tightens in my throat. It feels wrong to have

something so intimate seen so clearly.

“The tribunal should’ve enforced the sea’s will,” he continues. “I trusted its decision—until I saw you sinking. I need you alive, little fish. And you do not deserve to die. So I stepped in.”

I nod once, because I don’t trust myself to say anything. Useful things are kept. That doesn’t mean they’re wanted. Silence stretches between us until I sigh and lean against the railing beside him. The sun hangs low now, tinting the sky gold. Below, the enchanted water sparkles, ribbons of pink and orange folding into one another.

“You still took a risk,” I say quietly, and catch him turning toward me from the corner of my eye. “I hope whatever the sea took from you will be worth losing in the end.” I hesitate for a moment. “Because we both know I don’t control the Glim.”

“You don’t know that for sure.” His voice is calm. “You’re a siren, little fish. Tail or not, you wield the magic of the sea.”

A short laugh slips out of me. “Wielding is a strong word for what I’m capable of.”

“I think you’re capable of more than you think.” His gaze sharpens. “And I know you’d be better at it if you’re not dead.”

Before I can react, he grips the side of my head and turns my face toward him, firm enough that I stumble half a step closer. He’s close enough that I can feel the heat of him through the blanket, and my pulse jumps in answer to his questioning eyes.

“So don’t ever try to drown yourself again,” he says quietly. “Okay?”

The light in his grey eyes looks like polished metal for a moment, and I hate how easily it pulls me in.

“We’ll see about that,” I say, not breaking eye contact.

He releases me at once.

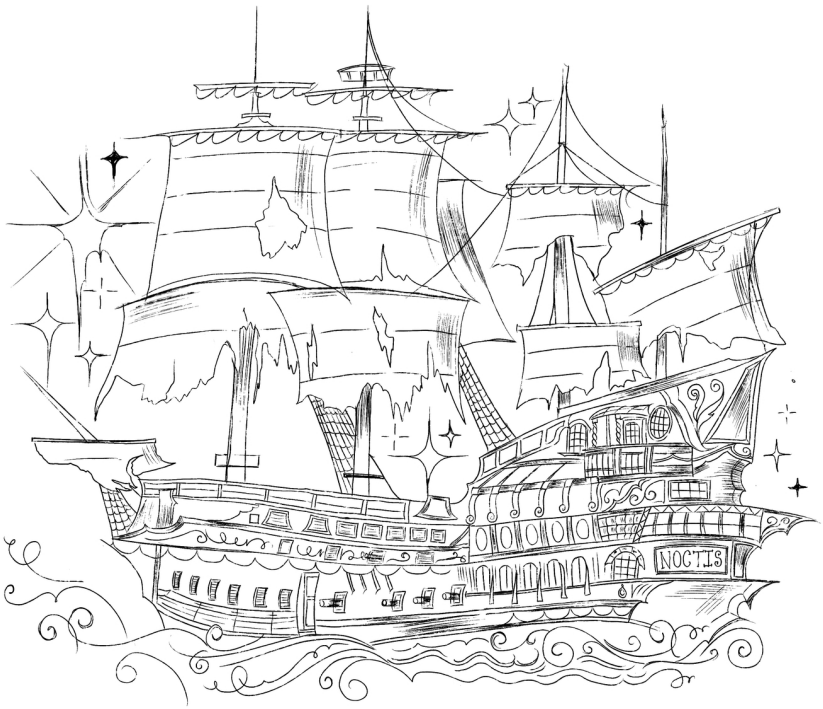
“You’ll summon the Glim again tomorrow,” he says, already stepping back from me. “We start after breakfast.”

He turns on his heel, his wet coat whipping around him as he heads for the steps, throwing droplets of water into the air.

“Wait,” I call after him. “Am I not sleeping in my cell? Where do I sleep?”

He keeps walking away from me, not even bothering to shoot me a backward glance as he gives his last remarks.

“Ship’s big enough, darling.”


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirteen

PIRATES ARE THE MOST stubborn kind of humans I have ever met. Turns out, finding a place for me to sleep is an almost impossible task. The Noctis offers more than enough space, but all the cabins are already occupied by crew members with higher ranks, and apparently, about half of the crew members don't trust me. I guess that explains the tribunal votes.

I've already been threatened with being thrown overboard twice. Three wanted to bed me in exchange for their bed, one spat horrible insults about my kind, and another was mute, so he only shook his head and wrinkled his nose in disgust. The worst thing about it is that, wherever I go, I have to take my dresses with me. My mother always taught me that it is not polite to return a gift.

So before the sun sets, I find myself carrying the pile of dresses down into the orlop. The steep steps almost make me stumble and fall twice, the fabric slipping in my arms, but in the end, my dresses and I make it down safe and sound. The orlop is already dim, lit only by a few lanterns that sway gently with the movement of the ship. Every creak of timber sounds louder down here, the hull groaning softly around us.

Lark is still preparing the hammock that he said he'd organize for me when he found me wandering earlier, and pulls the strings tight. His father is by his side, instructing him on how to tie the knot the right way. The pirate-in-training listens carefully as he pulls at the rope exactly as his father told him to.

“There you go,” Nightglass leans over to inspect the work. “That’s how you do a proper bowline knot.”

I carefully place my dresses on a clean-looking piece of sailcloth, smoothing the fabric once out of habit, then step toward the two sailors.

“Thank you for helping me with this.” I manage a soft smile, keeping my hands folded in front of me, unsure where else to put them.

At the same time, Nightglass steps half a pace back and pulls Lark with him. The space between us widens. Sighing, I nod in understanding.

“No lady should sleep on the floor. That’s what I’m teaching my son.” He places a hand on the smaller pirate and squeezes it, guiding him to turn, and moments later, they disappear into the dark, their footsteps fading toward the stern.

They’re both sleeping down here, a few feet away, on the other side of the stairs. Lark is still a cabin boy, so he is the pirate with the lowest rank, or so he proudly told me earlier. He didn’t forget to mention that I am even lower in rank, though, which would make him my superior. It still means that he must sleep in the orlop. His father doesn’t want to leave him down here alone, it seems, so they’re both here with a few other lower crew members. And me.

It is truly not the best place to sleep on a ship, but what counts is that I am not held captive anymore, behind iron bars. I feel their eyes on me at all times while I’m on deck, as if watching a predator that might snap if given the chance. Though they have seen me at my weakest today, there’s no sign of trust or even indifference. I can’t blame them, though. I don’t trust them either. There’s a chance that someone quietly slits my throat while I’m sleeping, the way they do at the markets to bleed the siren out and get the last drop of magic from her. Then there’s the fact that I’m the only woman on board.

Thinking about it makes me shiver, so I shake it off and focus on something else. While I was roaming the ship earlier, searching for a sleeping spot, I collected a treasure that I now keep around my neck — a charm carved out of bone in the shape of a shell. I tell myself that it is fine, as they have stolen, I mean, organized it in the first place. I don’t know why I kept it, but it kind of spoke to me. Pirates believe that these kinds of charms bring them luck while sailing and spare them from foul weather. Of course, that’s not true. The sea disregards such meaningless trinkets. But belief has weight on a ship like this, and I’ve even seen the captain wearing

them around his neck. I also found a pair of boots. They're a bit too big for me, worn thin with holes along the sides, but I took them anyway. In the state they're in, I doubt anyone will miss them. And with the way my feet have already begun to ache, I couldn't afford not to.

Suddenly, the lantern to my right flickers. I curl my hands around the charm tightly without thinking and whip my head toward the light. I wait, listening past the creak of wood and the distant murmur of waves. Nothing moves. Exhaling, I shake my head and tuck the charm back into the neckline of my dress.

I test the hammock, gripping the ropes and shifting my weight carefully. When I'm sure it holds, I lie down and sigh as the fabric cradles me. This is so much better than the cell. The slow sway of the ship carries even here, and I can go on deck whenever I need fresher air. The rest of the crew is already sleeping, though their distant snoring does not bother me. I wonder if Sable gets some sleep tonight, or if his thoughts are as restless as mine.

If he hadn't come for me, I would be dead now. Just another life lost to the sea. I let the moment replay in my head. His silhouette above me, the shock of his grip, my vision already blurring. I screw up my face, remembering something else. Something in the water. Something—or someone—pushed me upward. It felt like smoke curling around my waist. Like…what I'm feeling now.

I tear my eyes open and stare into pitch-black eyes.

A scream claws its way up my throat, but a hand clamps over my mouth. It feels strange against my lips, weightless and heavy at the same time. Ribbons of smoke coil around his fingers, dusted with silver-blue sparks when the lantern light catches them.

I can make out his frame and clothing vaguely from the outlines. He's wearing breeches and a loose shirt, tugged inside of it in a messy way.

"Shh." He presses one finger against his mouth, instructing me to be quiet. My muscles tense and I swallow, then exhale the breath I've been holding. The ghost removes his hand slowly, a smile tugging at his lips.

"Just wanted to check in on you." He moves back as I carefully sit up in the hammock, then takes a seat next to me. The hammock doesn't dip because of his weight, it is as if he's not sitting in it at all.

"Sea almost took you today. Cap'n took a risk saving you."

"He said I should not talk to you." I swallow down the knot in my throat and hug my legs to my chest.

“And you listen to what the captain says like a good girl, huh?” It looks like he shakes his head and chuckles, but I can’t be certain. His movements are delayed and blur into each other, and his voice overlaps with itself with every word. If I didn’t know better, I’d think that I was dreaming.

I think of what Harrow said, that talking to these shadowy beings keeps them away from where they should be. That I shouldn’t even acknowledge them. So I close my eyes and press them together as tightly as possible, trying to block him out.

“Go away,” I whisper, over and over again.

“You know that’s not going to work.” He’s closer now, his voice whispering directly into my ear, sending the hairs on the back of my neck into a frenzy.

Still, I ignore him. He sighs, and it multiplies itself over and over again as it echoes through the orlop. When I open my eyes, I expect him to be gone, but he has made himself comfortable in the hammock, now lying in it on the opposite side from me.

“What do you want from me?” I finally ask, disregarding the no-talking-to-the-ghost rule.

“I wanted to see how you’re doing after today’s suicide mission.” He shrugs, then runs a hand through what is supposed to be his hair. It looks more like black flames dancing on his head. I wonder what it would feel like if I were to run my own hand through it.

“I’m doing wonderful. Now, what else do you want?” I spit, a biting edge to my voice. I am done playing games today. Tiredness is bringing out the worst in me.

“The Glim. Summoning it won't be an easy task.”

“Tell me something I don’t know,” I mutter as I lean back in the hammock. I wonder what it’s like being a ghost, and if he’s all alone on this ship.

“It’s a creation of the sea and will only show up when it must interfere,” he continues, stretching his limbs, his phantom legs brushing against mine. The sensation almost tickles, like walking through a spider web before you notice it. It isn’t unpleasant, just unusual. Unexpectedly pleasant.

Curiosity stirs within me. I can’t help myself. “Interfere?”

“In fate,” he murmurs, lowering his voice. “You’re here for a reason, Risa. The sea doesn’t make mistakes.”

My heart thumps in my chest. “Wait—what do you mean the sea doesn’t make mistakes?”

Suddenly, the ship lifts and drops so heavily that barrels topple and roll down the corridor. Water slaps violently against the hull. As fast as the wave came, it was gone again. The ghost carefully sits up and stills, checking if someone woke up. There’s only snoring in the distance.

“I can’t tell you more. But the Glim will not show up again unless the sea needs it to.”

“And the captain doesn’t know that?”

“He does. He’s just blinded by fear of losing his crew—and he is a very, very stubborn man.”

A smile tugs at my lips, and I can’t help but chuckle.

“I see. Insulting the captain is the way to make you laugh.” He grins mischievously, one of his silver brows lifting in mockery. “I like it, your laugh.”

Blushing, I quickly shake my head. He looks down at me, his gaze catching on the scales on my collarbones.

“I bet your tail would’ve been beautiful,” he says quietly, admiration softening his voice.

My chest tightens, and it becomes increasingly difficult to breathe. Tears sting my eyes, and I avert my gaze. I don't want him to see how much the thought upsets me.

“Sorry,” he whispers. His presence retreats slightly, but I still can’t bring myself to look at him. “I didn’t mean to upset you.”

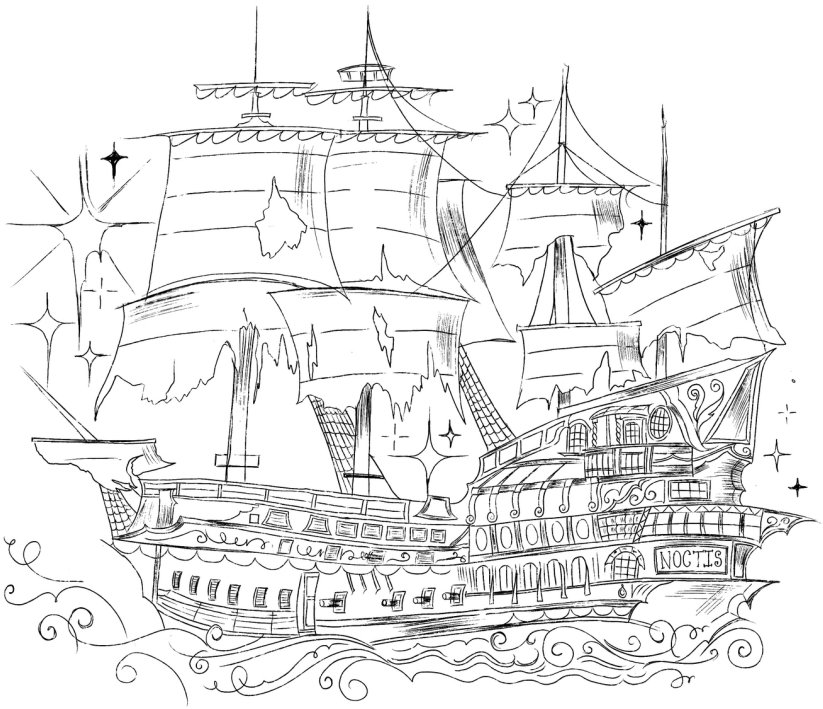
I wipe a single tear from my cheek and prop myself up, then force myself to meet his gaze. He stands a few feet away now, his hands clasped behind his back. Shadows dance around him like black flames as his empty eyes find mine again.

“You should know,” he adds lightly, “your legs are beautiful too, in their own way.”

And with that, he steps back into the darkness, clinging to the wall, his body dissolving into smoke until the last swirl fades into the thin air, and I am alone once again.

“Thank you,” I whisper, even though he is already gone. With a pounding heart, I lie down fully and close my eyes, glad for the chance.

My last thought before drifting into dreamless sleep is the strange warmth of his skin brushing against mine.


NOCTIS

Chapter Fourteen

THE HAMMOCK ROCKS IN a slow, steady rhythm, almost convincing my body to sink back into sleep. Everything still feels heavy from yesterday. My throat is raw from all the coughing, from the salt water I swallowed. Just as I drift into consciousness, a boot thuds against wood. Then another. A rope squeals overhead, loud enough to snap me fully awake.

The orlop is still dim, light spilling down from the hatch above and tinting the space in a warm, dusty gold. When I blink and sit up, careful not to rock the hammock too much, I notice how damp my clothes still are. The air clings to my skin, humidity pressing in from all sides. If the Sea of Renewal is known for anything, it's the heat. And we sailed deeper into the heat of it during the night.

A few feet away, Lark is already up. He sits on a chest with his knees pulled up, rubbing his eyes with the heels of his hands like he hasn't fully woken up yet. Nightglass crouches beside him, tying something at his ankle. A strip of cloth, it looks like. His movements are careful and practiced. He doesn't look at me. Neither does Lark, at first.

"Good morning, sailor," I say quietly, forcing myself to swing my legs over the side of the hammock and stand.

My bare feet hit the cold boards, and I suck in a sharp breath. Now I'm more thankful than ever for the boots I found.

Lark's head snaps up. He gives me a quick nod and a tight smile. "Morning."

As his father finishes the knot, Lark hops off the chest. “It’s already late. You’re helping me with breakfast today,” he announces as he pulls on his boots and bolts for the stairs.

“You coming?” he shouts from above.

I glance at Nightglass. He finally looks at me, just briefly.

“He’s right,” he says, “make yourself useful here, lass.”

I bite my lip and scan the space. A few other men are already moving around below deck, lower ranks, from what I’ve gathered. They give me a wide berth, passing as if I carry something contagious. I reach for the charm, reassured when I feel it beneath the fabric of my gown.

“I’m coming!” I call after Lark and start up the steps.

Of course, I’m not nearly as fast as he is. He’s already waiting on deck, shifting impatiently from foot to foot. Someone brushes past me with a bucket, face turned away, the impact making the water splash over the edges and onto my feet.

Fine. Pretend I’m not here. Better than hurling abuse at me, I suppose.

I follow Lark toward the stern, where the galley sits tucked into the ship. I remember this place from days ago—though it feels much longer than that.

This time, the galley is alive.

Heat rolls from the stove. A pan hisses, fat spitting as something fries. A large pot simmers beside it, steam curling upward. The smell of ham and vegetables fills the space, making my stomach growl loudly in response. I haven’t eaten since yesterday morning, before the tribunal.

The cook stands over the stove, broad-backed and solid, sleeves rolled up to reveal scarred forearms. His hair is streaked with grey and pulled back with a string, his face stern and lined, like someone who’s spent years under the blazing sun. When he turns, his eyes are sharp as he assesses me.

“You bring some help, boy?” he asks, not unkind, but direct nonetheless.

“Aye,” Lark answers, already rolling up his sleeves. He slides a small blade across the table toward me before grabbing two loaves of bread and setting to work. I take the knife and start slicing. The crust of the bread is tough to cut through, the blade almost slipping into my fingers. I soon get the hang of it, though.

For a while, no one speaks. The galley fills with the sounds of work, knife on wood as we cut, the scrape of plates, and the steady simmer of the pot. Lark watches my hands from the corner of his eye, either trying to copy

my movements or making sure I don’t mess up and lose a finger. Maybe a mixture of both.

“I voted to keep you," the cook says suddenly as he turns to set bowls and plates on the table.

I pause for half a breath, then keep cutting. It feels good to know that some pirates voted in my favor, and to know who they are. One less man I have to watch as closely as the others.

“It was almost a tie,” he continues, smoothing the front of his makeshift apron. “Many of us lost family to the song of a siren. Vicious little things you are.”

I nod, focusing on the bread again. “I understand. But it’s good to hear that only half of you want me dead.”

He lets out a deep laugh, and I fight a smile as it fills the air. As instructed by the cook, Lark and I fill the plates and bowls, setting out portions as the crew filters in one by one. Some ignore me completely. Others give curt nods of thanks. A few still spit curses at me as though they have witnessed first-hand what my kind is capable of.

The hostility is becoming grating, and I have tired of it very quickly. I understand the preconceived notions they may have about me due to my siren heritage, but I myself have given them no reason to believe they are at risk in my presence. I’m not here to win them over. I just need to make it through the day. When the last plate is taken, the cook wipes his hands on a cloth and looks at me again.

“You eating?”

I hesitate. “If that’s alright. I don’t expect to–”

He shrugs. “You cut. You eat. Easy as that, siren.”

Lark grins like he’s personally responsible for the decision. We eat in silence while the sounds of the ship carry on around us. The bread is a little bit hard, but not moldy. I dip it into the stew, soaking up the thick broth before bringing it to my mouth. It’s simple, but so rich in taste. I don’t realize how fast I’m eating until the bowl is empty. For the first time since I boarded the ship, I don’t feel like I might collapse at any moment.

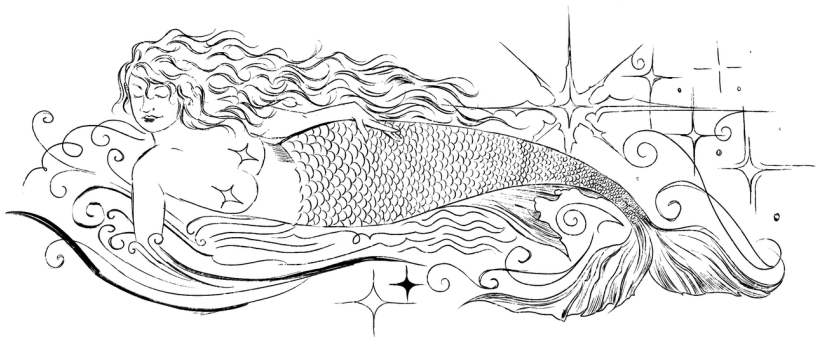
When we’re done, Lark nudges my elbow carefully.

“Cap’n said after breakfast,” he whispers, eyes bright, visibly excited by the impossible task the captain has given me. “About the Glim.”

I nod. “I heard.”

He straightens, the muscles in his face tightening into a more serious expression. “I know you’ll make it.”

I really hope he’s right.



Grim stands near the main mast as I reach the deck, arms crossed, posture rigid. His gaze flicks over me once, then shifts past me to Lark.

“Better get back to work, lad. Earn your keep,” he instructs, his tone sharp, serious, and Lark immediately hurries away to whatever chores were assigned to him. I know he wanted to see me summon the Glim, even though I told him multiple times that it won’t work like that.

Sable is a few paces away from me.

He’s still without his tricorn, his coat damp at the edges. He stands with his weight planted, his posture high and commanding, like the sea belongs to him and has to argue for every inch. Then his eyes land on me. The familiar cold pins me where I stand, all signs of empathy gone where they had glimmered briefly before.

“Up here, siren,” he says, jerking his chin toward the bow.

I move toward it, and as I pass, a few men fall quiet. The weight of expectation hangs thick in the air, almost suffocating. A crewman mutters something I’d rather not have caught.

“Should’ve let her drown.”

I keep walking.

Sable doesn’t react to the words, his face schooled into a neutral expression. I stop near the bow, where the wind is stronger, and there’s less clutter around us. The sea stretches out ahead, bright and open, painted in pinks, oranges, and turquoise. Coral reefs are visible near the sandbanks surrounding us, reflecting their colors. The water here is shallow and calm —almost too shallow for a vessel of this size.

The captain braces one hand on the rail and looks down at the water, then back at me.

“You’re out of the cell,” he says.

“I noticed,” I answer before I can stop myself.

Something crosses his gaze, then he straightens.

“Don’t confuse it with freedom. You’re here for a purpose.”

“I’m not confused,” I say, because it’s the truth. I don’t mistake this for hospitality or kindness. They want me to fulfill a task. That is all I am here for. His eyes linger on my necklace for a moment, then he looks away, as if he doesn’t care to ask where I got it from.

“You’re a siren, but you steal like a pirate,” he remarks, turning fully toward me. “You know why you’re here. You’re going to bring the Glim back.”

I blink, my fingers curling into loose fists at my sides. “I can’t.”

"I'm not asking if you can do it.” He closes the gap between us in a single step, voice flat. “I’m telling you that you will.”

Heat rises within me, the same heat that always flares when someone tries to claim my magic as their own. I clench my hands harder, nails biting into my palms. He’s no better than the hunters, thinking he has a right to take what isn’t his – what isn’t even mine to give.

“The Glim doesn’t belong to me,” I say, careful to keep my voice even, remembering what the ghost told me. It’s a creation of the sea and will only show up when it must interfere. “It appears when it wants to. When the sea wants it to.”

Sable’s mouth tightens. “It appears when you’re on deck. That’s no coincidence to me.”

“That doesn’t mean I can control it.”

His gaze shifts again, scanning my face, clearly searching for a lie. When he finds none, he exhales through his nose.

“Then you’ll have to learn,” he finally says.

I almost laugh. Learn. As if the sea can be trained into obedience.

“Why are you so sure I’m connected to it?”

As I ask the question, I try to catch something in his face that will give him away. He looks past me now, toward the horizon. His brows draw together slightly, focused, as if he’s turning the memory over in his mind.

“Because the Glim saved us from certain death. We were trapped in the harbor of Aurelith. The Royal Navy waited for us in the west, so the only

way out was through the intermaria. We weren’t sure it was the right choice, but then the Glim showed us the way.” his voice is quiet, contemplative. “And it appeared the night you came aboard.”

My stomach dips.

“You may think I brought it here with me,” I whisper. “But I can’t remember how I boarded the ship.”

“I think you’re tied to it,” he corrects, drawing in a deep breath.

“And if I can’t call it?” My palms are slick with sweat as I consider the impossible task ahead.

“Then you keep trying.” Sable turns his back toward the open sea. His dark hair whips in the wind, and like yesterday, the light turns his eyes to polished metal. “Until I’m satisfied.”

His words make my skin crawl. I can’t afford to fail, but I know what the ghost said—that it won‘t be an easy task. It only appears when the sea needs it to. And I don’t want to find out what will happen to me if I cannot summon it. Right now, I need it more than anything.

A creaking sound shifts my attention. The crew is gathering behind us, their expectant eyes boring into me. Rat stands among them, leaning against a coil of rope like he’s waiting for a show. His jaw is bruised where Sable struck him yesterday, the swelling warping his sneer.

Good. My inner siren is very satisfied with the sight.

Sable notices my glance. “Eyes forward,” he grunts.

I face the sea again with a sharp exhale.

“Do it,” he says, as if it is a simple task.

My throat tightens. I grip the rail, my fingers curling around the wood, and force myself to steady my breathing. The wind presses against my skin, and suddenly I feel very small standing here with their stares boring into my back. If I fail, I am not sure Sable would consider me worth keeping.

My pulse stumbles as I reach inward, searching for the magic within me, grabbing at it and pulling. There isn’t much to take, but the salt from yesterday recharged me a little.

Nothing.

Just water. Just the sound of the ship cutting through the waves.

I close my eyes and try again. I can’t even pretend I know what I am doing, what I’m searching for within myself. This time, I picture the Glim as it looked before—thin as a strand of hair, shining far brighter than is

natural. I imagine it slipping between the gap that separates the sky from the waves like a silver snake.

My muscles strain with effort. Wielding sea magic takes time, and I barely had any practice with the swarm. And even if I could, if the Glim truly belongs to the sea, I have no authority over it. Behind me, the crew's attention presses like heat against my back. Some chuckle at my failure to muster up any power. Others simply sigh, most likely in disappointment that they were wrong about me.

Sable speaks, low and close. "Again."

I bite down hard on my tongue until I taste blood. I won't give them the satisfaction of watching me fail. I definitely won't give Rat that pleasure. And most importantly, I won't allow the sea the satisfaction. It has witnessed my failure too many times before.

So I try again.

I open my eyes and stare at the water until my vision blurs. For a heartbeat, I consider stepping onto the rail and letting myself fall. Letting the sea take me. Maybe the shift would finally come. My fingers tighten until my knuckles ache.

Sable's hand lands on my shoulder, squeezing gently. His breath is hot in my ear. "Don't."

My breath catches in my chest. I swallow hard. He couldn't possibly have known what I was thinking, and yet, it's like he can sense my temptation to jump.

"I'm trying," I grind out and turn towards him.

"I know you are," he says. "But not hard enough."

"You think I'm holding back?" I snap before I can stop myself.

Sable turns, meeting my gaze. "I think you're scared."

I open my mouth, then close it when the right words don't arrive.

Of course I'm scared. I'm on a pirate ship I don't remember boarding, I almost drowned yesterday, and now my fate depends on summoning a cursed thread of sea magic I don't have the power to control. I don't understand why the sea keeps me alive just to test me again. Why he keeps me alive just to test me.

I grip the railing tighter, then force myself to breathe and allow my fingers to loosen. My shoulders drop a fraction as I turn my attention back to the water. Heat surges through me like fire in my veins, my inner siren

stirring beneath my skin. I rarely allow it to surface like this. Only in the water, when I try to force my shift. Because the cook was right.

We are vicious little things.

I close my eyes and let the feeling flood me. I embrace it. Desperation follows, and I pray to the sea like I have countless times before.

Please.

When I open my eyes again, a thread of silver glides beneath the surface. My breath catches. It's there. A line of metal-light drifting through the water ahead of the ship, as if someone drew it with an unshaking hand. The sea has finally answered my pleas.

Exclamations of surprise rise behind me.

"By the seas—"

"Glim—"

"Impossible—"

I don't move, I don't blink, afraid it will vanish if I look away. Sable steps up beside me, close enough that his shoulder brushes mine. Tilting his head slightly, he follows the thread, eyes narrowing as if he's reading a language he never learned but somehow understands. Then he pulls a compass out of his pockets, flips it open, and flicks his gaze back and forth between the Glim and the needle.

"Home!" he suddenly shouts, throwing both hands in the air, and the pirates roar behind us. Sable turns, his gaze sweeping across the ship as his voice carries clean over the wind.

"All hands," he calls. "Make ready. We follow the Glim into the Sea of Bones!"

The crew responds at once. Lines are hauled, sails adjusted, and the Noctis answers beneath my feet, turning in the water with a low groan as she gains speed.

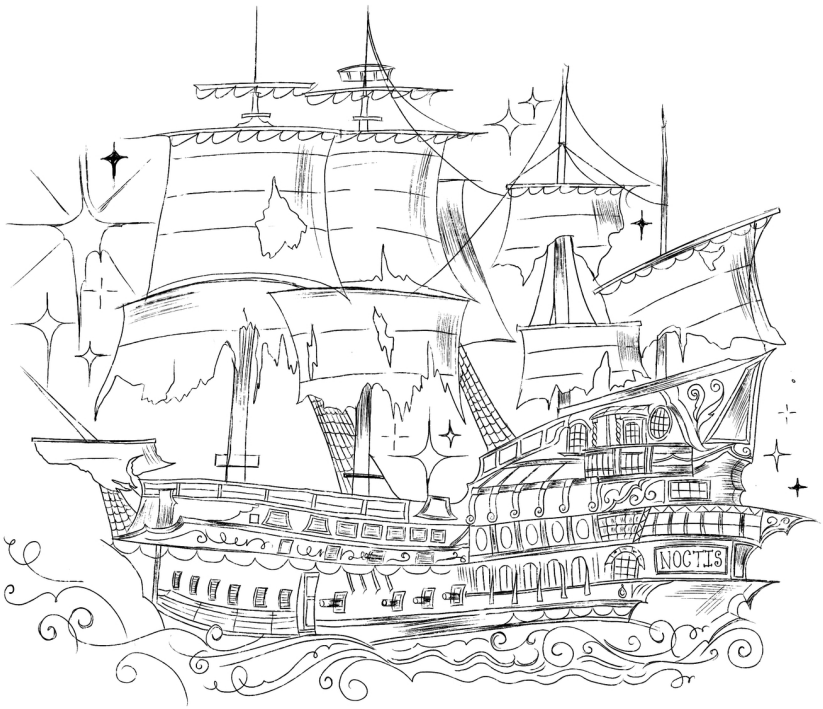
He turns toward me, eyes storm-grey and serious, but there's a flicker of excitement in them I haven't seen before.

"I knew you'd be more useful alive, little fish," he remarks with a devilish grin before striding off toward the helm, back in his element, barking orders.

I stare at the silver thread cutting through the water and realize that, for the first time, I don't know which frightens me more.

The sea's silence.

Or the fact that it finally answered my call.


NOCTIS

Chapter Fifteen

I SPEND THE NEXT FEW days working alongside the lower ranks. I help cook in the galley, serve meals, sweep the decks, and carry buckets that are far too heavy for me. I do so with few complaints. Because it gives me a purpose.

Lark apparently hurt his ankle two days ago when he slipped on deck, and he's taking some time to recover. I take over all his chores and then some. Nightglass seems to appreciate it and even paid his thanks with a slice of cheese and a comb. Another treasure I can keep for myself. Other than that, the crew still very much hates me. But still, I do not complain. I am still being watched and glanced at with skepticism, but I'd rather run from one task to another than risk spending another day in that moldy cell. I avoid the orlop like the plague and only go there to sleep.

The pirates down here keep their distance and even hung up a piece of sailcloth to separate me from them. Lark and Nightglass sometimes play cards with me in the evenings though. It's difficult when you can't recognize numbers, but I catch on quickly, and I've started to look forward to it once the sun begins to set.

The Glim is constantly there, guiding us through the colorful waters of the Sea of Renewal. Nightglass keeps an eye on it at all times, a task assigned to him by Sable, so of course he takes it very seriously. The ship moves steadily, but slowly. The winds aren't very strong, and the waters are considerably shallow. I know we're headed toward the Sea of Bones now, and even young sirens know what that means.

Pirate territory.

Which is also why most sirens avoid these waters. Only a few of us dare to live there, which is why I don't know much about it. Mother called them death sirens, and even I can admit that the thought of it terrifies me.

"Eryse!"

The shout snaps me out of my spiraling thoughts. I toss the holystone I'm using to scrub the planks into my bucket of seawater and crane my neck, shielding my eyes from the sun with my arm. Nightglass appears above, already back at his station in the crow's nest, eyes fixed on the Glim.

"Come up here!" he calls again, then turns back to keep his eye on the horizon.

Up… there?

I stare at the mast. It towers above the deck, rising straight and proud at the ship's center. It must be taller than the ship from keel to deck. My gaze follows the ratlines swaying around it, only loosely secured by iron hooks.

I've climbed one before, and that didn't end well. I do not like heights at all. Sirens live in the water. We do not climb mountains.

Swallowing, I grab the railing and set my foot on the lowest rope rail. The coarse fibers bite into my soft skin. Then I pull myself up and start climbing, the ropes rough and damp beneath my palms.

I've seen the men do this during storms, one-handed, knives clenched between their teeth. They make it look effortless. I certainly do not. When I reach the middle of the mast, I glance down.

I regret it instantly. This is so high.

Swallowing, I force myself to take a deep breath.

"Come on, lass," Nightglass chuckles from above, and I look up to glare at him.

"This is not funny," I snap, continuing upward with trembling legs.

"It kind of is," he says, laughing. In that moment, I want to throw him overboard so he knows what it feels like to be outside your natural element.

Okay, that might be a little drastic. The siren within me likes the idea, though.

When I reach the small wooden platform, Nightglass grabs my arm and pulls me up securely. A low rail surrounds it, and I'm grateful for solid ground beneath my feet.

"There you go," he smiles, already making his way back down the rigging.

“Wait.” I grip the rail, focusing on his face instead of the drop. “What am I supposed to do?”

“Watch the Glim,” he replies. “I’ll be back in an hour. Need to check on Lark.”

I give him a curt nod and quickly turn around so I don’t lose sight of the Glim. I still have no idea how I summoned it, and I don’t know if it’s repeatable, should it ever decide to disappear.

The ship’s movement is stronger up here, and so is the wind. The Glim moves beneath the waves, even fainter in the distance. The sea looks unreal. Gasping, I take in the view in front of me.

The water reflects the surrounding corals in shades of pink, orange, and purple. As cursed as it is, the way it sparkles and moves is breathtaking. Of course, it’s a trap. It wasn’t until the 90th Year of the Tide that humans realized that yes, the water heals, but it also takes a memory in return.

Sighing, I rest my elbows on the railing and watch the world pass in silence. The warm breeze smells of salt and something sweet, and it reminds me of home, wherever that was.

I don’t remember which sea I grew up in. Not because of the lost memory, but simply because I was too small to remember. My mother made me swim with the swarm whenever she could, but I was never fast enough to keep up and couldn’t stay beneath the water for long. Too often, she left me waiting on nearby islands. When I was lucky, my father was near, and he would stay with me until the swarm returned. They did not tolerate a pirate among them, though, so those moments soon became rare. I remember thinking I would be better off with him, how easy it would be to spend my life sailing the seas at his side. But my mother didn’t want to give up on me, and even when I was little, the sea was calling my name, always insisting me to try again, to stay. I was always in between the worlds, but didn’t feel at home in either of them. Finding my swarm would be nearly impossible, even if I got my tail back. Still, a small part of me hopes I’ll one day be reunited with my mother.

Moments later, my peace is interrupted by a brooding pirate captain. The wood creaks behind me, and the mast sways as his heavy steps reach the platform. It’s strange that I recognize him by scent now, but when I catch that salty, spicy musk, I know it’s Sable.

“What are you doing up here?” I ask, swallowing down my bitterness without taking my eyes off the Glim. He’s the reason for my nightmares,

after all.

“Making sure,” he says, stopping beside me, one hand bracing the railing, his shoulder brushing mine, “that you’re completing your task correctly.”

I nod slowly, a smile tugging at my lips.

“I understand. You don’t trust me with watching the Glim.”

“No,” he replies sharply, tapping his ringed finger against the railing. I refocus on the Glim, not wanting to give him the satisfaction.

“It’s too important to place in the hands of an outsider. Especially you.”

“Especially me?” I don’t look at him.

“A siren,” he answers matter-of-factly. Heat rises within me, threatening to burst. My inner siren suggests throwing him from the nest. I inhale deeply and force her down.

“Interesting,” he murmurs, studying me from the corner of his eye. “You know something about you changes when you get angry, right?”

“What in the abyss are you talking about?” I snap, glancing at him before staring straight ahead again, my breathing quickening.

“Your eyes. I saw it yesterday too. They turn white and foggy. And your scales…” he lowers his voice slightly, “they start to glisten.”

“I would know if that were true. Stop toying with me, Sable,” I mutter, pressing my lips together.

“Believe it or not, it proves my point. You might not have a tail, but you are what you are. You don’t control your anger. You act on instinct, not reason.”

He turns back to the sea, his gaze fixed on the Glim ahead. When he looks away, I turn toward him sharply, my hair whipping in the wind.

“You know nothing about me. And you want to lecture me on self-control?” A laugh escapes me. I spit my next words.

“You were the one who held a dagger against my neck.”

My breathing grows heavy, a knot tightening in my throat. “Threatening to pluck my scales,” I add, moving my hands over them instinctively.

“I wasn’t myself that day.” His words come out like a confession, his voice rough.

“That’s what Grim told me. But you did what you did, and I am what I am. Maybe we’re not so different.” I inhale deeply and swallow my anger. It isn’t worth it. He won’t see me differently, and I won’t see him differently either.

If I’m a monster, then so is he.

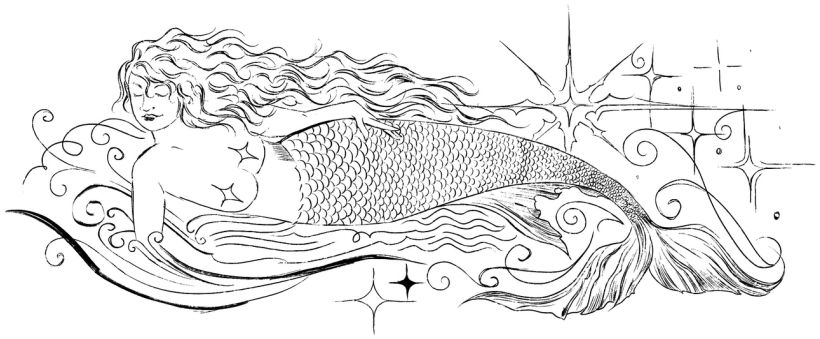
“Maybe. But that doesn’t mean I trust you.”

“I don’t trust you either,” I snap.

“Good.”

“Wonderful.”

Silence stretches between us as we watch the Glim and the sun sink toward the horizon.



Another week passes after my encounter with Sable in the crow’s nest. I avoid him, and he doesn’t seek me out as long as the Glim remains steady. Nightglass says it may take another day or two before we reach the Sea of Bones.

While the crew’s mood lifts at the thought of sailing home, fear grows in me. I don’t know what awaits me there, but I’m certain I won’t be welcome. There’s been no chance to jump overboard since we left the smaller islands behind, and even if there were, I don’t think I’d take it.

If the Glim is the Sea enforcing fate, leaving the Noctis would be going against its will. Maybe staying is part of something I don’t understand yet, something that will bring me closer to getting my tail. Besides, I’ve grown to like life at sea. It’s as close as I’ll ever get to living a life I would’ve lived with my father. I tell myself these things so I don’t have to admit that nothing ties me to Aurelith, that no one is waiting there for me.

So I survive, day by day, clinging to the last scraps of trust I still have in the sea.

Tonight, the crew celebrates sailing home beneath a cloudless sky. A makeshift table stretches from the main mast toward the bow, and nearly the entire crew gathers there, singing, eating, sharing stories. Like most nights, I eat nearby, perched on a barrel or a low stool. I’m never invited to join them, so I don’t. Instead, I refill mugs and carry empty plates below deck. I

come back from my last run and sit down on my spot, the barrel, and swallow down a dry piece of bread. I'm lucky today, because there's no mold on it.

"Eryse!"

My head snaps up. Grim sits at the far end of the table, waving me over and pointing to a free space beside him.

"Come eat."

I furrow my brows and glance around, briefly wondering if another woman has somehow appeared on the ship without my noticing. Once I'm certain he's addressing me, I rise and move toward him, the hem of my gown brushing the deck as the warm wind pulls it along behind me. I climb over the bench and squeeze into the narrow space beside him, ignoring the looks I get.

"Thank you," I whisper, warmth creeping into my cheeks when I realize he must've made room for me.

"It's naught," he says gruffly, and I still smile.

He heaps a generous portion from the center bowl onto an empty plate and slides it toward me. "You're all skin and bone. Eat."

"Thank you," I murmur again, suddenly shy. I eat quickly and let hunger win over any remaining pride. Grim chuckles beside me, but doesn't comment on it.

Then someone taps my shoulder.

Lark stands behind me, holding a plate with a whole grilled fish. The smell alone makes my mouth water. I haven't had fresh fish in a long time.

"From the captain," he mutters, pressing it into my hands before darting off.

I set the plate down, irritation prickling. Sable sits at the head of the table, his gaze briefly catching mine. His jaw is tight, his mouth a thin line, a muscle on his upper chest ticking once before he breaks his gaze to his untouched food. This is most likely his poor attempt at making up for what he did. Either that, or he doesn't want me collapsing mid-deck. Who would summon the Glim then? What a tragedy that would be.

Still, I nod at him in thanks. Grim murmurs something next to me that I can't understand as I take the fish with both of my hands and start tearing pieces of it away with my sharp canines. I save the best part for the end, the head. After I've swallowed that down as well, I lick my fingers, a low moan escaping my lips.

By the seas, that was delicious.

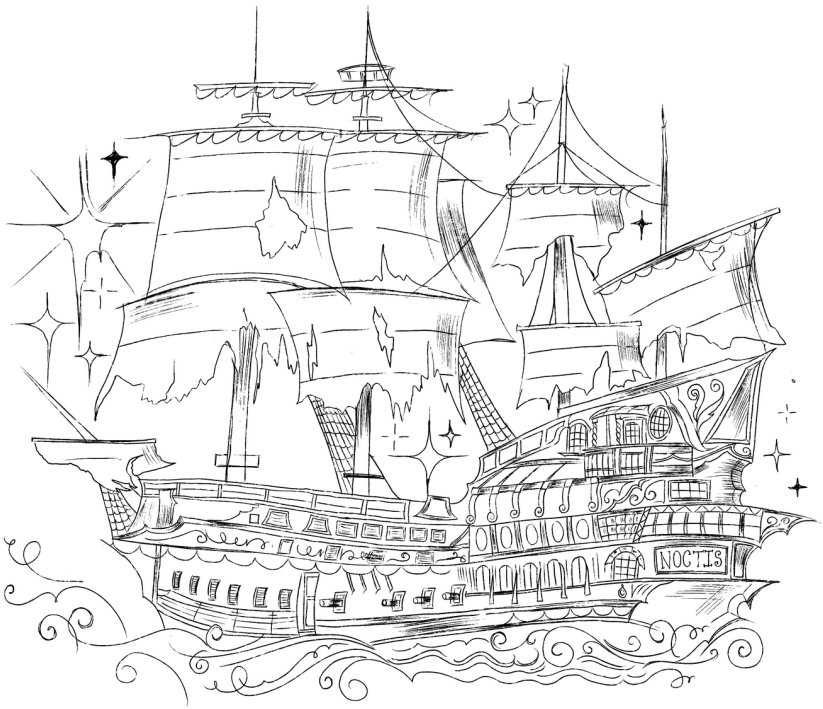
Only then do I notice the staring. I screw up my face and look around me.

“What did I do now?” I ask in a low voice.

“That’s not how we eat fish,” Grim explains in a whisper. “We don‘t eat the head.”

“Oh.” I bite down on my lip, my stomach dropping. I draw my elbows closer, suddenly aware of my hands, my teeth, the way I must look. How feral and unladylike it would seem to them. I dare to glance toward the head of the table. Sable is already staring at me, his mouth pulled into a knowing grin, that infuriating dimple deepening as his eyes flick to the fish bone.

That’s why he gave me the bloody fish.


NOCTIS

Chapter Sixteen

THE SEA LAST NIGHT was rough as the Noctis made it through the intermaria. Though this time, the crew didn't need my help. The Glim led them through the waters safely, and according to Lark, they have sailed through these waters many times before and know their way around.

When I step onto the deck that day, the weather has changed. It is still warm in the Sea of Bones, maybe even warmer than in the Sea of Renewal, but instead of a cloudless sky, it is now a never-ending grey void. An endless, dull sheet stretched from horizon to horizon, as if the world itself forgot how to make color. The water looks all-consuming, as if I were to throw a stone in it, it would sink for days. A sea like this could swallow the Noctis whole. There's no hint of coral, no light or sparkle dancing beneath the waves. When the hull of the Noctis moves, ripples spread like ink instead of light water. It looks like death itself cursed these waters.

Goosebumps spread all over my body at the thought of it.

The Glim is more visible in the darker waters. Thank the Seas, it has not disappeared yet, but ever since we passed through the intermaria, my inner siren is on high alert. She tries to break through, and I have a hard time containing her in the little, dark corner of myself I have cooped her into.

The unsettling feeling doesn't let go of me, and it becomes worse after nightfall. I constantly shuffle in my swaying hammock, but my thoughts keep drifting back to the ink-like water and the death it seems to contain like treasure.

The sea shouldn’t scare me. And it is not necessarily the sea that uneases me, but the fact that besides Lark, no one was really excited about our arrival in the Sea of Bones.

The ship is quiet. I can hear water dripping from a beam somewhere above me while the waves silently crash against the hull.

It is too quiet, I decide. I sit back in my hammock just in time as I hear an odd splashing sound that doesn’t seem to match the rhythm of the waves.

Carefully, I swing my feet over, meeting the ground with a thud, and climb the stairs to the deck as quietly as I can. I don't want to risk waking up any of the crew. When I reach the hatch and lay my hands against the damp wood, I hesitate. My instincts tell me that something’s wrong. But I can’t risk not checking – we could be in danger. So I push the hatch open and peek outside.

It’s pitch dark. I can’t even make out where the railing stops, and where the sea begins. Another splash. My stomach clenches tight as I push open the hatch with shaking hands. I get to my feet and let my eyes wander over the deck, searching for anything untoward. And then I see them.

Ghosts.

Their dark figures are standing along the railing, their outlines made only faintly visible by a flickering thin line of silver and blue. My breath seems to solidify in my throat as they stare at the sea in front of us. If they know I am present, they do not pay me any mind. One of the ghosts breaks loose from the formation and turns to me. It is the ghost with the loose tongue that has visited me during the night. I recognize him based on the way he walks towards me, the movement slow and deliberate.

“Risa. You should not be wandering the deck at night,” he whispers as he reaches me. Weirdly, his familiar presence soothes me, and I release a shaking breath.

“What is happening?” I ask him, glancing towards the sea, but I can’t see past the ghosts, not even with my precise eyesight.

“Go back below,” he presses again, his figure flickering, almost blending into the dark if not for his unearthly light.

“I’m not going anywhere until you tell me what’s happening. I know something’s wrong.”

His fingers tighten around mine briefly, as though he is debating whether to pull me back into the orlop by force.

“This is not for you to see,” he insists, glancing toward the dark water behind him. “Some things are easier to accept when you don’t witness them firsthand.”

Another splash cuts through the night, and my muscles lock.

“Tell me, what is going on?” I press again, louder this time.

“They‘re jumping,” he murmurs at last, sorrow filling his voice.

I furrow my brows in confusion.

“Jumping?” I repeat. “From where?”

He closes his eyes for a moment, hesitating, but then nods toward the sea.

“Come,” he takes my hand in his and gives it a tug. His shadows dance over my skin, the prickling sensation causing goosebumps to spread all over me. I trust him, I decide, and follow after him, towards the railing and the other ghosts.

We’re sailing past another ship, or at least the remains of a ship. The hull is almost completely swallowed by water, the mast looks broken and black sails hang uselessly and torn. No lantern burns aboard her. No one shouts for help. A sailor climbs the railing of the sinking ship, pauses, and lets himself fall into the water.

For a moment, I stand there, frozen, until my brain catches up to make sense of the sight.

“Man overboard!” I scream and rush towards the next rope. The ghosts gathered along the railing turn their heads towards me as I run past them, but do not interfere or make a move to help the drowning man. I try to pick up the heavy rope that is coiled on the floor and fail.

“Someone help!” I scream again, the muscles in my arm tensing as I try again, the fibers biting into my skin. I heave up the rope and throw it overboard with all I have. It splashes into the water and goes under. In horror, I watch the next man climb the railing and jump. He just sinks. He doesn’t even try to reach the rope. His body disappears in the water, until only bubbles at the surface remain. I stand there, utterly useless, as the Noctis silently passes the other ship.

“Their time has run out,” he says from behind me, his voice quieter now.

I keep my eyes on the dark water. “Run out of time for what?”

“For the bargain,” he says. “To rid themselves of the curse they were given.”

The ghost steps beside me and wraps one arm around my shoulder, then pulls me against his chest. I let him, because it tears my gaze away from the

crew jumping into the water, one by one. He feels so steady, so grounded, and I become acutely aware of the way my body fits against his. Without meaning to, I lean into that stability. He holds me until the sound of splashing becomes fainter, and I am sure we have completely passed the ship. I look up to find black eyes staring into mine. He blinks, slowly, and I try to remember how to breathe.

“Every pirate is cursed by nature, love,” he continues. “The sea does not let men take from her without demanding something in return. She gives them a trial. Sometimes a quest, sometimes a burden, sometimes a promise they must fulfill. It differs for each crew. But it is always binding.”

I swallow. “And if they fail?”

“They are called.” His fingers grip the rail beside me as he turns his head to look past the Noctis, where the shape of the other ship becomes smaller in the distance. “And the sea collects its debt. It pulls at them from the inside, until drowning feels like a mercy.”

When another swell lifts the ship, his hand slides from my shoulder to the curve of my upper arm. His thumb brushes there once, and warmth blooms beneath my skin, pushing back the fear.

“How cruel,” I whisper. “But I know that’s what the sea has always been.”

He lets out a low breath against my temple. “It is the only justice the sea believes in.”

I turn slightly in his hold so I can see his face properly, but it is nothing more than a blur of shadows. No matter how real his body feels against mine, he is not a man. I must remind myself of that.

“How often does it happen?” I ask.

“Often enough,” he replies with a sigh, his mouth tightening faintly. “Crews vanish between one full moon and the next. We often find ships drifting around with no hands aboard. Some try to outrun it. But none of that makes a difference once the sea decides it is time. They sail home to follow its call. That’s why—“

“—It’s called the Sea of Bones.”

He nods softly, a sad smile tugging at his lips.

“Aye,” he says, his voice quieter. “Because this is where they end, where they come to sink into the depths. Layer upon layer of bone on the ocean floor, that’s what lies beneath us.”

“And this crew?” I ask, though deep down, I already know the answer.

He hesitates.

“This crew,” he says carefully, “is no different. They were cursed the day they became pirates.”

I am at a loss for words. My breathing becomes heavier, and I grip the railing in front of me to not tremble and fall.

Can you help us?

Lark’s words echo in my memory and wrap themselves tight around my heart. This is what he asked me on my first day in captivity.

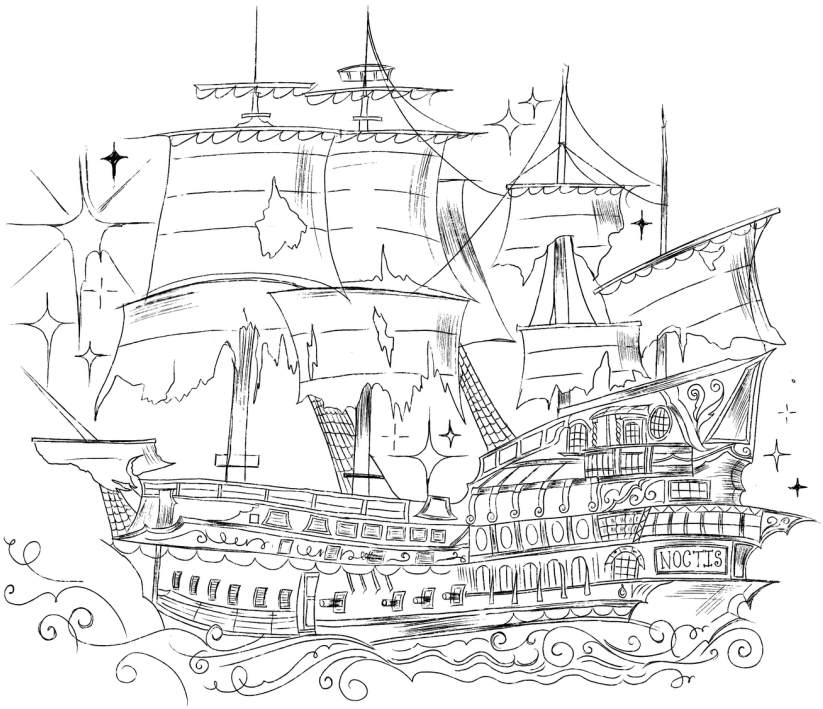
They haven’t broken their curse.

Their time is ticking, and if they fail to break it, this is what awaits them. This is their fate. The string of Lark’s words around my heart tightens and cuts deep when I imagine him climbing the railing and jumping overboard to drown like the others.

Tears blur my vision, but as I turn around, the ghost is gone.

The deck is empty. Only the dark water moves beside me, as if nothing has happened at all.

As if men did not just jump to their deaths in front of my eyes.


NOCTIS

Chapter Seventeen

“LAND HO!” NIGHTGLASS SHOUTS from the Crows’ nest, and the pirates interrupt their tasks to rush to the rail. Boot steps scatter across the deck as the whole ship suddenly becomes alive again after days of sailing through the black waters that have felt endless.

I haven’t dared ask any of the crew members about their curse. It feels too intimate for me to ask about such a sensitive thing as an outsider. Still, the truth lingers all around us, like the grey mist that constantly blankets the dark water. They must know that I know, and yet, no one has approached me. No one has addressed it.

And Sable? I have avoided him. His actions have unsettled something in me that I don’t know how to handle. It would be easier if he were cruel. But he isn’t, not in the ways that matter, and that leaves me with thoughts that I would rather not follow to their end. As long as I keep my distance, I don’t have to ask him about the curse. I don’t have to watch his expression, don't have to hear him tell me that he doesn’t trust me again. Most importantly, I don’t have to face the way my body reacts to him, or what that might mean.

Finally, curiosity gets the better of me, and I rush towards the bow of the ship, alongside some of the crew. The wind whips my hair away from my face as I lean over the railing to get a better look at the dark stone rising from the sea in the distance.

“We will reach it before the sun sets,” Grim appears beside me and lowers the spyglass from his eye, snapping it shut.

“Will I be allowed to leave the ship when we do?” I blurt out, unable to contain my excitement at the thought of feeling the sand beneath my feet again.

Grim laughs and shrugs his broad shoulders. “Captain has the final say, lass. Are you sure you want to leave the ship and set your scaled foot on an island filled with pirates?”

Of course, I’ve had this thought already.

“What, you think I’ll stay here on this ship like a coward?” I ask while glaring at him playfully.

“Aye. That you should do,” He replies with a smug grin on his face. “For my part, I’ll drink and find myself a wench to drown my sorrows in. There’ll be no time to protect you, Eryse.”

“She’ll stick with me.” A deep voice cuts in behind us, and I turn to find Sable standing behind us, one hand braced against the rail and his gaze fixed on the distant shape of land. His dark, thick hair falls in loose waves, and it is the first time that I fully notice the black ink that swirls across his arms before disappearing behind his rolled-up sleeves.

I can say all I want about his personality, but by the seas, he is devastatingly handsome.

Grim studies him for a moment, then nods once. “Of course, she’s your responsibility, Captain.”

Sable slowly turns, shifting his weight on his feet, his gaze falling on mine. I clench my jaw and swallow down the anger that starts to creep its way up my throat in the form of cursed words. Not directed at him, but instead, at myself. Not only is he a pirate, but he is also my captor. We seem to have a mutual agreement to hate each other, which is understandable given the situation, but still, my body seems to betray me at the sight of him eyeing me up, his gaze tracing every inch of me as though it is new to him. He clears his throat, bringing his eyes back to mine. Locking my attention on his.

“Why are you not working?” He shouts towards the crew still lingering near the rail, slightly cocking his head in their direction, refusing to break eye contact. The crew obeys and jumps back into work. Grim glances back and forth between us with a smirk on his face, then strides back towards the helm.

“I see you’re still here,” he says and crosses his arms over his broad chest, muscles flexing. I cannot keep myself from taking a glimpse of his

tattoos as his shirt falls slightly, exposing skin. The arms of an octopus curl around words that I cannot read. Next to it, there's a skull, sitting shoulder to shoulder with a heart, and a—

“Little fish, as much as I enjoy your eyes on me, I asked everyone to get back to work.” He steps closer, and I take a step back in response, pressing my back against the railing. My heart begins to beat so fast that I fear it might jump straight out of my chest.

A grin starts to spread on his face. He’s toying with me. Again.

I push my hands against his chest, and he steps back to give me space within an instant. I can’t ignore the heat of his skin against mine. The anger takes control again as I give him another shove for good measure, before crossing my arms over my chest.

“I have no work to do,” I declare, trying to sound nonchalant.

“Then go find yourself some,” his voice drops, suddenly drenched in seriousness again. “Everyone earns their keep on this ship. Looking pretty won't get the job done, although I must admit, it’s almost enough for me to let it slide. Almost.”

Narrowing my eyes into slits, heat crawls up my neck and seeps into my cheeks.

“I was not aware I applied for employment,” I say boldly.

One corner of his mouth lifts. “You are right, you did not,” he agrees calmly. “You were sentenced to it.”

The islands ahead grow clearer by the moment, dark shapes rising from the sea. My chest tightens at the sight of land.

“So, you will allow me to leave the ship if I stick by you?” I ask, trying to sound indifferent but failing miserably.

“You may,” he says, turning his focus to the approaching island. “If you stick with me. You do not want to wander around on pirate grounds alone. You are my—”

“Responsibility? Why must everyone keep saying that? I am perfectly capable of looking after myself on my own. I’ve gotten this far, after all.” I blurt out before I lose the nerve.

He hesitates, and for a moment, I think he will dismiss me, as he has done before. Instead, he turns his gaze again and looks at me with an intensity that almost makes my knees buckle beneath me.

“When the tribunal voted,” he says, “they voted for the sea. I chose otherwise.”

“That much I remember.”

A flicker of amusement passes through his expression. He might not admit it, but he likes my loose tongue.

“The code allows the captain to overrule the verdict,” he continues. “But if he does, he must bear the consequence.”

I watch him carefully. “Consequence?”

“You are under my authority.” He says, his eyes slightly darkening. “If you draw attention to us on those lands, I will answer for it. If you run, I will be punished for that too. If you cause any harm to another pirate, I am as good as dead. My life, my position on this ship, now depends on you.”

My fingers curl slightly at my sides as I think his words over. He chose this. Not just pulling me from the water, going against his crew, but this– tying his life to mine. I am not used to that, to someone choosing me when it costs them something.

“You took a risk for me.”

"A calculated one. That is not the same as doing it blindly.”

His gaze holds mine, and I keep my chin held high.

“Do not mistake this for kindness, little fish. I overruled them because I believe you are more useful alive than dead. That is all. I already told you as much.”

I nod, though I am not certain I fully believe this to be the only reason now.

“And because,” I add quietly. “You very much dislike being told what to do.”

“Careful, siren,” he says, the corner of his mouth tilting into something that almost looks like a smile, but I can see the promise of danger flickering beneath it. Silence stretches between us, and I become painfully aware of how close he stands, how easily he could close the distance if he wished.

“You will stay by my side on the islands,” he says, the sharp edge returning to his tone. “You will not speak a word to anyone unless I permit it. And you will not use that siren voice of yours. Not a screech, not a single hum. Not even a whisper of it should be heard.”

“You still trust me very little, it seems.”

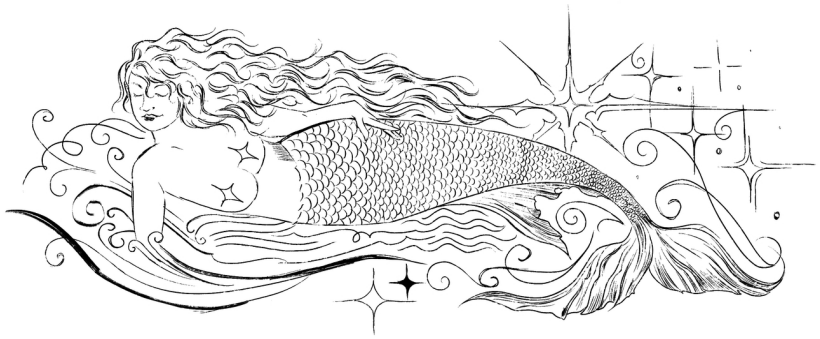
He sighs, annoyed with my natural resistance against him. “I trust you exactly as much as I can afford.”

“Mh,” I roll my eyes, not moving my body an inch, not even when he takes another step closer.

“You will be good. Aye?” he asks quietly, his hot breath caressing my face.

I hesitate for a moment, then nod. “Aye.”

It is the least I can do seeing as he risked a great deal saving my life, and personally, I have no intention of giving a dockside full of pirates a reason to look at me twice.



Grim was right. By the time the sun begins its slow descent, the islands have risen fully from the sea.

They fade into view piece by piece as the Noctis cuts through the black water. Dark cliffs break from the surface of the islands, jagged and uneven, their surfaces carved with sharp drops. Wooden houses cling to those ledges, built into the rock wherever there is space to hold them. They stack upward in uneven rows, one perched above the next, connected by narrow stairways, rope bridges, and plank walkways that stay between them. Smoke curls into the sky as it fades from a light grey to a dark shade of indigo.

The closer we get, the louder the ship becomes, and the dimmer the Glim shines. Sable barks commands to ready the ship to make port. The crew moves with purpose, tightening ropes and shifting sails. The Noctis slows down as we reach shallow waters, as if she knows this place as well as they do. Figures gather along the docks, and more appear on the cliffs above.

Slowly but surely, the Noctis stops moving, and the gangplank slams down with a heavy thud. With that, the Glim disappears. The crew pours onto the land, and laughter erupts around us; names are called in greeting. Someone even starts singing a tune in an awful off-key note.

I’m still standing at the railing, watching Nightglass and Lark reunite with who I assume is their wife and mother. She’s a gorgeous woman with

red hair braided down to her hips. She crouches down, and the little pirate clings to her like a little monkey. A smile tugs at my lip at the sight.

More pirates reunite with family as the lower ranks are still busy bringing the goods on land up from the hold, carrying more and more chests and barrels until they line up on the surrounding beach and the docks.

They must've been quite busy organizing things on their travels.

Sable is the last one to leave the ship. His shoulder brushes mine as we walk down the plank. Eyes follow me as our feet touch solid ground for the first time in weeks. A man leaning against a crate lets his gaze linger on me, dragging it from my face down to my collarbones. Sable stops. His head turns, and his eyes lock onto him. The man holds his stare, then his jaw tightens and he looks away first, pushing off the crate as if he suddenly has somewhere else to be.

"You have to remember," he carefully places a hand on my back and leads me through the crowd. "That many of us have lost someone to a siren. They will know what you are. The sea has its way of carrying rumors through the wind."

I quickly nod, pulling my guard up, though weirdly, him being with me gives me a sense of security that I haven't felt before. I'm not used to feeling protected.

"You remember what you promised me earlier?" he asks in a low voice, not wanting anyone to hear.

"I must stick with you. I am not to talk to anyone. And under no circumstance should I use my voice."

"Well remembered, little fish," he replies, and his shoulders relax by the second. No one has attacked me yet, which I take to be a good sign. The crowd naturally splits in front of us, which clearly proves that Sable's got a reputation that extends beyond his ship.

"Where are we going?" I manage to ask, while his hand stays firmly planted on my back. It doesn't feel like control, like a reminder that I am under his authority. This is nothing he does to keep me in line. In fact, it feels like he does it simply to…be close to me. To touch me. At the thought of it, my heart stumbles, and I become aware of the steady weight of his hand, the heat of it through the fabric. It would be easier if I could pull away, but I don't. And I can't. With a flicker of unease, I realize that I wouldn't want him to pull away either.

“To find my sister,” he replies decisively, “and then, we’ll have some much-needed fun.”

When I glance in his direction, a corner of his mouth is pulled into a slight smile.

“We will be having fun? Am I included in this scenario?” I ask, and immediately regret the question.

“Well, joining is optional. You can choose to stay miserable and mysterious, little fish. Whatever you prefer.”

I stop walking and punch him against his broad chest. Sable only flashes me a grin and then laughs, not even pretending that my hit hurt him the slightest.

“Stop calling me that,” I cross my arms over my chest as we keep walking further into the harbor. Fires burn along the quay, their heat warming my skin as we pass by. Nets hang from posts, heavy with drying seaweed and bone charms. The lanterns swaying above us cast a warm light on the wet cobblestone beneath us.

“Calling you what?” He asks, playing dumb.

“You know what I mean,” I roll my eyes, then glance behind me again. “Little fish.”

“Ah. Well, I have gotten used to the name. I guess you have no choice but to live with it.”

When the crowd becomes tighter again, and the wooden buildings seem to lean into the narrow pathway, Sable's hand finds my back again. Softer, this time, but it’s there. I want to shake off the feeling of electricity jolting through my body. I can’t be sure what it means exactly, but I know I shouldn’t be feeling it nonetheless. Not with him.

I swallow and take a deep breath. I catch Sable looking at me from the corner of my eye, and he removes his hand slowly, as if he himself feels what I feel, that it is too unnatural a feeling for him to keep his hand there. We are not the kind of people who would be touched in that way. But no matter how odd the feeling of his hand on my back was, I can’t help but feel disappointed when the pressure of it lifts.

He leads me further into the village. Now and then, I catch people gawking out of their windows or looking down from makeshift balconies as we pass by. Almost all the houses are made out of wood, and it looks like they just reused whatever was left from broken ships or was brought to the shore by the tide to build them. The door frames are painted or carved

beautifully. And then there are the bones that decorate almost every door. A symbol of loss and death, likely a memorial to family members they lost.

When I look ahead of us again, Grim disappears into the crowd.

Sable doesn’t slow his pace.

We leave the busiest part behind and climb higher into the rock, following a steep and uneven path. The noise becomes duller up here, and as I look behind us, I find fog already separates us from the life below. We cross a bridge, which brings us from one cliff to another. The stone walls pressing in on either side make the path even narrower, so that I have to walk in front of Sable now. Strange things hang from above, bundles of dried seaweed, glass bottles filled with cloudy liquid, and strings of shells that do not seem to be there for decorative purposes.

Then the path opens up in front of us, and Sable’s footsteps slow down behind me.

Built into the cliff itself, half made of wood and half made of stone, the house looks like it grew into the rock instead of being built there. There are no bones above the door frame, but instead, hundreds of shells surround the door that appears to be made out of driftwood.

For the first time since we made port, he hesitates.

“You don’t want to see her?” I ask quietly, looking up into his face, trying to read his expression.

Sable just stares at the door, eyes flickering towards the light spilling through one of the windows of the house.

“She doesn’t like surprises.”

“Sable, I don't think there’s any chance she doesn’t know we‘re here, it’s like you said, the sea has its way of carrying rumors through the wind.”

His gaze drifts for a moment, his jaw tightening slightly before he nods. He strides towards the door and is about to knock, but the door swings open before his knuckles meet the wood.

Behind him stands the most breathtaking woman I have ever seen.

“There you are,” she says, her white teeth flashing in her smile. “Took you long enough, brother.”

I stand there awkwardly as the siblings share a hug, and I use the opportunity to gawk at her shamelessly.

Her hair is black, like Sable’s, but where his is loose and slightly waved, hers is like dark, dripping oil, not unlike the waters that surround the island. Corals and shells seem to grow out of her, as much a part of her as her skin,

scattered around in all the colors imaginable. Faint pinks, deep reds, and oranges. The biggest corals sit on her shoulders like decorations. Like jewelry gifted to her by the sea. Her dress slides loosely over her figure, glistening in the lantern light like a seaweed layered over black silk.

When her eyes land on me, I do not look away. Instead, I meet her gaze and offer her a slight smile, careful not to show off the sharp point of my canines. I am certain that if she didn't want me here, I wouldn't even have made it up the cliffs. She is powerful. I can feel it in the buzzing of energy that radiates from her. Sea magic.

"So, this is the siren I've been hearing about," she says as she releases Sable from their embrace and steps towards me. The corals on her shoulder clink together as she moves. "The sea whispered about you days ago. It was all she could talk about."

The magic radiating from her makes the air around us hum. Where the imbalance of power between us may be a point of jealousy within me, it does not frighten me. Instead, I feel a connection there in the air between us. We're both creations of the sea, one of us decidedly more than the other, I'll admit, but it counts nonetheless.

I have never met someone even close to being what I am. She must know what it's like to be stared at. To be different. To be feared.

"Nice to meet you," I say quickly, offering her my hand. "I'm Eryse."

"Eryse," she repeats, a smile tugging at her lips as she looks at me knowingly with sharp eyes.

"I'm Cailia."

"Alright," Sable says from behind his sister, reminding us of his presence. "Now that you two have sniffed one another or whatever is customary for you, can we go inside now? We have a lot to discuss."

Cailia raises one brow, a smile tugging at her lips.

"He's impatient," she tells me quietly before turning to follow Sable into the house.

Tell me something I don't know.

As soon as the door is closed, the candles inside the room come to life and flicker, immediately brightening the room.

The walls inside are fused with corals in places where brick should be, pale branches of it crawling up the corners and jutting out underneath the roof. There are shells embedded into the walls too, not hung or placed, but as if they grew there. As if it is their natural place in the world. Glass jars

line rough wooden shelves, filled with water, sand, bones, or strands of kelp. In between them, books are stacked on top of one another, looking old and ancient.

Sable pulls a chair draped with nets and dried seaweed from under the wooden table and perches on it.

“We finally found the Glim,” he announces in all seriousness, straightening his posture against the back of the chair.

“Wrong,” she interrupts, walking around the table in slow circles, her long gown sweeping behind her. I am yet to fully enter the room, lingering by the entrance with uncertainty.

“It found her.” Cailia points one finger at me before continuing her pacing, the candles flickering each time she passes them. What does she mean by "the Glim found me”? The ghost told me it shows up to interfere and enforce fate. It doesn’t fully make sense, no matter how many times I think about it. The Glim is guiding the Noctis. Not me.

“So she is tied to it? Is it her fate we’re following?” I exchange a look with Sable. His grey eyes bore into mine, and I can’t bring myself to look away. He’s right to ask. If the Glim is there to make sure the sea gets what it wants, it could be leading me towards my fate, not the crew to theirs. And they have a curse to break, they cannot afford to follow the Glim blindly. A lump forms in my throat.

“Not necessarily. It could be tied to all of you.”

Cailia’s eyes land on me as she stops in her steps.

“Have you seen the Glim before you boarded the Noctis, siren?” she asks, her tone demanding, direct.

“No, I hadn’t even heard of it before I ended up on the ship, ” I answer truthfully and step toward the table, quickly glancing towards Sable for reassurance before looking at his sister again. He knows I don’t remember boarding the ship. She squints her eyes as though she is assessing my answer. She must hate dishonesty as much as her brother.

“If it first appeared after you boarded the ship, then that’s where you needed to be, I am certain,” she says and begins pacing the room again, her arms folded neatly in front of her chest.

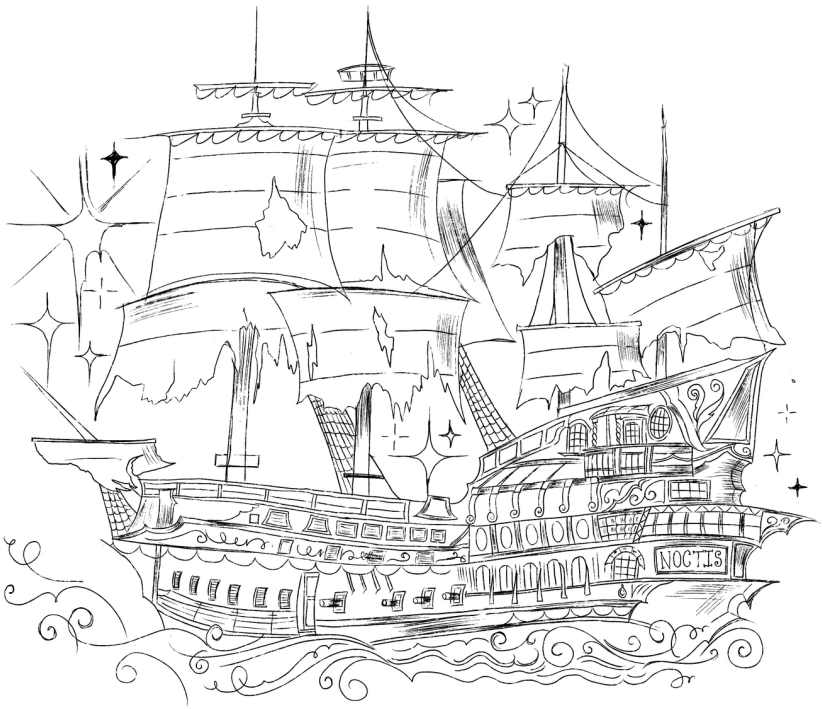
“Why do you think the Glim brought us back home? Could it be a sign that our fates are intertwined in some way?”

“I don’t know, brother. But do not question the sea. She knows. I can’t tell you more, but—“

She stops talking mid-sentence, inhales deeply, and closes her eyes, listening for something neither me nor Sable seems to hear, before exhaling slowly. When she opens her eyes again, they are pitch black. The light of the candles surrounding her creates flickers of light on their surface. Little dots of light, like stars reflecting on the surface of the sea at night.

"—the siren is your fate, Sable Crowe," she says in an otherworldly, smooth voice. I know whose voice that voice belongs to instantly. She has whispered things into my ear ever since I was a little child. Reassuring me. Mocking me. Taunting me.

The sea.


NOCTIS

Chapter Eighteen

CAILIA'S LIP CURLS INTO a smile that promises death.

"Follow and find me in the Sea of the First Song. This is where everything ends. Or everything begins." She continues, then snaps her head toward me.

"For both of you," she adds, her dark gaze dropping to my legs.

Then her body stills. Cailia drags in a sharp breath, her chest rising, the sound scraping through her throat as though she has been held underwater and this is her first gasping breath of air. Shoulders sinking, the magic that possessed the room moments ago unwinds. When her eyes lift again, the darkness inside them is gone, and so is the sea.

Sable and I stare at her, mouths slightly agape. Dumbfounded. She stands very still, her breathing steady, then blinks and glances between us.

"So, what did she say?"

The question sounds almost casual, as though nothing unusual or out of the ordinary has just occurred. As though the sea did not just speak through her. I furrow my brows and exchange a look with Sable, shock still visible in his features.

"She said we must follow and find her in the Sea of The First Song," he replies and straightens, though the tension in his shoulders does not ease.

Cailia's brows lift faintly.

"And that this is where everything ends," he continues, "or everything begins."

His eyes flick briefly toward me. "And that it concerns both of us."

“Hm.” She tilts her head, considering her brother's words. “Following her means following the Glim. That’s clear.”

She begins pacing again, slow steps circling the table while her fingers trace along the corals growing out of her collarbone.

“The Sea of the First Song...” she murmurs, more to herself than to us.

“I have never seen it marked on any map,” she says. “Nor mentioned in any charts.”

Another step follows, then she stops.

“But I have heard of it.”

Sable’s gaze sharpens. “Where?”

“In mother’s grimoires.” She glances toward the shelves crowded with jars and books. “It isn’t just another stretch of water. It is said to be where the sea itself was born.”

My stomach tightens. I have never heard of the Sea of the First Song. If it’s a well-kept siren secret, maybe my mother was not willing to tell me. Or she didn't know. That’s an explanation easier for me to accept.

“What do you mean by born?”

Her eyes move to me.

“Where the first tide rose. Where the sea first breathed life into its children,” she explains. “Sirens. Witches.” A brief glance lands on her brother. “And pirates.”

Sable falls into silence, then takes a deep breath.

“Just so I am not getting any of this wrong,” he begins. “You‘re saying we should sail to a place that we have no real record of? And then hope to begin instead of end? Whatever that is supposed to mean.”

“Yes.”

Sable gets up with a grunt, the movement abrupt. His hands curl into fists at his sides, fingers flexing once before tightening. “You’re a witch,” he says, voice taut. “Can you not perform some bloody magic trick that tells us what exactly we should do? ”

“Sable.”

Cailia raises her voice slightly, a clear warning in her voice.

He turns away from her and strides toward the round window overlooking the sea that now lies dark and still. He draws in a breath through his nose and holds it, shoulders lifting before slowly settling again. His sister follows and stops behind him, places a hand on his shoulder, and squeezes it softly.

“You know what you have to do,” she tells him, and the lights around us flicker in response, shadows shivering along the walls. “You’ve already come this far.”

Sable’s jaw is set tight, his throat bobbing as he swallows.

Her head snaps toward me. I avert my gaze at once, pulse stuttering, suddenly aware of how closely I have been watching him. I have never seen him appear so open, so vulnerable. His emotions aren’t usually so evident on his face.

“Will you give us a moment?” she asks, her tone hushed but demanding.

I give her a quick nod of understanding and step outside to give them some privacy. The sun has completely set by now, covering the pirate island in darkness. I wander towards the cliff beside the house, the cool night air kissing my face. Below, the sea spreads out endlessly, the waves crashing against the rocks in a steady rhythm. The fog has settled slightly, and for the first time since we entered the Sea of Bones, I can see the moon. Somehow, it has always given me comfort to know that wherever I was, sea or land, the moon was always there. A consistent force pulling the tide.

Sighing, I sit down on the cool stone beneath me and pull my legs to my chest. This explains a lot. Sable seems to think that the Glim will help them break their curse, and it sounds like he was right. That's why he insisted on me bringing it back when it disappeared. Why he jumped in after me. He’s trying to save his crew from the cruelty of the sea, and honestly, I cannot blame him for that.

I swallow down the knot that has formed in my throat. The beginning or the end, that’s what the sea said. I know what this means for me, either I die or…I finally get my tail.

“Eryse.” A deep voice snaps me out of my thoughts. Behind me, Sable makes his way towards me, and for reasons I don't want to examine too closely, my pulse stutters.

“Please don't tell me you’re thinking of jumping again.” He comes to a halt beside me and reaches out a hand with a smile creeping onto his face.

I look at it with widened eyes, hesitating. It’s a simple gesture, but the meaning of it hangs between us like an unspoken truth.

I will help you if you help us.

His fingers curl around mine as I put my hand in his, and he pulls me to my feet.

“I wasn’t thinking about jumping,” I snort, and keep my hand in his for a little while longer, before he pulls away in the same moment as I do. “But I still need to try.”

He nods slowly and puts his hands into the pockets of his breeches. When his gaze lifts and finds mine, there‘s understanding in it.

“You can. When the Glim appears again and we have to leave. But if you get your tail back, be prepared to be towed back on board regardless,” he says with a shrug.

“Of course,” I mutter and roll my eyes.

Sable already turns, ready to leave.

“Sable,” I blurt out, and he freezes. “Do you think the Glim will help us? With both of our…problems?”

For a moment, he doesn’t react. I bite down on my lip, unsure if I have overstepped. But eventually he turns toward me and sighs.

“I hope so, little fish. For both our sakes.”

I nod, thankful that he gave me any answer at all.

“Now come,” he says with regained confidence. “Or the good stuff will be gone before we arrive at the tavern.”

With that, he turns on his heel and begins to stride back towards the narrow path we came from. Seems like he is done discussing our respective curses for the moment. From the corner of my eye, Cailia is standing in the door frame. Her shoulders are no longer tense as she watches her brother leave.

I would like to stay a little while longer. To talk to her more.

Long enough to ask how the sea speaks to her. Long enough to understand how she learned to wield her magic instead. Long enough to ask whether she could help me with mine.

Instead, I will leave with more questions than answers.

“We’ll see each other again,” she says quietly.

Her gaze drops to the necklace around my neck. She nods toward it. “And keep the charm.” A small smile tugs at her lips. “I made it for Sable when he was little. But he doesn’t need it anymore. He’s gathered enough of his own.”

“Oh, I found it—”

“On the Noctis. I know.” Corals shift with a brittle sound as she tilts her head. “It will bring you luck. Now go, before he grows impatient.”

I nod, even though my chest tightens at the word go. I hold her gaze for a heartbeat longer, then turn away.

Sable is already halfway down the path, his silhouette almost swallowed whole by the dark. I hurry after him and catch up at the bridge spanning the jagged cliffs upon which the island is built. Moments later, we make it back to the center of the village that is now buzzing with life. Next to me, Sable relaxes as his shoulders brush mine. Shops line the path, their doors now thrown wide open. Glass charms and mismatched panes catch the lanternlight, throwing fractured colors across the ground. Coins are exchanged as different goods are handed over. Bright fabric, carved figurines, and of course, liquor.

It’s kind of chaotic and disorienting, but it’s also so…alive.

He walks beside me, his attention drifting to the crowd. When he glances at me, there’s something lighter in his expression, a hard contrast to his previous mood. Whatever Cailia said must have worked.

“Come,” he says, almost casually, “I’ll show you my favorite tavern.”

Sable walks ahead of me and slips through the crowd. I almost lose sight of him twice, but eventually, we make it to a tavern set slightly apart from the others, wedged between two leaning buildings. A crooked sign swings above the door, painted with a faded symbol that I don't recognize.

“Stick with me, little fish.” Sable places a hand against my back again and slightly pushes me forward as we walk through the open doors.

Pirates crowd around makeshift games, coins are exchanged, and dice made out of bones are thrown in the air. The air is thick with the heat of all the bodies, smoke curling low beneath the ceiling. It smells of spilled ale and sweat, all of it blending into a smell that my siren does not really like. The tavern itself is carved straight into the rock, its uneven walls reinforced with rough timber wherever the stone looks like it threatens to give. Lanterns hang from hooks and beams, their dim light throwing shadows over scarred tables and mismatched chairs. A long bar stretches along the far wall, crowded with bottles in dark colors. Behind it, a broad-shouldered man serves the pirates, slamming mugs down and pouring drinks without ever pausing.

Music weaves through it all. They are singing a scandalous song about a fine woman who gets swept off her feet by a pirate and ends up in bed with him. Someone plays a fiddle in the center of the room, and men and women dance around him.

I instantly notice a familiar face, one of the men dancing is Grim. He's dancing with a brunette woman, swaying on his feet with both hands wrapped around her waist. Their movements are fluid and perfectly in sync. I have never seen him so at ease.

Sable steers me through the crowd of bodies toward the back of the tavern, where a long booth has been claimed by some familiar faces and a few others I don't recognize.

"—and I swear on the bloody sea," a blond-haired man is saying, already halfway through his tale. "The maelstrom has us dead to rights. Waves as tall as masts. One wrong turn and the Noctis would've been swallowed into the depths."

Groans and laughter follow.

"Aye, and the Cap'n thought we were done for," another voice cuts in, grinning. "Didn't you?"

Sable laughs, but doesn't deny it.

The pirate slams his tankard down, sloshing rum across the table. "Then this one—" he jerks his chin in my direction just as Sable guides me to the edge of the booth. "—comes out of nowhere. Stands at the rail and tells the Cap'n how to cut the current."

I still, heat creeping up my neck, as heads turn to look at me.

"The siren girl saved our asses," someone else adds, lifting their mug toward me. "Whether she meant to or not."

The bench creaks as Sable slides in and shifts to one side, leaving space beside him. I hesitate until he tips his head toward it.

"Sit," he says briefly.

I slide in next to him. His arm remains along the back of the bench, close enough that I can feel the warmth of him through the thin fabric of my gown. My pulse stumbles as the story continues around us. I'm suddenly too aware of the way Sable leans in, of how his knee brushes mine when he shifts in his seat.

When I glance at him through my peripheral vision, I catch him watching me instead of the storyteller. Heat rises along my neck, and naturally, my body leans into the attention instead of shrinking away from it. When our eyes meet, he withdraws his arm and straightens his posture. I can't help but feel disappointed. By now, I can admit that I like his touch, the feel of his body against mine.

Eventually, someone slides a mug filled with a light brown liquid towards me. I take a cautious sip, then another, and feel the tightness loosen by friction. Liquor. One drink turns into another as the tavern grows louder. I stop counting my refills at one point and lean back against the uneven wood behind me, barely able to follow the conversation at the table. The liquor burns less now, or maybe I've stopped noticing.

Then Sable shifts beside me. Moments later, his hand settles against my thigh. The touch is casual, the alcohol has emboldened him, yet my breath stills all the same. His thumb presses into my skin before moving in a slow, absent circle, as if he is not entirely aware of what he is doing.

But I am aware. So ridiculously aware that warmth begins to spread from where he is touching me, all the way through my body until I am engulfed in flame. My eyes lift to his, and this time when our gazes meet, he does not pull away. The tavern noise fades away, becoming distant as we stare at one another.

Then one corner of his mouth lifts. So he is aware.

"Dance with me," he says.

I blink at him once, surprised. "You dance?"

A low chuckle leaves his throat. "Sometimes."

Before I can think too long about it, he grabs my hand and pulls me to my feet, gently guiding me past the bench and toward the dancing crowd. The fiddle player shifts into a faster tune, and boots begin stomping along the floorboards before the melody has even settled.

"Come on," he says, already reaching for my other hand. He pulls me toward the dancers before I can protest, weaving through bodies until we are in the middle of the circle that has formed around the fiddler.

The crowd shouts and whoops as Sable and I step in, though I can see some of the surrounding pirates glancing at me in hatred. Swallowing, I lower my gaze, not wanting anyone to stare at the scales on my collarbones for too long. He draws me closer, his hand settling at my waist while the other keeps hold of mine. His mouth lowers to my ear.

"Ignore them," he whispers. "Focus on me."

The weight of the stares on me doesn't disappear, at least not immediately, but then I shift my focus to him. On his firm hand on my waist, on his breath against my ear, the heat of it. Suddenly, all I can feel is him, and everything else fades away.

When he begins to move, my feet recognize the dance before my mind does. My father taught me dances like this when I was small, laughing as he spun me across tavern floors, way past my bedtime. Even though my heart stings at the thought of him, right now my heart is filled with something I haven't felt in a long time. Something I haven't allowed myself to feel. Joy.

We spin across the floor together and move with the rhythm of the music. The circle of dancers shifts and opens, partners passing one another before catching new arms and swinging again. Laughter rises around us as Sable lets go of me, the world spinning around me. The next moment, Grim has his arms around me, grinning down at me.

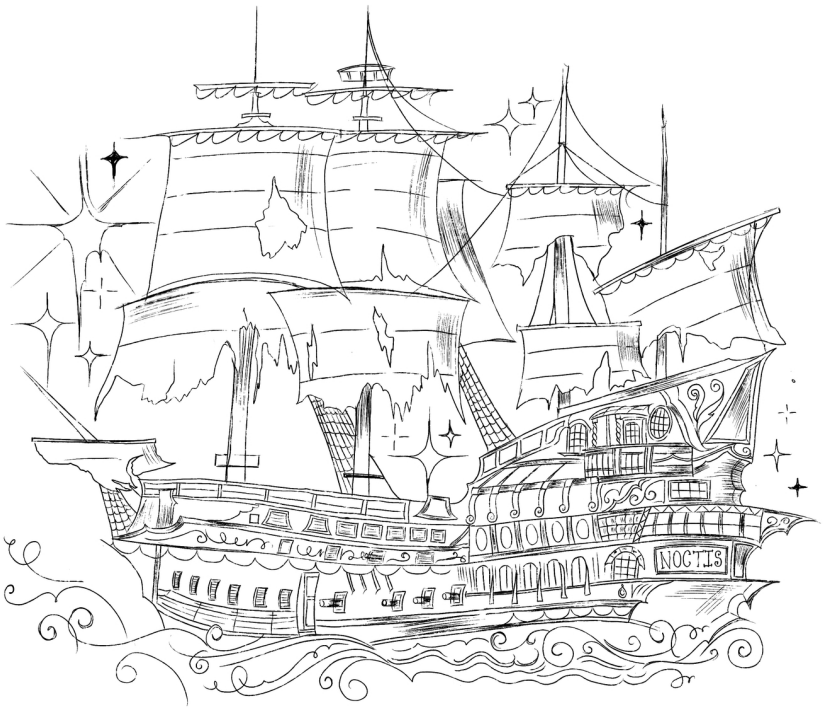
"You and the captain," he shouts through the noise. "Anything I need to know?"

The heat instantly finds its way to my cheeks. I quickly shake my head.

"There's nothing to know," I shout back to him.

He laughs, then spins me again, and I collide against a familiar chest. Sable catches me with ease, and as I look up to him, his grey eyes shine bright in the lantern light. When his grip tightens and he twists me around once more, a laugh bubbles out of my throat. To my surprise, he laughs too. The weight that usually sits in his shoulders seems to vanish as the music carries us along, and for one fleeting moment, I can see past the curse, past the mystery of the pirate captain. I see only him.

Just Sable.


NOCTIS

Chapter Nineteen

THE BOW OF THE fiddle lifts, and the music cuts off. Cheers erupt as the dancers break apart, stumbling outside or back toward their tables. My chest rises and falls quickly as I push damp strands of hair away from my face.

“I need some air,” I say, half laughing as I catch my breath.

Sable's gaze flicks toward the door and back to me again, hesitating. Then he nods, a smile still tugging at his lips.

“Go on,” he says. “I’ll be with you in a minute.”

His hand lingers on my waist for a little while longer before he lets it fall away.

“But don't wander far, little fish. You remember what you promised me earlier?”

I dip my head in agreement and slip through the crowd toward the door. Someone spits the words “siren whore” as I pass by, but I shake it off as nothing more than a heated insult. Cool night air greets me the moment I step outside, cutting through the haze in my head. With the door swinging shut behind me, the tavern noises become distant and muffled.

Drawing in a deep breath, I realize I had a little too much rum. When the lights from the lanterns swaying in the breeze above begin to blur, I lean against the stone wall of the tavern, trying to anchor myself. Nearby, pirates lean against crooked walls and sit on overturned barrels, tankards dangling loosely from their fingers while they shout over one another or stagger

between the buildings in uneven lines. It is still very much crowded and very much chaotic.

“Look there,” a voice mutters somewhere to my right.

Another answers with a snort. “That’s the captain's little siren,” he snarls.

“Disgusting,” another one says and spits on the stones near my feet.

Within the blink of an eye, the alcohol vanishes from my veins. It was foolish of me to allow myself into such an inebriated state. So foolish to once again forget how dangerous it is to look like me in a place like this.

Glancing back toward the tavern, I hesitate. The doorway is no longer clear. More bodies have gathered, pirates spilling out into the streets. A few of them already look my way, their attention fully on me as the murmurs begin to spread. Going back would mean walking straight into them.

I lower my head and start walking past the other pirates, in an attempt to get away. If Sable follows me as he said, I am sure he will find me. And even if he doesn’t, I can’t spend any other second breathing the same air as them. The last thing I want is to lose control and break my promise.

My feet carry me downhill as fast as they allow me, away from the lights and the noise. Their eyes follow me as I move deeper into the paths of the village, the muttered words trailing wet and slippery behind me like eels.

“Her eyes—“

“Creature—“

“Monster.”

My hands curl loosely at my sides, nails pressing lightly into my palms as I remind myself again and again that losing control here would be worse than any insult they can throw. I promised Sable not to use my voice. Not even a whisper. A flicker of guilt passes through me, one I would rather ignore. He also told me not to wander far, yet here I am, wandering away.

The street begins to slope downward as I move farther from the harbor square. The paths grow quieter, but still, the pressure inside my chest refuses to ease. The siren in me doesn’t like the fear that pulses through me. She is restless, turning beneath my skin, begging me to set her free. My throat tightens, and I swallow hard, forcing my lungs into calm, steady breaths, but my thoughts continue circling, like gulls taking to the air above a ship.

In the distance, there’s the long hush of waves breaking. Somewhere beyond the houses, the tide breathes against the shore.

Come to me, the sea whispers.

Without thinking, I follow its call. Each step towards it loosens something in my chest, yet my pulse still beats faster than it should. It is only until the sand cools my soles and the water washes over my ankles that I can catch a clear thought. I let the sound of the gentle waves fill the empty space in my mind, letting it wash over the anger still tangled in my chest until it begins to soften.

I close my eyes and draw in a slow breath, when suddenly, the water ripples a few yards out. The siren inside of me goes very still. The ripples form again. I snap my head up to follow the movement.

Eyes rise from the dark water and fix on me, unblinking. My breath catches in my throat as I catch a glint of a tail beneath the surface, the familiar slow movement sending a sharp ache through my chest.

My heart lurches. I know what is watching me from afar.

The siren is calm, her movements in the water barely noticeable. Her eyes look like mine, white and foggy, split clean down the middle by a dark, narrow slit, watching me without blinking.

I am rooted in the spot as she stares me down, and I stare right back. Someone without my eyesight probably wouldn't even have noticed the creature lurking beneath the water.

Then, ever so slowly, she lets her body drift towards the shore, edging closer. Her head tilts slightly to the side as she examines me carefully. There are gills at the side of her throat, scales that scatter along her collarbones up to her temples. They're in the same shades of grey as her magnificent, long tail, making her almost invisible in the surrounding water.

"You're far from the currents," she whispers in a soft, soothing voice. "Why do you walk among them?"

I forget how to breathe for a beat too long as recognition glints in her eyes. She knows what I am. She can see it in me.

"We follow the Glim," I whisper as I carefully glance to both sides, ensuring no one is watching us. "It's the sea's will."

"Mh." She drifts through the water again, this time even closer, until her pale shoulders rise and her hair is slicked back against her head. "And you trust them?"

There's the strain of judgment in her soft voice, and the pity hits my face sharply.

"I don't have a choice," I explain, "I have nowhere else to go."

Her eyes glance down towards my legs before looking at me again, now with a deep line between her brows.

“Nowhere,” she says quietly, “is still better than with those men.”

She turns her head toward the open water, chin tilting just enough to draw my attention past the shoreline. The sea stretches out, dark and endless.

“They will rip your heart out when they’re done with you and say it was a merciful end,” she adds in her lilting voice, no hint of fear clinging to her words. The world narrows down to what is in front of me. I know what she’s saying is true. I remember the stories told in our swarm about sirens taken by men who hoist black colors. That they are cruel, and the sacrifice of a cruel soul gives us our magic in return. But my father was not cruel. He was strict, but kind. The Crew of the Noctis could’ve treated me way worse if they wanted to. But they didn‘t. Sable didn’t.

“I don’t think they’re all the same.” My voice is nothing more than a whisper as I think about Lark. He’s still so small. He has never killed, I am certain. An image of Sable flashes through my mind, but I do my best to push it away. I have broken his trust by coming here. He probably won’t trust me again.

The siren tilts her head again, the gills at the side of her throat subtly pulsing as they try to pull in water that is not there.

“You are foolish if you mistake their laughter for kindness,” She drawls, her tail lazily flapping against the surface.

“They do not love sirens,” she continues. “They love what sirens can give them.”

My heart aches as I take her in, how she blends in effortlessly with the sea. At the sight of her tail, I dig my toes deeper into the sand until they are completely buried in it. Her eyes flick past me, fixing on something behind my shoulder.

“Pirate,” she whispers.

I turn to find Sable coming down the path from the village with a lantern in his hand, his stride long and purposeful. He doesn't slow when he sees me, but he slows when he sees her.

His entire body locks.

The air between us tightens as his hands drift toward his leather strap on instinct, fingers curling around his knife. His jaw clenches as they rank over the siren's face and her tail half-hidden by the dark water.

“Get away from her,” he snarls.

The siren's lips curve, slow and knowing. She does not retreat. She does not use her voice either. Her eyes lock on me again.

“If the sea shows mercy and gives you your tail, I hope you are as far away from humans as possible, sister.”

Sable’s gaze flicks from the siren to me. Whatever thought crosses his mind, he cuts it off with a step forward, placing himself between us. The tide kisses his boots, then retreats.

“Leave,” he says quietly, the warning clear in his voice. His hand is curled around the handle of his dagger now, ready to draw it.

The siren doesn't flinch. With a tilted head, she studies him instead. I don't miss the way Sable stills, like he’s aware of exactly how thin the line is, how close the siren is to just using her song on him and pulling him into the depths.

“Very well,” she says with a smile on her face, flashing her canines. Then she turns and sinks back into the sea. To me, it is clear that she spared his life, not the other way around. Sable doesn't move as the water settles again, the last ripple smoothing itself out.

Neither do I.

I keep my eyes on the dark water, on the place where she disappeared, because looking at him feels like it would make something in me snap.

They will rip your heart out.

Her words echo through me, relentless. I want to dismiss them. It would be easier to blame the siren for stirring my fear, for turning ordinary men into monsters in my mind.

But tonight I have seen the way they look at me. The memory of the spit striking the stones near my feet returns so vividly that my jaw tightens, and it feels as though my canines lengthen, the siren inside me baring her teeth in front of the man who spared my life. The man who spun me around the tavern mere moments ago. Anger, embarrassment and sadness hit me all at once. Anger, because of how easily they turned against me. Embarrassment, because of how defenseless I was without my song. And sadness, because of how Sable is looking at me right now.

I haven’t even noticed until now that I’ve started crying. Tears well in my vision as I avert my gaze, looking anywhere but at him. My hand covers my mouth, hiding my canines, but I know he has seen them.

Next to me, footsteps shift in the sand. I expect him to pull out his blade. To hold it against my throat, as he did when he found out what I was.

But it doesn’t come.

The lantern light grows brighter as he approaches, the warm glow cutting through the cold sheen the moon has painted across the water. I keep my eyes fixed on the sea, trying to console myself.

“Risa.”

The sound of my name on his lips sends goosebumps down my spine. Sable places the lantern in the sand between us, then takes another step towards me.

“Look at me.”

Something in the steadiness of his voice anchors me, and I let the sound press against the chaos inside my chest. Suppressing it. I can’t face him though. Not yet. I am not ready to see the fear, the disgust in his eyes. But he wraps his fingers around my wrist, with a gentleness that I was not expecting. My lungs draw in a shaky breath before I can bring myself to turn to face him, bracing myself for the look on his face.

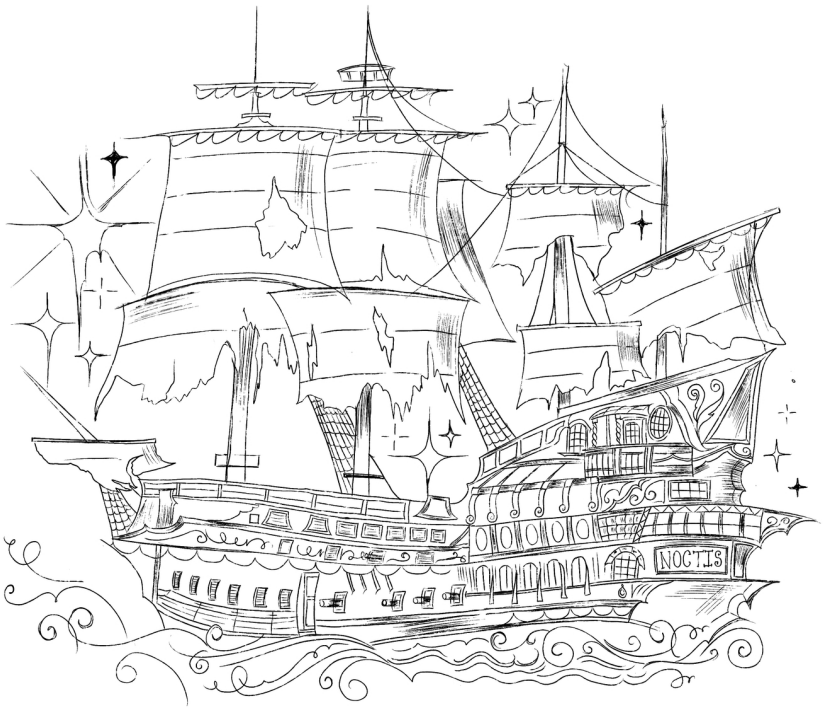
“The siren is wrong,” he whispers and presses his thumb against the inside of my wrist.

His brows are drawn together, his jaw set tight, but there’s no fear in his eyes. In the lanternlight, they remind me of the sea just before a storm breaks, carrying currents beneath the surface that reveal themselves only when the lightning strikes them the right way. Right now, those eyes scan my face with quiet understanding.

“I’m not afraid of you,” he continues after a moment, his voice low enough that the waves almost cover it. “I know what it’s like to stand face to face with a version of yourself you don’t recognize. And to feel it winning an unspoken battle.”

His eyes hold mine as he gently takes my hand covering my lips. I do not resist as he lifts it away from my face. My breath catches. If he sees my canines, he doesn’t acknowledge them. Sable simply looks at me as he lets his thumb caress my knuckles, before tightening his fingers around mine in a brief squeeze.

“Believe me when I tell you this,” he says, his voice steady. “I know the difference between a monster and someone who is simply trying not to become one.”


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty

I LOWER MYSELF INTO THE sand, processing what he just said, and shortly after, Sable sits down next to me. The lantern sits between us now, casting a golden glow against the dark water in front of us.

For a considerable amount of time, neither of us says a word. The village behind us has grown quiet, leaving us alone with the rushing of the sea. I don’t know what to say to him, or rather, I don't know where to start. I want to apologize for wandering off. For making him chase me down, even though I promised him to stay. And I want to ask him about his inner demons, and if they had the upper hand when we first met.

Eventually, Sable shifts beside me.

“How did you learn that dance?” he asks, his voice breaking the silence.

I glance at him.

“The one in the tavern.”

I bite down on my lip, trying to decide whether I want to tell him the truth about my father. It could change things, make it more complicated between us than it already is. Telling him feels like opening a door I have kept barricaded for years. I try to avoid thinking about my father, my pirate heritage. It leaves me thinking about all the what-ifs. What if he didn’t die? What if he picked me up on that day? Would I be sailing the seas with him now, far away from the chaos of the Noctis? I can’t help but wonder if I would’ve felt at home, with my father and his crew, if I had accepted the absence of my tail and grown to love and appreciate my legs for what they are – a reminder that I come from him. That I belong somewhere.

“My father taught me,” I say finally.

Sable turns toward me, the light catching his expression as his brows draw together, confusion twitching at his lips, causing them to tremble.

“Your father...”

“A pirate,” I add quietly.

It feels as if I have dropped a stone into still water. My words will only ripple out until I cannot rein them back in, until they’re out of my control.

“A pirate,” he repeats, and a corner of his mouth lifts, a light chuckle escapes. “I have to say, I wasn’t expecting that.”

I shrug one shoulder, drawing my knees closer to my chest.

“I suppose it explains a few things,” he says and leans back on his hands, the movement casual. “Like your stealing. The bone charm. The boots you are wearing.”

I turn my head towards him now, staring him down as heat prickles the back of my neck. I have to fight back an embarrassed laugh.

“You noticed that?”

Sable chuckles. “Little fish, I command a ship full of thieves. I notice everything.”

My lips press together, but I cannot stop the small smile from forming.

“You can’t steal what has already been stolen,” I say, lifting my chin slightly.

“That,” Sable replies dryly, “is exactly what every pirate says.”

The moment softens between us, the quiet laughter fading away into something easier, less tense. And we sit like this, a little while, we sit here listening to the water as it laps on the shore. It’s Sable that breaks our wordless silence first.

“What happened to your father?” he asks carefully.

I sigh, not wanting to think much more about it, but I knew he would ask eventually, that my admission would spark even more questions in him. I have buried that truth deep inside of me, even deeper than where I contain my siren. It still hurts, even after all these years. I don’t think it will ever stop hurting.

“He was hanged.”

The words leave my mouth easier than expected. Perhaps time has worn the sharp edges from them, softening their escape. Perhaps I have slowly learned to live with the truth of it.

“I was seven,” I add after a moment. “When my mother left me and told me to wait for him. I waited, but he didn’t come. Fishermen took me to Aurelith, where the royal navy made a spectacle of it.”

Sable stills beside me, but I watch the water instead of him.

“You witnessed it?” he asks, his voice nothing more than a whisper.

“I did,” I answer and swallow down the knot that has formed in my throat. “But I went to the Sea of Renewal after. I begged the sea to take the memory from me, and it did.”

When I turn to look at him, his hands tighten in the sand beside him. His gaze is fixed somewhere out over the water, his jaw set as though he is holding something back.

“I’m sorry you had to carry that alone,” he finally says and exhales slowly through his nose.

“Sometimes I regret it,” I whisper, hugging my knees tighter. “Because it was the last time I saw him. And I let the sea take that memory.”

Sable rubs his thumb across the side of his jaw, a gesture I’ve begun to recognize as one he makes when something unsettles him.

“My father was hanged too,” he says eventually. “You don‘t want to remember it, trust me.”

His head turns towards me reluctantly, as if it costs him a lot to confess this to me. I give him a reassuring smile, one that tells him that what he said is safe with me. That he is safe with me.

He swallows, then watches the sea again.

“What about your mother? Where is she now?”

I sigh. My mother’s story is more complicated, and somehow it cuts deeper than my father’s.

“My swarm abandoned me,” I say, and realize how strange the explanation might sound to an outsider.

“I think she loved me,” I add. “But I was never meant to live in the water with the others. I couldn’t. Without a tail, I would have been vulnerable. And that impacts the safety of the whole swarm. She was forced to leave me in my father’s hands. She had no choice.”

Sable says nothing, but his attention rests fully on me now. A memory of my father and my mother flashes through my mind, him kissing her from a rock near the shore.

“They loved each other,” I say with a smile on my face. “They loved each other dearly. And they loved me.”

“A pirate and a siren...” he says with amusement heavy in his voice, “How scandalous.”

Silence stretches between us again, both of us staring at the water like it might hold the answers to questions neither of us is brave enough to ask out loud.

“You said you understand what it's like to…try not to become a monster.” I start carefully, knowing how fragile the trust we have built between us is.

Sable’s shoulders stiffen beside me.

“Is that…related to the curse?” I whisper, not wanting to upset him. I regret the question the moment it leaves my mouth.

“That’s not something you need to worry about,” he says, and gets up, brushing away the sand from his breaches.

“But you’re—”

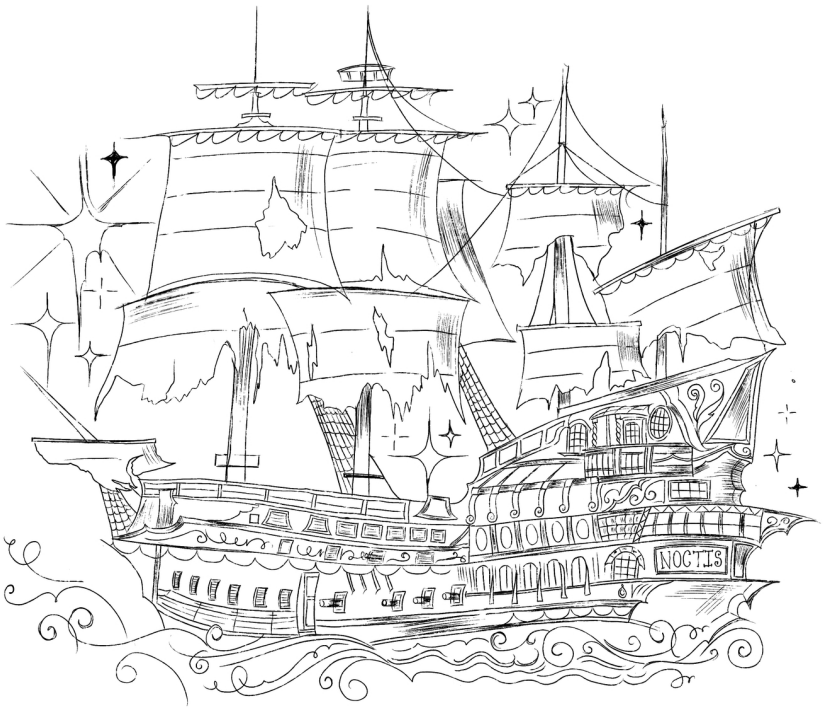
“That conversation,” he interrupts me harshly, “is not for tonight.”

He leans down to grab the lantern, its light casting shadows across his tensed face. Within the blink of an eye, Sable turns back into the notorious captain of the Noctis. We were both beginning to open up, and I have ruined it. I should’ve expected him to react like this, but I was blinded by the vulnerability of the moment.

“We should get back to the ship,” he says and turns to walk back towards the Noctis looming in the distance. He doesn’t wait for me to follow him, so I remain seated, watching him leave, until his shadow disappears behind the rocks.

The space beside me feels empty now that he is gone. I always knew that there was something about him, something dark and conflicting. But now I am certain that whatever it is, it is tied to the curse.

And to the monster he tries not to become.


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-One

WHEN I WAKE ON the Noctis the next morning, the island and its people are still asleep. It feels strange to lie in this hammock, without the water rushing beneath the hull the way it usually does. I stare at the wooden ceiling above me for a moment longer, watching moisture gather along one of the beams before slowly dripping down.

Sable simply vanished last night. He made no effort to find me again, no attempt to explain why he just left me sitting there like a fool. I stayed by the water for a long while, staring into the endless night, a small part of me hoping the siren might return so I could ask her more questions. But she didn't. And he didn't.

When the water droplet hits my cheek, I stretch, trying to coax some of the tension out of my muscles. The ship is quiet, unusually so, as though the Noctis itself is still asleep. The damp wood beneath my feet feels almost familiar by now, its uneven grain pressing into my soles. My gaze drifts to the small pile of clothing tucked near the wall. Dresses Sable gave me. The thought of him makes my chest ache. I push my worry for him away before my thoughts begin to spiral again, forcing my hands to stay steady as I dress.

No one stops me when I walk down the gangplank minutes later. I know I promised Sable to stay close, but the street leading to the village is still empty, and I have the urge to take a walk all by myself. Low-hanging fog blankets the docks, thick enough that the sun is little more than a pale blur

behind it. I half expect someone to call after me. A hand to close around my wrist. A command barked from the deck.

The further I get from the Noctis, the lighter my chest feels, even though I know it’s only temporary. The ship looms behind me all the same, dark and expectant, swaying gently in the calm morning sea. She doesn't frighten me, what frightens me is the unknown path ahead of us. I wish I knew what the sea has planned for me and for the crew and for me. For Sable. An idea of where we’re headed would be much better for my sanity than following a light across the six seas without having any idea of what it’s leading to.

The smell of grilled fish pulls me forward before I consciously decide to follow it. It’s the same path I walked with Sable yesterday, though it feels different now, stripped of whatever illusion of welcome the night had offered. I keep my head down as I walk and remember every turn I take through the narrow streets. Slowly, the settlement stirs to life around me. Stalls begin to line the main stretch, packed tightly together. Necklaces made out of pearls and shells glint softly in the fog-muted light as they are arranged, and pieces of dyed fabric hang from beams, their colors so oddly beautiful on the grey island.

My breath stutters when I see the glass jar.

It sits near the edge of a stall, between other trinkets and bone charms. The scales inside catch the light even through the fog.

Pale.

Iridescent.

I step closer without thinking, my pulse roaring in my ears. These aren’t fish scales. I know that instinctively, with a certainty that settles in my gut. When I look up, a man is already watching me, his gaze sharp and assessing. He looks familiar, but I can’t bring myself to remember where I know him from.

I open my mouth. Close it again.

A movement draws my attention back to his hands. He uses a mortar and pestle, grinding the scales into fine powder with practiced ease. When he notices me watching, a cruel grin spreads across his face, revealing yellowed teeth. I force myself to breathe, to remember that they fear me more than I fear them. They don’t know how little control I have over my voice. Not even the crew knows.

“You’re the siren without the tail,” he drawls eventually, keeping his gaze on me. “He will be pleased to hear I found you.”

I bring my hand to my collarbones instinctively, in an attempt to hide them from him. He must've seen them already, seeing as he recognizes who I am. But the man he is talking about, he is not from Noctis, that I am sure of. My throat tightens as I try to make sense of what he is saying. The only other crew that knows me…is Grimsbane's.

"Grimsbane?" I stutter, cold rushing down my spine. "He is here?"

He just smiles at me, before his gaze drifts behind me, eyes widening. I am about to turn when a hand clamps around my arm and spins me around.

"I've been looking for you everywhere, woman," Grim says, breathing hard. "The Glim has shown itself again. Right now. We have to leave. The captain's gathering the crew. And you—"

I slowly exhale, relieved that it is Grim and not Grimsbane.

"I'm being very politely urged to come with you?"

"Exactly." Grim presses his lips together, shifting impatiently from foot to foot.

I sigh deeply. I thought I had more time on the little island, to talk to Cailia, or maybe have another relaxed evening with the crew. But it seems like the sea has other plans, and if Grimsbane knows where I am, I can't risk staying.

"Fine."

I turn back to the man one last time, but he's already busy selling siren scales to a customer, his attention elsewhere.

Grim keeps glancing back at me as we make our way through the crowd that keeps streaming in the opposite direction. Voices swell around us, louder and more frantic than before, the quiet of the morning already erased. Shoulders brush mine, some of them harder than necessary, and I focus on keeping pace, on not letting myself be swallowed by the movement.

When the Noctis comes into view below us, she appears to be waiting on me, her presence eager. I drop my shoulders in relief and let out a breath I didn't realize I was holding. The sight of her steadies something in me, even as the knot in my chest tightens.

Nightglass and Lark stand a little apart, saying their goodbyes to their weeping wife and mother. I swallow as Nightglass wraps her into his arms and presses a kiss into her red hair, slow and careful.

My throat tightens.

I wonder how it must feel to be loved like that. To always have someone waiting for you, wanting you. It’s not that I don’t believe in love. It’s just so out of reach for me that I rarely waste time thinking of it. All the men I have met either feared me for what I am, or only wanted me because of it. So I avoided them altogether. I want someone who sees me, all of me, and decides to love me despite it.

I’m not afraid of you.

Sable’s words echo through my mind, pulling me back to the moment we shared last night. He doesn’t fit into either category. He does not fear me, but he also doesn’t want me simply because I am a siren. Which leaves me wondering if he could ever want me despite it. If he could ever feel something like that for me.

“...Sable,” Grim says, pulling me out of my thoughts.

“What?” I ask him, still half caught in them.

“I said we have to leave as soon as possible, if we don’t want to further aggravate Sable.” Grim repeats, jerking his head toward the docks. “They‘re loading the remaining loot already.”

Blinking, I meet his gaze, then square my shoulders. I haven‘t tried shifting in the bone-infested waters yet, and I won’t leave before I try to do so. I told Sable as much.

I draw a slow breath. “I need to go for a swim before we leave.”

He knits his brows together and glances towards the Noctis, hesitation flickering across his face.

“We can’t risk losing the Glim,” he says, looking at me again. “It wants us to leave the island now.”

Cailia said the Glim found me, and not them. So, it will wait for me. Even though the thought of Grimsbane being here unsettles me, I can’t lose my only chance at swimming in this sea and potentially triggering my shift. I would never forgive myself.

“Please wait on me," I say. “It will only take a few minutes.”

Grim opens his mouth, then closes it again.

I don’t wait for permission. Instead, I turn on my heel and head down the docks toward the narrow stretch of beach hidden behind jagged, dark rocks. The slick stone makes my footing clumsy, and I curse under my breath as my feet slide.

As I already said, sirens do not climb mountains.

I inhale deeply as the wind picks up, bringing with it the taste of salt. The descent is much easier than the way up. The beach opens up before me, the same one where I met the siren last night. Where I talked with Sable last night. It looks different in the daylight. The sand is pale and coarse beneath my feet, dotted with shells and fragments of coral worn smooth by the tide. As the water pulls back, more dark rock is revealed near the shore. Under the faint sunlight, the sea shifts between blue and green, as though it can't decide on one set color.

I loosen the strings of my bodice and step out of my gown, folding it carefully on a flat rock. My undergarment follows. As is usual with sirens, I care little about modesty. If we cover our breasts, our bodies, we do so because we like how it looks.

The moment my feet touch the water, relief floods through me so fast it steals my breath. The siren inside of me stirs, then settles, easing in a way she hasn't for weeks. After yesterday, she has become restless. She slips through more than I would like to admit. I like to tell myself that I am in control, but by now I know that this is not true. Leaving the tavern last night, I was a heartbeat away from sinking my canines into the flesh of the nearest man who dared to give me a nasty glare.

We don't kill without reason. We kill those who are a threat to us.

Sighing, I wade into the water without hurry, letting the water take more of my weight, until it is deep enough for me to float. I lay back, stretching my arms out wide. Water slips into my ears and dulls the world around me, until it all narrows down to my shallow breathing. Above me, the fog is still fighting with the sun.

Deep down, I know that this is not the sea that will trigger my shift. But I owed it to myself to try. These waters don't feel like home, but they ground me all the same. A smile spreads across my face. How freeing it feels to swim without expecting something to happen. Maybe it is in these moments where changes sneak up on you, because you have stopped seeking them out, because you have stopped forcing it, and allowed it to happen naturally.

My thoughts circle back to the brooding pirate captain that I have tried to avoid thinking about too much this whole morning. The way he stepped in front of me protectively. The way his hand curled around mine. The feeling of his arm around my waist. I let the sea lift me, then lower me again. I wish it was more simple.

Hating him would be so much simpler.

Frustrated, I force my body upright. I wade toward the shore at a faster pace than before, my legs fighting against the water to reach the shore. My foot catches on a rock, and I stagger, arms lifting to steady myself. Teeth clenched, I push through and step out of the surf with a sharp splash.

That's when I see him.

Sable sits on a rock just beyond the reach of the tide. One knee is drawn up, his weight settled like he's been there a while. Watching. An apple rests in his hand. He slices into it with his dagger, calm and precise, and eats a piece of it straight from the blade as he watches me intensely, with an air of nonchalance. His eyes linger on mine, then lower towards my breast, my waist, and finally, the short curls showing between my thighs.

"You're a prick," I mutter, staggering through the soft sand towards the rock I had placed my gown on. It gives way beneath my feet, stealing what little grace I have.

He shrugs. "I'm a pirate."

I glare at him as I reach for my chemise and throw it over my head, letting the soft fabric slip over my body.

"How long have you been here?"

"Your instincts aren't the sharpest." A smug grin spreads over his stupid, handsome face as he cuts another piece of apple.

Heat flares up my spine as I lift my chin and meet his gaze head-on.

"That doesn't answer my question."

"I've been here for…well," He furrows his brows and glances away briefly, putting on a show of thinking. "The whole time."

I reach for my gown next and put it on, before pulling the strings of the bodice tight. Too tight, my annoyance getting the better of me.

Bloody pirates.

"And why," I ask as I cross my arms over my chest, fingers digging into the fabric, "would you spy on me like that?"

"Grim told me you were here. I wanted to check on you," he says, and there's no hint of untruth in his voice. The honesty of it catches me off guard. This newfound openness must be something he is trying lately, to combat his usual grumpiness.

I narrow my eyes on him. "You mean to make sure that I don't disappear into the sea?"

For a moment, neither of us speaks. The salt air brushes against my cheek, carrying the scent of brine and wet stone, and lifts strands of his ink-dark hair so they fall forward over his brows, throwing a shadow across his face.

“No,” he finally says, still watching me. Not blinking. Not looking away. “To make sure you’re okay. After yesterday.”

Deep within my stomach, a knot starts to form, and I press down on it with both hands in the hopes of quelling it. I watch him as he gets up and throws the remaining apple into the waves.

Thrusts his dagger into its mount.

Slides down the rock with ease.

Strides over to me.

I go dizzy and almost lose my footing when he reaches for my bodice.

His fingers slip beneath the crossed strings, careful but sure, and gently tug until the pressure eases. My chest feels lighter with every pull, the tightness loosening where I hadn’t realized it was stealing my breath. He finishes loosening them, fingers lingering just long enough to make my pulse stutter.

Our eyes meet and I swallow hard. They remind me of the fog still clinging to the shore. Dark. Calm. We stare at one another, words balancing there on the edge of our open mouths, reluctant to be spoken. The muscles in his face are loose, his expression unreadable. His breath meets mine in the air between us. We linger.

Suddenly all too aware of how close we stand, I break my gaze from his, clearing my throat. I take a step back, brushing my hands over my gown.

“I am okay, Captain,” I mutter, stepping behind him to put distance between us before I do something foolish.

He clears his throat too, mirroring me. “Then why are you trying to suffocate yourself with your gown?”

“I am okay,” I snap, already turning away from him and heading toward the rocks. “Don’t you worry. You will not lose your precious Glim-summoning little fish.”

To my surprise, a deep laugh breaks out of him. It’s rough and unrestrained, nothing like the sharp edge he usually carries in his voice. When I glance over my shoulder, it strips the severity from his face entirely, softens him in a way that I haven’t seen before. My mouth pulls into a smile before I can stop it.

I turn back and begin to climb, placing my foot carefully against the uneven stone. I reach for the next rock above me when something dark bobs into view on a passing wave. I narrow my eyes, leaning forward.

Black.

A hat.

A tricorn hat.

His hat.

The very hat he lost when he dragged me from the Sea of Renewal. I don't hesitate and slip down the rocks along the edge of the bay until my feet sink into damp sand, cold water rushing over my ankles. I reach down and lift the hat from the surface, water streaming from its brim as I turn it over in my hands.

The leather is rough beneath my fingers, worn by the water and the salt, marked by its time in the sea. But it still maintains its shape nonetheless. At the front, a golden metal emblem is stitched into it, dulled slightly by the elements. Two crossed swords appear to slice through a skull.

"That's mine," he says behind me with a breathy, disbelieving laugh. He rushes to retrieve it from me, arm outstretched and waiting to snatch it from me.

I spin around and clasp the hat behind my back, out of his reach.

"But I found it," I shoot back. "What is the pirate saying again? Take what you can and give nothing back, right?"

He glares at me, exhaling through his nose. The frustration is written all over his face, and I enjoy the sight of it, devour it even. That smile finds my lips again.

"You have no use for it," he says, extending his hand further toward me, palm open.

"I can wear it, " I counter, lifting my chin.

He steps forward.

I step back.

I don't want to give it to him. I don't even want to wear his stupid hat. I want this one small victory after he just spied on me without shame.

"Fine," he says eventually, exhaling and rolling his eyes. "But I wouldn't wear it in front of the crew. They'll either think something is happening between us or that you mean to assert dominance. One of which is sure to result in them throwing you overboard. Now, come."

He nods toward the Noctis, visible beyond the curve of the bay. At the mention of something between us, heat flares up inside me and rushes straight to my cheeks. Either he pretends not to notice this, or he simply doesn’t care. He doesn’t react at all. Instead, he turns and starts climbing the slick rocks with an effortlessness I can only envy.

I curl my fingers around the soaked hat and follow him back up along the rocks and onto the dock. The Noctis waits ahead of us, lines drawn tight and the crew readying the ship for our departure.

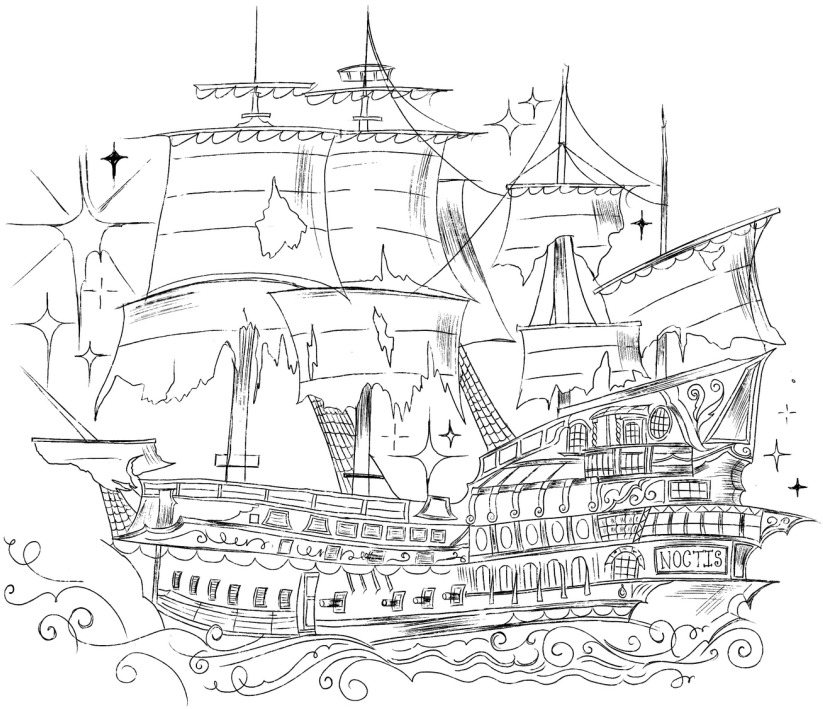
Sable boards first. I stop at the foot of the plank.

He doesn't look back right away. Only when he reaches the top of the gangplank does he turn to me. For a moment, I let myself stand there. The island at my back. The sea at my side. The ship in front of me. Sable in front of me.

I draw a breath and set the hat on top of my head, then step onto the plank. The wood creaks beneath my weight as I walk up to the ship and toward him without a word, pausing for a brief moment when I reach his side. From the corner of my eye, I can see a smile tugging at his lips.

“Looks better on you anyway, little fish,” he whispers into my ear. I roll my eyes and continue walking further onto the deck.

I do not look back, but I don’t need to know his eyes are on me anyway.


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-Two

THE NOCTIS GROANS IN anticipation beneath my feet.

Sable is at the helm.

There is nothing uncertain in the way he carries himself there. There's no hesitation in his body, his voice. He has certainly snapped back from the version of himself that lost control and loosened the strings of my bodice in considerable time. He holds the wheel as it belongs in his hands, shoulders squared and gaze fixed ahead.

I move along the boards toward the quarterdeck, keeping close to the railing. As I pass behind him, Sable glances over once.

"Cast off," he says in a steady voice.

The command cuts clear through the noise of the harbor. The lines slip free, one by one, until the dock pulls away in a slow, reluctant farewell.

"Easy," Sable adds, already adjusting the wheel. "Don't grind her on the rocks."

A sail snaps open overhead, catching the wind. The Noctis leans, then steadies, her bow turning away from the harbor mouth.

Saint's voice rises from midship, barking at two men still hauling the last of the timber aboard. Someone laughs. Others curse under their breath.

The island begins to drift backward from us. First the planks, then the clustered buildings and the jagged line of rocks guarding the beach. I watch until the island is nothing more than a tiny rock lurking out of the water, the same way it was when we arrived two days ago.

Sable straightens at the helm, eyes narrowing toward the open water as the Noctis surges forward, cutting clean through the dark sea.

The island fades fully into fog.

I draw a slow breath through my nose. Salted air floods my lungs. The siren inside me is at ease, sleeping beneath my skin, and that makes me trust I am on the right path. As I make my way across the deck, I make sure not to be in anyone’s way. Most of the men don’t acknowledge that I’m there. Others nod, or even manage what looks like the hint of a smile. Then there are men like Rat.

On the opposite side of the boards, he leans against the railing, one boot braced behind him. His arms are crossed, his posture loose, almost careless. He doesn’t bother looking away when our eyes meet. There is no curiosity in his gaze. Just hatred. Bare and unfiltered, hatred.

His stare bores into me until my chest grows heavy with the weight of it. I force myself to stay still, keeping my shoulders relaxed. Rat doesn’t move. He only watches, his shadow stretched at his feet in the light.

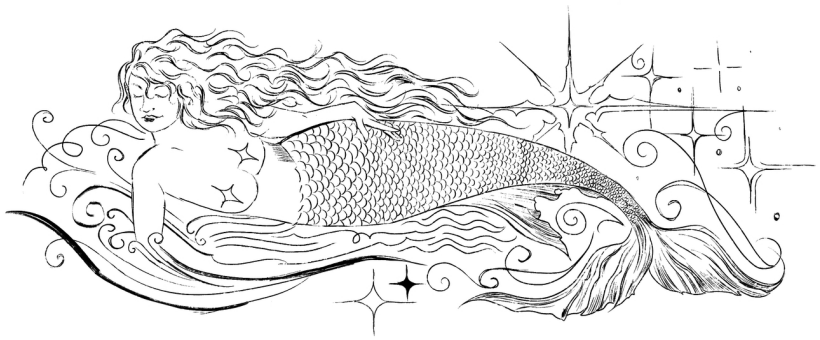
Something inside me vibrates, like a string plucked within me. It’s the siren. She stirs, alert now, reacting to the threat in front of me.

Cruel.

I am the one who looks away first, turning back toward the sea. I feel his eyes on my back as I walk away. When I reach the bow of the ship, I lean my body against the railing and let my eyes wander over the uneven surface of the water. I force myself to take deep breaths and let the salty air fill my lungs once again. I don’t need to see my eyes in the reflection of the water to know they are misted and white.

In the dark water, it is easy to make out the thread of silver that leads us toward unknown seas. I distract myself by tracing its every movement beneath the waves. It looks hurried now, almost frantic as it jumps from crest to crest.

Still, the siren in me does not settle. She stays awake, humming low beneath my ribs. I know it’s only a matter of time until she finally snaps.



Hours pass slowly, dragging me into the middle of the seemingly endless night. The singing and shuffling of the crew above the planks has ceased, and what remains is the sound of the water rushing against the hull in a steady rhythm. As I lie here, struggling to sleep, I wonder if it might be more productive to seek out the ghost. Perhaps he can tell me more about the curse, seeing as Sable seems reluctant to do so. I push myself upward and swing my legs over the edge of the hammock, set my feet on the wooden floor, and tiptoe to the stairs. I bet he’s out on the deck.

With the hatch halfway open, I peer out and scan the deck. The moonlight paints the boards and the railing in dark shades of purple and blue. It lays a thin sheen across the waves, turning their crests silver before they collapse again, melting into the sea.

I push against the heavy piece of wood and step onto the deck. I inspect the deck, the railings, the mast, sighing when I do not find him.

No ghost.

A faint tension settles between my shoulders. I roll one shoulder, then the other, trying to shake it loose, but find no release. The tension turns into a humming within me that vibrates through my body, the same kind of effect a throbbing wound has. The siren in me hasn’t gone quiet since earlier. She lingers just beneath the surface, like she’s waiting for something. Biding her time.

I scan the deck again, slower this time, and make my way toward the bow. At least I can distract myself and watch the Glim lead the ship. Something about it puts me at ease, knowing that it is bringing me where I need to be, no matter where that might be.

I close my hands around the railing—

And freeze.

Heavy footsteps make the wood squeak behind me. My pulse picks up, pumping blood through me so hard that it rushes in my ears. The ghost doesn't make any sound.

Slowly, I turn around, curling both hands around the railing behind me, bracing myself.

It's Rat.

He stands half in shadow, half caught by the moonlight spilling across the deck. Way too close. The light carves his face into sharp planes and hollows his cheeks, like the shape of his skull is pressing too close beneath his skin. Eyes glinting, he lifts his head.

"You shouldn't have boarded the ship again, siren."

He spits the word siren like it's an insult. I keep my shoulders still, refusing to look afraid and give him the reaction he wants.

The space between us narrows as he takes another step toward me. My breathing comes in shallow waves as I search the deck around us, hoping someone will appear and step in.

"I am not your enemy," I swallow. "All I want is to survive. To help you."

A vicious smile tugs at his lips. "Help us?"

"To break the curse," I state, my voice no longer as steady as I want it to be. The throbbing and humming within me becomes unbearable. Sweat starts to bead on my skin, making me shiver in the night's cool air.

"Don't you know?" Another step closer. "We are already doomed. But I know what could help…"

His gaze shifts, tracing my collarbone, where the light pink scales cover most of my skin.

"No," my voice is no more than a whisper. The pressure behind my ribs pulses deeply and sends a wave of something old and familiar through every nerve in my body.

"Scales hold a lot of magic, enough to buy us more time." He says serenely, as though it is the most rational thing in the world. As though he is compelled by the thought of what magic my scales could produce, and that thought only.

Rat's hand slides over the leather strap that holds his knife and draws it with one swift movement. The sharp blade now points decidedly at me. I instinctively bare my teeth and hiss at him. Shit.

"Look at you," he sneers, his empty eyes boring into mine. "Just look at what you really are. A monster that cannot be controlled. You will always

be a threat to this crew.”

I press myself against the railing, the wood now cutting into my flesh. Something shifts. I lose myself in a state of unconsciousness, the world around me moving in a blur. His fingers curl around my wrists behind my back and press them together violently. He is almost pressed fully against me now. Terror shoots through me as he lifts the knife in anticipation of a blow. Paralyzed with fear, I cannot defend myself. Cannot fight.

But she can.

And I won’t let him take what’s left of me. Not this easily.

I draw a breath and reach out to the vibrating force within me. I do not loosen a single thread of it. I pull at them all at the same time, desperate. Determined. The sound starts as a hum, but a mere hum will not be enough. A note of an ancient song slips free and curls around my tongue before it echoes, multiplying around us. The voice is so soft, so enchanting. It doesn’t fully feel like mine.

His focus shifts, as if something has brushed against his mind. Finally, it slips inside his ear and takes root. Eyes widening, the grip around my wrists loosens. The knife he was holding slips out of his hand and clatters down on the boards beneath us.

Pressure keeps building behind my ribs until I cannot contain it anymore. It bursts free and pumps my body full of what feels like thick, hot power, until I can feel it in every inch of me. It rushes through me like the blood in my veins.

I let it consume me.

His body goes slack as his muscles melt with my compulsion. Swaying, he grabs the railing behind me and leans forward. The unmistakable desire to drown him rises in me, taking hold.

A small part of me screams out, begging me to see that this is wrong, that I am not a killer. But that part of me grows distant, its screaming pleas growing muffled as every second passes, until I can no longer reach it. As the sound of my voice deepens and finds its shape, my vision begins to distort. It pours out of my mouth with no resistance, pulling more from me than I mean to give.

Rat swings one leg over the railing in one smooth, obedient movement. The other one follows. The scene feels flattened, as if someone has pressed it beneath glass. His eyes are glassy, unfocused, as if the person who once lived behind them has already stepped away.

His body tips forward. I don’t move to stop it.

Rat falls over the side and disappears without a sound. No struggle. No resistance. The splash follows a moment later as his body is swallowed by the dark waters below.

Only then does something inside me tear loose, the song stuttering and breaking apart as the world rushes back in all at once. The feeling vanishes so abruptly that my body jerks forward, lungs collapsing in on themselves as if I’ve been struck in the chest. Air tears back into me in a sharp, broken gasp that burns all the way up. My knees give out.

The sudden silence crashes in, my ears ringing. My chest spasms, breath coming too fast, too shallow, each inhale dry and rough. I try to swallow and can’t. With slippery hands and knees on cold wood, I crawl toward the railing and pull myself up to lean over. I search the surface for movement. All I find is the familiar roll of the sea, split by the wake of the Noctis.

Rat is gone.

The thought lands hard and hits me in the gut. Dizzying nausea washes over me, threatening vomit. My throat locks, tight and aching, as if the song still sits within it, desperate to be unleashed again. What follows is a bitter taste on my tongue. Wood and salt and remorse.

Someone is shouting my name. I recognize it only because the sound keeps repeating itself. Hands grab at the railing beside me and footsteps thunder across the deck.

This wasn’t meant to happen.

This wasn’t—

A sick heat floods my chest, rising fast, stealing more air from my lungs. I bend forward with a strangled sound, gagging, but nothing comes up. Power. Raw and undeniable power. It rises within me and floods my system until it settles into me with a terrible unease.

“No,” I whisper. The world around me barely exists. “No, no, no.”

He’s dead.

The sea kept his soul in sacrifice and gave me power in return. The thought makes my stomach twist. I shouldn’t have let it come this far. I could’ve screamed for help, could’ve used my canines. Anything. Anything would be better than this. I press my forehead against the rails, breathing hard and trying to ground myself, to anchor to anything that isn’t this feeling. Oh, by the seas, I have made a mistake. One I cannot take back. Cannot come back from.

The siren inside me, however, is completely, utterly satisfied.

“Everyone back to your bloody cabins!” The roar in Sable’s voice cuts through me like a blunt blade. The crew around me shuffles and murmurs, some arguing loudly. What they are talking about, I do not hear. But I don’t need to in order to know. He is dead. Heavy footsteps draw near before a steady hand meets my shoulder.

“Risa,” he whispers, his voice distant, muffled, as though I am underwater. “Look at me.”

“Risa,” he repeats, and this time it is enough to wrench me back into my body. Into myself.

His grip on my shoulder tightens, but instead of restraining me, it grounds me. Tension runs through him, similar to mine. His gaze flicks past me, over my shoulder, tracking the last of the crew as they retreat below deck.

“All of you,” he says, not to me, but to them. “You too, Lark.”

There’s more shuffling. The hatch slams shut somewhere behind us, and finally, silence. I cannot get myself to look at him. I look at his boots instead— his black, worn leather boots. For a moment, I wish the deck would open beneath my feet and release me into the sea. I deserve it for what I have done.

“Look at me,” he says again, quieter this time.

I try, but my eyes won’t focus. The boards tilt beneath my feet, the aftermath of the song still echoing in my bones.

“I didn’t—” The words tangle and break apart again.

“I know,” he cuts in and crouches in front of me. “Breathe.”

Nodding, I try to breathe. I drag in air that tastes of salt and iron. As I glance down, there are red stains on my gown. Panic rises in me once again. I don’t remember hurting him before I made him toss himself over. And I am empty of wounds.

“It’s your nose.” He pulls out a piece of fabric from his coat and gently presses it under my nostrils, then holds it out for me to see. “Your blood. No one else’s.”

I swallow hard and nod slowly. Sable shifts closer, putting himself between the open deck and me. Finally, I draw a slow breath through my nose and look up at him. His eyes meet mine, darker than the water below us. He draws a slow breath through his nose. Lets it out just as carefully.

“I’ll handle this,” he says as his thumb gently presses into my shoulder. “But not here. Not now.”

I nod because speaking still feels impossible with the lump that has formed in my throat. He doesn't wait for anything more. His hand slips from my shoulder and settles on the small of my back, and gently guides me away from the railing.

But my body is so weak.

My legs give out once again without warning. I barely have time to register that I'm falling.

Sable catches me.

His arm hooks around my back, the other sliding under my knees in one smooth motion. I suck in a breath as the ground drops away, my weight shifting fully into his arms. The warmth of his skin against mine is comforting and confusing all at once. I curl my fingers into the fabric at his shoulders, gripping as though in fear of being let go.

Beneath the quarterdeck, the air is much warmer. He carries me down the corridor, past the holding cell. When he opens the door to a cabin, light spills into the corridor before us. Lanterns sway gently with the movement of the ship, their glow leaving no corner untouched. He steps inside and nudges the door shut behind us with his foot, then carries me to the bed and lowers me onto it.

I know this room. It's his cabin. His bed.

His hands linger on me for a little while longer before finally letting go, as if making sure I'm steady before he straightens. For a moment, I just lie there, staring up at the low ceiling, my breath shallow and uneven. I still feel as though I'm outside my own body, watching this unfold through someone else's eyes. The truth presses in from all sides, insistent. I know I won't be able to keep it out forever, that sooner or later I will have to lower my guard and face what I've done. But not here. Not now.

Sable sits on a stool at the side of the bed, watching me. There's a deep frown between his eyes. As I stare into them, relief settles low in my ribs, replacing the pressure that was there moments ago. He looks worried, but his body is no longer tense. When he reaches for a cloth beside the bed and lifts it toward my face, I flinch before I can stop myself.

He stills immediately.

"It's alright," he says in a low voice. "Let me get you cleaned up."

I nod and let my eyes drift shut as the cool dampness of the cloth brushes my cheek, my nose. His touch is gentle, as though he is cleaning a porcelain doll that will break if he isn't careful enough. I try to focus on that. On the

simple fact that he's here, despite what I've done. That he didn't make me into something I am not. That he understands. When I open my eyes again, he's still seated beside me, pressing the cloth against my blood-soaked skin with the utmost care.

"How do you feel?" he whispers and studies me with a quiet softness that I haven't seen since we talked on that little beach.

I want to answer him honestly, but how do you tell someone that you feel like you're drowning, even though you're above water? The truth feels too tangled to put into words…too complicated.

"Like I lost," I mumble eventually, a tear slipping from my eye. "Like I lost to the monster."

Sable lowers the cloth, his brows drawing together slightly.

"I've never heard of a monster," he begins quietly, "who cares about its actions the way you do, Risa. You show empathy, constantly, to people who treat you poorly. That's a strength, not a weakness. I would've thrown him overboard myself if I had the chance. I would do it in the blink of an eye, if I saw him lay a hand on you."

I stare at him, trying to understand why his words affect me the way they do. I know what I have done, and that I could do it again if I lost control. That has always been enough to define me. But the way he speaks of it forces me to look at myself from a different angle. Until now, I have only measured myself by the harm I could cause, by the danger I carry beneath my skin. And by what I am not. By the absence of my tail that has followed me my entire life. But he speaks of me as if none of this is the whole truth. As if the moments where I choose not to use what I am, where I hold back when it would be easier not to, matter just as much.

"I didn't want to drown him," I admit, squeezing my eyes tight as though to rid myself of the memory. "I just wanted him to stop."

He pauses.

"I believe you."

His words make my throat tighten, and more tears stream down my cheek. He lowers the cloth back into the bucket before cupping the side of my face with his hand.

"You are," he says, brushing away the tears with his thumb, "not a monster. You're a siren. A siren with song and teeth, who defended herself against a man who actually became what you're so afraid of. A monster."

My gaze drifts across his face, following the line of his brow down to his eyes. I expect him to look away, to break the tension. He doesn’t. Instead, he looks at me with an intensity that disarms me. The longer his eyes hold mine, the more the tightness in my chest begins to loosen.

“Thank you,” I whisper.

When his gaze drops to my mouth, my breath catches. He leans forward, just slightly. The shift is small, but I feel it like the pull of the current in calm water. He is so close that I can see the rise and fall of his breathing, feel the warmth of his body against mine.

I do not move toward him. But I do nothing to stop him either.

His thumb, still resting against my cheek, drifts lower until it brushes my bottom lip, and I fight the urge to open it for him. The warmth of his touch sends a shiver rippling over my body, and for a heartbeat, I think he might close the distance entirely.

Then he stops. Realization flickers through his eyes at the same time as it reaches mine. With something close to reluctance he lowers his hand.

“You should rest,” he says quietly.

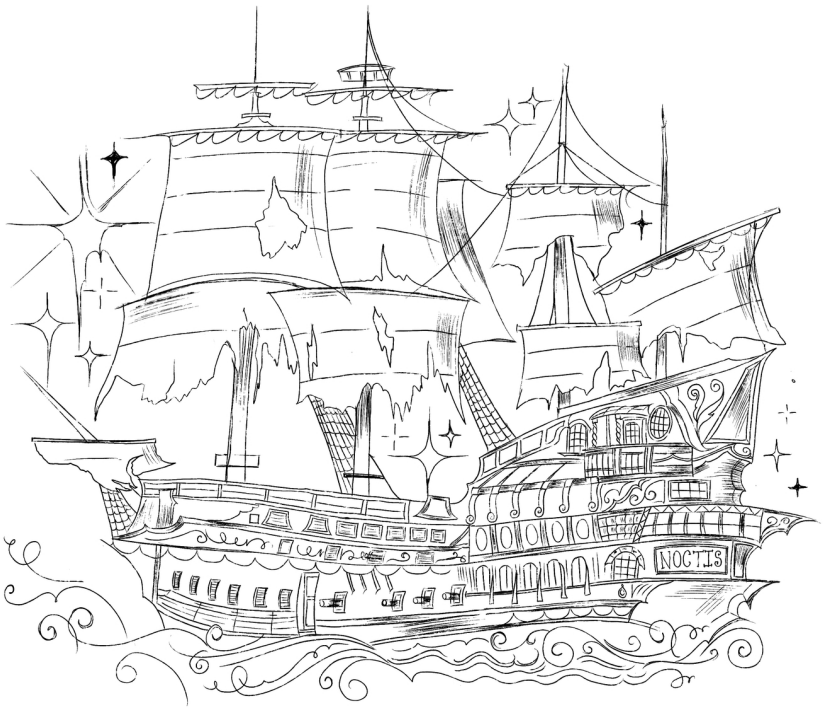
I expect him to leave. But he doesn‘t.

Instead, his fingers wrap around mine, and he remains seated beside me. I look down at our hands, surprised by how natural it feels. His presence somehow anchors me, and slowly, my body settles back into itself, the tension draining until all that’s left is a heavy, bone-deep exhaustion.

I am so tired.

So deeply tired that the fear, the shame, the angst become distant. I shift on the mattress, my fingers tightening around his.

Through half-closed eyes, I catch the shape of his face in the lantern glow one last time. Storm-grey eyes are the last thing I see before falling into a dreamless sleep.


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-Three

I AWAKEN, COCOONED IN SHEETS that I do not want to leave anytime in the near future. Waking in warmth is not a common occurrence in the Orlop. Blankets and soft pillows surround me, and I turn over, pulling the blanket closer to my body, inhaling deeply. Salt and a trace of leather and smoke hit my nose, and I hold my breath for a while longer before exhaling slowly. It is his scent that surrounds me. I sigh at the smell.

Because this is his bed.

The memories of last night come flooding in, the way a dream you cannot fully remember does, in dregs, all blurred out and distorted. Voices. Images.

My siren song. Rat climbing the railing. Sable's lips inches from mine.

By the seas, what have I done?

Drowned a cruel man.

The siren inside of me whispers in reassurance. I grab the blankets and tear them off me, my skin suddenly on fire. Gasping, I prop myself up on my elbows, running my fingers through my hair. They snag slightly on the knots that have formed during my fitful sleep, but I can't help but wonder if I deserve the pain it brings. Rat was a cruel man, yes, but did he truly deserve to die? That wasn't my decision to make. But the sea took him almost immediately, without hesitation. A dark part in me knows that this is proof enough that my actions were not completely and utterly unjustified.

Would he have killed me if I didn't stop him? Perhaps.

Would he have plucked my scales off my skin and left me to bleed out on the deck? Of that, I am certain.

I take a deep breath, in an attempt to calm myself, but it is of little use. I look around the cabin. The lanterns along the wall are still lit, their soft glow painting the room in gold. There's no light spilling into the room through the round windows. I am certain after the length of my sleep that it must be morning, so the darkness outside is a source of confusion. To my quiet disappointment, there is no sign of Sable. Sighing, I let my head fall back into the soft mattress. If I could stay here forever, I would. The thought of going out there and facing the crew makes my heart palpitate and my throat dry. I have killed one of their men. They will never forgive me, and rightfully so.

A monster that cannot be controlled.

There was no control. As soon as his blade came near me, something inside me snapped. Broke free. Everything that happened afterward is a blur. I remember little more than a faint echo of how my voice had sounded, so it is difficult to ascertain where the words came from or how I was able to wield such ancient magic. I swallow. I also remember the desire that rushed through me, taking over me, like a wave crashing in and flooding a ship. The desire to drown him.

Maybe he was right, and I am a monster.

I don't know the code they follow, but whatever punishment they have in store, I will accept it without a fight. If they ask me to walk the planks and follow his path into the darkness, I will. And I will make sure Sable does not jump in after me.

What I don't want is for him to see me as a monster. The way he quietly whispered to me yesterday and carried me here gives me hope he doesn't. I can't name what it is that I feel about him, but I do care what he thinks of me. Care about him. I know I shouldn't. It is against everything I was taught to believe. But, in all the chaos and suffering of the last few weeks, he is the only one to fully try to understand me. The only one to succeed.

Faint shuffling starts in front of the door. I get up quietly, creep toward it, and press my ear against the cold wood. I can make out hushed voices coming from the corridor.

"Captain says it's better she stays in there," someone whispers. It's Grim. "Just until we're through the Sea of Shadows."

I hold my breath. The Sea of Shadows. That's where we're aiming for. I glance toward the foggy glass window. This explains the darkness outside. The sun doesn't rise here, not fully. I've never personally been here before, but I know what the sea is known for. Nothingness. Not death. Not bones. Just a never-ending black void.

This is where the dark water sirens live. They're vicious, primitive beings. The worst of our kind. I hesitate, guilt pressing heavily against my ribs. After what I've done, I have no right to talk to the crew. No right to speak at all. But I know I will not forgive myself if I stay silent now.

Slowly, I open the door with shaking hands.

I've never felt so small. The guilt almost knocks me out as Grim and Nightglass stare at me with wide eyes.

"Eryse, you shouldn't leave the cabin—" Nightglass begins.

I interrupt him, my voice thin. "You have to plug your ears."

Grim shakes his head. "Plug our ears? We don't fear you, we know—"

"No, not because of me." Relief crashes down on me like a wave on the shore. They do not fear me. "It's them. The dark water sirens. They will not let you pass without trying to attack."

I swallow hard, my fingers still clinging around the doorknob. They exchange looks, uncertainty lingering between them. That dark, dangerous siren part of me begs me to stop talking, urging that I shouldn't feed this information to them. To pirates. I push her far away.

"Okay," Grim nods once and turns to Nightglass, who stands next to him with squared shoulders. "Burn some candles, give wax to each man. Start with your son."

He bobs his head at Grim in understanding and hurries out onto the deck.

"You have to stay in there," Grim jerks his chin toward the cabin behind me. "Orders from the captain."

"And where might the captain be?"

"That's none of your concern. Trust that he's doing what must be done."

By the look on his face, I know that asking more questions wouldn't bring me more answers. As I glance over his shoulder through the open door leading toward the deck, the crew of the Noctis is moving with purpose. They're working together in silence, bringing a bunch of things up from the hold.

"What are you doing?" I furrow my brows as our eyes meet again. "Let me help."

“We’re lighting the deck. Otherwise the darkness will swallow the ship whole. But you,” he points one finger at me and then into the cabin, “will stay here.”

“No,” I reply sharply and plant both feet into the ground. “I will help.”

Uncomfortable silence stretches between us until he exhales through his nose and shifts his weight.

“Fine, but only until we’re through the intermaria. You can help to fasten the lanterns and light them.”

I jerk forward, ready to at least help them make it through the sea alive without another man drowning. Grim’s arm curls around me and pulls me back.

“You should change,” he nods toward my blood-soaked gown. “Better not to remind them.”

“Oh. Yes,” I reply quietly, avoiding his gaze as heat floods my cheeks. Deep splatters of red cover the bodice of my dress.

I return to the cabin with no further words, suddenly all too desperate to get out of this cursed dress. I quickly find the chest that Sable pulled all those dresses out of for me. I kneel in front of it and open it slowly, the hinges creaking as the lid lifts. I glance over my shoulder at this as if he might crash into the cabin any moment and tell me not to go through his stuff. But he doesn’t. Somehow, his absence unsettles me more than the danger closing in on us.

The chest is filled with various things. Clothes, a few daggers, and a considerable amount of bone charms. More than I care to count. Big ones, tiny ones, some bound to leather, some with mere pieces of string, each one more detailed than the last. His sister was right when she said he has enough of them. He has bone charms in abundance.

Someone behind me clears their throat. I turn, expecting to find a lightly amused yet rightfully annoyed Sable, but I am met with no one. I shake my head, turning my attention back to the chest, feeling slightly like I have taken yet another step towards madness. I rummage a little more before a shift of darkness flits by me out of the corner of my eye. Only when I follow it does it lead me to him, standing in the far corner of the room.

The ghost.

I exhale deeply, pleased it is him and not a figment of my own imaginings. A part of me wants to throw my arms around him and tell him what happened last night. To tell him what I have done. Somehow, I know

that he will understand. He has yet to show any judgment towards men. And he has never been anything less than kind.

“I tried not to scare you this time. Did it work?”

A smile tugs at my lips as I shrug, trying not to let the rapid beating of my heart unsteady me. “You never frighten me,” I answer honestly. “These days, I am more scared of myself.”

The shadows curling around him do not leave the space he stands in, the faint outlines of his face moving, as if he’s shaking his head.

“I just came to tell you something—” A sound rises from the corridor. We both freeze and wait until it settles, my pulse drumming too loud in my ears.

“It was not your fault.”

I know what he means in an instant.

I do not reply. Instead, I go back to digging through Sable’s things, unable to focus on anything properly. My fingers meet what feels like the hard fabric of a bodice, and I pull the gown free from the chest.

“Ash has always been brutal. Believe me, I was beginning to grow quite tired of seeing his sour face on this ship.” He steps forward, but the darkness in the corner of the room still surrounds him, his figure blurring with the rest of it. “It was simply his time.”

Ash. That’s the name of the man I drowned. The man who now lies somewhere on the bottom of the sea.

“And I was the one who decided it was his time,” I spit, more angry at myself than him. “I am responsible for his death. I murdered him. Don’t try to defend me.”

“I won’t,” he says gently. Like in the orlop, his voice multiplies and hits the walls around me, his words softening the guilt coiling inside of me. “But I know you are kind at your core. Remember that, Risa.”

He withdraws and takes a step back, then another one. His features blend into nothingness, bit by bit.

“I must go. Don’t look for the captain.”

“No, wait!” I get up quickly and almost stumble over my own feet trying to get to him. But as I reach out to grab his arm, my hand is only met with air.

And, I didn’t even get a chance to ask him about the curse. Sighing, I pull the dirty gown over my head and slip into the new one, a powder pink one, then put on my boots. The fabric feels awkward and wrong against my skin,

like I’ve stepped into a version of myself that doesn’t quite know who to be. What to be.

The room already begins to darken. Time is running out.

I rush out to the main deck. Lanterns and candles are distributed amongst the men and somehow mounted to the rigging, the railing, and on top of barrels. I take a taper from the hook by the mast, its wick already burning low. The flame gutters as the ship shifts beneath my feet. I cup my hand around it to shield it from the wind and step toward the nearest lantern.

Light blooms as the wick catches, filling the lantern with a muted glow. I close it and hurry toward the next one. Slowly, the deck begins to lighten. The lanterns swing in the gentle wind, casting their warm light onto the boards, imitating sunlight. Dozens of them, if not a hundred, make the Noctis look like it has been decorated with live stars.

If certain death was not creeping up on us, I might let myself think it looks beautiful.

“Lass,” I hear Grim’s voice behind me. He appears by my side and gives a short nod towards the sea in front of us.

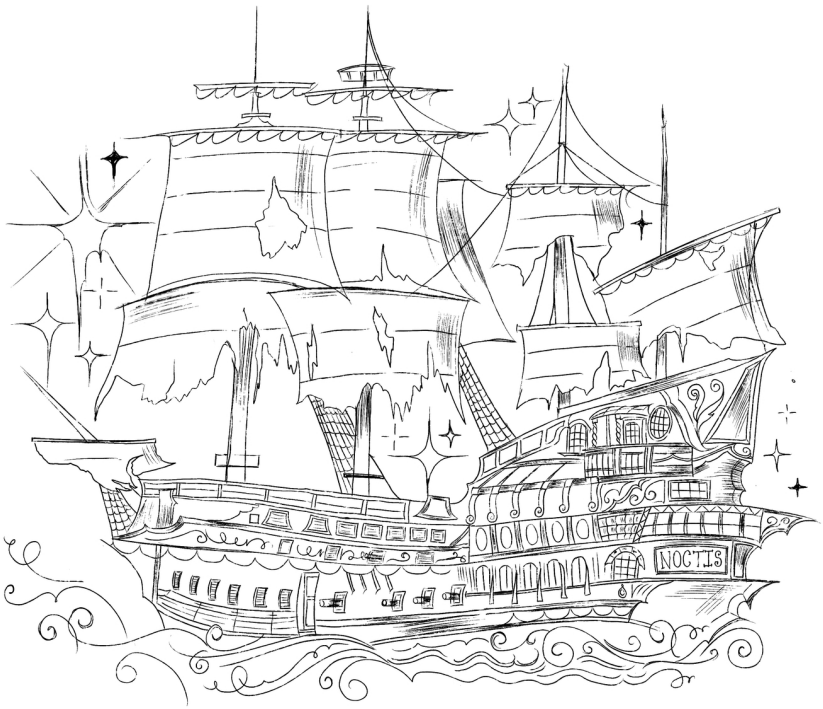
The intermaria is straight ahead. The familiar dark blue water of the Sea of Bones stretches out before us and then simply… ends.

What lies beyond is different from anything I’ve ever seen before. It is darker, yes, but not in the way the night darkens the sea. It looks thick. Oily. Like a heavy blanket laid across the surface, swallowing reflection instead of returning it. The line between the two seas is unmistakable, and the Glim leads us right toward it. A sharp seam, as if someone has pressed two vast carpets together but hasn't bothered to blend the edges. The waters don’t mix. They remain separate, even as the Noctis slowly passes through.

“You need to go,” Grim says, the seriousness in his voice making me flinch a little.

When I turn towards him, I can’t help but focus on the lantern beside him, following the row of them as they flicker in unison. They suddenly seem muted, as though I’m looking at them through squinted eyes, their light fighting against the darkness. Out of the corner of my eye, there’s movement in the spaces the light does not fully reach.

Despite being told to leave, to retreat inside to relative safety, a feeling in my gut tells me I have to stay. Out here, with the crew. Before I get the chance to make any decisions, the remaining light from the Sea of Bones is swallowed by the void, leaving us in complete, all-encompassing darkness.


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-Four

WITH THE DARKNESS COMES silence.

Nightglass moves through the crew, handing out candle wax, and each man presses it into his ears with rough fingers. No one speaks. No one looks at me. I cannot tell whether they are still processing what I did to Rat or whether the threat ahead of us has pushed everything else aside.

I feel them before I see them.

The magic in the water carries a familiar pull, close enough to my own that my chest tightens in recognition. Slowly, I step toward the railing and lean over it, careful not to tip too far forward. The surface below stirs, then smooths again in an instant, as if nothing had ever disturbed it.

A hum rises in the distance, faint and ancient, carried just above the water. I hold my breath as it stretches into a song. At first, there is only one voice, then another joins, then another and another, until there are too many to count. They weave together until the sound fills the air around the ship, encircling us with the dangerous song. I scan the deck for any signs that this is affecting the crew. That the wax hasn't worked as they'd intended.

The pirates stand in place. Some sway gently with the movement of the Noctis, caught somewhere between awareness and trance. Others hold themselves rigid, jaws clenched, fists curled at their sides, the wax in their ears the only thing keeping them upright. As a siren, their song does not affect me, but it sure does affect them.

"Go inside," I shout, my voice echoing across the deck. I don't know if they can hear me over the singing or through the wax, but it's all I can do.

They hesitate, then begin to move, hauling the affected men below the quarterdeck and into the cabins. I release a breath I hadn’t realized I was holding as the deck slowly clears. Only Grim remains at the helm, his eyes fixed on the dark water ahead.

Even with their ears sealed, resisting the song cannot be easy. I see it in him, the way his focus slips and returns, as though he’s fighting for something just beyond his reach. Grasping for his consciousness to remain with him. Behind him, a dark figure stands with his arms behind his back. He places one hand on Grim’s shoulder, as if reassuring him. Grim flinches at his touch, but doesn’t turn around. His pitch-black eyes find mine, and I recognize him as my ghost.

I give him a small nod, and he returns it without a word.

The water stirs again, closer this time. I lean over the railing once more and glare into the dark.

Be brave.

My mother’s voice surfaces like a memory pulled from the deep water of my mind. I straighten my spine. I am not afraid of my own kind, and I will not let them tear this ship apart.

“There’s a child on this ship,” I shout into the void, anger pooling hot in my chest. I know they can hear me. “Retreat. Let us pass.”

The singing falters, cutting off so abruptly that my pulse spikes. For a brief moment, I think they might actually let us pass. But the song surges back, louder than before. Stronger. My fingers curl into my palms as I draw in a slow breath through my nose and force myself to stay steady.

Bang.

The hatch bursts open behind me and slams against the deck. Someone stumbles up the steps and collapses onto the boards, gasping, palms splayed against the wood.

He looks up.

“Lark,” I whisper, already moving toward him. He doesn’t have even the glimmer of a chance against the song of the dark water sirens. They’re too powerful. Too compelling.

His eyes dart wildly, skimming over the lanterns as though they find no focus. His breathing comes too fast, catching in his throat as he tries to breathe, tears streaking down his face. When he finally manages to pull in a full breath, it breaks apart into a sob.

He is terrified.

I drop to my knees and pull him against my chest, wrapping my arms around his shaking body.

“Shh,” I say, brushing my fingers through his hair. “It’s okay. I’m here.”

I glance toward the open hatch and then toward the quarterdeck. Nightglass hasn’t followed him up, which is unsettling given the fact that he is usually so protective of his son.

“Nothing’s okay,” Lark gasps, clutching at the fabric of my gown. His words cause tears of my own too. In this moment, I understand why they fear us. Why the Pirates see my kind as a sort of enemy. The sirens do not show mercy. They do not relent.

“I feel wrong,” he whispers. “Something’s wrong.”

Without letting go of him, I check his ears. There’s wax in his ears, properly sealed. Thank the seas, I dread to think how badly he’d be affected without it. Carefully, I guide him toward the nearest barrel and sit beside him. A lantern rests on top, casting a small circle of light that barely pushes back the darkness pressing in around us.

“You’re safe,” I tell him quietly, though I am not sure if he can even hear what I say. I stroke a thumb across his cheek, offering him a weak smile in the hopes that it convinces him that all will be well.

His brows crease together as he nods faintly, but his eyes keep drifting past me, toward the edges of the light. Each time the lantern sways, his shoulders tense again.

That’s when I notice.

As the lantern shifts, the shadow of the barrel stretches and pulls across the deck, and so does mine. But Lark’s doesn’t follow. Instead, it lingers at his feet, darker than the others, immovable by the swaying of the lantern light. Frowning, I lower myself a little to watch it more closely.

Lark’s shadow twitches. Not with the sway of the ship, not with the lantern, not mimicking Lark even. It moves entirely on its own. I tighten my grip around his shoulder and pull him closer, trying to give him comfort, while fear creeps in on me too.

This has nothing to do with the song of the sirens.

A cold rush settles low in my stomach as the shape at his feet begins to thin, stretching upward and slowly peeling away from his boots. Lark gasps, fingers digging into my sleeve, his whole body locking down again.

“No,” he whispers, panic surging in his voice. “No, no, no—”

The shadow slowly lifts, almost as if it is hesitating, like it isn’t sure whether it’s allowed to leave or not. It draws itself up from the boards, lengthening, gathering form, until it stands there, in front of us. In the shape of a boy, much like the one pressed into my side. A darker outline of him. The edges of him waver like smoke caught in still air, in a faint shade of silver.

Lark lets out a broken sound.

“I don’t—” His breath stutters as his eyes find mine, wide and filled with so much fear. “I don’t feel right.”

There’s something different about them now. They look emptier than before, a contrast to the excited and so deeply passionate pirate I have come to know.

I pull him closer, one hand sliding up to the back of his neck, feeling in this moment that all I can do to comfort him is bring him close. As I look up at the figure standing in front of us, I finally come to understand. He blinks slowly, as if his existence unsettles him the same way it does Lark.

They aren’t ghosts.

They’re shadows.

And they belong to the crew.

The thought fractures into a dozen others before I can stop it. The curse I never learned about. The kind ghost. Sable. The lanterns that seem to follow him wherever he goes. I push them all down as Lark sobs beside me. Whatever this all means, I will deal with it later.

“Look at me,” I murmur, my voice steady even as my chest tightens. “You’re here. You’re breathing.”

The shadow shifts beside us, and my pulse jumps in response. The siren inside me stirs as the shadow starts to wander the deck, as if he’s looking for someone. I return my focus to Lark. He stares at his shadow, sweat now covering his face. By the seas, there must be something I can do to help him.

The idea hits me like a stiff wind. I have the ability to calm him – the power to. With shaking hands, I pull the wax out of his little ears and lay it aside on the planks, just in case it becomes necessary again. He looks at me, still visibly distraught, and I give him a gentle smile.

“I will sing you a song now,” I whisper. “And you will focus on me. Only on me. Do not give in to the pull of the sirens, understand?"

He hesitates, and a deep line settles between his light brows. Something softens in his eyes, and he gives me a curt nod. I take his hands into mine and caress the palm of his hand with my thumb, before drawing in a slow breath. The humming behind my ribs comes to life, and I smother the swelling fire of fear that it ignites in my stomach with it. I know what I am capable of should I not be careful. An image of Rat flashes into my mind in a blinding light, him climbing the railing in a trance, followed by the dead, empty air where he fell from. But this time, I will be in full control.

I am in full control.

I loosen a single thread of my power and let the hum come out in full. Lark's eyes widen in recognition as it slips into his ear, the muscles in his face melting into calm with almost immediate effects. The hum turns into a song. I remember the words well, for my mother used to sing the lullaby to me whenever I couldn't sleep.

She would sit by the rocks near the shore, stroking my hair, still damp from a day spent in the water. Most nights, she stayed with me until my eyes grew too heavy to keep open, her voice and touch the only things that kept the dark at bay. I was always exhausted, but that never stopped me from trying to keep up with the swarm. My father had shown me how to build a small fire, and I would sleep beside it, the warmth chasing away the chill that clung to me after the sea. The sand beneath me was soft enough, though I never gave it much thought. I would lie there, watching the flames flicker, listening to the waves, and wait for the next day to arrive.

The memory makes it easy for me to shape the lullaby into something gentle and sweet. My siren claws at my insides, desperate to take over, but this time I don't let her.

It costs me a lot of power and energy. My muscles tense as the power inside me swells and tries to burst free. It's hot as it pumps through my veins like thick, heavy oil, causing my limbs to feel weighted and laborious to move.

But it is worth the price. It works. And it works well. Lark slowly folds into my arms, his body no longer shaking but loose and relaxed. I keep my voice gentle as I carefully run my fingers through the soft waves of his hair.

There in front of us, his shadow shifts.

I look at him in wonder as I continue the lullaby. He doesn't seem as scared as Lark. He doesn't shake or whimper, but still appears to me

somewhat restless, pacing back and forth, shadows whirling and dragging behind him as he moves. As if he doesn't know where to go, or what to do. The shadow stops his pacing and turns his head towards me ever so slowly, then tilts his head, the way Lark does when he's slightly puzzled by something.

He looks at me as though he recognizes who I am, before blinking.

Once.

Then again.

He takes a careful step forward, then another, moving toward Lark and me with a childlike hesitance that mirrors Lark's own. Each step pulls him closer, the darkness pulling inward instead of spreading wide around him. When he reaches Lark, I do not stop my hum. I keep it steady, pulling another thread from the power inside me. It is in this moment that I realize that I am no longer only singing for Lark, but also for his shadow. The song not only soothes it, but seems to call it back to where it belongs.

My eyes widen as the shadow gravitates forward, folding back into Lark's body which swells slightly, as his shadow returns to him like breath returning to lungs. The edges of the silver silhouette dissolve. The darkness sinks into his chest, his legs, slipping beneath skin and into bone until there is nothing left on the deck but the faint glow of lantern light.

Every instinct in me urges me to keep going, to hold the song steady and press further, as if letting go would undo everything. I still feel Lark's shadow testing the hold I have on it, and I fear it might tear free again if I loosen my grip. So I don't. I push, drawing more and more power, forcing the song deeper, to not just return the shadow to Lark, but to bind him there. Finally, the resistance falters, and it feels as if two halves no longer pull against each other but align, coming together as one.

Lark releases one long gasping breath, and my hum comes to an abrupt stop. His hand flies to his chest as he seems to come to life again, the boy and the shadow made whole. He looks down at himself, then around the deck, eyes wide and searching.

The space at Lark's feet is no longer empty. His shadow lies where it should be, tethered and flat, in the distorted shape of his tiny body. Most importantly, it is synchronized with the boy's movements, its arm retreating from the shadow of my skirts when Lark hesitantly lets go of my gown.

"See," I whisper, pressing a kiss to his temple. "Everything is fine. You're fine. All is well."

He doesn't respond, but I don’t expect him to, seeing him calmer and looking more like himself is enough for me. As I glance up toward the helm, Grim looks at me with his brows set in a straight line and his jaw set tight, like he’s asking me a question I don’t have an answer to.

It is only then that I notice the silence around us. There’s no singing anymore, no splashing against the hull, and when I look out across the dark surface, it lies unnaturally still. My fingers tighten slightly against Lark's back. The dark water sirens surely would not simply let us pass, and yet there is not even a ripple to suggest they are circling below.

I glance toward the helm, then lift my hand and gesture for Grim to remove the wax from his ears.

“When did they stop singing?” I call out, my voice carrying across the deck as I keep my other hand moving over Lark’s back in slow, steady circles to settle him.

Grim pulls the wax free and pushes it into his pockets before straightening, then puts his hands back on the wheel.

“It looked like they retreated when you started singing,” he says, his gaze fixed ahead. “Maybe they showed mercy because you’re one of them, or because they heard Lark.”

Swallowing, my eyes drift back to the water, as if one of them might just break the surface. Maybe they really retreated. They are sirens, and they are the most vicious kind, but I know for a fact that we do not kill without reason, and we are not without a heart, no matter what the sailors might believe.

“Put the wax back in,” I say, quieter now, though the unease has not left me, my gaze lingering on the dark stretch next to us before I force it away. “It’s not worth the risk.”

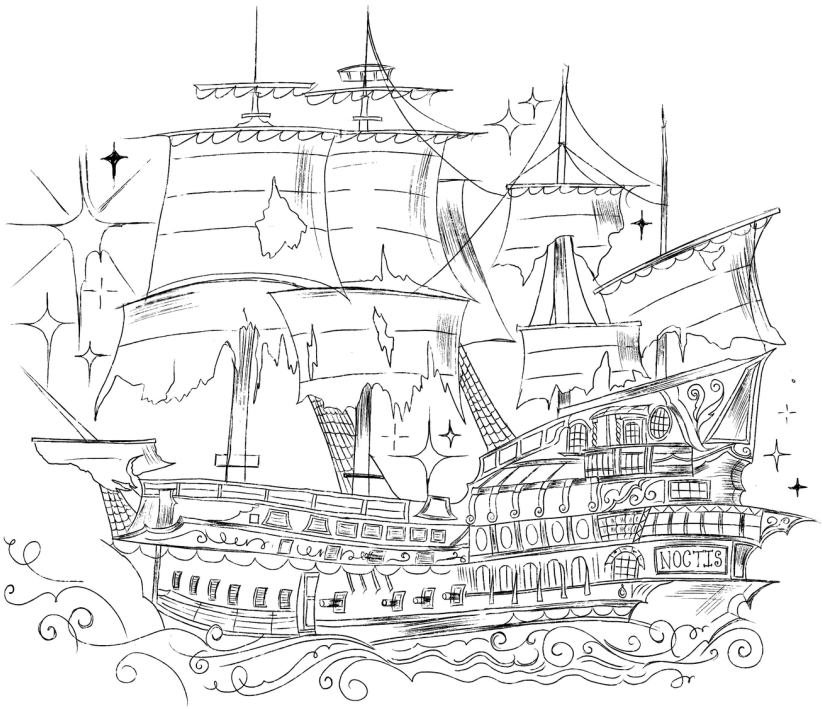
I adjust my hold on Lark, settling his weight more securely against me as I turn toward the cabin.

“I’ll bring him inside.”

Grim nods, takes the wax out of his pockets and pushes them into his ears again.

I wonder where his shadow is, and what it costs these men to lose them. But one question outweighs all the others, growing in my mind like an uncontained flame.

What have I just done?


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-Five

THE DARK WATER SIRENS remain in their unsettling silence, but the threat of their presence still presses in on us like a looming storm cloud. The sea feels too still beneath us, as though it is holding its breath. Watching us. Waiting. Whether they have been deterred by my song or are simply waiting for the next chance to strike, I cannot tell. But I will not take a risk with Lark's life. Or the life of any man in this crew. Not after what I did to Rat.

I hold out the wax pieces to Lark. Lantern light glints off his damp hair, and for a brief moment, I am struck by how small he still looks standing there in the dark. He likes to think of himself as a little pirate, twice as brave as any man, but the reality of it is unavoidable. He is just a boy.

"Put them back in," I say, keeping my voice steady despite the tension overcoming my body. "Then we'll find your father."

I manage a soft smile, hoping he feels the sincerity of it. "Okay?"

"Okay," he answers. His voice wavers, but he takes the wax from my hand and presses it into his ears with careful fingers, his jaw set as if fear is something he can command into obedience.

I kneel beside him and check the seals, pressing gently until I am sure the wax sits properly. When I rise, my hands linger on his shoulders longer than they need to. I tell myself I am steadying him, though I know it is myself I am bracing. Together we cross the deck toward the cabins beneath the quarterdeck, the boards creaking softly beneath our steps.

Sable must be somewhere around here. I wonder if the same can be said about his shadow.

Grim's vague answer to my question on where Sable is sits poorly with me.

Trust that he's doing what must be done.

I know for certain that he'd never leave his crew alone without reasoning, so whatever he must do, it must be important enough to distance himself. Sable does not step away when things turn difficult, and he certainly does not leave others to shoulder his burdens. That has never been who he is. The thought of him being unaccounted for tightens into a sharp, persistent stabbing beneath my ribs.

I bite the inside of my cheek, and push open the door to the cabins.

Lanterns line the narrow corridor, their flames swaying with the movement of the ship and casting uneven light across the worn wooden floor. At the far end, the small glass window set into Sable's cabin door spills a brighter glow into the passage.

"Maybe he's in there," I say, glancing back at Lark. Fear still clings to him, visible in the tight set of his shoulders, but he follows without hesitation.

I slow in front of the cabin door. My hand hovers over the latch. I am here for Nightglass, I remind myself. I'm simply bringing Lark to his father. Still, my pulse quickens as my fingers close around the cold iron and I push the door open.

The cabin is crowded.

Too crowded. Men fill the space shoulder to shoulder, packed in tighter than the room should allow. Whatever conversation they were having dies the moment I step inside. Some of them look hollow, as if something essential has been taken from them. Others watch me with open fear, shoulders drawn tight, hands clenched as though they expect me to unleash something I cannot stop. Something they cannot stop.

I scan the room first in search of Nightglass. Then, without meaning to, I look for Sable, but he is not here. I swallow, trying to ease the knot tightening in my throat as the door creaks shut behind us.

Nightglass stands near the far wall, half turned toward the entrance. He looks worn in a way I have never seen before, his posture rigid, his features pulled thin.

Before I can say his name, Lark slips free from my side. He crosses the cabin quickly and throws himself at his father. Nightglass drops to one knee and catches him just in time, arms closing around him with relief. Lark buries his face in his chest and breaks into sobs, his small body trembling.

“I’ve got you,” Nightglass coos, his voice low and steady.

There is something so achingly human in the way they hold each other. These men are not just pirates. They are fathers, brothers, sons, bound together by more than salt and duty, and by something darker that I still do not fully understand.

Around them, the shadows of most of the men fail to follow their movements. One stretches along the wall instead of staying at its owner’s heels, another drifts across the ceiling beams, untethered. My gaze tracks the way they linger at the edges of the lantern glow. Each time the light shifts, they pull back before moving closer again.

“I will bring more lanterns,” I say in a tremulous whisper, breaking the silence. I turn on my heel to gather the lanterns that are placed on the main deck and bring them in, leaving a few for Grim at the helm. When I return to the cabin for the last few lanterns, the conversations do not stop as I enter. Some of the tension has eased, and I thank the seas for it.

Now that I am sure they are fine, and Lark has returned to his father, Sable crashes into my thoughts again, dominating all others. As far as I’m concerned, he is not yet safe. I need to find him.

“Where’s Sable?” I ask in a voice that is steadier than it has been before, facing the crew.

Nightglass looks at me and gently squeezes Lark’s shoulders. His mouth turns into a thin line, clearly hesitating before he sighs.

“Lass, better not look for him. He is not himself—”

“Where—” I draw in a deep breath and exhale slowly through my nose. “—is he?”

If he didn’t leave me alone in my darkest moment, then I owe him the same in return. I don’t care what demons he is fighting or why he thinks he must go through this alone. I saw what it did to Lark. I can only imagine what it does to him.

“He’s on the balcony by the galley.” His words come out like a confession.

Ruffling the skirt of my gown into my hands, I practically fly through the narrow corridor until I reach the steps that lead into the galley. I take two

steps at a time, then stumble straight into the galley. The oven is not lit. Pots clink against each other as the ship moves beneath us. Strange to see a room once filled with life so empty of it.

My gaze drifts to the familiar door, framed in oak. The salt-clouded glass panes do not spill any light through them, not like they did the first time I saw them.

Sable is behind that door.

What worries me the most is that there's no light to protect him from the curse the sea has cruelly put upon him. I place my hand around the iron handle, but the heavy presence behind my back makes me freeze.

I know he's behind me. The shadow I came to know, to care for, in the same way that he cares for me. I remember Harrow's words. That I shouldn't acknowledge them, as it keeps them away from where they should be.

From who they should be with.

Tears start to sting in my eyes as I take a shaky, slow breath. I have been so, so good at not admitting to myself what I realized the moment Lark's shadow detached from his body.

That the ghost is Sable's shadow.

"Don't—" His voice echoes through the galley, distant yet near, soft yet thundering. I feel his presence closing in on me from behind, like a million tiny spiderwebs brushing against my skin, but I do not turn around. I do not give in to him.

I push down the handle and open the heavy wooden door. Outside, the sea breeze brings the smell of salt and whips strands of my hair over my face. I find him on the right side of the little balcony, clenching his hands around the iron rail. His posture is not straight and confident like it usually is. Instead, he is leaning over the banister, so tense that I see his muscles clenching through his shirt from where I stand.

He doesn't acknowledge my presence. Doesn't even lift his head.

"Are you—" I cut myself off. I don't even know what to say to him, what to ask him. I came here without a plan, without employing any rational decision-making skills. All I know is that I didn't want him to be alone.

I should've brought a damn lantern.

My eyes scan the boards at his feet, but there's no shadow following his movements. It could be anywhere now.

“Are you okay?” I manage to say, my voice nothing more than a whisper. The boards squeak as I take another step toward him. From here, I can hear his shallow breathing. Another step.

When my hand touches his shoulder, he flinches. Not wanting to unsettle him, I pause for a moment but do not withdraw my touch. There is a relentless kindness to be found in fearing someone and offering them help despite it, and the pirate in front of me has done that exact thing for me.

He takes in a slow breath and lifts his head slightly.

“You naive, little fish. You came here expecting to do what?” A laugh slips out of him. “Save me? To make sure I feel good? What good is that if I don’t even know my own name?”

I swallow hard and let my gaze wander over his face. Dark locks fall over his knitted eyebrows, and below them, empty, black eyes stare into mine. I blink slowly. Looking away means acknowledging that there’s nothing left to be saved, that seeing him like this is uncomfortable.

“Why are you not with the others? I—”

“Please,” he says through his teeth, looking to the sea now instead of at me. “I do not want to throw you overboard. But right now, that’s all I can think of. So please—” he draws in a long breath again, then exhales. “—leave me alone.”

Something inside of me stirs.

“Is that what it does to you?” I slowly remove my shaking hand from his shoulder. “It makes you cruel? Makes the monster win?”

“I wonder how long it would take until your body hits the surface. Longer than Ash, perhaps,” he says, and the calculation in his voice makes me shiver. “He was heavier than you.”

Nightglass was right. He has to be right. He is not being himself. The absence of his shadow makes him… different. Like all light has been taken from him. Taking shallow breaths, he slowly turns toward me. The siren in me screams and pumps power through me that can’t go anywhere — that I won’t let go anywhere — and instead breaks against my willpower like shuddering waves over and over again. Run. She shouts. Run.

But I don’t. I lift my chin and meet his stare.

“You think you’re not worthy of being saved,” I whisper, and for a short moment, his eyes flicker in hesitation. “But I know you. I know your shadow. And it has nothing in common with the man standing in front of me now.”

“You know nothing about me,” he speaks through clenched teeth, each word measured. “And nothing about my shadow.”

“I know more than enough.”

Silence settles between us. The sea stretches beneath the stern, dark and endless. His breathing somehow syncs with mine, our chests lifting and falling at the same time. As I glance to the side, there’s a dark figure lurking behind the wooden door. I know it's the curse that makes the shadows detach, but I want to scream at him for doing so nonetheless.

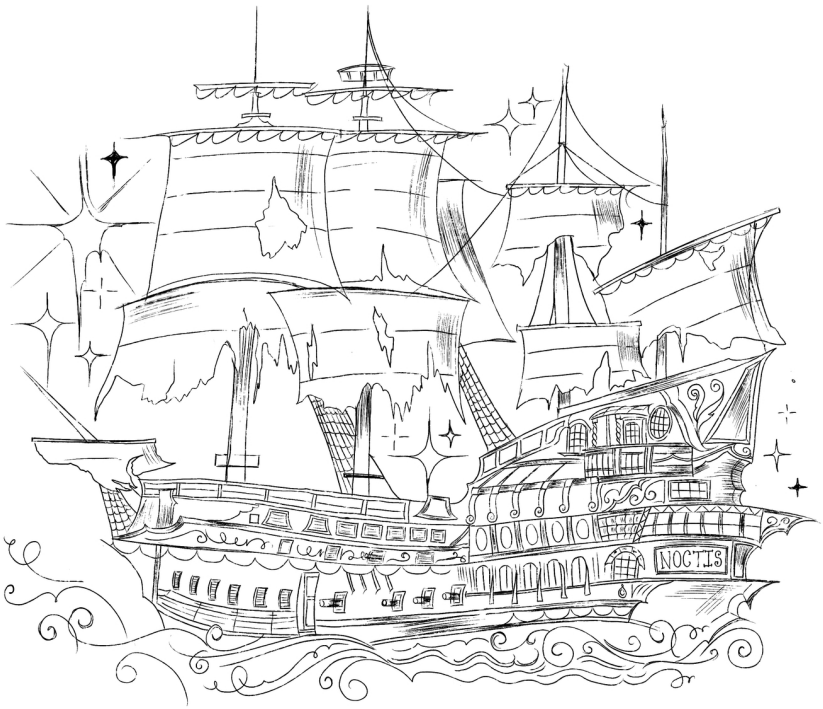
Then the light changes.

It is subtle at first. A pale shift at the edge of the horizon. The sun does not rise here, not fully, but it pushes through just enough, and soon, a muted glow breaks across the water.

Sable stiffens as the light reaches his face, making his skin glow golden. I come to stand next to him, to be able to support him, just in case he needs me to.

The boards at his feet darken as the shadow pulls itself back into place. It gathers beneath him, like smoke curling around his ankles, before finally settling, slow and quiet, like ash falling from the sky after a wildfire. When the last curl of darkness is gone, he exhales and loosens his grip on the rail.

Neither of us speaks. He doesn’t ask me to stay, and I don’t leave. We remain standing side by side, shoulder against shoulder, as the ship moves on, the light holding just long enough for the sea to release him from its hold.


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-Six

THE WARMTH OF THE sun floods my face with sleepiness, and for the first time in a long time, I dream of home. It meant something entirely different to me than it did to them, the other sirens in our swarm. While they lived under the water, in the dark caves of a sunken mountain, my life happened above the surface. In my dream, I lay on the rocky little island that jutted out of the water and let the sun wrap me in its gentle, warm embrace, before my mother scolds me for spending so much time up here. Her face appears so vividly to me that I wish I could go back just to see her again. Even just one more time.

Blinking, the world around me comes into focus in layers of golden, bright light. I push myself upward, both hands against the wood beneath me, startled by the warmth that seeps into my palms. The Noctis sways beneath in a slow, steady rhythm that threatens to lull me back to sleep.

I lean forward and look over the rail.

The sea stretches out below, smooth as glass. There are no ripples trailing the stern, no white churn where the hull should be breaking the surface. The water barely moves at all. It gleams instead, pale and glistening, laced with various colors when I tilt my head. It appears shallow and endless, reflecting the sky in colors that remind me of those you'd find on an Abalone shell. Blues and pinks and greens flowing into one another. Glistening and shifting depending on how the light hits it.

Only after looking out do I realize, we are not moving.

With my brows knitted together in a frown, I find a sleeping pirate captain next to me. We are still on the little balcony that sits above the sea, and it seems like somehow, we have fallen asleep. I must've been so tired after using my song on Lark's shadow, considering how drained I had felt afterwards. I'm not used to employing so much power at once.

Sable leans with his back against the wall, his head fallen to his chest. Dark curls hang loose and cast a shadow on his sun-kissed skin, his closed eyes, and ridiculously beautiful lashes. Good to know he's sleeping well after threatening to throw me overboard.

I haul myself up with a grunt and smooth the folds of my gown. He is the most stubborn, irrational pirate I have ever met. Locks himself out here, without so much as a candle, because he thinks he's not worthy of saving, that no one would care if something were to happen to him.

Getting up this fast was not a good idea. I am overcome with dizziness, and grab the railing in front of me to steady myself. The soreness of my limbs makes me buckle, so I take a deep breath to ground myself against the dull pain. Now that Sable is safe, at least for now, the feeling of betrayal overwhelms me. I can't believe he didn't trust me enough to tell me about his shadow.

A hand finds the small of my back.

"Risa, are you—" he begins, but I cut him off.

"I'm fine. But are you?" I turn toward Sable, who now stands next to me, and sigh. "I have no interest in playing pretend anymore."

His brow furrows slightly, then he slowly withdraws his hand from my back. "Pretend?"

"Yes," I say. "Pretend that you're not cursed, that you're not going to die if you don't break it."

My breath stutters, and I hesitate before my next words. "Or that the ghost you warned me about is not your own shadow."

The sleepiness that still clung to his features a moment ago washes away in an instant, as if I have just emptied a bucket of ice-cold water over his face. He blinks at me, opens his mouth, and closes it again. I cross my arms over my chest in anticipation of his defensive speech. For him to deny what I have just revealed I know.

But he doesn't. He barely even moves a muscle.

"That's what I thought," I whisper. "Did you even consider telling me?"

His jaw tightens. "I did."

I lift my chin. “And?”

“And it would have complicated things.”

I would say that things are complicated now, too. I really thought that he and I were starting to be more than just reluctant allies, more than friends. I am sure he has his reasons for not telling me the truth, but I can’t help but feel a sting in my heart at his lack of trust in me. And right now, that pain is feeding into an anger that I really don’t want to unleash upon him.

Taking a deep breath, I stare at him, incredulous. “Of course. How careless of me. My questions about your shadow would’ve been terribly inconvenient.”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“No?” I step closer, my voice low now. “Because from where I’m standing, it looks like you decided it was simpler to let me stumble through the dark. More simple than telling me the man I was learning to trust becomes someone else when his shadow is gone. Why did you not trust me with this?”

“Because…” he sighs, then runs a hand through his hair, “I didn’t want to put you at risk.”

I laugh, a brittle sound that surprises us both. “You threatened to kill me.”

His eyes flash. “I would never—”

“You did,” I cut in. “You stood there and guessed how long it would take for my body to hit the surface.”

He freezes as something flickers across his face. Confusion. Uncertainty. A crack in the confidence he usually wears like armor.

“I don’t…” He exhales slowly. “I remember vaguely.”

The word lands heavily between us.

Vaguely.

It’s the same word the shadow used when I asked him if he knew the captain well. By the seas, I was so blind.

“You don’t remember,” I say quietly, tears blurring my vision. “None of it?”

His silence confirms it.

“So you don’t remember helping me,” I continue, my voice steadier than I feel. “You don’t remember gifting me that dress. Or when you pulled me from the depths when I was drowning. You don’t remember holding me that night, when I found out about the curse.”

His gaze drops to my throat, then to my mouth, as if searching for something he can’t quite grasp.

“I remember how it felt,” he says after a moment. “Like a dream you cannot remember after you wake. I knew my shadow reached out to you, so I tried to keep my distance, tried to keep it from slipping away. But I failed. I know I failed because in the last few weeks, I only remember the moments I spent with you.”

My chest tightens. He doesn’t remember. If what he’s saying is true, and he can’t remember the moments I spent with his shadow, that changes… everything. The sting in my heart eases a little, then becomes worse again. Not because of anger, but because I am sorry for him. I can’t imagine what it felt like to see the emerald dress on me and not remember giving it to me, only to realize it must have been his own shadow. Or to watch me learn about the curse and only recall the feeling of holding me in his arms.

“On that beach,” he continues. “When you asked me about the curse, my shadow slipped away. I don't remember what I said or did to you, Eryse. That’s why I came to check on you, to make sure you were okay. Do you know what it’s like? To lose your memory, lose yourself?”

A knot tightens in my throat as I swallow against it. I don’t. But I know what it’s like to lose control over yourself. To become something you don’t recognize.

I step closer again, drawn in despite myself, close enough that I can feel the heat of him, the tension in the way he holds himself so carefully still.

“You could’ve told me,” I say, quieter now. “Could’ve trusted me. You truly think I can handle my own monster, and curses and hunters, but not you and yours? We could’ve carried that pain together, Sable.”

“I know,” he whispers, his voice breaking. “I’m sorry, Eryse. You were still my captive when you first met my shadow, and I couldn’t tell you then. But then…”

My breath falters. This is the first time either of us acknowledges that somehow, in between maelstroms, dances in taverns, and siren encounters on hidden little beaches, something between us has changed. That he’s maybe even more than a friend.

“Then?”

His hand lifts, then hesitates, hovering near my arm as if he doesn’t trust himself to touch me. The restraint in the gesture makes my breathing come in shallow waves.

“Then I started seeing you differently,” he says. “I saw your pain, who you are behind those glistening scales. I saw how you started to care about me, about the crew. I knew that if you ever found out, you wouldn’t keep your distance. You would try to save me, so I didn’t tell you. I was trying to protect you,” he says in a low voice, and his finger presses briefly against his chest. “From me.”

Biting my lip, I turn his words over. Maybe he’s right. I would’ve gone after him, would’ve made sure he’s not alone whenever his shadow slipped away. But that choice should’ve been mine.

I shake my head. “It’s not up to you to decide what I need protecting from. That’s not your burden.”

Something in his expression breaks, just slightly. His breath stutters, and the atmosphere in the space between us feels charged and dangerous and fragile.

“You don’t understand what I become,” he says. “The fate I am facing.”

“I’ve seen it,” I reply. “Last night. And I’m still here.”

His eyes darken, something conflicted flashing through them. It must be hard for him, not remembering what he did and said to me.

“You sent me away, Sable. You didn’t just toss me overboard,” I continue, my breathing heavier now. “Even with your shadow gone, you recognized me. I don’t think you would’ve hurt me.”

He looks away, out toward the open, calm sea. He swallows, then knits his brows together, as if he has a hard time believing what I am saying. I hesitate, then reach for his hand. His fingers are rough against my skin, but I don’t mind. Not even the slightest.

“I trust you,” I whisper and brush my thumb over the back of his hand, reassuring him that I won’t leave.

Not now.

Not ever.

“You shouldn’t,” he says and abruptly turns toward me again, the sunlight catching in his grey eyes. His chest rises faster now, tension coiled through him, his free hand clenched at his side. But he doesn’t remove my hand from his. Instead, he threads his fingers through mine, and it feels as if a thousand little waves are breaking against the shore of my heart.

“Then do something that makes me leave,” I say, lifting my chin as I meet his gaze. Truthfully, I am not sure what he could do that would actually make me leave. And from the intensity of his stare, he might come

to the same conclusion. His gaze drops briefly to our joined hands, then lifts again. I follow it, my pulse stuttering again at the sight of his fingers laced with mine. When his tongue drags slowly over his lips, my eyes lift to his mouth, and I forget how to breathe.

He doesn’t make me leave.

Instead, he closes the last inch of space between us. The air feels tight and charged, like the moment before a storm breaks. I should pull back. I should say something else.

I don’t.

The first brush of his lips against mine pulls a light gasp from my throat, the sound slipping out before I can stop it. Heat spreads through me too fast, turning my body numb until I can no longer feel the ground beneath my feet. I lean my body towards him, even though my brain screams not to, I cannot help myself. I cannot resist. I kiss him.

This seems to be what he was waiting for. He places one hand against the small of my back and removes the other from mine, tangling it through my hair instead. He pulls my body flat against his. He tastes like salt and smoke and something distinctly his, and it pulls a sound from me that I don’t recognize as my own.

For a moment, there is nothing else. Not the sea. Not the shadows. Not the things he didn’t tell me or the things we don’t know how to fix. There is only the way my body responds to him, as though it was always meant to be pressed against his.

When we break apart, my breath comes uneven, my lips tingling. Thoughts twist through my fogged brain, blurred and entirely unintelligible. I wonder if this is what it feels like to be compelled by the song of a siren and then be snapped back into reality the moment it fades.

“I was foolish,” Sable mutters, his nose brushing against mine, his breath hot against my skin.

I keep my eyes down at our feet, not able to form any words just yet. “Mh?”

“I was foolish,” he whispers, his dark brows knitting together slightly, “thinking I could resist a siren.”

“Wha—”

He kisses me again. More confident this time, as his mouth crushes against mine. It feels honest and desperate at the same time, like a confession of a man who is finally allowing himself to feel. Allowing

himself to act on his desires. His lips are soft and sure as I tangle my hands through the hair at the back of his head, making him groan into the kiss.

I am kissing Captain Sable Crowe.

Again.

When I am about to break the kiss to draw in some air, he pulls away and rests his forehead against mine.

“I’m sorry,” he whispers, his voice breaking.

“You don’t have to apologize,” I assure him, and lean back so I can look at him properly.

The man in front of me appears conflicted, the muscles in his jaw tense, his brows drawn together. No sign of the usual smugness or confidence. I try to look him in the eyes, but he averts his gaze, staring at the sea instead.

“I must,” he murmurs and lets me go, his hands brushing the fabric of my gown back into place, as if he wants to remove all evidence of him letting himself go. Of him losing control. “Because I promised myself never to cross that line with you. And yet, I just couldn’t help myself. You deserve better, love. Someone whole. No curse. No shadow.”

He couldn’t be more wrong. We’re both not whole, both fighting our inner monsters. Maybe we’re two broken pieces that belong together so perfectly that even the sea itself intertwined our fates. But he doesn’t seem to think that way. I get the feeling, now more than ever, that he has already given up on himself. And with that, has given up on us.

Sable shifts his weight from one foot to the other, then runs his hand through his hair, leaving it messier than it was before. My silence must make him nervous.

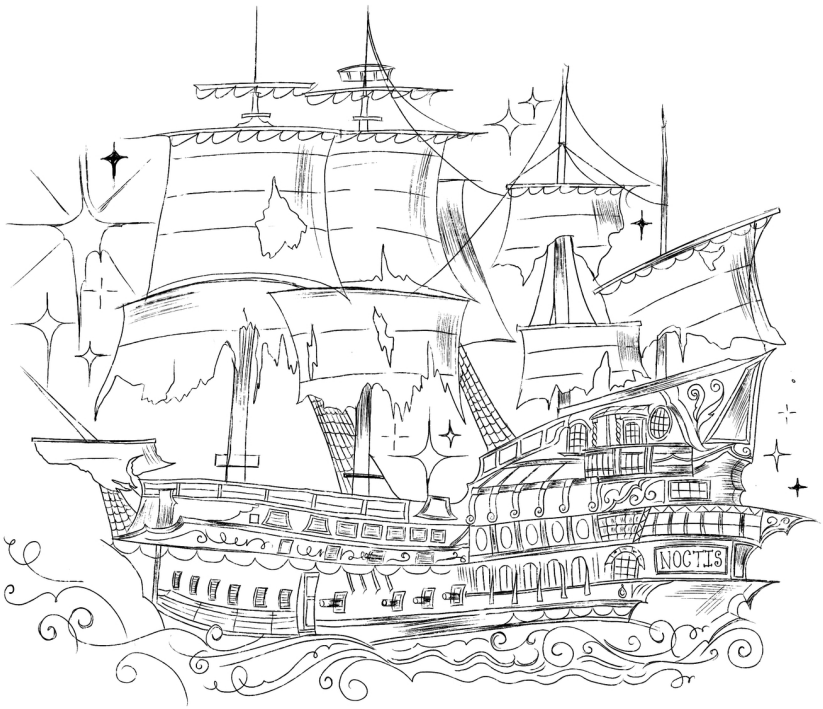
“Won’t you say something?” he eventually asks, and lifts his hand toward me, then drops it a moment later.

I swallow down the knot that has formed in my throat as wetness wells in my eyes. I try not to blink so that it does not spill. I don’t want to cry, not now.

“The next time you kiss me, make sure not to make me feel like you regret it the moment after,” I say, my voice nothing more than a whisper, and yet it feels like I just screamed at him. “And only do it if you are willing to fight for yourself. For us.”

Sable clears his throat and retreats. I watch him turn his back toward me and leave without another word, the warmth fading from where he last touched me. Suddenly, the balcony feels much bigger than before, and all I

long for is to slip back into my dream, back to the little island just above the water.


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-Seven

I STARE AT THE DOOR Sable left through for what feels like hours before gathering myself enough to bear making my way to the orlop. Most of the men there are still asleep. Morning light spills down from the deck above, catching on the low beams and the curve of the hull, dust motes drifting lazily in the air. The hammocks hang perfectly still, unmoving, bodies resting heavy inside them. My boots sound too loud against the boards in the quiet, the rhythm of my steps the only thing breaking through the calm, aside from the soft rise and fall of breathing.

It makes sense. There is no wind. No sail to tend. Nothing urging the ship forward.

Lark sleeps in his hammock, damp hair clinging to his forehead, his chest rising in slow, even breaths. Seeing him like this loosens something in my chest, and a smile creeps onto my lips before I realize the feeling it evokes in me. He looks peaceful. Safe. Nightglass's hammock beside him hangs empty.

I blink against the brightness as I step onto the main deck. Sunlight floods the ship in a way that feels almost unreal after the darkness we passed through, warm and steady, reflecting off the pale, glassy water around us. I do not look toward the helm. Even if I did, I doubt I would find the captain there while the Noctis lies motionless.

Instead, my eyes search for the Glim.

It circles the ship in slow movements, as if waiting for us. The faint silver thread it leaves behind is almost invisible against the smooth, iridescent

water. I grip the railing a little tighter and lean over to get a better look at the surface. It mirrors the dark hull of the Noctis perfectly, as though the ship has been set in a mirror.

I tap my fingers against the wood and bite down on my lip.

I have no idea where we are or how we got here. But the kiss unsettles me even more than that. Not the kiss itself, but the way he left afterward. He opened up to me about the curse, about how he feels about me, only to pull away again. I don't know where that leaves us now, caught somewhere between a kiss, or rather two, and him telling me I deserve better than him. He seems to have given up on himself, yet he is still searching for a way out for his crew. Everything he has done these past few weeks has been leading to one thing: following the Glim to break the curse.

I sigh, annoyed with myself for being unable to control my emotions.

A shout from above cuts through my thoughts.

"Lass!"

I look up to see Nightglass waving down from the crow's nest.

"I will not climb up there again," I call back.

He grins. "No need. There's nothing to see. Looks like an endless bloody mirror. Tell that to the captain, will ya?"

I frown. Of course.

I briefly consider telling him that the captain probably does not want to see me, but the thought of announcing our… issues to the entire ship is enough to make me clench my teeth. So I give Nightglass a short nod instead and cross the deck as slowly as is physically possible.

If Sable isn't at the helm, then he must be in his cabin.

My hand hovers over the familiar iron handle. I am not ready to see him. An hour has passed, perhaps two, since he pressed his lips to mine and shattered the careful distance we had kept between us. I draw in a breath, then another, before finally pressing down the handle and stepping inside.

The cabin is crowded with unlit lanterns. They hang from the ceiling, line the walls, and sit in clusters on the floor. They are everywhere. The sight of them sends the memory of last night flashing through my mind. The hollow stares of the crew. The way Lark's body was shaking.

I feel his gaze on me before I see him. He and Grim stare back at me from either side of the wooden table, and his eyes fall from mine as soon as I look directly at him. He clears his throat, refusing to acknowledge my presence.

I lift my chin and cross the room with deliberate strides, stopping at the wooden table in the center. Sable and Grim lean over an ancient-looking map I have not seen before, marking points with pins only to remove them again and turn the parchment in frustrated increments. I watch them silently, trying to figure out what exactly it is that they are doing.

“It must be the Sea of Dreams,” Grim murmurs under his breath, tapping a stretch of water on the map.

I furrow my brows, leaning into the table until the wood bites into my hips. The sea he points out lies beyond a thin black line, the Sea of Shadows, I assume—the one we have somehow survived against all odds with little struggle.

“What do we know about it?” Sable asks Grim quietly, his eyes not leaving the map, pointedly ignoring me.

“Not much,” Grim replies, rubbing his chin with his hand.

Then both of them look up at me.

“Do you?”

“No.” I shake my head, keeping my focus on Grim. “Why would I?”

Sable shifts his weight from foot to foot. “You’re from here. Aren’t you?”

“No,” I lower my eyes on the deck, on the worn wood behind the table. “I mean, I don’t know where I’m from. I told you I was abandoned when I was seven.”

Silence stretches, and neither of us dares to look at the other.

“What is wrong with you two?” Grim’s eyes flit between us, confusion forming a deep line between his brows.

“Nothing,” we answer in unison.

I roll my eyes as Sable turns away and takes a book from the shelf tugged against the wall. I allow myself to look at him while his back is turned. When he returns, I avert my gaze again, folding my arms over my chest. Paper rustles as he flips through a book, then places it on the table in front of me.

The pages are filled with tight, careful handwriting, observations recorded with methodical precision. My eyes skim until they catch on familiar words woven into the title, something about sirens and dreams. Now is not the time to admit that I can't read. On the opposite page is a watercolor. My pulse stutters at the depiction of a siren.

She looks like me.

Her hair is blonde, almost white, the same pale shade as her eyes. The siren’s tail looks strong yet delicate, iridescent scales covering every inch and climbing up parts of her torso. There is nothing monstrous or uncomfortable about her, she simply looks beautiful.

Seeing a picture of what I could have, and likely never will, makes my heart grow heavy. The weight of it drags me down, and I feel like I'm drowning all over again.

“Put it away,” I whisper.

He doesn’t move.

“Please,” I add, “put it away.”

Sable snaps the book shut and puts it back on the shelf. I bite my lip hard enough that I’m surprised it doesn’t bleed.

“My mother had a black tail,” I say quietly. “She wasn’t from here. I don’t know anything about this sea. But Nightglass says there’s nothing to see. Just an endless mirror.”

“And there’s no wind,” Grim adds, already lost in his thoughts. “Without wind, we’re stuck. Supplies won’t last forever.”

“We’ll ration,” Sable says. His arms fold behind his back again. “And wait.”

“And there’s more,” Grim continues, shoulders tensing as he glances at me. “Eryse, this is yours to tell. I don’t remember most of it.”

Because his shadow was separate from him too.

I sigh and begin to pace the cabin. I don’t know what I did, or how I did it, or whether I can do it again. False hope is a dangerous thing, so I choose my words very carefully, though deep down I hope that it will make Sable see things differently.

I tell them about Lark.

Not every detail. Not the way Lark trembled in my arms, or how the fear clawed at my ribs as his shadow pulled away from him. I tell them only what matters. That his shadow detached. That he panicked. That I sang for him when nothing else seemed to work, and that somehow, his shadow was drawn to it and returned to his body.

When I finish, the cabin is quiet. Unsettlingly so.

“I…” My voice falters. “I was exhausted afterward. But the fear of what could’ve gone wrong kept me awake until… I fell asleep.”

Fell asleep with him on the balcony, the truth remains unspoken between us, and we leave it there. We don’t need to go over all the details.

Grim clears his throat first. “Is it permanent?”

“It felt pretty final to me.”

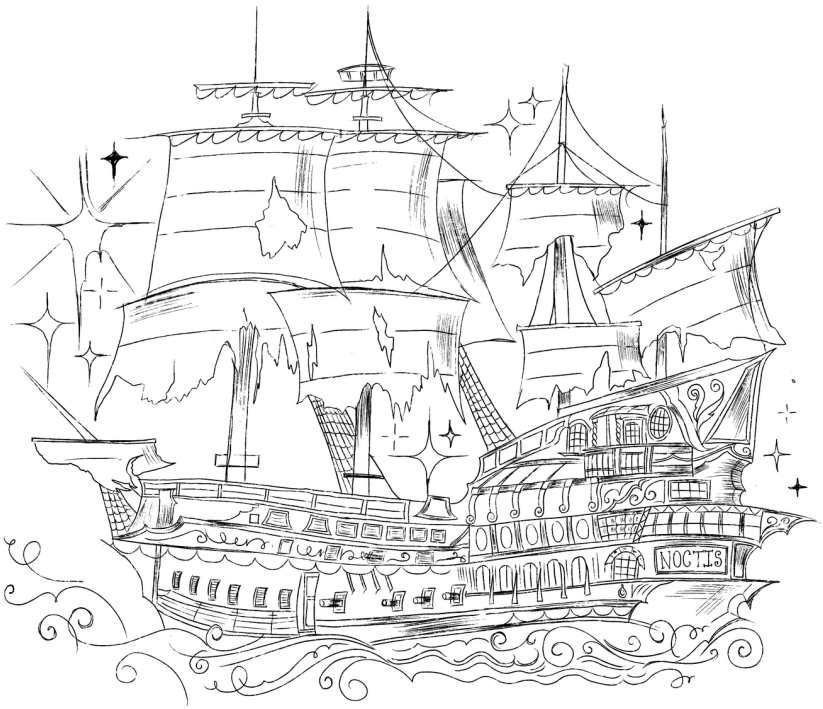
“If this is true…” Sable says, beginning to pace too.

“It might be our cure,” Grim finishes, both of their gazes landing on me. Hope flashes through Sable’s eyes, and from where he’s standing beside the little round window, the sun makes it look like they are sparkling. He looked so broken hours ago, as if he had truly lost all hope for a life without his curse. Perhaps I was a little too hard on him.

“I don’t have control over it,” I say, the words leaving me like a confession. “My voice. I don’t know how to use my siren song. I have never compelled a man.”

“Then we practice,” he says, walking over and stopping in front of me with a smile on his face. Something about him being in such proximity to me makes me lift my head despite myself, feigning nonchalance. Grey eyes bore into mine, and even though it has been some hours, my lips begin to tingle at the thought of our kiss. At the thought of it happening again.

“If we’re stuck here, we might as well use the time to our advantage. You will practice,” a smile tugs at the corner of those rosy lips of his. “And you will practice on me, little fish.”


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-Eight

SABLE HAS SENT THE whole crew below deck for our so-called training. He stands a few feet away from me, arms folded neatly behind his back, shoulders squared, stance secure in a way that feels calculated rather than relaxed, as if he's already bracing himself for whatever I might do. His black, slightly curly hair sits untouched by the lack of wind, not a single strand out of place. Bone charms and necklaces hang loose around his neck, catching the sun whenever he shifts, and I do not even try to ignore the tattoos that disappear beneath his linen shirt, because pretending they are not there would be a lie.

Seducing this man might be more difficult than I thought.

"So," he says, spreading his arms wide, the gesture open and infuriating. "You can begin."

A humorless laugh bubbles out of my throat. "That's not how it works. My inner siren is fueled by strong emotions. Fear. Anger. Hate and…"

I trail off, my brows drawing together as the missing word settles heavier than the rest.

"And?" he asks, one brow lifting as his arms fall by his sides. He is watching me far too closely.

I cross my arms over my chest and glance away.

"Lust."

Sable chokes on his breath, styling it out by clearing his throat.

"And I'm not feeling any of those emotions right now," I add, tapping my middle finger against my arm in a restless rhythm that gives me something

to focus on.

He takes a slow, intentional step toward me.

“Are you sure about that? Because the glare you always shoot at me would set the average man on fire. Or cause him to drop dead right on the spot.”

“I don’t hate you,” I say, meeting his gaze again. “If that’s what you’re getting at.”

“That may be true,” he leans his head closer to mine to whisper, the temptation of a smirk tugging at his lips. “But you hate how much you want me.”

I gasp, my fingers tightening around my arms until the pressure borders on pain. Heat spreads through me, anger first and foremost, rushing straight to my cheeks before I can stop it.

“I beg your pardon?” I ask through clenched teeth.

“You heard me,” he says, inching closer again, the half-smile on his face sharpening into a devilish grin. “A siren wanting a pirate, imagine that. I bet you couldn’t compel me even if you wanted to.”

“I know what you’re trying to do.”

“The way you look at me when you think I’m not watching…”

The boards creak beneath his boots as he straightens his back and lifts his head, looking down at me, waiting for a response. A vibration sparks to life deep in my center. Small at first, then stronger with every word he speaks, like a flame being fed piece after piece of dry wood until it cannot be contained.

“Stop it.”

“And let’s not forget about my shadow,” he continues quietly, his voice slipping into something almost thoughtful. “How could you not realize it was me? I already told you that your instincts aren’t very sharp.”

Clamping my eyes shut tight, I draw in a slow breath and let it out through my nose, forcing the air past the humming that has begun to slink and coil behind my ribs. How dare he mention the shadow now. He knows exactly how betrayed I feel, how deeply it cut to realize I had formed a bond with an altered version of him without knowing the truth.

When I open my eyes again, the world seems sharper, as though everything has been brought back into focus, after so long in the dark. I feel the presence of the water beneath the ship as if it were part of me, its stillness pressing upward, its salt calling out to something ancient inside my

chest. Sable stands close enough that I can feel the heat of him, the quiet danger of his proximity to me further fueling my hum. My inner siren responds before I can stop her, drawn to exactly what she knows she should avoid.

“And now,” he breathes, storm-grey eyes locked onto mine without fear or hesitation. “Sing for me, little fish.”

The nickname snaps something in me clean in two. I reach inward and gather the strings of my power one by one, curling my fists around them before pulling all at once. The tension folds my body at the center, forcing me to lean forward as my breath shudders and the song lodges painfully in my throat, refusing to come free.

“Steady.” His hand finds the small of my back, the other on my waist, holding me upright. His touch sends a pulse through me, sensation and power colliding until it feels like lightning skittering beneath my skin. “Don’t let it consume you. Control it.”

With Lark, it had been different. I had wanted to soothe, not command. Sable resists instinctively, as if he has built a wall of iron around himself, and I feel it in the air before I even give the song shape.

“Okay,” I whisper.

His hand only leaves once I’m steady on my own again.

I reach inward more carefully this time, coaxing out the humming power in my core instead of dragging it forward. One thread. Then another. I let them flow through me slowly, testing the balance, waiting until I’m sure they won’t overwhelm me before taking just a little more.

“You have to sing,” Sable whispers, a deep frown line settling between his eyes. “Give it a purpose. Make me do something. Whatever you want.”

The whimper that escapes me barely deserves to be called a note. I shake my head as the panic in me rises, and instead of letting go, I draw in more power than I should, my chest tightening as fear tangles with my power.

Sable takes my hand in his. “I trust you. And jumping overboard wouldn’t kill me here.” His thumb brushes over the back of my hand, sending a shiver through me. “Sing.”

So I do.

The sound slips out of me without clear shape, more hum than song, vibrating behind my teeth before settling into my chest and pouring out in full. It flows directly from the place where my inner siren usually stirs.

Sable stills.

I keep my eyes on the deck at first, on the way sunlight spills across the boards in pale, shifting lines. My voice curls outward, wrapping around us both, leaving a faint echo in its wake, like a rope drawn tight but still slinking around us.

His grip on my hand loosens before slipping away completely. When I finally look at him, his jaw is clenched, his eyes dark and fixed on me with an intensity that makes my pulse stumble. His hands fall at his sides, fingers flexing as if he's fighting the pull.

I draw in more power, letting the song push harder against his resistance. Before I can decide what I want it to do, his knees hit the deck with a thud. He kneels in front of me, head bowed slightly, breath uneven, as if he has run a great distance and only now stops to catch his breath.

At the sight of him, my heart slams against my ribs, and the song dies on my tongue.

"I didn't mean…" I don't continue, because there are no words that seem to fit.

He doesn't move.

The moment stretches, the echo of my song still humming through my body. When he still doesn't move, instinct takes over. I gather my gown and drop to my knees in front of him, lifting his face carefully until his eyes meet mine.

He's smiling.

"Darling," he breathes, "if you wanted me on my knees, you could have just told me."

I gasp and release a breath I hadn't realized I was holding, my hands falling away from his face, numb and shaking.

"You scared me," I say with a shaking voice and try to stand, but his hand closes around my wrist.

"I'm messing with you," he says, eyes lingering. "That was good."

We stare at each other, the silence stretching between us, heavy with everything we haven't yet said. It reminds me of this morning and the way he looked at me before he kissed me. And even though I miss his lips against mine, I am not ready for that yet, not until I know what's behind his lack of hope.

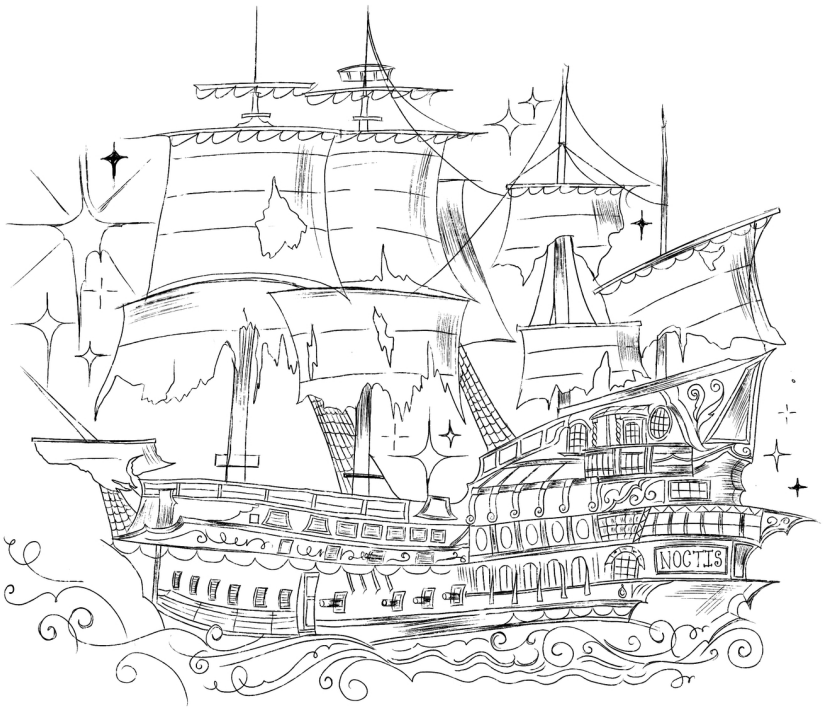
As the silence stretches, the world seems to soften at the edges, the lines of the deck and the sea blurring just slightly as it sways beneath my feet.

I blink, and I'm not sure how long we've been staring at one another.

Swallowing hard, I avert my gaze. “The training is over,” I say and tear my wrist free.

“Eryse, I—”

I rise too quickly, catching on the hem of my gown before I steady myself, then turn and walk away, leaving him behind.


NOCTIS

Chapter Twenty-Nine

"WE HAD BARELY EVEN started!"

I keep my eyes fixed ahead, walking toward the bow with a determination that stiffens the muscles in my face into a frown. Of course, he catches up after a beat. His footsteps follow me, close enough that my pace falters before he reaches me.

A hand slides around my waist to my abdomen, stopping me mid-step and pulling me directly into his warm, solid chest. It knocks the breath out of me, caught completely off guard by how easily he does it, how confidently he touches me. His fingers spread wide over my stomach, his thumb pressing into the soft skin there, steadying and possessive. Whatever I mean to say dies in my throat.

"We could do something else instead," he whispers, his breath warm against the side of my neck. "It might be worth taking a swim, considering you're likely formed from the same magic that makes these waters so hard to resist."

I swallow and close my eyes, just for a moment, just long enough to feel the heat of him seep into me before it's gone. I take in the salt of his skin, the steady weight of his hold, the way he anchors me more securely than any chain ever could. I place my hands over his, not pushing him away yet. Just feeling him. Just this once.

"Sable," I say, my voice thin when I finally find it. I push him back to turn around, and this time, he lets me. "Is your shadow near? Because if it's not, please just tell me."

He studies me, brows furrowing slightly, and it feels as though he's looking straight through the barrier I've built, as if it were nothing more than clear water.

"My shadow's with me," he says quietly. "It feels like the light's been following me around. I've never felt more like myself."

"Oh."

My gaze drops to the bodice of my light pink gown, my cheeks likely matching the color of the fabric now. If this is what Sable is like when he's whole, then I am in trouble. Big time.

"Aye," he says, the smile audible in his voice. "Oh."

We stand there in silence on the empty deck, the ship utterly still beneath us. I wonder if not talking about what happened this morning will make everything worse, like pressing a bandage over a wound that's already infected and pretending it won't fester underneath. Perhaps ripping the bandage off is the better option.

I lift my head and meet his eyes, picking at a loose thread on my sleeve so as not to let my nerves show in the shaking of my hands. "Why did you kiss me this morning if you don't see any hope?"

He steps closer, his silhouette a harsh contrast against the blazing sun.

"You know exactly why I kissed you," he says and tucks a strand of my hair behind my ear, a gesture so gentle that it sends a shiver rippling through me.

"No, I do not. Please, feel free to enlighten me."

He takes another step forward, closing the distance between us.

"Because, darling," he says softly, "I'm selfish. And resisting you is like telling the moon to stop pulling the tide."

I close my eyes and breathe through it, through the things I can't say out loud. That he confuses me. That he shattered everything I thought I knew about pirates, about fear, about safety. That he hurt me by keeping the truth from me. That I can fear someone and still care for them, even when I wish I didn't. But I cannot say any of these things.

Sable lets out a sigh and places both hands on the sides of my head, then makes me look at him.

"You singing back Lark's shadow," he says in a low voice, "That has given me hope. You are my hope, Eryse."

I swallow, trying my best to keep it together. "So you are willing to fight?"

“I am always willing to fight for my crew,” he continues in a serious voice.

“And for yourself?” I press, searching his face for the truth he refuses to say out loud. “Tell me that you’re willing to fight.”

For a moment, he only looks at me. Then exhales and drags both hands over his face before pressing his palms into his eyes. The silence is deafening.

“Yes,” he adds, his eyes holding mine. “I am willing to fight, love. But there are things you don’t know about me, about my shadow—”

“Then tell me,” I cut in, the sharpness in my voice surprising even me. “Because if you won’t tell me what it is you continue to keep from me, I can’t help you.”

By the way his throat moves as he swallows, I know that he doesn’t want to give me an answer. Not yet. Taking a deep breath, I try to get a grip on my emotions again. The words are there. I can see it in the way his chest rises a little deeper, like he almost speaks, then stops himself. It seems like this isn’t easy for him. I could push and force him to say it, but I don’t. Not when it would make it harder for him. I have to trust that he will tell me eventually, and hope that it won’t be too late.

“I’ll go swim,” I say instead, a faint smile tugging at my lips.

His shoulders drop, the relief in him immediate.

“You’re right. Maybe it’ll trigger my shift.”

I turn on my heel and leave him like that, walking toward the ladder fixed to the hull. I make quick work of my gown, draping it over a clean barrel, and start down the ladder in nothing but my undergarments. I’m halfway down when a dark crown of hair appears over the railing, the jewelry at his neck clinking against the wood.

“You’re not going alone, woman.”

“In case you need reminding,” I call back, continuing my descent, “I’m a siren. I swim better than you ever will.”

He curses above me, and a grin tugs at my mouth. Stubborn pirate. A moment later, his presence looms over me, and the ladder creaks beneath our combined weight.

The closer I get, the more beautiful the water becomes. It gleams softly, almost like silk, pale and shifting, so smooth it barely looks like water at all. Thin lines of white foam gather near the hull where the sea kisses the ship, waves so small you’d miss them if you couldn’t get this close.

Just before my feet touch the surface, I hesitate. If what Sable showed me in the cabin is right, if this sea really did shape me, maybe it has the power to give me my tail. But hope has teeth, and it bites hardest when you place all your faith in it. In my hesitation, I look up.

Sable meets my gaze, his eyes creased by a gentle smile. “Go,” he says. “I’ll carry you back up. Even with a tail.”

I laugh, and that brief lightness he gives me is enough. I let myself sink into the warm, shallow water. He follows with far less grace, splashing down beside me.

I brace myself for disappointment. I remind myself that I don’t need a tail to be a siren. That this doesn’t define me. A miracle of two worlds, my mother used to say, though I never understood why she would call me a miracle.

Still, my chest tightens when I look down and see my very human legs floating beneath the surface. I hold back tears, defeated by the reality I’m faced with. A quiet whimper escapes my mouth. I’m so tired of pitying myself. Of being let down by the sea time and time again.

“Risa.”

“Please, don’t—”

“No. Look.”

I frown, heart sinking. And then I see them.

Scales. Dozens of them, scattered along my hips, my thighs, my feet. They shimmer in soft, iridescent hues, almost disappearing against the blues and pinks and violets of the water.

“Where did they come from?” I whisper, soft tears spilling down my cheeks as I turn my legs slowly, unable to look away in case they disappear.

“I don’t know,” Sable says quietly beside me, his gaze fixed on my legs. “But they’re magnificent.”

“Careful, captain.” A smile tugs at my mouth as another tear slides down my cheek. “That almost sounds like you don’t despise everything I am.”

He slips an arm beneath my knees and lifts my legs gently from the water. “I don’t despise any part of you,” he says.

My heart flutters when I understand what he’s done. He didn’t touch me just for the sake of it, but to lift my legs enough for me to see the scales for myself. Still, I don’t pull away when his fingers trace along them, slow and careful, as if he’s touching something fragile rather than something that was created to withstand the currents.

Without speaking a word, he swims us to a nearby sandbank, a small piece of land in an otherwise endless sea that I haven't noticed before. We both lie down in the soft, white sand and let the warmth of the sun seep into our bodies. I keep my eyes closed, and for a moment, I am scared it will all be wiped away when I open them again.

The silence ripples between us, but not in an uncomfortable way. Instead, it feels like we have both wordlessly decided that right now, right here, it is just the two of us. No curse. No shadows. Not a pirate and a siren, but just him and me.

A drip on my forehead makes me open my eyes.

Sable's wet, dark hair hangs loose above me, casting a shadow over his grey eyes. There is a glow in them, an intensity that makes me hold my breath.

"The moon and the tide," he murmurs softly and places a hand on my cheek, his thumb brushing just beneath my eye. We stare at one another, both knowing how fragile the moment is and that we might not get the chance to feel like this again. He leans in, slow enough that I could stop him. But I don't. His mouth meets mine with a certainty that steals the air from my lungs, and I rise into the kiss without thinking, answering him just as fiercely. The world narrows to the press of his lips, the heat of him, the way his body fits against mine.

I gasp against his mouth and reach for him, my fingers sliding into his hair. It's damp and coarse beneath my hands, exactly as I imagined it would be, and I curl my fingers tighter, tugging just enough to draw a low sound from his throat. His strong hand finds my waist, and he pushes me deeper into the sand in response. The cool metal of his jewelry brushes against my collarbone, along my scales, and the sensation sends a subtle heat through my body.

A hungry kiss soon turns into something more. Desire burns as it rushes through my veins, feeding the coiling power behind my ribs. For a brief moment, I am scared I will lose control. My breath turns shallow, and Sable's head snaps up in an instant, breaking the kiss, his brows drawn together as he searches my face for the answer.

"Are you okay?" he asks in a low voice.

I nod quickly. "Yes. I am okay. Can you do me a favor?"

"Anything," he says, a teasing smile tugging at his lips.

"I want to see your tattoos."

His eyes widen a little in quiet surprise, but he doesn’t hesitate. Sable sits up and pulls his wet linen shirt over his head before tossing it aside. The sight of his bare chest knocks the breath out of my lungs. Dark ink swirls from his arms, over his shoulders, across his broad, muscled chest, and down his stomach before finally disappearing under his breeches.

Sable follows my gaze, and when our eyes meet again, heat rushes into my cheeks.

“You like them?”

A smile tugs at my lips in response, and finally, I let my siren take over. I push him back into the soft sand, the dark hair on his head a stark contrast against the white beneath him. By the six seas, he is beautiful. I take a moment longer to appreciate him before straddling him and pressing my lips to his again. My hands roam his chest in slow exploration, trying to commit the feel of his skin to memory.

Large, strong hands grip my hips as the air suddenly falls dead around us.

A scream erupts from inside the Noctis.

We both snap our heads toward the sound, a sharp gasp tearing from my throat. Because she does not lie there alone. Right behind her, another ship has appeared, smaller, but unmistakably real. Strange men board over a plank while someone else drags up the ladder clinging to the side of the ship, the very ladder Sable and I just descended. What makes panic flood my veins is the sound of metal striking metal coming from the orlop, dulled by the thick wood separating us from it.

The blood drains from me as the realization hits me. Sable sent all the men below deck. They wouldn’t have seen the enemy coming. They didn’t have time to prepare. Some of them were likely sleeping. And now they are likely being slaughtered.

“No,” Sable says, his voice thin and broken as he scrambles to his feet, his gaze searching his ship for another way back, though we both know there is none. The hull is too high to climb.

Time stretches, endless and distorted. From the corner of my eye, I see Sable shouting, trying to negotiate, offering his treasures, promising more than I know he can give. They ignore him, and he only shouts louder in response.

His gaze finds mine. He grips my shoulders, shaking me, likely screaming at me, but it is as though we are underwater. His mouth moves, but every sound is muffled, the world around us blurring at the edges. I try

to reach for my power, but it feels distant, slipping away no matter how desperately I grasp for it.

Dark figures approach the railing, dragging someone in front of them. His boots skid over the boards as he struggles, screaming, kicking, trying to wrench himself free. He is too small for the hands that hold him.

By the six seas.

It is Lark.

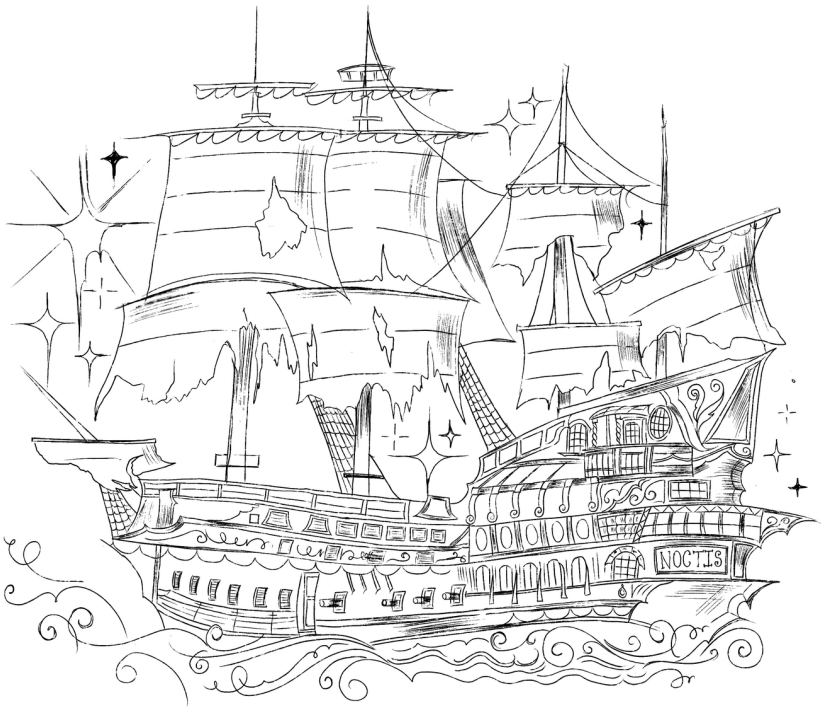
Tears sting my eyes and spill down my cheeks as I stand paralyzed in horror. I search for my power again but still cannot find even a single thread of it. What good is it to be a siren if my power fails me now? Why must I be so utterly useless?

One of them lifts a knife.

I whimper, throwing my hand over my mouth, holding my breath as I reach for my power again. Whatever I grasp for shatters the moment I touch it, slipping away like sand through my fingers.

The blade flashes. Bright, red blood spills from Lark’s throat as the knife cuts clean through. I watch in horror as the life drains from his widened eyes. His small body tips forward and falls over the railing, the wind tearing at him, but I do not hear him hit the water.

Instead, I hear myself scream. The sound tears out of me, uncontrolled and violent, as the world collapses into black.


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty

THE SCREAM IS STILL pouring out of me as I wake. It rips through my throat, way too loud for a human voice, and echoes back at me from the timbers and the rails, from the open stretch of deck and the air above it. I jerk upright, lungs burning as I drag in breath after breath, my hands clawing at the planks beneath me.

I can still feel it.

The sand beneath my feet, the vision of Lark's lifeless body falling, and falling, and falling. The way the world went quiet right before it went dark. I suck in another breath and choke on it. The salt on my tongue tells me I am crying, but I am way too numb to really pay it any notice. My thoughts are a spiraling mess, trying to make sense of what happened.

I'm still in the middle of the deck, where we ended my training. I swallow, my gaze flicking across the planks, the rail, the empty stretch of sea beyond. There's no sign of blood on the spot where they slit Lark's throat. There's no sandbank. No other ship.

That shouldn't be possible.

I press my palm harder against the deck, as if reassuring myself that it is real. I try to remember how we ended the training, but that specific memory slips away when I try to hold onto it, blurring at the edges. What I do remember is how everything softened, and how I lost the feeling of time.

My chest tightens. I fell asleep.

It was a dream. All of it.

I press a hand to my chest, my heart still hammering like it's trying to escape my ribs, but I will take any discomfort as long as it means that Lark is still alive. A throbbing pain shoots through my body from the back of my head, and as I carefully move my fingers against it, I flinch. The tips of my fingers are covered in blood. I must’ve hit my head against the wood.

“Risa.”

I twist toward the familiar voice instinctively. Sable is half on his side beside me, one arm braced against the planks, the other already reaching for me. His hair is mussed, curls falling loose over his brow, his expression twisted. He looks as disoriented as I feel, like he woke up mid-fall and hasn’t found the ground yet. How did we not notice falling asleep?

“You’re here,” I breathe. “Why are we here?”

“I hate to admit this,” Sable answers, “But I have no idea.”

I push myself up and glance around the deck, which is slowly filling with members of the crew. I have to see Lark. See that he’s well and alive with my own eyes.

“Your head.” Sable is already crouching next to me, placing his thumb on my chin, before turning my head to the side so he can inspect my wound.

“We have to get you to the bonesetter,” he murmurs and helps me to my feet with one arm wrapped around my waist.

“No,” I say, but with my sore throat, the words barely make it out. “We have to leave. Right now. We can’t risk falling asleep again. Don’t you understand?”

Sable furrows his brows as he takes me in, his thoughts likely spiraling as mine.

“This sea is cursed, just like the others. Before we even realize it, we’ll be dreaming again. We will die out here, Sable. We have to lea—“

“There‘s no wind,” Sable interrupts me, and his muscles tense behind my back.

Meanwhile, the siren inside of me tries to rip free, clawing at my insides. My instincts tell me that we have to go.

“We cannot leave this bloody sea. But we can bring you to the bonesetter, so —“

“No,” I say again, and this time, my voice is steady. I step closer to him, so the crew won’t hear what I say. “Listen. I know you always say my instincts aren’t the sharpest, but right now my inner siren is pleading with me to get out of here. And fast.”

Sable's jaw tightens so hard that I see the muscles ticking beneath his skin as he looks over my shoulder and towards his crew, then back to me.

“And how,” he asks under his breath, “are we going to do that without wind?”

“I don’t know,” I whisper truthfully. “But the Glim is enforcing the sea’s will, right? Why would it keep us trapped here?”

“You know, the sea and I usually aren’t on good terms.” Sable mutters, and his gaze drops to the floor for a beat. “Especially lately.”

“The sea and I usually aren’t great friends either,” I reply. “But there must be a way to get out of here. Every sea has its dangers, but also its weaknesses.”

I begin pacing, my thoughts spiraling as I try to remember what my mother has taught me about the seas.

“The Sea of Crowns is known for its brutal storms, but there’s a short time period where the waters lie calm. The Sea of Renewal can heal, but takes a memory in return. And the Sea of Bones.”

“Can be survived by breaking the pirate's curse.”

“Exactly.” I stop in front of him with widened eyes. “And the darkness-infused sea we just survived is incredibly narrow. We made it through in what? One day?”

“Twenty-one hours.” Sable corrects.

My eyes roll. “Right. So what’s the weakness of this sea? There must be one. We just have to find it.”

The question is, where can we find out more about a sea that none of us has been in before. I press my lips together and begin tapping my finger against my thigh. “The books.”

The brooding pirate captain furrows his brows and looks at me, confused.

“What books? Those in my cabin are just sailors' tales and diaries from my father. I don't think we’ll find anything truthful in them.”

“We already found one truth,” I mutter before finding a steady voice again. “The drawing of the siren that looks like me. Whoever wrote that must’ve been here before. Maybe there’s more.”

Something flashes across Sable’s gaze, and a smile tugs at his lips. He gives me the tiniest of nods. As he turns towards the crew, folding his hands neatly behind his back, the smile slips away.

“If you see someone falling asleep,” he announces, his voice carrying over the ship without even raising it. “You wake them up. Splash them with

water, punch them in the face, I don't care. If nothing is working, find Eryse.”

I curl my hands into fists and keep my gaze fixed on the deck as I zone out. My siren song is not in the slightest bit reliable. Sable continues barking orders, but I don't hear any of it. Instead, my feet move on their own, and the next thing I know is that I’m in the orlop, looking for Lark.

The little pirate sits on a barrel, white as a ghost, covered in sweat and shaking. In front of him is Nightglass, who presses a wet piece of cloth against his forehead.

“Lark,” I sigh in relief and rush towards him, throwing my arms around him and pressing his shaking frame against my chest. A single tear slips out of my eye, and pure joy floods me when he hugs me back. I kiss the side of his head and then check his face for any marks anyway, to make sure that he is okay.

A solid hand on my shoulder makes me turn towards Nightglass. He looks confused, with his brows furrowed.

“You had the same dream?” he whispers. “Of my little boy?”

There’s no way. We can’t have.

“The same dream?” I whisper.

“That I died,” Lark says in a raspy voice. “They cut my throat.”

Nightglass flinches at his words and puts a protective arm around him. My throat dries up, and I bring my hand to my mouth to stop a gasp from escaping.

“You mean...” I stutter, not wanting the truth to settle.

“Aye,” He quickly nods. “I think we were all having the same nightmare.”

“Oh, Lark,” I take his hand in mine and give it a squeeze. “You know that something like that would never happen. Your father would never let any harm come to you, right?”

His posture straightens. “I can defend myself.”

A quiet laugh bubbles out of me, and I nod. “Yes, of course you can.”

“Lass,” Nightglass says, nodding towards my head. “Let’s get you to Harrow. There’s a pool of red on your white hair. Doesn’t look good.”

“I’m aware,” I straighten and smooth the folds of my dress. “But we can’t lose any more time. We have to leave the sea, or risk falling asleep again. And I need you in the crow’s nest to watch the Glim.”

“I obey the captain only.” He replies shortly.

Heavy footsteps make me turn my gaze towards the steep steps. Sable descends into the orlop, his eyes widening as he takes the scene in.

“Is Lark okay?” he asks Nightglass, his face twisted with concern as he strides towards us and inspects the boy himself.

“He’s good, just a little frightened, eh?” Nightglass says with a wink, ruffling his son’s hair.

I press my lips together and catch the exact moment it dawns on him that we all shared the same dream. His eyes widen.

“Wait,” he says, his gaze flicking towards me. “We were all stuck in the same dream?”

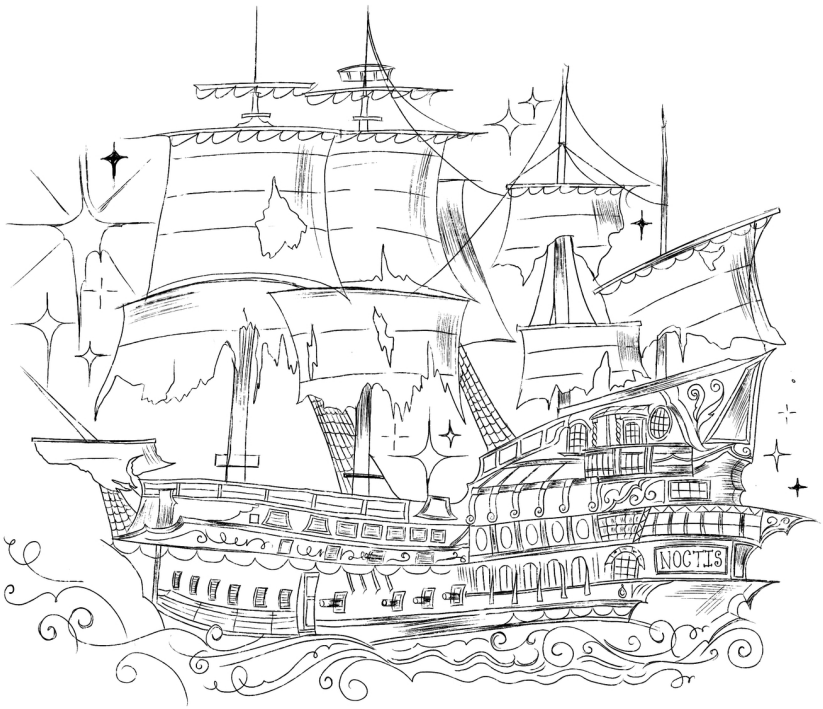
“Yes, Cap’n. Seems like it. Eryse came down here to check on Lark, same as you.”

He presses his lips together and scans the little pirate again before giving a curt nod. “Praise the seas, it was just a dream. Bring him to Harrow, just to be sure. Go to your station after. We have to follow the Glim and leave this bloody sea as soon as possible.”

“Aye, captain,” Nightglass replies with a nod and heaves Lark off the barrel.

Finally, Sable’s eyes meet mine. Something flashes through them, but before I can grasp what it is, it is gone again. More members of the crew gather around us now, checking on the little pirate. Even though it warms my heart to see how they all care for him, my stomach tightens. It seems as though he’s not willing to acknowledge what happened between us, out there on the sandbanks. Even though it was a dream, I experienced it as if it were reality. For me, the kiss was real, and so was him telling me that I am his hope, and that he is willing to fight for his crew and himself. But maybe for him it’s nothing more than a dream, a world in which he was not cursed, and I was not broken. That’s why he was so careless, why his shadow was with him. It all comes crashing in on me again, the ugly truth we call reality, like a wave crashing into cliffsides.

He leaves without another word.


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-One

THERE ARE A LOT of things that I would like to do right now, and letting myself into the captain's cabin is not one of them. Not even the sea itself could get me to go after him now like a whelp. If he can act as if none of this ever happened, then I can too.

Grunting, I push my shoulder against the door and turn the iron handle. Sable's cabin looks like it did before, though someone has carried the lanterns back outside. With my hands curled into fists, I stride towards the wooden shelves that dozens of books rest upon. The colors have faded from most of them, a clear sign that they have been here for quite a while.

This is going to be difficult, considering the fact that I cannot read. But I'll be damned if I don't at least try. I sigh and take the book that Sable showed me before from its shelf, along with a few others that look similar enough to be helpful. The heavy-looking, worn working desk in front of the stained-glass window looks exactly like the right place to get to work, so I carefully place the books between the clutter and sit down in the red leather chair that rests in front of it.

The desk is crowded with journals, each covered with a thin piece of leather. Ink pads, bottles, and pens are scattered across it, along with the odd golden coin and a few bone charms. He really must like those charms.

Shaking my head, I try to get my mind free of the captain and open the book I know has the sirens in it. From looking at the drawings it explains the different types of sirens that live in the Six Seas. The Sea of Dreams siren looks delicate, ethereal, and not obviously dangerous — but I know

from personal experience with my swarm that sirens usually are. The next page shows a sleeping sailor, and right next to him, a skull, which must symbolize death. I sigh. We really should’ve turned to the next page.

As that was the last entry about this sea, I take the next book and flip through the thin, fragile pages. This one has fewer drawings, and more writing, which makes it harder for me to understand anything.

Dream.

Wind.

Squinting my eyes as though it’ll help me understand the words better, I flip to the next page. There are more long words that I do not understand, and my inability to read has never felt more painfully inconvenient than it does now. I turn the page again.

Wait. I know this word.

Water

Then, a few lines below, another familiar word.

Current.

Underneath it, there’s a small drawing of a ship that glides through water.

Biting down on my lip, I try to make sense of any of this. We know that the sea will lull you into a dream, or better, a nightmare, and that will kill you if you do not realize it soon enough. The body can only survive so long without water or food. There’s no wind to move the ship to safety.

But there‘s a current. There’s always a current. Maybe the ship can be moved with it if it's strong enough. That would explain the drawing of the ship. But what that drawing doesn’t tell me is how to find out where the currents are. The water surface looks calm, almost like a mirror, likely hiding what’s going on under the surface.

I flip through the remaining pages, looking for any clue that will tell me more about the currents, but the word does not appear on the page again. Sighing, I lean back against the soft, red leather of the chair. I guess there’s only one way to find out where the currents are the strongest. I have to look for them myself.

I take the books and hurry back to the main deck. I do not look Sable in the eyes as I press the books against his broad chest moments later, forcing a grunt from him.

The words spill out of me like a waterfall. “Read them for me. There must be strong currents here, at least I think there should be. I will get into the water and—“

“Risa,” He takes the books from me and furrows his dark brows together. “Slow down. On which page did you read this?”

“None,” I mumble, heat crawling towards my head. Instead of looking at him, I stare at the deck, counting knots in the wood. “I think it’s written there, and I would like you to confirm this for me.”

Sable studies me for a moment, trying to make sense of my words. As realization hits him, he shifts his weight from one foot to the other.

“Aye,” he simply says. “I will go through them again.”

My head snaps up, surprise breaking through the shame I was hiding behind, as my eyes find his. There’s no judgment in them, no bitterness. He does not mock me for it.

“And if you need help, we have one yawl ready that we can lower into the water. It’s small and faster than the longboat. Grim can accompany you.”

My mouth opens, then closes again. His trust in me makes my heart fill with warmth, and for a moment, it almost drowns out the disappointment still lingering beneath it.

Almost.

Because he still hasn’t said anything about the kiss or what he said to me about hope, as if he wanted it undone, as if it didn’t matter.

I draw in a slow breath and feel my shoulders tense.

“It‘s the easiest if I just swim by myself. After Lark, I need to recharge anyway.”

“Recharge?” he asks, the sharpness in his eyes dulling a little.

“Salt water. It fuels my powers.” I let out a breath. “Unless you want me to drown another man, that’s the only option.”

The words come out harsher than I intended, and I regret them instantly. He was the one taking care of me after I broke down that night. His brows pull together, and his jaw sets as he looks at me.

“I’m sorry,” I murmur, already turning on my heel, ready to stride off to not make things worse between us. “I better get going.”

His hand wraps around my wrist, turning me back towards him in one swift movement. My pulse jumps at the unexpected touch.

I look at him until he loosens his grip.

“What did I do?” he asks, lifting a brow.

“What did you do?” I repeat. My fingers curl into my palms as the frustration I have been holding back since we woke up from that nightmare

finally pushes its way out. “You… kissed me. Again. And you continue to act as if none of it happened.”

“Oh, I’m sorry,” he says dryly. “I thought you wouldn't appreciate me discussing our love life in front of the crew. But say the word, and I can gather them on deck to tell them in detail just how much I enjoyed kissing you.”

Oh. Heat rushes into my cheeks as if commanded, and I cross my arms in front of my chest as if that might hide it. We haven't been alone ever since waking up. The crew was always around. So that’s why.

“No?” he asks, a glint of amusement returning to his voice. “Thought so.”

“You could’ve given me a hint,” I murmur, my gaze drifting past him instead of meeting his eyes. I know I sound desperate, but I just can’t help myself. This man just does things to me, makes me feel emotions that I have never felt before.

“You’re right,” he says.

Before I can react, he leans down and presses a kiss to my cheek.

My pulse stumbles, and I tighten my arms across my chest. More heat rushes into my head.

“Here’s your hint,” he murmurs near my ear. “Now go and find the current, little fish.”

I do not wait for anything else and stride off towards the ladder, and suddenly, it feels like a deja vu. The only difference is that this time, Sable doesn’t come after me. He doesn't splash in next to me as I descend into the water. It feels less warm than it had in the dream.

The good thing is, I am not disappointed when I glance down at my legs. I was not expecting them to magically turn into a tail. Suddenly, something glistens in the sun. A scale appears on my skin, and I pull in a sharp breath. I follow them as more scales appear, one by one, all over my legs. At the sight of them, I smile, and to my surprise, they look exactly as they did in the dream. Iridescent, they shimmer in the water, as if they’ve always been there. Tears well in my eyes.

At least that part was actually true.

In utter awe, I stare at them for a while longer before remembering my mission to find the current. Within me, the siren stirs with excitement as I let my body glide through the shallow, silver waters. My legs kick and kick behind me, until I reach deeper water and I cannot see the sand any longer.

I draw in a deep breath just as the Noctis creaks. They're lowering the yawl into the water, and even from far away, I can hear Sable shouting his orders to the crew. I can't help but smile before I finally go under.

As I dive deeper, pressure begins to bloom in my ears, but I have learned to ignore it at this point in my life. Down here, the water is cooler, and still crystal clear. The light that trickles in from the surface makes it gleam in iridescent colors as I shift and continue my descent.

What doesn't quite sit right with me is that the water lies completely calm. I don't have to fight any resistance in swimming downward. Maybe I'm looking in the wrong place.

I float in the depths and turn in all directions, trying to see anything out of the ordinary. My hair gets in the way multiple times, floating around me in strands that seem to catch the light and glow on their own.

In the distance, the dark hull of the Noctis looks out of place. The water ripples where they let the little boat splash into the water, and I follow the movement with my eyes and see it disappear somewhere on the left. I furrow my brows. It seems to have just vanished completely. That's strange. Normally, that wouldn't happen, not unless there was a stronger current guiding the water into a different direction.

At this point, my lungs begin screaming for air, so I lock in the position and kick my legs until my head breaks the surface. With a heaving chest, I gasp for air and watch Grim row the little boat in my direction.

"Found anything?" he asks as he reaches me and offers me a hand.

I shake my head in answer and reach for his hand. "Not yet, but I have an idea where I might. Over there, on the left."

Grim pulls me up, and I tumble into the boat clumsily, scratching my knees in the process.

"There's nothing," Grim says as he scans the area with a spyglass lifted to his eye.

"The surface is calm, but from beneath, it looks like there's a current."

He lowers the spyglass before folding it shut with a practiced motion.

"Let's hope you're right."

Grim begins to row, the boat gliding through the water towards the place I pointed out. For a moment, nothing changes. The sea lies smooth and indifferent beneath us, the hull barely meeting any resistance. But the moment we reach the one stretch of sea in particular, the boat shudders. The

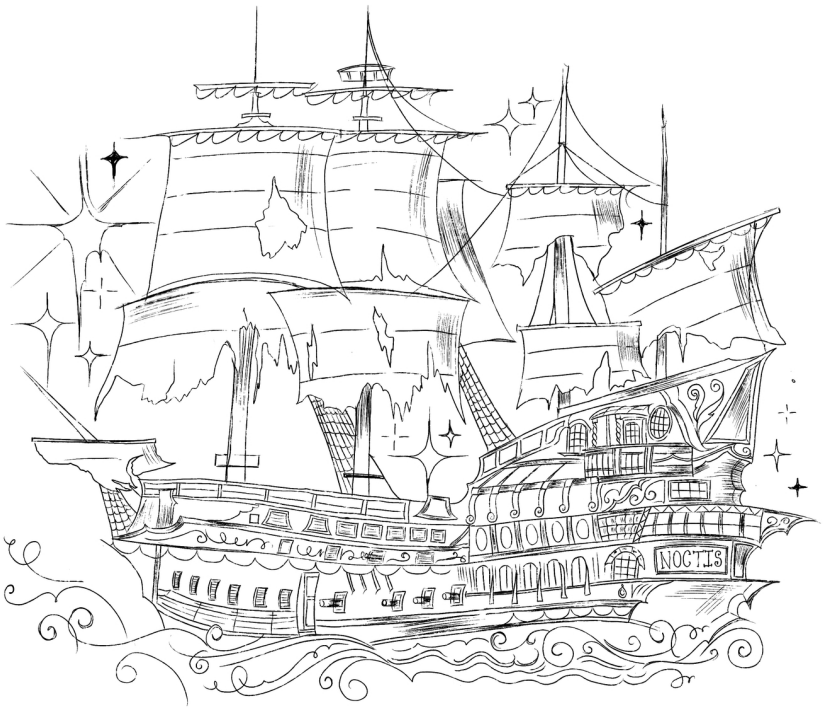
low pull beneath my ribs tells me that I was right. The boat decides to move on its own now, dragging sideways instead of forward.

“Grim?” I turn my head towards him. The pirate is already adjusting his grip and lets out a sharp breath as he tries to maneuver the little boat. Then it tilts, and I brace my palm against the bench to steady myself. The water is pressing against the hull beneath us, no longer sleeping, but instead flowing steadily.

My pulse quickens. This must be the current.

It runs clean and strong beneath the surface, invisible unless you’re caught in it. And by the way the boat is pulled along with it despite Grim slowing his rowing, it must be a strong one.

I look back toward the Noctis, my chest tightening. If it can carry a boat like this, it will drag something as large as the Noctis with far more force.


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-Two

"ROW, YOU LANDLUBBERS!" SABLE shouts from the helm, watching the crew row two longboats towards the current. Two heavy tow lines run from the boat to the bow of the Noctis, connecting them.

I stand beside him, completely useless. He denied that I may help the men to row the boat, and explained that it would only rip my fragile, soft skin open. We went in circles, arguing back and forth, until I decided that the energy the debate costs me is not worth it. In the end, the captain gets what he wants, and it's not like I don't appreciate him caring for me.

I am still a bit wet from my swim as Lark brings me my gown of dusty rose. I thank him with a smile and pull it over my head, before leaning against the railing of the forecastle again, trying to see what's going on in the water ahead of us.

"Will they be able to move the Noctis with just those little boats?" I ask.

"Aye," Sable takes a spyglass out of the loop of his belt and presses it against his kohl-rimmed eye. "They can, and they will."

The moment the ropes strain, an abrupt, jolting movement runs beneath my feet. The Noctis refuses to move, heavy and as stubborn as its captain.

"Row!" Sable shouts and puts his spyglass away. "Row like your life depends on it, because it bloody does!"

The men in the longboats groan as they row and fight to pull the Noctis. The tow-lines draw tight again, vibrating with strain until, very reluctantly,

the ship moves forward. The water changes. A pull beneath the hull, sliding past the keel.

“The current,” I whisper.

Sable curses, but when I look over my shoulder, there’s an unmistakable smile on his face, that stupid dimple of his showing on his cheek. He puts both hands firmly on the wheel, then turns it a few inches to follow the pull beneath us, as if he could feel it too. He most likely does, for the shifting of the water as it tugs us onwards is unmistakable. When Sable is at the helm, it’s like he becomes one with the sea.

In moments like these, it feels like we’re not too different after all.

The ropes slacken as the current takes over fully, the longboats drifting back once the Noctis begins to move on its own. Just as fast as they were descended, the boats are hauled back abroad, the crew moving with practiced ease.

As if commanded, the crew gathers on the deck with shuffling feet. There’s anticipation in the air, mingling with excitement as we further embark on our adventure to our fates once again. Despite this, the danger of the Sea of Dreams still hangs heavy around us.

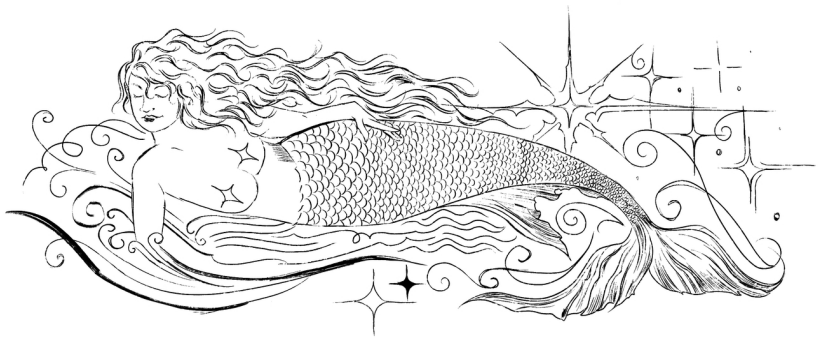
“No one goes to sleep until we’re shot of this cursed sea,” Sable announces, and the crew accepts his order with a couple of nods.

“Now get to your stations. Make her fly.” He hands over the wheel to Grim, who takes it with an “Aye, captain.”

“Nightglass?” The captain calls towards the Crow’s Nest.

“Glim is moving, Cap. Northward.” He shouts back, not turning to take his eyes from the thread of silver.

I slowly exhale, the tension of the last few hours easing just a little. For the first time since what feels like forever, we are following the Glim again, into an unknown fate. We just have to make sure we don’t fall into a cursed sleep again.



As the sun begins to set in shades of teal and purple, there is still no end of the sleep-cursed sea in sight. The plan sounded simple when Sable announced it earlier: We all gather on deck, eat dinner under the steady light of the lanterns and celebrate the fact we're still alive, until the sun starts to rise again. I have used the time well to prepare the lanterns for the night, and help cook dinner together with Lark. The bleeding wound at the back of my head I had checked by Harrow, just a surface wound apparently, but it still throbs every time I move.

Sighing, I put down the last filled plate on the long makeshift table, just in time for the green flash. The sun disappears behind the horizon and sends out a wave of green light, blink at the wrong moment, and you might miss it. My throat tightens as the crew gathers at the table underneath the golden light that the lanterns cast down on us. I try not to glance at their feet, but fail. Their shadows flicker; some detach partly while others stay with their owner. As I sit down next to Grim, the simple chair at the head of the table remains empty. My stomach tightens with worry. Nightfall means something entirely different now than it did one day ago. Where is Sable?

"Lass," Match, the wiry, tall pirate who put me in my cell on the first day, snaps me out of my thoughts. "He's not coming until he's gathered his shadow."

I furrow my brows. "Gather?"

"Aye." He laughs as he reaches out for a bottle of rum. "You know that man is stubborn. He's determined to hunt his shadow down. It slipped away this afternoon."

I suddenly itch with the need to rise and look for him. I stare at my plate instead, swallowing. It didn't end well last time, and if I am really honest

with myself, I am not ready to face that side of him again. Not now. Even if I know that the man I encountered on the balcony was not really him.

I bite down on my lip. There are too many questions unanswered. What his shadow really is, why they detach and not come back, when this started to happen. Sable might never answer these questions, because he is not aware when his shadow slips away. But maybe his shadow can.

Against protests from Grim, I take one lantern and stride off towards the hatch that leads to the orlop. I have become used to the steep steps, descending with the lantern in one hand, stretched out in front of me to light the way. Below, darkness swallows the ship whole. There's no silvery outline of a shadow in sight. Sighing, I carefully walk between stacked barrels and chests until I reach the end of the room, the creaking wood beneath my feet the only sound I can hear.

"Sable?" I ask into the darkness, knowing that he's not here. If he was, I would feel him.

Nothing. I leave the orlop through the forward ladder instead of heading back toward the main deck through the hatch, feeling slightly defeated. I climb until I emerge near the bow, just beneath the forecastle, and take the steps up, pulled forward by the force of an invisible string.

As I step onto the small deck right in front of the bowsprit, the familiar tingling feeling against my skin greets me, like I've walked through hidden spider webs without realizing it until it's too late. In front of me lies a dark figure, not moving or turning as I approach it.

Carefully, I put down the lantern, and where the light meets his dark frame, it flickers faintly. But it doesn't make him bolt as I expected it to.

"Can I sit with you?" I ask, my voice steady but low.

"You may," he replies quietly. I let the sound of his voice wrap around me as I gather the long fabric of my gown and carefully sit down on the cool boards next to him.

Sable, or at least the shadow version of himself, stares at the night sky, his gaze flickering back and forth, as though he was seeing something in them that I couldn't. Now that I really look at him, I should've realized his true identity sooner. The dark eyebrows, the slightly crooked nose, and the way he carries himself with confidence. The evidence was there, I was just too blind to see it.

Sighing, I lay down next to him, close enough that I can feel his presence but far enough so that our shoulders do not brush.

“Go ahead,” he says. “You‘re here for a reason, aren’t you?”

For a brief moment, I do not reply. I play with my fingers instead, looking at the constellations above.

“Yes,” I whisper. “I need to know the truth. About you. About Sable.”

“I am Sable.”

“I know,” I shake my head and sigh, cursing myself for my stupidity. “I know you’re a part of Sable. But why are you here and not with him? Wherever he is.”

From the corner of my eye, I can see his chest slowly rising and falling, as if the question doesn't bother him at all. As if he is truly breathing instead of just imitating breaths.

“I like to look at the night sky.”

All the questions I have start spiraling in my head, twisting into a knot of words that I fear won’t be able to untie if he keeps on being so vague.

“You know that’s not what I mean. Why are you here, while the other part of you is actively trying to hunt you down? Why not just… be where you belong?”

His head turns towards me now, and I mirror the movement. Black eyes that reflect the moon light like marbles stare into mine.

“Where I am right now feels like where I belong,” he whispers. “And the man you are referring to is not me. Not really.”

I frown at him. “What do you mean ?”

Sable’s shadow sighs and goes back to staring at the night sky, while I continue staring at him.

“This will only make things worse,” he says under his breath, pinching the bridge of his nose. “I am his shadow, but at the same time, I am his soul. I am him. The man searching the ship right now is just my physical form, the shell that contains me.”

I let his words sink into me, into my heart, and suddenly, it weighs there in my chest as solid as a stone. A stone so heavy that if you were to drop it onto the ocean, it would sink and sink, never to be seen again.

He pulls his hand back down from his face, his arm now almost touching mine.

“I have been cursed for a long, long time. I was the first one. You see, while the others are mostly whole,” his voice cracks. His pinky softly brushes mine. “I am not.”

I bit down on my lip, tears threatening to spill from my eyes. This is what he didn't want to tell me about his shadow. I never would've thought that the curse affects him more than others, or that he feels this broken.

"Why can you not return?" I ask softly, and the question hangs heavy between us the moment it leaves my mouth.

Silence follows. For a long time, he doesn't answer at all, his pinky retreating, the subtle touch gone.

"It feels like dying," he eventually says, his voice fragile and broken. "Returning doesn't feel like coming home, it feels like death. It wasn't painful in the beginning, but it has become almost unbearable now. That's the way of the sea to enforce its curse. So I stay away longer. Not even the light forces me back these days."

Seeing him like this makes my heart ache. I find no words that could comprehend the pain. I can't ask him to return to Sable's body now, cause him to suffer like that.

"Come. I'll show you something."

He's suddenly above me, his hand reaching out for me to take. I place my hand in his without hesitation and let his light fingers wrap around mine. Tiny shadows curl like smoke around them and spiral lower until it reaches my elbow, leaving behind a sensation on my skin that feels like a breeze.

Sable's shadow pulls me up and retreats his hand from mine, then places it at the small of my back. The same gentle gesture that he always does.

"I should've known it was you," I sigh.

"Aye," he replies, a smile tugging at his lips. "You should've."

He walks me to the forward ladder leading into the orlop, then towards the back of the ship. At the end of it, we use the ladder to get into the galley, then slip past the wooden table and climb the narrow ladder tucked against the back wall, emerging into the hallway in the quarterdeck.

"Where are we going?" I ask him in a low voice as I follow him down the empty corridor.

"My cabin," he replies as he reaches the door and turns the knob, then keeps the door open for me to pass through.

Once inside, he walks towards the working desk in long strides and takes one of the leather-wrapped notebooks. I knit my brows together as I close the door behind me carefully, not wanting to alert anyone to our being here, and follow him to the desk.

“Here,” He holds the notebook out for me to grab. “I know you can’t read, but you’ll be able to understand anyway. You’re pretty smart.”

I meet his eyes for a brief moment and then take it from his hands. The leather string comes loose easily beneath my fingers, and when I open the cover, the pages inside reveal lines of careful black ink. The handwriting is neat at first, but as I reach the end, it turns messy and looks rushed, as if the person who wrote them was running out of time.

“They’re my journals,” he explains.

I turn the pages slowly, even though the words themselves mean nothing to me. Yet I can tell that he wrote a lot, and I can also tell that he wrote about me. I recognize the letters of my name, as my mother taught me to write it in the sand when I was little. As I flip to the next page, Sable’s shadow leans closer.

“A girl boarded the ship tonight,” Sable reads. “She was escaping hunters.”

My breath catches. This was from the night I boarded the ship. Even though I can’t remember how I ended up on the ship, I remember him telling me he saw me do it. The shadow’s finger traces further down the page.

“She claims she is not a siren, but I know she is lying.”

A smile tugs at my lips at the memory. He knew what I was from the very first meeting.

“Siren.”

A row of question marks trails after it. The next page is completely messy, with many words being stretched out, and notes added between the lines.

“Shadow gone.”

“What did I fucking do to her in the hold?”

He told me he can’t really remember what he does when his shadow is gone. But the way he writes about it now makes my chest tighten. In the crow’s nest, a few days after the incident in the hold, he told me that he wasn’t himself that day, and I remember it sounding like a confession. It all makes sense now.

“My shadow gifted her a dress. At least I do not remember giving her one. It gets worse.”

“She looks beautiful in it. She is beautiful.”

At the compliment, I lift my gaze from the journal to his face. Our eyes meet, and I find myself smiling at him, something warm and quiet settling in my chest. I can't believe he has thought this way about me all this time, that he never truly saw me as a threat or someone he despises.

Sable's shadow lowers his head again, his attention returning to the journal.

"Remember: She helped us through the intermaria," he continues to read for me.

"I will hold the tribunal when the sun is the highest. Hopefully the shadows of the crew will be there."

By the seas. Even that decision was made to protect me. He knew the crew would be less likely to vote against me if their shadows were there.

"My shadow jumped after her before I could."

At the memory of almost drowning, a shiver runs down my spine. I remember how he looked at me right before he jumped, how his eyes darkened, and how an invisible force pushed me upward, toward the surface, toward Sable. My breath catches. It was him. Always him.

The shadow turns another page, continuing to read out loud.

"We arrived back home. Cailia seems to like Eryse. She said we have to sail to the Sea of the First Song."

I almost laugh at that. It didn't feel like she liked me from the very start, always calling me Siren instead of my actual name, but she began to loosen up when the sea told her that Sable's fate and mine are somehow intertwined.

"Beginning or the end. I hope she's my beginning."

Sable's shadow takes a deep breath, and my heart pumps blood so fast that it rushes in my ear. Before I can say something, he continues.

"We spoke on the beach. She told me about her father, who was executed for piracy. Even in such a heavy moment, I really wanted to kiss her. To show her my affection."

He wanted to kiss me? Heat rises within me at the thought. But then I ruined it by asking about the curse. I regretted it then, and I regret it even more now.

The ink gets darker, as if he applied a lot of pressure to get the words down.

"The Glim returned. I have no memory of last night. After she asked about the curse, everything is a blur. I hope I didn't hurt her."

Oh, Sable. You didn’t hurt me. Tears begin to well in my eyes, and I swallow hard, trying to hold them back.

“Remember: She has my hat.”

I giggle. I still have that hat.

“We are sailing toward the Sea of Shadows. I am sure my shadow will not stay with me. Will try to keep my distance.”

Another page. The ink is smeared here, as if written in haste. By the time I reach the final pages, the writing has become frantic. Lines repeat, and then the same sentence appears again and again, filling entire pages.

“What does it say?”

The shadow presses one finger to the paper, following the line as he reads aloud.

“My name is Sable Crowe,” he says in a low voice. “I am the captain of the Noctis.”

I gasp as tears finally blur my vision. He told me he doesn’t remember his name on the balcony, but somehow, I haven’t second-guessed it. I thought what he said didn’t have any meaning because his shadow was gone. But him writing his name in his journal confirms it. Devastated, my whole body tenses.

“You forget?” I whisper, the notebook almost slipping from my fingers. “When your shadow is gone, you forget who you are?”

“Aye,” Sable nods. “I forget, and it becomes worse the more and the longer I am away. I write it in there to remind myself, though my shadowless self rarely checks the diaries. The farther I am away, the less my physical form is aware of himself and what he is doing. After the incident with Ash, I was fighting for dear life, trying to hold onto myself. It worked, but when we sailed through the Sea of Shadows, it was helpless. I told you to stay away, to not search for me. We both know how that ended.”

“But you know what will happen?” A single tear escapes from my eye, wetting my cheek. “That he will die, I mean, you will die if you do not break the curse.”

He straightens and folds his arms behind his back. “I am aware.”

“Then why?” I toss the notebook back onto the desk. “Why are you still not seeing any hope for yourself? What happened to I am willing to fight?”

My chest is heaving now, as I glare at him with my feet planted to the ground, tears now streaming down my face.

“Because I know that by the way Lark’s shadow drained you, you won't be able to return mine. When you told me about the salt recharging your powers today, I realized that it won’t be enough. Not if you must sing back the shadows of all crew members. It costs you every time you use your song, haven’t you realized?”

I look away. Of course I have realized. The blood dripping from my nose, how sleep claims me for longer than usual, the headaches.

“I can do it,” I whisper, my voice raspy. “I can do it right now.”

“I know you can do it.” He takes my head in his hands and gently wipes away my tears. It feels so wrong and at the same time, the most natural thing in the world, as if my soul recognizes his.

“I fear for your life,” he finally whispers, and I let my tears fall in silence. “I never told you about my mother. She was a sea witch, like my sister. When my father was murdered…”

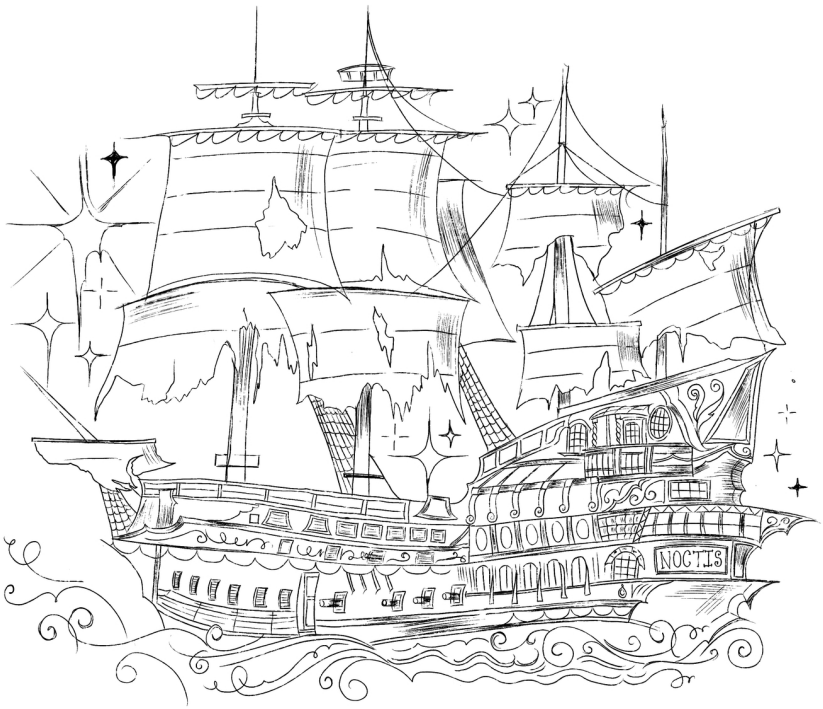
His voice breaks, and he draws in a steadying breath before continuing.

“She tried to bring him back. She used more power than she could hold, and it killed her in the end. I can feel that I’m too far gone, and if you try to sing my shadow back, you might end up like her. I won’t let that happen.”

“I can gain more power, I can—”

“Kill more cruel men?” he interrupts me. “I saw what it did to you when you drowned Ash. You were terrified. I won't let you go through this again just for the sake of a better chance of saving me when I am already lost.”

He takes a deep breath, his shadows softly caressing my cheek. “But you can save my crew. Because the curse hasn’t taken hold of them the way it has of me.”


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-Three

EVEN IF SLEEP DIDN'T mean certain death, I couldn't have closed my eyes. I lay awake in my hammock, staring at the dark beams above, going through his words over and over again. I want to argue the truth, but I'd be fooling myself. Singing back Lark's shadow drained me, and the whole crew is twenty men strong. If only he would let me try to sing his shadow back just once. I know this is selfish, but I want to save him first, and only then his crew. The truth about his mother shakes me to the core, and just thinking about it makes my gut twist in agony again. He lost both of his parents in a tragedy, and now he carries yet another burden. I can't imagine how he must feel.

Sighing, I swing my legs over the edge of my hammock and tiptoe up the stairs towards the hatch. The sound of shuffling feet above me makes me sigh in relief. The crew must still be awake. As I push it open with my hands, the weak light of the rising sun peaks through the clouds. It seems like the long table has long been abandoned, empty rum bottles and plates the only thing left scattered across it. Nightglass is already at his station in the Crow's Nest, and right next to him, Saint hangs somewhere in the riggings, fixing a sail that still hangs lifeless without the wind. But the strong current rushing along the hull makes the Noctis move with incredible speed, as though she is determined to get somewhere.

At the helm, Sable and Grim are arguing whilst staring at a map. Grim turns the map a bit, then squeezes his eyes together, as if that would make

him see clearer. At their feet, both shadows are where they should be, though Sable's flickers, as if it would bolt if given the chance.

I wonder if he remembers I talked to him last night. By the way he's been filling the pages in his diary, probably not. Guilt prickles under my skin. I know I shouldn't feel bad for reading them, as he showed them to me himself. Still, it feels as though I have violated his privacy.

Sable is now taking over the map, spitting an insult to his first mate that I cannot make out from where I'm standing. He turns it again, his dark eyebrows knitting together more the longer he looks at it. Grey eyes catch the sunlight in a way that reminds me of the light cutting through the dense fog on the pirate islands, dull, yet gleaming at the same time. Underneath, dark, violet circles bloom, the evidence of a sleepless night.

He glances above the map and lets his gaze rest on me. Pressing my lips together, I try my best not to avert my eyes, feeling like I've just been caught staring at him.

"Eryse!" Lark appears in front of me with his arms behind his back, snapping me out of my thoughts.

"Hey Lark," I say with a smile on my face. "You managed to stay up? Aren't you tired?"

"Nah." His chest puffs up with pride. "I am not tired. I was up fishing all night. I came to give you something."

The next moment, he holds out a whole, fresh fish to me, so big that it could easily feed two.

"It's for you." There's pure delight in his voice. "You like fish, aye?"

"Yes," I reply, a grin spreading on my face. The thoughtful gift makes my heart warm. „But Lark, why are you giving me this? Shouldn't we bring it to the cook and share it?"

He widens his stance and holds the fish out further towards me.

"No. It's for you. For bringing back my soul." He smiles. "Father said you know about our curse. I would have told you before, but he said it would only scare you."

His eyes land on the ground beneath my feet.

"A fish is a poor trade for a soul, I know," He continues, muttering. "But that's all I've got to give."

"It's perfect." I take the fish with a smile, the scales still slimy and wet, as if he just pulled it out of the water. Just how I like it. "Thank you."

He gives me a curt nod before jumping up the stairs towards the helm. Sable lets him hold the wheel while they continue to study the map. My chest tightens as the feeling of responsibility overcomes me. He wants me to save his crew and believes that I will have the power to do so. I cannot let him down. Will not let him down.

I cross my arms over my chest and follow Lark to the helm. Sable glances at me over his shoulder, then returns his focus to the aged piece of paper. As I stand behind him, I get to peer at the map, unnoticed. It's the same one that was pinned to the table in his cabin. It shows the Sea of Dreams, and right next to it, the Sea of Shadows, the death-infested sea we sailed through a few days ago. Above it, the map ends.

“You don’t know where we’re going?”

Both heads snap in my direction. By the way they glare at me, it seems like they don’t like when someone calls out the obvious.

“I always know where this ship is going, lass,” Sable says, then taps his ringed finger in the middle of the Sea of Dreams. “We’re somewhere here.”

“Where precisely?”

He raises one brow. “In the north.”

“And where are we going?”

Sable moves his finger further upwards, towards the edge of the map and then across it, into nothingness. Thin air.

I press my lips together and nod once. “Great. So we’re headed straight for the abyss?”

Silence follows.

Grim drags his hand down his beard and exhales through his teeth, a sound like an irritated hiss. “You’re gambling with our lives, captain.”

Sable doesn’t look at him. He rolls the map back up again and thrusts it into its leathered cover.

“It’s not a gamble,” he says. “It’s our course. We must continue to follow the Glim.”

“A course into nothing,” Grim snaps, stepping closer to the railing and pointing out at the sea ahead. “We don’t know what lies beyond.”

Sable turns then, finally, his gaze sharp as it lands on his first mate. “No,” he murmurs through gritted teeth. “But what can be worse than the fate that awaits us should we not continue. If we can place our trust in the sea, it will lead us to the Sea of the First Song. And based on its name, I assume it will somehow help Eryse with her song.”

His words fall heavily between them. My gaze lands on Lark, who is still holding the wheel, staring ahead and pretending not to hear their words, when I know he does. They never exclude him. Not during the maelstrom, not now, forming into him the pirate he must be to survive.

Grim's jaw tightens, then he shakes his head. “You’re leading us into the abyss.”

Sable steps closer, close enough that Grim has to tilt his head back to meet his gaze. “ I’d rather die there,” he says quietly, “than rot in the Sea of Bones like the others.”

His words are the last drop in a barrel already filled to the brim, causing it to finally overflow.

Grim curls his hands into a fist at his side. “You don’t get to decide that alone.”

I hold my breath. I know that challenging the captain’s decision means mutiny, and what it does to a crew.

“I do,” Sable replies, his voice calm and controlled. “That’s the curse of being captain. Unless you want to challenge me for the spot?”

Silence. I glance between them, unsure what to do. I feel like an outsider again, watching a conversation I shouldn’t be hearing.

Grim steps back, lips pressed into a thin line, and turns away without another word. The argument dies there, unresolved. I exhale the breath I’ve been holding and watch Sable take over the helm again.

“Captain,” Lark murmurs to excuse himself, then slips away towards the nearest rigging to accompany his father in the Crow’s Nest.

I don’t dare to speak as the Noctis keeps dashing through the water. He has made the decision, for all of us. There’s nothing to do about it.

I am about to leave, my back already turned away, when he speaks, causing me to freeze on the spot.

“You spoke to my shadow,” he says in a sharp tone. It’s not an accusation, but it’s not a question either.

I lift my gaze, but do not turn towards him yet, even though I know that the confrontation is unavoidable and needed.

“I had a feeling,” he continues, quieter now. “And I don’t like being left in the dark.”

For a heartbeat, I consider deflecting. Lying, even. Pretending I don’t know what he’s talking about. I don’t want to make him say it a second time, to drag him through that pain again. But I know it has to be done, that

this conversation must happen between us, not just between me and his shadow.

“Yes,” I say. “I did.”

He doesn’t meet my gaze. He stares ahead, his hands gripping the wheel with such force that his knuckles turn white.

“What did he tell you?”

“That returning to you feels like dying,” I say finally. “That staying away hurts less than coming back.”

Sable’s breath leaves him slowly, his lashes fanning against his cheek for a moment, before he finally turns towards me.

“And?” he asks.

“And that he doesn’t believe you can be saved.”

His jaw tightens.

“You told me about your mother,” I continue, my voice steady despite the way my chest aches. “And that you’re scared I’ll end up the way she did.”

He steps closer, the space between us shrinking, but there’s no softness in the movement. The color has almost completely drained from his face.

“Is that true?” I manage to say, sadness rising fast, threading itself through the familiar hum behind my ribs. “You think I will die if I try to save you? And that you’d rather fade away?”

His eyes darken. “You think sacrificing yourself will fix that?”

“I think you’re worth fighting for,” I say, and all I want to do is hug and hold him close.

With the silence that follows comes a soft breeze against my cheek, making me shiver. My hair whips away from my face moments later.

My eyes widen.

Wind.

Sable seems to be too caught up to even notice it, his chest now rising and falling fast, his dark curls dancing on his head, reminding me of the swirls of his shadow.

“My crew comes first,” he says at last. “Always.”

My hands curl at my sides. “You expect me to save everyone else and let the sea take you?”

“Yes,” he says without hesitation. The certainty and definitiveness in his voice is like a punch in my guts.

“Promise me,” he continues. “Promise me you’ll save them first. That you won’t endanger yourself for me.”

The hum behind my ribs surges, and I clench my hands over my stomach as it becomes insistent.

“I can’t promise that,” I say and shake my head. “I won't help you erase yourself.”

His gaze softens, just slightly, only for a heartbeat. “Darling, you have to. I am too far gone.”

I hold his eyes, heart hammering, the weight of everything he said pressing down on me and fueling the throbbing behind my ribs, making me feel physically sick.

“I swear to save your crew first,” I say slowly. “But after I’ve sung back the last shadow of this crew, I swear to the seas, I will sing and drag your shadow back towards you.”

For a long moment, he studies me.

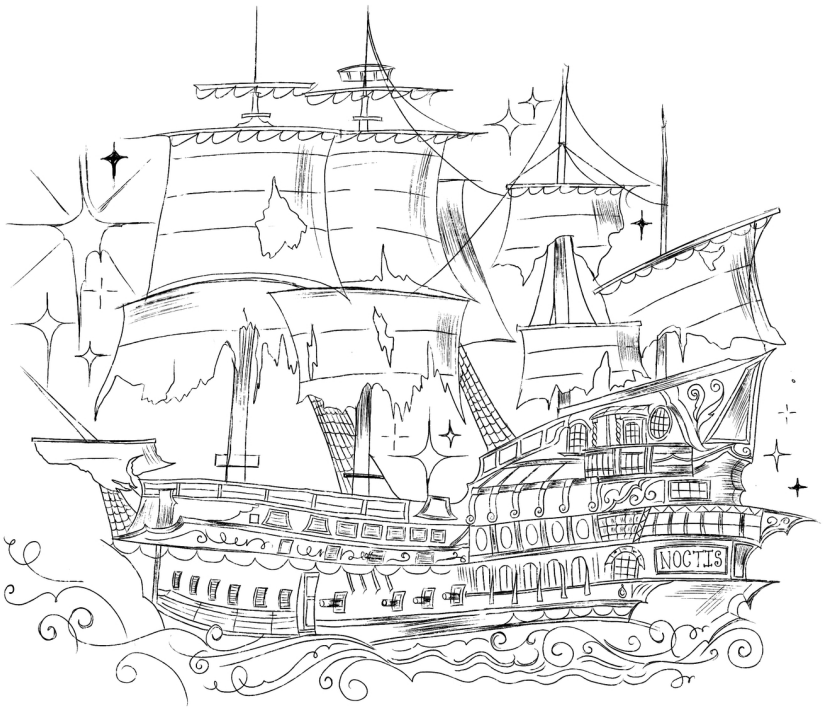
“I want to see you whole,” I whisper. “I want to see that version of you that I met in the dream again.”

Moments pass. His gaze drifts back and forth, undecided, before he folds his hands behind his back and straightens.

“Aye…” His eyes drift past my shoulder, toward the Glim. “But we’ll need to strengthen your power.”

I swallow, relieved that he permitted me to at least try to save him. “How?”

A corner of his mouth lifts. “I have an idea.”


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-Four

I LOSE COUNT OF THE days that I spend submerged. At first, I try to count them by the rise and fall of the light above the deck, by how often the sky shifts from pale gold to deep blue and back again. But time in the Sea of Dreams does not seem to move in the usual way, and soon that becomes unreliable.

So I stop counting altogether, and climb into the shallow tub on the main deck that Sable has ordered to be filled and refilled with seawater over and over again.

With the lack of sleep, all I know and have become is salt.

Salt in my hair, stiffening until the strands cling together. Salt drying on my skin, crusting along my shoulders and collarbones where the scales aren't there to protect it, collecting in the hollow of my throat and at the curve of my ribs.

I soak in it for hours, sometimes multiple times a day, then close my eyes to sleep for a few hours.

We sleep in shifts. Someone is always on watch when others are sleeping, and that same person makes sure you wake up again when it is time to. We can't risk sleeping at the same time, not while we are still in the Sea of Dreams. But even when exhaustion pulls at me, my thoughts circle like a restless bird gliding through the air and do not settle. I lie awake in my hammock at night, staring at the beams overhead, listening to the hull cut through the current we found. Together with the wind, the ship moves faster than it should be capable of.

It feels like we’re running out of time.

That only means I will stay longer the next day, until the humming behind my ribs becomes stronger, more potent. It feels different from how it did with Rat. When I drowned him, the power came rushing in on me like a flood. Here, it gathers and trickles in through a faint, steady stream.

Each day, the salt draws more power out of me and pours even more back in. But it also hurts. My joints ache and tighten with each passing day, as if my body is a vessel too small to contain so much power.

Sable always makes sure that a clean, dry towel awaits me every time I get out of the tub, laying it neatly folded on one of the barrels nearby, as carefully placed as the emerald gown his shadow gifted me what feels like a lifetime ago.

Only today, Sable brings the towel himself.

He watches me get out of the tub, the saltwater dripping down my body, my hair, into a small pool at my feet. He spreads the towel, steps closer, and carefully lays it around my shoulders, then wraps it around me.

“Nightglass has spotted something,” He says as he rubs the towel against my shoulders in a slow, gentle motion.

I swallow down my confusion, my focus placed entirely on his hands. Despite the comfort his touch gives me, it feels like he is preparing me for something.

“What is it?” I ask.

“We don’t know yet.” He sighs. “It looks like a giant wall.”

I glance over his shoulder toward the open sea. In the distance, a white stripe meets the horizon. Even from afar, it looks like it stretches endlessly toward the sky before disappearing into the clouds. At least it’s not a giant waterfall.

“It’s better than the abyss,” I whisper.

A smile tugs at his lips. “Aye.”

He studies me for a moment, his eyes softening, the faintest hint of a smile touching his lips. Without wanting to, I glance at his feet. His shadow is barely there, flickering and faint.

“You’re not fighting the urge to throw me overboard?” I ask him, my voice nothing more than a whisper as I keep my eyes fixed on the dark shape at his feet. I expect him to brush it off with a dry remark, to deflect.

“No,” he says quietly. “And I hope you know that under normal circumstances I’d never—”

“I know.”

I cut him off, looking up at him. I don’t want him to apologize for something he can’t control.

My thoughts leave me as I step towards him and take his hand in mine, venturing to give him comfort. It feels rough against my sensitive, salt-coated skin. The tingling sensation it leaves behind feels new and familiar at the same time. He has held me before, as has his shadow, and I cannot help but crave the feeling of his hand around my waist.

First, he tenses. His shoulders draw together tightly, and he stands there like a statue, seemingly caught off guard. As I brush my thumb over his palm gently, his shoulders slacken, and his muscles loosen.

“I‘m glad,” he begins, breathing through his nose. “I’m glad you know I’ve never wanted to hurt you, little fish.”

I squeeze his hand, then drop it, a smile tugging at my lips as I cross my arms in front of my chest, wrapping the towel tighter around my shivering body.

“But insulting me never has been a problem for you?”

He shrugs, smirking slightly. “Not really. Stay close. Try to rest. We should reach the wall by nightfall.”

“Captain!” A crew member shouts behind him.

He turns before I can respond, calling out a sharp order as he strides back toward the helm. The crew moves with new purpose, adjusting the sails or pulling ropes, but the tension in the air only tightens. As I walk across the deck, the cold air tearing at my hair, the shape at the horizon ahead grows more defined.

The wall rises higher with every passing minute.

It stretches from water to sky, its surface pale and uneven, catching the light in ways that make it hard to tell where it ends and where it dips into the clouds. The longer I look at it, the more my skin prickles with nervous sweat, the hum behind my ribs deepening in response.

It feels old. Not untended or abandoned, but as though it was shaped by the sea itself, like it has been hidden here, unintended for the eyes of those not formed by the sea. The pirates shift uneasily around me, tension vibrating through the deck, but it does not unsettle me the way it does them. Instead, something quieter settles in my chest. Recognition. Relief.

The sensation wraps around me in a slow, almost gentle shifting, until it feels inescapable. Whatever waits beyond this place knows me. I feel it in

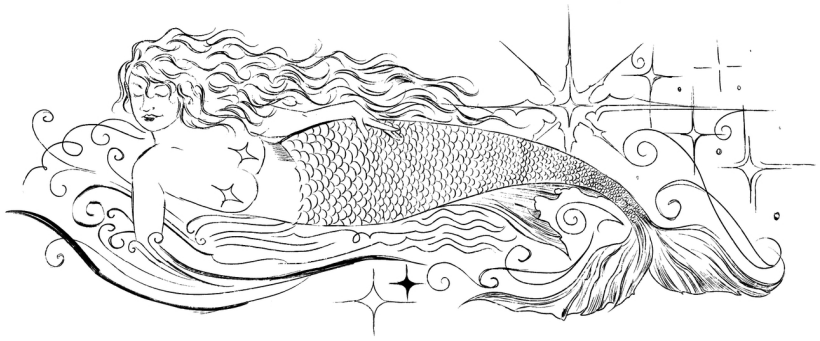
my gut, in my bones, in the salt that clings to my skin.

The Glim burns brighter than it has before, its silver thread stretching forward, pulled tight toward the wall.

As we drift closer, something else becomes visible.

An opening.

And we’re sailing straight for it.



I stand on the forecastle of the ship, right behind the helm, the wind tearing at my frame. I welcome the spray of the sea as it needles my face, the cold that came with the setting of the sun. I don’t feel any of it, not really. What I feel, there under my skin, is the stirring of anticipation. Pure, sweet excitement that makes every vein in my body feel electric, like little bolts of lightning shooting through me.

I curl my fingers around the railing as the wall rises ahead of us. I crane my neck to look up at it, but the pale formation seems never to end. It is curved and smoothed in some places, uneven in others, like the inside of a shell. It gleams softly, almost iridescent, as if it were alive beneath the surface. I follow it with my gaze until it disappears into the clouds.

We are close enough now that I can see the opening more clearly. It is wide, wider than the Noctis by far, a dark mouth carved into the wall where the water parts in two.

The deck is crowded. Even though they are still hard at work, each pirate cannot help but gawk up at the tear in the sky before us. Grim moves along the starboard side, calling out adjustments as the current shifts. He glances at the wall with open concern, his jaw set tight. The other pirates haul on the lines, follow his orders. Lark is near the rail, knuckles white where he grips it, eyes wide and unblinking. When the Noctis shudders slightly

beneath us, he swallows and straightens, forcing himself to be brave. To stand taller.

At the helm, Sable's gaze stays fixed ahead.

His hands are on the wheel, shoulder squared, coat and hair pulled back by the wind. I know that absolutely nothing would now be able to stop this ship, not even the sea itself. Not if he has anything to say about it.

But there is something other than determination flashing across his face too.

Fear.

I see it in the way his jaw ticks, from the way his index finger taps against the wood of the wheel, and in the way he shifts his weight from foot to foot, nervous. This is his last chance – his last hope – to save the crew and break their curse. If what lies beyond this opening isn't the Sea of the First Song, if it doesn't help me with the power of my song, then this whole journey becomes just another tragedy in his life. It is only now that I realize my tail is no longer my priority.

He is.

As I reach him, I carefully place a hand on his shoulder, though I know he has noticed me before already. I am wearing the emerald gown that his shadow has gifted me.

"You're wearing the dress," he says quietly, keeping his gaze fixed ahead at the giant mouth about to swallow us whole.

"Yes," I say and glance down at the bodice, then brush my fingers along the jewels. "I wanted to wear it for today."

He clears his throat, his lashes flashing as he glances at me for a moment. "It looks good on you."

A smile tugs at my lips, as though this is the first compliment he has ever given me. I already know he thinks I look beautiful in it. And yet, heat rushes into my cheeks. How ridiculous. We are about to sail into an unknown place, most likely falling right into the clutches of death. And here I am blushing over the words of a man. The Captain of the Noctis' words no less.

"Thank you," I say sincerely and come to stand next to him, close enough that I can feel the warmth of his body, close enough for our shoulders to brush.

We stand there in silence and watch the curtain-like opening in front of us grow taller. Grim shouts commands at the crew, navigating them towards it.

The wall opens up like a giant mouth, its jaw widening like a hungry beast in anticipation of its next meal. We're about to pass through, and still can't see what lies beyond. I cannot find any certainty in the emptiness that awaits on the other side of the wall.

"Sable?"

I hold my breath.

"Yes?"

Only a few more seconds. The Noctis glides through the water, aiming at the opening and groaning under the strong current that seems to work against us now.

"When all of this is over, and the sea finally claims me." I begin, my voice watering as the light cast by the moon begins to fade. "Will you stay?"

Sable takes one hand off the wheel. My heart skips a beat as he threads his fingers through mine, skin against skin.

"I told you already," he says, squeezing my hand gently. "The moon and the tide."

At that moment, the figurehead at the bowsprit passes the opening. The sound changes instantly, the open air replaced by a deeper echo as the wall begins to swallow us. The roar of the waves is replaced by vast, hollow quiet that makes every sound carry further than it should.

The formation opens around us, so large that the ceiling is lost to darkness, the surface arching overhead in a curve I cannot see the end of. Along the walls, corals cling to the rock in patterns that make them look like they've been carefully placed there instead of naturally growing. Their colors are muted, pale greens, deep violets, and pink. Plants grow in them too, their leaves and vines swaying where the water brushes them and the wind breathes into them.

The crew falls silent. Even the ship falls into silence, her timbers creaking less as she glides through the calmer waters.

The recognition I felt earlier now settles in my bones, wraps around my spine, and finally, hums beneath my ribs. Whatever lies beyond this passage was never meant for ships like the Noctis, never meant for pirates, but it lets us pass through.

Because it was meant for me.

"Easy," Sable says, quieter now, though his voice still carries far and echoes against the walls. "Keep her centered."

“Risa?” He asks, his voice nothing more than a whisper.

“Yes?” I ask, in complete awe of the scenery that unfolds around us.

“You’re squeezing my hand.” He says, his mouth curving into an almost smile. “I would like to take over the wheel again, if you will allow me.”

“Oh.” I let go of his hand, and only now realize how terribly tight I squeezed it. I rub my forehead with the back of my hand, wiping away the sweat that has gathered there.

Grim steps closer to the helm, lowering his voice. There’s still tension between the two, though I know that he’d follow Sable into the abyss if he asked him to. Perhaps that is precisely what he just did.

“Nightglass reports no end in sight, Cap.”

“The glim?”

“Pushing forward.”

The Noctis moves deeper into the cave, the corals around us wet and glistening as we pass. One by one, lanterns are being lit. Lark hurries across the deck with a candle in his hand, and slowly, the Noctis lights up like a sky full of golden stars. We are prepared.

As Sable grips the wheel with his other hand again, his shoulders tense and then loosen. His shadow is there, not completely, but almost. From what his shadow told me, I know what it costs him, the pain he must be in, and the fact that I cannot help him yet makes me feel sick.

“Captain, sir.” Lark appears in front of the helm, his chest heaving from running across the ship. Alongside his candle, he has an additional lantern in his hand opposite.

“Yes, sailor?”

“The crew insists that you have this lantern at the helm.”

“I told you already, I’d rather have you—“

“If you don’t take it,” he interrupts him and widens his stance, “we’ll raise mutiny.”

Sable raises one brow, a smile tugging at his lips. Lark is brave for speaking up against his captain like that.

“Well, in that case,” Pride flashes across his face. “You’d better place it here, Lark. Don’t want to risk a mutiny at the end of the fucking world.”

He nods and hurries up the stairs, then places the glowing lantern at his feet. He glances at the captain’s shadow, only for a moment, before he straightens and waits for Sable to speak.

“Rest now, Lark. We’re out of the Sea of Dreams. You can sleep.”

Now that he mentions it, my limbs feel heavy, my muscles sore. I yawn. I haven’t properly slept for weeks.

“You too, Risa,” Sable adds, as if reading my thoughts.

His hand slides around my wrist before I can step back.

“Not in the orlop. Take my cabin.”

“But—”

His jaw tightens, his top lip twitching once as his eyes lock on mine.

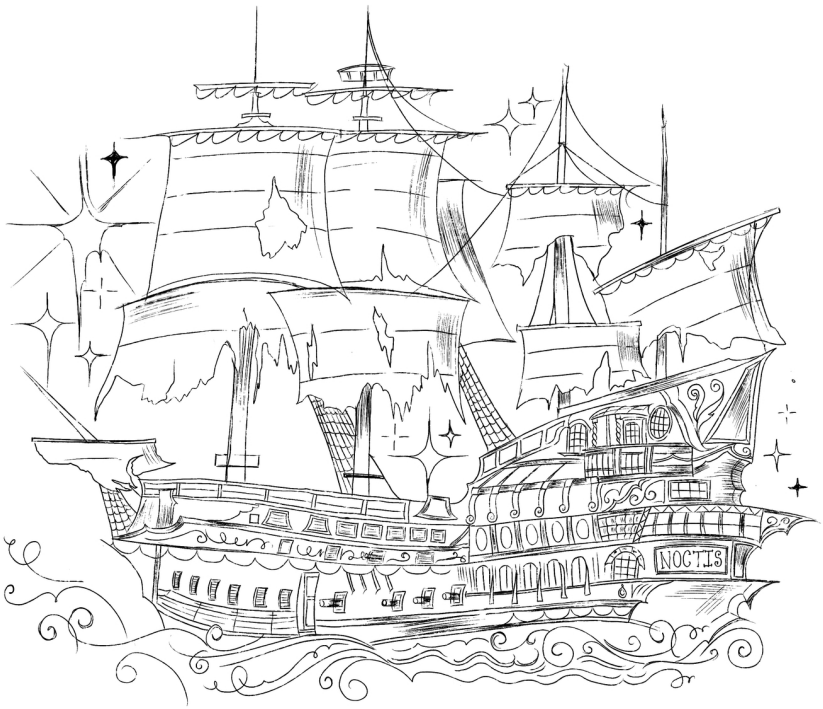
“This is an order.”

My mouth opens. For a heartbeat, I am certain that I will fight him on this. But one look at his face makes the protest stall somewhere between my lungs and my throat. His eyes swirl like smoke in a glass sphere, an inner storm, glistening on the surface like the faint flashes of lightning amongst the clouds. His turn to compel me.

I close my mouth again.

“Okay,” I whisper instead and give a single nod.

His eyes linger on me as I make my way to his cabin. The last thing I see before closing the corridor door is the cave widening around us instead of closing in, and the water carrying us deeper into something ancient and unknown.


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-Five

I WAKE UP TO THE clinking of metal. Blinking, a man's silhouette comes into focus, pulling his shirt over his head. A lantern now stands at his feet, painting the room in a soft, golden glow.

My eyes widen as I watch him push his breeches down too, revealing strong, muscled thighs. The shadow that he casts looks faint and stretches unnaturally wide against the other side of the cabin. I cannot get myself to look away, keeping my lips sealed, I start to pull the sheets over my face.

"I know you're awake," he says in a low voice, making me jump. "You were snoring when I came in, now you're dead quiet. I tried not to wake you, but—"

"It's okay." I interrupt him, my voice nothing more than a whisper. I prop myself up upon my hands and pull the blanket against my chest. Neither of us says anything, the moment between us thick in the air like honey.

The mattress dips where his weight settles as he climbs into bed with me. There's only one sheet, but he doesn't tug at what covers my body. Instead, he lies on his back and stares at the ceiling, with his body draped with a sliver of the sheet.

"You're being silly," I say while lifting the blanket, before throwing it over his chest.

Sable moves his head to the side with a huff and sets his eyes on me.

"I'm trying to be a gentleman."

"You're a pirate," I argue. "Isn't that against your nature?"

"Isn't sleeping in a bed with a pirate against your nature?"

A smile tugs at my lips as I shrug. He's right. We've stopped letting what we are define our actions, our feelings towards each other a long time ago. My back softens against the mattress at the thought, the warmth of the thought wrapping around me as we grow more comfortable with one another.

"So, what do you think is out there?" I ask, my voice low.

Sable swallows. "I wish I knew. I don't think the passage will open up or bring us somewhere else. There's nothing here, besides water. It looks like —"

"The womb of the sea?"

"I wanted to say a giant cave," he says with a light laugh. "But yes, that describes it pretty well."

I bite my lip. "What about the Glim?"

"It stopped moving. It's…there, but faint and pulsing. We've set anchor for the night, the crew is exhausted."

"We have arrived? We're in the Sea of the First Song?" I try to contain my excitement at the thought of it, but a smile pulls at my lips anyway.

It would make sense, considering how well the walls of the cave echo every sound. If I were to use my siren song in here, I'm sure the echo would multiply it, and with that, my powers.

"Aye," he sighs. "But we can't stay long. We're running low on supplies…and I have to sail home."

"Home?" I whisper, my voice thin as the truth settles heavy in my chest. I know what sailing home means. I have seen it with my own eyes.

"The curse. I've run out of time, darling. The sea has been calling me back home since we woke up from the dream. I tried to tell you that I am too far gone."

His words land like a punch to my gut, knocking something loose inside me, and suddenly I remember the words of his shadow as if it were yesterday, along with the splash of water as the bodies of the pirates broke the surface.

Some try to outrun it. But none of that makes a difference once the sea decides it is time. They sail home to follow its call.

"I don't have enough power yet, I can't— I mean, I don't know if I can. I can take another salt bath, I can—"

"You're ready, Risa," he says, his voice so sure that I almost believe it. He lifts my fingers to his mouth, then kisses them once, the brief touch of

his lips against my skin making me shiver. “Tomorrow, you sing back the shadows of the crew. I know you can.”

None of us dares to say what we both think. That I might not have enough power to actually save them all, even with the echo and the power radiating within the cave.

“Sable—”

“Don’t,” he says, his voice sharp. “Don’t apologize for something that hasn’t happened yet, little siren. We are still here. We are alive. We are breathing.”

He takes my hand and gently puts it on his chest, then lays his fingers on top of mine. His heart drums behind his ribs, a steady rhythm that soon syncs with mine. The contracting muscles pump blood through his system the same way that the power is pumped through mine. Closing my eyes, I follow the urge to lay my head on his chest, to not only feel, but hear the beating of his heart.

Alive. His body is warm, not cold. He is not going to be climbing over the railing in the Sea of Shadows, and he is not going to drown. His bones will not become part of the collection that rests at the bottom of that seabed. Not if I can help it. With a quiet exhale, Sable curls his arms around me as I do him, and we lie there, counting the synchronized beats of our hearts.

In this very moment, I decide that I will do anything not to lose him. I will not accept a fate in which he is not here with me, a fate in which he is not made whole.

“There’s something else I want to tell you,” he says, his voice suddenly unsteady.

I lift my head slowly to take in his face, his grey eyes now look hazel in the subtle glow of the lantern.

“If you fail to sing my shadow back tomorrow,” he takes a deep breath. “I want you to know that I have never regretted the kiss. I have never regretted touching you on that little sandbank either.”

I open my mouth to say something, but he squeezes my hand, making me close it again.

“Not for one single second have I regretted you, Risa,” he continues. “In fact, you had me in your hold from the very first moment you stood there, in your white night gown, so otherworldly, so… beautiful.”

Adoration flashes through his eyes, and I forget how to breathe. His eyebrows knit together as the drumming of his heart becomes faster.

“While I tried to resist, tried to avoid you, to make you hate me,” he says and glances away, only for a brief second before our eyes meet again. “My shadow couldn’t. My soul was drawn to you, and I knew I was doomed to want someone I could never have.”

“Don’t you dare say goodbye to me now, pirate.” I sob, tears falling off my cheeks freely and onto his chest. “Don’t you dare, Sable.”

“I wish we had more time, my little siren. How I would love to see the world with you and shower you in dresses and gold. I’d bring you men to drown if you asked for it, and more.”

I sniffle as he places one hand on my cheek, brushing my tears away with his thumb.

“I want you to know,” he says, his gleaming eyes locked with mine. “That on some days I forgot my name, but I never forgot yours.”

The world slips out from under my feet like sand washing away from the tide. My mouth wobbles, the tears still streaming down my face. He catches every single one of them as they fall and brushes them away before they reach my lips. All this time, he didn’t loathe me. He didn’t fear me. He was trying to withhold, knowing his fate would take him away in the end.

“Then kiss me,” I whisper. “We are still here. We are alive. So kiss me.”

His eyes widen in surprise as he leans back and releases a long breath. He smiles. With one hand at the back of my head and one at my hip, he turns us in the sheets. His head is now hovering above mine. He bites his lip, waiting for permission.

I curl my legs around his body, hooking him closer. Whatever leash he had on himself seems to snap, and his mouth crushes against mine in a hungry kiss. It isn’t gentle, it is devouring, as if he wants to make up for the time we likely will never have.

As his teeth scrape over the bottom of my lip, I moan into the kiss. My mouth opens for him, and his tongue slips in, caressing my own. Strong hands move over my hip, stroking me above the thin fabric of my gown, before moving lower, lower, lower, until his fingers slip underneath.

Sable tears away from the kiss, pressing his mouth against my shoulder as his fingertips brush the bottom of my chest. Each feather-light touch of his lips against my skin feels like little bolts of lightning shooting through my system. His hand moves further up until he cups my breast, all while planting kisses upon my shoulders, my collarbones, my throat. I arch my

back into the touch, wanting more. Desperate, I thrust my hands into his thick hair and tug.

The sound he makes almost causes me to lose control. I am about to beg when he removes his lips and finally lifts my gown above my head. Sable pulls back to look at me, to devour me with his eyes, before leaning down to cover my nipple with his mouth. As his tongue circles around it, I gasp and tense and wiggle underneath him.

Within one swift movement, Sable grabs my wrists and pushes them into the mattress above my head. I gasp and test his hold, but he has his hands firmly locked around them, keeping me in place. When I glance down at him, our eyes meet.

“We will do this one time,” he says, a devilish smile now spreading on his face. “So I’ll make sure we do it right. Keep still for me.”

Biting my lip to hold back a whimper, I give in and nod. Whatever I want to say to him dies on my tongue as he sucks on my nipple, and I roll my hips against his body.

“So eager,” he murmurs between kisses, his teeth now scraping against sensitive skin. “We have all night, love. And I intend to use every last minute. Because I’m selfish like that.”

He kisses my stomach now, my belly button, until his hands leave my wrist to grab my thighs instead. His dark curls sit between them now, his lips hovering over the skin of my thighs, but never touching.

I thrust my hips up, towards him, so that he would finally touch me there. Sable groans in response and pushes my hips into the mattress with his arm, keeping me still.

The first flick of his tongue against my sensitive nub sets me on fire.

Moaning, I cling to the blanket, the cushions, anything that surrounds me to not lose my senses as he begins licking through my folds in long, torturing strokes.

“Sable—” I gasp, but that only makes him more eager. Within me, I feel myself changing, how the lust fuels and feeds the power behind my ribs. It burns bright now, buzzing with life and climbing higher, and higher like a wave rolling towards the shore.

His tongue then dips into my channel, making me whimper.

“Please,” I whisper, lost in the haze, not even knowing what I‘m begging for.

But he does. His fingers replace his tongue, slowly pumping into me as his tongue flicks against my clit again. It takes one more stroke, and I shudder, like a wave crashing into cliffs. My hips buckle, my entire body shaking, but he keeps me pinned to the bed and continues to devour me.

He builds me up, and I come again, gasping and panting, until stars burst across the ceiling of the cabin. Only when my muscles are soft and my body feels limp, does he let go. From the corner of my eye, his shadow is partially detached, watching me with intent.

“Sable—”

“It‘s okay,” he assures me as he places a soft kiss on my stomach. “I am not whole, but as whole as I can be.”

I nod, still floating in between the climaxes, and wrap my legs around his head. The locks of his dark hair have fallen into his face, and by the seas, he looks delicious.

“Are you thinking about devouring me now?” he asks, a slow grin spreading across his face. “Should I be worried?”

I hiss, baring my sharp canines. “ You should be if you don’t bed me right now, Captain.”

“Captain,” he murmurs as he climbs on top of me again. “I think I like that word coming from your mouth.”

With one hand, he pushes down his linen shorts, and his hard length springs free. I swallow at the sight of it, so thick and velvety and exactly what I need. When he lets the head of his cock glide against my slick core, I whimper.

“I want you,” I whisper and curl my hips against him, trying to pull him closer. “I want you inside of me, Sable, want to lose myself in you.”

Something flashes across his gaze, and he parts my legs further before nudging his cock at my entrance.

Then, ever so slowly, he pushes inside of me, filling me up and giving me time to adjust. I moan softly as he leans down to press his lips on mine in a searing kiss. He thrusts deeper, making my toes curl, and my hips lift to meet his.

When he bottoms out, I see stars.

He tears away from my mouth, his gaze studying me with care. “You okay?”

“Yes,” I say breathlessly and hook one leg around his butt.

“Good. Because this is about as long as I can hold myself back.”

Slowly, he pulls out again, before thrusting back inside, his hips meeting mine. By the seas, he fills me up so good. He sets a faster pace now and tips his head back, moaning. With every stroke, my own moans grow louder, wilder.

The power buzzing through me feels as if it is about to burst free. Somehow, I still need him closer, so I grab him and pull him down into a desperate kiss. Our tongues meet in a dance neither of us has learned before but still master perfectly. The kiss turns into nudging and scraping teeth, into something hungry and primal.

We kiss as he rocks into me, until I shake beneath him. The waves keep on building and crashing, as if he knew exactly how to set the pace, how to make me wiggle underneath him.

With my next climax, Sable follows, pushing deep into me and then keeping still. He groans as his hands caress my body, like a man possessed. As he collapses on top of me, I welcome the weight of him, the warmth of his skin against mine. I don’t know where my body begins and where his ends, and I wish I could just stay here, with him, forever.

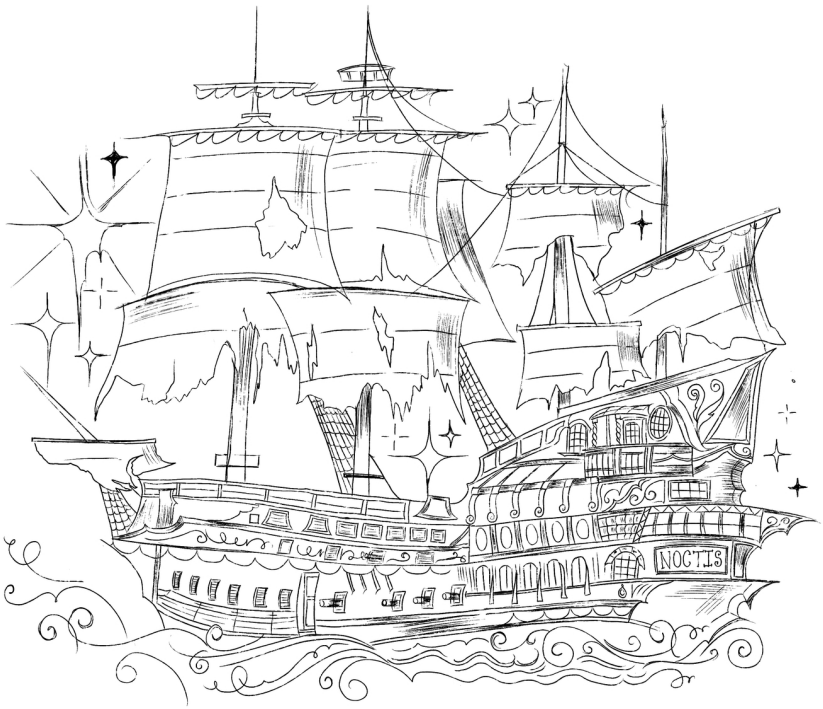
With the desire and the proximity comes the devastating truth that I might lose this man tomorrow. This man, this pirate, that I have come to care for. To yearn for. To love.

When he lifts his head again to meet my gaze, a tear slips from my eye. Sable leans down and kisses it away, then gently presses his lips against mine again, coating them with salt.

He pulls out then, slowly, and curls his arms around my body to hold me close. For a while, neither of us moves, our breaths still uneven, the world narrowing to the quiet space between us.

“Promise me you won't mourn me,” he whispers. “I was never meant to last. Find comfort in knowing I’ll be with the sea.”

Little does he know, the only thing I find comfort in is the sound of his beating heart.


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-Six

THE SHEETS NEXT TO me are still warm when I wake up, but Sable is gone. I push myself upright, looking around the cabin, but he's not at his desk either. Panic rises within me, mixing with the sadness his absence brings. Doesn't he know you don't leave a woman alone after bedding her?

Ignorant, uncivilized, Pi—

The door bursts open as Sable strides in, a bucket in one hand, a cloth in the other. He curses something under his breath before his eyes lock on me.

"Ah. You're up," he says as he walks towards the bed, puts the bucket down, and pulls the sheets from my naked body, as if it's the most normal thing in the world.

My gasping makes him stop dead.

"You want to be modest now?" he asks, raising one brow. "Darling, I was between your thighs last night. I want to clean you up."

Heat rushes into my cheeks. "You don't have to—"

"It's the least I can do," he interrupts. "Please. Let me."

Pressing my lips together, I give him a short nod. Sable removes the blanket from my body completely, then dips his hand into the bucket and begins to clean me. With his eyebrows drawn tight, he focuses on his task, as if it's the most important thing for him to do.

When he finishes, he smiles and pulls the blanket over my exposed body again.

"Thank you," I murmur, and give his hand a gentle squeeze.

He winks, but the smile on his face doesn't reach his eyes. "It's naught."

“I should probably get up. Have you told the crew that I will sing their shadows back?”

“Aye,” he nods and gets up, then crosses the room to dig through his chest of treasures. I watch in surprise as he pulls another dress from it, one I haven’t seen in there before.

“Please,” he walks back towards me, then lays it on the bed in front of me. “Wear it today. I want to see you in it, just once.”

The dress isn’t emerald or blue. It’s in the lightest shade of pink that I have ever seen, so light that it matches my iridescent scales.

“Where did you get this from?”

“My chest.”

I roll my eyes. “You know what I mean. Where did you get it from?”

He straightens and runs his fingers through his hair. “I got it from the markets back home.”

I raise one brow and let my fingers gently run over the sheer sleeves, the bodice, the lace details there. It is the most beautiful dress I have ever seen, even beating the emerald-colored gown.

A smile tugs at my lips. “You got it? Meaning, you bought it?”

“No. I stole it.” He clarifies and nods his head towards the dress. “Put it on.”

A smile tugs at my lips at his confession. He *stole* it for me.

“You stole it with the intention of gifting it to me?”

I press my lips into a thin line before taking the dress and pressing it against my chest, a treasure of my own to keep.

“I love it,” I breathe. “Thank you.”

Sable returns a curt nod, as if he were shy about it, making me smile even wider. He stares at me in anticipation now, with his jaw locked tight.

“I won't put it on now.” I decide. “Because this isn’t goodbye. You will see me wearing it when all of this is over.”

He opens his mouth to protest. “But I—“

My lips press against his in a gentle kiss, making him forget his words, and making me forget the world around us, even if it is just for a brief moment. Heat flushes into my cheeks in surprise at my own bravery. I’m kissing him.

When I tear away from him, Sable looks at me with widened eyes. Both of us are out of breath and at a loss for words. His short beard feels rough on my skin as I place my hand on his cheek.

“You are going to see me in this,” I whisper. “Afterwards.”

The line of his mouth tightens a fraction more.

“Okay. Afterwards.”

I put on my emerald gown in silence, all while he is busying himself with fastening the straps of his coat, though I can see the tension in his shoulders in the small mirror by the wall.

When I finish, Sable’s eyes find mine, and I give him a slow nod before he takes my hand in his.

I am ready.

Or at least, as ready as I can be.

“You know that you don’t have to do this, right?” He squeezes my hand once, then presses a kiss against the back of my hand. “I would never put this burden on your shoulders.”

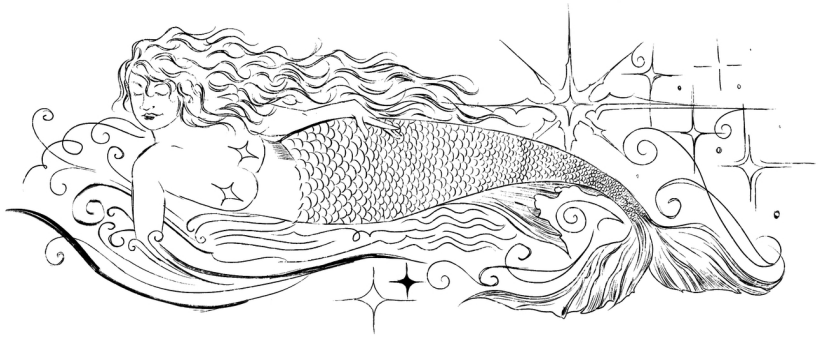
“I know,” I swallow. “But I’ll never forgive myself if I don’t. Not just because of you. But because of me.”

Sable frowns, and his gaze sweeps over my legs. He knows.

“Ever since your sister told me that the Glim could be leading us towards your fate or mine, I have come to think our fates are intertwined. Maybe it leads us to both of our ends, or both of our beginnings.”

A faint light twinkles in the depths of his dark eyes. He sees it too. Our future. Hope.

“So yes,” I say with a soft voice, “I want to do this.”



The air in the cave is cold and damp as we step onto the deck, laced with salt and something that I can’t quite name. It tastes like iron on my tongue, the same taste that came with the drowning of Rat.

Death.

Swallowed by distance, I can no longer make out the walls of the cave. Around the Noctis, the water lies black and still.

The crew is already assembled, waiting for us. Not lined up, not neat, but gathered in a loose half circle near the mainmast. The same way they stood for my Tribunal. Lanterns swing gently above us, but the light doesn't go far. What's not swallowed by the dark planks is swallowed by the shadows that surround us, each belonging to one of the men. Dozens of them, way more than I have ever seen at one time.

Even with their faces turned downward, I can see how hollow they look. When I glance back at Sable, I am struck by how hollow he looks too. How his skin stretches over his cheekbones, how deep and dark his eye sockets look.

Only when we reach the center of the deck does Sable let go of my hand.

"Crew of the Noctis", he begins, his gaze sweeping over his men.

"In the past few weeks, we have followed the Glim, not knowing if it will be the cure to our curse, or if it will lead us to our doom. I don't take any of your trust for granted."

When he tenses, I give him an encouraging nod.

"Today, Risa will sing your shadows back. We will do it quickly," he continues, voice low and controlled. "We will do it in order. You follow orders and keep your heads."

A few men bob their heads in agreement, some swallow loud enough for me to hear.

Sable turns to me, and for a moment, the mask of the captain slips, leaving only the man who so carefully cleaned me moments ago. The man whose bed I shared last night.

"You will not endanger her," he commands, all while keeping his gaze on me. "If your shadow is too far gone and will not return, make space for the next man."

He turns again, facing his men.

"You'll feel their pain," he says. "The shadows don't want to return. They'll push. They'll pull. They'll make you consider letting it slip away, presenting it as the easier choice."

My mouth goes dry, my heartbeat too fast. They all stare at me now, their expressions shifting between unease and hope. One of them presses his lips into a thin line, another's brows draw together, while a few others watch me with quiet intensity, as if trying to measure whether I can truly do this.

“Let her voice command them,” he finally says. “Let her bring them home.”

Command.

My stomach twists at his words. I have spent so long with my voice buried by instinct and shame and the ache of what I’m missing, that I forget it was ever meant to be a weapon. But this is my chance to use it as something different. To use it to heal rather than harm.

One of the men steps forward.

“What if she fails?”

“She already saved one of us,” Sable replies and straightens his back. “You will not disrespect her by doubting her. And if you do, you’d better get the fuck out of the line.”

Murmurs erupt throughout the crew, some voices doubting, others reassuring.

They are scared.

They should be.

“Aye,” Nightglass’ voice carries above the others. When our eyes meet, he gives me an encouraging nod. “She saved my son. She will save me.”

Sable steps towards me, close enough that I can smell myself on him, salt and smoke combined.

“You can stop this at any time,” he whispers. “This is your decision. But if you fail to make it in time, I will make it for you.”

He pauses and draws in a slow breath before something flickers behind his eyes.

“You will not die today.”

My throat dries up at his words, making the words I want to say stick there.

Sable lifts his chin, returning to the captain's voice.

“We go in order,” he says, clear enough that the men at the far edge can hear. “We start with the youngest. One by one. You hold still, you don’t flinch.”

“Match.” His gaze pins the wiry pirate, apparently the second youngest after Lark. “You go first.”

The lad stiffens, then steps forward, his hands curling into fists at his sides. His shadow surges, stretches too long across the boards, reaching toward me like the living thing it is. I don’t step back. Instead, I widen my stance and plant my feet firmly into the ground.

Sable shifts closer behind me, not touching me but near enough that I can feel him at my back. His steady presence is a warning to whoever watches from the dark.

Heat crawls up my spine when Grim appears in the line, somewhere near the end. I have to make it.

One by one. Not just for them, but for myself. I may not have a tail, but I will bring their shadows back with my voice, even if it's the last thing I do.

I drag in a slow breath and let the anger guide me. An emotion so dense I feel it in my core, fueling what’s behind my sternum, coiling with fear and grief.

It feels different now. Before, the power had always come like instinct. Like a reflex I didn’t trust, that only surfaced when the circumstances demanded it. There was no control when I made Rat climb over the rail.

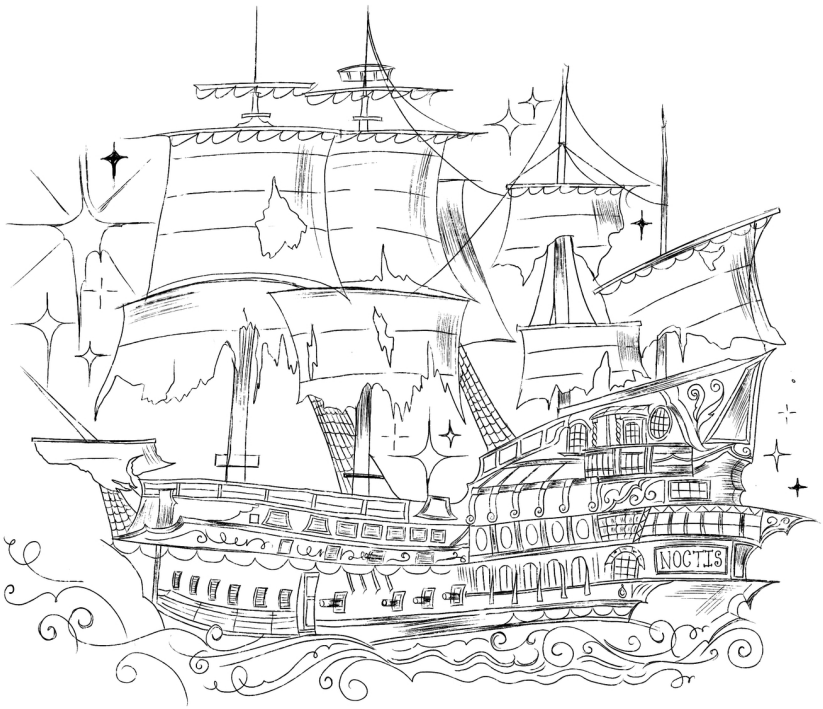
Only destruction.

Now it answers me. It has weight.

It’s the direct result of immersion and surrender, of me letting the saltwater press into my skin until there was no clean edge between where I ended and it began. My voice feels like an instrument that once was unfamiliar, one I haven’t dared to use because every time I do, I am reminded of my limits, of what I am. Or rather, what I am not.

I close my eyes for a heartbeat and reach for it.

And it rises to meet me.


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-Seven

THE POWER ANSWERS IN an eager rush, like a barrel overflowing with water after something heavy is dropped into it. It slides through me like a current finding its path, filling spaces in my body that feel entirely too small to hold it. My hands go cold when it presses against my sea-formed bones.

Now.

I have to sing now, give it an outlet, like I did when I sang for Sable.

I open my mouth and let the first note slip free. It vibrates through ribs and spine, through the soles of my feet and into the ship, as if it was trying to find its way back into the water.

The cave returns the sound in a soft echo. It doubles, triples, then repeats itself all over again, like the voice of Sable's shadow often did. This is not a coincidence, I find. This place is made for the song of a siren.

Match's eyes widen when his shadow surges forward, detaching from his frame completely. It reaches for me without hesitation, as if he knows what I am trying to make him do. His dark hands claw at my arm, like a man slashing for the surface when he's drowning and desperate to live.

It feels like dying.

I remember the words of Sable's shadow and pull at another string of my power. My voice is steady as I focus on Match now, on his physical, shaking body. Return home. I try to command it, but it pushes against my song's pull, writhing and twisting in the hold of my magic.

Match grits his teeth as his shadow finally lets go of me and surges toward him instead.

A sound escapes him, a strangled groan that proves his pain.

Sable’s voice cuts through. “Hold.”

Match's eyes flick toward the captain, then back to me, and he nods again, telling me to continue.

At the next note, my throat tightens. The power presses upward, demanding me to give it a way out, but I have to hold it back, and I'll have to hold it back for a while longer.

Match’s shadow buckles, then goes thin, crumping over. Its hands lash across the boards like hungry flames, reaching for the other shadows in desperation.

Then it snaps back toward him, like a rope yanked and dragged by force.

The young pirate jerks as if struck in the gut and lets out a wheezing gasp. The shadow slams into his feet, pours up his legs, and finally, sinks back into him. His eyes roll back for a second, as dark as black pearls, then snap forward again.

Some of the other pirates gasp at the sudden calm of him, and I force my voice back into a hum. Match looks up at me, eyes shining, then nods timidly, before stumbling out of the line.

A soft touch at my elbow makes me flinch.

“You did it,” he whispers into my ear.

I can’t look at him, because if I do, my siren might decide that he’s next. I have to keep my promise, and the only way to do that is through control.

I swallow through the throbbing ache in my throat and focus on the line ahead.

The next man steps forward.

He’s older than Match, thicker in the shoulders. His shadow stands beside him already, not surging or trying to escape. Instead, he looks steady and immovable, as if he has grown roots into the planks.

This might be more difficult.

I draw in another breath. The power is still there, coiled behind my sternum, but it doesn’t feel untouched or infinite. The salt-fed weight inside me shifts, and suddenly I become well aware of the edges of it, the limit I don’t want to reach.

His shadow is trying to anchor itself against my pull, so I just pull harder and take another string. My voice threads through his will, and finally, the

shadow shudders.

It returns to its owner in a slow, reluctant sweep. He backs away without a word, and the next man steps forward.

One by one.

I find a rhythm in my song.

Call. Resist. Pull. Return.

Each time I use my song, the ache in my throat deepens. The power doesn't feel like strings anymore. Instead, it feels like a heavy rope that I have to drag through a narrow space, scraping at my insides in the process.

After the seventh shadow, a dull throb blooms behind my eyes. I blink against it and try to focus on the men in front of me, and on their shadows that roam the deck.

After the tenth, my voice roughens at the edges.

Sable remains behind me, silent except when he gives an order. His steadiness is both a comfort and a pressure. I can feel his gaze on the back of my head, like he knows that I am already pushing against my limits.

"Drink," he says, and presses a waterskin into my hand. I gulp down the water, closing my eyes as the cold liquid numbs my throat, and then hand it back without looking at him.

The shadows become more and more resistant, and there are still so, so many. Grim is still near the end of the line, with his arms crossed and his face set in stone. Behind him is Nightglass, who keeps watch on Lark, who stands quietly off to the side.

I curl my hands into fists at my sides, so hard that I am sure my nails dig into flesh, but I have lost all sensation in my skin. Hot liquid trickles out of my nose and coats my lips. I recognize the taste of iron immediately. Blood.

He told me to save his crew first. But I will not follow his order anymore. I will not save those who voted for my death before the ones who were kind to me.

"Nightglass," I say, my voice steady again. "You're next."

Sable doesn't protest, and the rest of the crew doesn't either. He's Lark's father, after all.

Nightglass looks confused for a heartbeat, but after another glance at his son, he steps forward.

I give him a short smile, then wipe away the blood with the back of my hand.

“Don’t cross a line for me, lass,” Nightglass says. “My shadow is far gone.”

“Don’t worry,” I tell him. “I will find it.”

When I start my song again, the cave holds all of it and more. For him, and for Lark, I drag the heavy ropes through me once more. Nightglass’s shadow comes into my view after a while, and I focus on it, then on Lark, to remind him what he’s fighting for.

Nightglass goes rigid, his face twisting in agony, as the shadow gravitates toward him.

I hold the note, push the command through it until the deck sways beneath my feet. The edges of his shadow are sharp, and I can feel it searching for a break in my control.

The shadow fights, but eventually it gives. It snaps back into him so fast he chokes on a sound, hands flying to his chest. Lark rushes to him immediately, throwing his arms around his father.

Sable’s hand appears on my waist, his fingers firm and warm against my body.

“You’re shaking,” he says with a hushed voice, his words meant for me alone.

“I’m okay,” I manage, but the words scrape at my vocal cords.

His grip tightens a fraction.

“You need a break.”

“No,” I say through gritted teeth, and keep my gaze fixed ahead, on the line that is still way too long. “I need more salt.”

Moments later, buckets of ice-cold water are poured over me. My head, my chest, my arms, and back. The salt sinks into my skin instantly, fueling my power.

Grim stands in front of me now, with his head slightly lowered, in anticipation of the pain. He looks worse up close, drawn, even. His shadow barely touches his heels anymore, stretched thin and restless.

I take a deep breath as I steady myself. The cold sharpens my vision as my song scrapes its way out, vibrating through my chest before it reaches the air.

Grim’s shadow recoils.

It fights harder than the rest did, scraping fingers across the deck, slamming into the planks. When my knees are about to give in, Sable steadies me with his hands on my hips.

He is so warm, so steady against my back, anchoring me more than the salt ever could.

“You have to stop,” he says into my ear and tightens his grip on me once again.

I ignore him.

When Grim's shadow snaps back into him, a burning sensation rips through me, so painful that it almost knocks me blind. Darkness creeps upon me now, but it's not a shadow. It’s my body giving in.

I sway, the world fading.

Then the darkness fractures.

A resounding crack breaks through the air. Wood explodes near the rail, splinters biting into my calf as a lantern shatters right next to me. Another shot follows, this time even closer.

“Down!” someone shouts.

The man in front of me jerks, the spot where Grim stood a second before, his body snapping backward as if yanked by an invisible hand. He collapses in a heap, blood already slicking the planks beneath him.

Gunfire.

The world tilts as Sable tackles me to the ground. I land on the planks with a heavy thud, his body covering mine. Something whistles above us and embeds itself in the main mast with a bang.

The power I’ve been holding wavers, my voice breaking off mid-tone as splinters of wood rain down on us.

“You stay here,” he snaps, not unkind, but demanding. “Do not move. Do not sing.”

“But the shadows—”

“Risa!” he barks, shoving me behind one of the intact masts, before pulling his long cutlass. “You will do as I say.”

The world narrows to him. To the way his hands shake, despite the steel in his voice. To the fear he isn’t trying to hide anymore. My vision blurs, pain pulsing, where exhaustion has already hollowed me out. It’s all too much.

I nod.

Sable exhales in relief, then presses his forehead against mine.

“Don’t move,” he murmurs, lower now. “I will come back for you.”

Then he’s gone.

Steel flashes as he steps away from me, shouting orders that cut through the chaos. When I peer behind the mast, he’s already engaged in a fight with one of the intruders.

They boarded the ship with planks and hawks. By the seas, how did we not notice them? They must’ve crept up on us, using the dark as protection. I never thought that someone would follow us here, into the womb of the sea. That the sea would even let them through.

I curl in on myself behind the mast, hands clamped over my mouth as the sound of battle swells around me. Out on the deck, the shadows have disappeared. Once my magic stopped fully, they were all gone.

Right next to me, a body slams against the boards. Blood splashes warm against my wrist, and then, a grunt that cuts off halfway through.

I don’t want to look, but do so anyway, right in the moment when a blade is pulled out of his chest with the sound of wet, tearing flesh. It’s Saint.

Blood pours across the planks, seeping into the grooves, trickling towards my knee. My breath catches as if the blade had been dragged through me instead.

No.

Only days ago, he fixed the starboard rail. He laughed when the mast rope snapped and bruised his shoulder, calling it a love tap from the Noctis herself.

Now he doesn’t move at all.

I suddenly feel so helpless at the sight of his body. I want to scream and end this nightmare, like I did the last time we were under attack. Only this time, I know for certain that this is real and that there is no escaping.

He is dead.

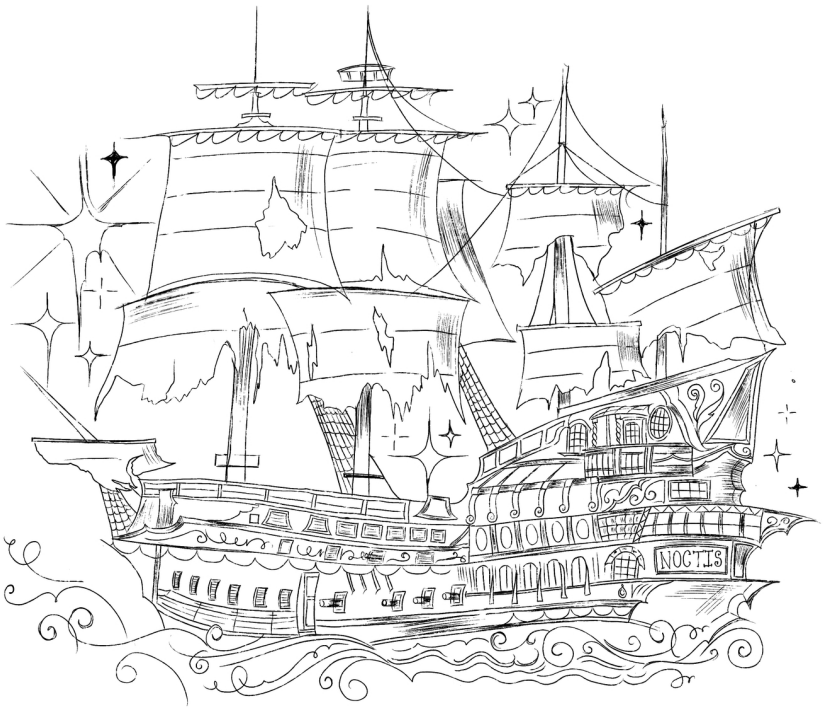
The attacker turns toward me, his eyes flicking over my frame.

That’s when I realize that he’s not a stranger at all.

Up close, he looks worse than I remember, broad and heavy in his grimy, cracked leather coat. His unkempt hair clings to his temples, and his skin carries a greyish tone, like something left too long beneath the sea. A faint shimmer clings to his throat, pale flecks that glint with an iridescent sheen.

Ground scales. That’s how they were able to pass.

He’s one of the hunters who have been haunting me my whole life, come to take what is most valuable to them—my scales, my blood, my power.


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-Eight

THE HUNTER STEPS TOWARD me with malicious intent, his boots sliding through the blood that spreads across the planks between us. I see the exact moment he understands who I am — what I am — before his gaze drops to my throat, to the place where my voice still vibrates softly. His grip tightens around the blade. In his face, there is no hesitation, no uncertainty of a man who questions the morality of what he is about to do.

I dig my fingers harder into the gaps in the wood beneath me as I look past him. More boots hit the deck, more men spill over the planks as the hunters climb aboard with weapons drawn. I understand with sudden, sick clarity that we never stood a chance against them. They waited, they watched, and they chose the exact moment when my voice would be the weakest and our guard the lowest, to strike.

We are outnumbered.

We are unprepared.

We are going to die here.

The realization settles into my chest with suffocating weight, and I become deeply aware of how fragile my body has become, how diluted the strength inside of me feels after everything I have already given to the crew.

I wait for him to close the remaining distance between us and drive that blade straight into my heart, before anyone can reach me. Before Sable could reach me. But the hunter doesn’t move.

“Captain said to capture you alive,” he spits. “Makes the highest profit. I see you got some shiny new scales too.”

His gaze drops to my legs.

Fear bubbles in my stomach, before it cramps so tight it makes the deck tilt beneath me. Frozen, I watch him pull a dirty cloth out of his breaches as he towers above me, and I press my back against the mast, as if I could sink into it if I tried hard enough.

The power within me is drained, and yet I wonder what happens if I reach for it anyway.

As he leans down to grab me, I pull at the strings of my song and open my mouth. My throat aches as the first note escapes, and it is dripping with the taste of iron. Blood runs over my lips and down my chin, clinging to my skin in slow, heavy strands as I try to drag air into my lungs. I spit it out to avoid choking on it, with both palms against blood-stained wood.

He laughs, and tears blur my vision.

I lift my head just enough to see him standing there, his blade loose in his hand now, his shoulders relaxed with the easy confidence of a man who knows the outcome of this fight has already been decided. His eyes move over me with open satisfaction as more blood spills from my mouth.

“Is that all?” he asks.

You are weak. The sea whispers into my ear, and for a moment, I believe it. Believe that this is how it ends, on my hands and knees in a mixture of Saint’s blood and my own.

Yes, I am weak.

But that does not mean I cannot be brave. I haven’t survived this long for it all to end like this, with me in the hands of the men I have been running from my whole life. I’d rather die before they pluck a single scale from my body.

My fingers tremble. Something moves beneath my skin, a slow pressure at the tips of my fingers, as if something buried deep inside my bones is trying to force its way free.

Then pain blooms, and my nails push forward, lengthening beyond what should be possible, thinning into clear, curved points that gleam faintly in the dim light.

Talons.

Slowly, I look up at him. The smile on the hunter’s face falters when he sees them. My mouth shifts into a smile that does not belong to the woman I was weeks ago.

His eyes widen.

Too late.

My arm lashes forward with a natural precision, faster than he can react. My talons slice cleanly into the back of his leg, just above the heel, sinking deep into the thick cord of his Achilles tendon before tearing through it completely.

He screams, and it is like music to my ears.

The sound rips out of him as his body collapses, his legs buckling beneath him as he crashes down onto his knees with violent force. The blade he carried a moment ago clatters across the deck, useless.

Blood pours from the wound. Bright. Hot. Alive.

Yes. The sea whispers again.

My hands press into it without hesitation, my fingers sinking into the warmth of it as the instinct takes over completely, guiding me. I drag the blood across my skin, smearing it over my arms in slow, deliberate strokes as if marking myself with it.

The siren rises, and so does my power.

It surges back into me with a sudden force, flooding my body, drowning out the weakness that burned through me moments ago. The strength returns to me, in unruly, sputtering bouts, growing more and more intense as fear begins to glisten in the hunter’s eyes.

He tries to crawl away.

I let my voice rise again, and this time, it does not break. The note emerges low and steady, vibrating through him instantly, wrapping tight around his failing will as his body stills. When his hands fall limp at his sides, I know my command has burrowed deep into him.

Stand.

His ruined leg drags uselessly behind him as he forces himself upright, his face pale with agony. Trembling, he turns toward the railing with slow, obedient steps.

The sea stretches beneath him, black and endless, its surface broken only by the violent rocking of the ships. Around me, the battle continues mercilessly, steel striking steel in sharp bursts that cut through the air. Somewhere close to my left a man cries out before the sound chokes off abruptly, replaced by the wet collapse of something heavy hitting the ground.

I know it was one of our men without looking.

The hunter sways where he stands above the water, his fingers tightening against the railing as if some final instinct is fighting to return to him. But I do not release him from my control.

Jump.

I command him, and he lets go. His body drops into the dark with a dull, distant splash that vanishes almost immediately beneath the roar of the battle. The moment he disappears, the power surges back into me with violent force, intoxicating my senses with sweet death and pure, unfiltered power.

I do not feel weak anymore.

The smell of blood and gunpowder fills the air around me, polluting my lungs with every breath, thick and suffocating. I turn to take in what unfolds in front of me.

Grim is several paces away, his frame locked in brutal combat with two hunters at once. To my surprise, he swings an axe instead of a sword, forcing back the attackers. But he slows down, his twisted face a clear sign of exhaustion.

One of the hunters lunges low, and Grim blocks the strike, but the second moves behind him and raises his weapon high.

I raise my voice with intent, focusing solely on him. The note tears free from me, cutting clean through the chaos as it finds the hunter just as his blade begins its descent. He freezes, body locking mid-motion as the sound sinks deep into the fragile center of his mind.

Grim sees him now, confusion flashing across his face as the hunter steps away from him instead of toward.

Walk. Jump. Drown.

He passes Grim, his shoulder brushing against him as he moves through the heart of the battle and toward the railing, ignoring the shouts of his own men.

When he jumps, Grim's eyes lift to meet mine, only for a brief moment, with him already swinging his axe again.

Understanding passes between us, and I lift the corner of my mouth into a smile as more power floods my system.

I scan the deck for Sable.

I find him. He moves between his attackers with lethal precision across the deck, his blade flashing in tight arcs that force them back one step at a time. But there are too many of them, their bodies closing in around him, no

matter how much he slashes at them. He won't be able to keep them off forever. My chest tightens at the thought of a blade ramming into his chest, of him bleeding out as Saint did.

So I do not let my song fade. Instead of forcing it back down and obeying the instinct that wants me to stop, I allow it to expand further. The power spills outward in slow waves, pulsing through the air around me as if the sea itself has chosen my body as its vessel.

Without a second thought, I lift my hands, my fingers spreading through the air as if I can feel the shape of the power itself. My song reaches further across the deck and slips past the clash of steel, then wraps around not one but two of the hunters attacking Sable.

One of them stiffens first, his blade faltering before falling to the ground. Then the body of another locks mid-motion, as if he is being held back by an invisible force. Their minds struggle against my power, and I feel the strain of it tearing through me, my lungs burning as if each breath must force its way through broken glass.

Movement flickers at the edge of my vision. Two more hunters break from the chaos, their eyes fixed on me and my throat. A quick glance to my sides tells me that no one can step in, that no one can leave their position, as they would risk their own lives in doing so.

"Risa!" Sable shouts, there is nothing controlled or commanding in it now, only raw fear stripped bare as my name tears out of him. He knows what it is costing me, and he knows he will not reach me in time.

I drag more power through me, ignoring the violent protest of my body as the sound lashes outward and wraps around them just before their hands reach me.

The impact of it nearly breaks me. Pain explodes through my chest as my hands jerk violently in the air, my fingers cramping inward as the force pouring out of me doubles, triples, far beyond what I have ever produced before.

My gaze finds Sable, who's using two swords now, trying to fight his way through the shifting crowd. With his eyes widened and his knuckles white around the handles of his blades, he screams my name again. But it all seems so distant. So out of reach.

My arms tremble uncontrollably as I hold them all in my power, my fingers curling tighter as if I can physically grip the threads binding them to

me. The terror claws at the edges of their minds, as it does to mine. I can feel it as though it is my own.

Killing them might give us the upper hand again. The crew will survive if only I can push a little further. The issue is the edge that I can feel rising inside of me, an invisible boundary between me and my power that I may not cross. It is absolute, and I understand with terrible clarity that if I push beyond it, there will be no returning from what I become.

At the edge of my vision, a presence rises. Darkness creeps upon me as Sable's shadow forms at my side. The familiar shape gives me a brief moment of comfort, but is soon replaced by a devastating realization.

I haven't sung his shadow back. And I might never get the chance to.

"Let them go," he pleads, and the sound of his voice makes me shiver, sickness rising in my throat.

"I can't." I whimper, a tear wetting my cheek. "I can't risk losing you."

The physical form of Sable still tries to cut through the chaos, his blade flashing with deathly precision, beheading one of his attackers without mercy. He doesn't even look twice at what he has done. Instead, he moves forward, already striking again, disarming the next man who dares to step into his path. It is like with his shadow gone, he is something else entirely. For a suspended moment, I understand him completely.

He looks like how I feel.

"I'm sorry," I whisper instead. "I wish we had more time."

My fingers curl inward with the last strength I have left, pulling tight on the invisible threads binding the hunters to my will. Obedience floods through me as all four of them turn to walk towards the railing in perfect, silent unison.

My throat burns raw, but still, I hold them.

I hold them as their hands grip the wood.

I hold them as they climb.

I hold them as they jump.

The moment they disappear, everything breaks.

The power feels like a punch in my gut, so overwhelming that it steals the breath from my lungs, the sudden collision of everything I gave and everything being returned tears through me faster than my body can handle. I am thrown backwards as my legs give out beneath me. The deck tips violently before the shattering pain of my hip striking the railing hits.

"Risa!" he screams my name before the world slips away from me.

I fall.

Cold air rushes around me as the sea rises to meet me, its dark surface swallowing the last fragments of light from the ship. It meets me with a crushing force, the freezing cold exploding around my body, swallowing me whole, as it has done many times before.

Above me, the surface fractures the light into broken shards. There's movement there. Something dark, twisting and shaking with the swaying of the waves. A man. His shadow. He dives downward without hesitation, reaching for me instead of returning to the man he belongs to.

I realize that he will never return to himself.

That he will never be whole.

Because he chose me.

No.

His shadow cuts through the water, refusing to abandon me as the sea pulls me deeper into its seemingly endless dark. The pain that had consumed me moments ago fades away as I drift further away from the fragile world above.

Something else enters the water. As I drift in and out of consciousness, it descends steadily toward me, its shape widening as it falls, passing through Sable's shadow without resistance.

I force my eyes to open again when coarse fibers brush against my arms and tighten around my body.

A net.

Unseen hands above begin to pull, dragging me upward against the will of the sea. And even though drowning is a scary way to go, I'd rather sink to the bottom of the sea than fall into their hands.

Sable's shadow seems to understand this. He stays close, his form wavering in the broken reflections of the lantern light above as he reaches for the ropes binding my body, again and again, but no matter how urgently he tries to tear them apart, they don't give in.

He shakes his head in panic, not in denial but in helpless acknowledgement that he cannot free me. But then his eyes widen, and his mouth forms a single word meant only for me.

Look.

His gaze drops toward my legs as pain begins to take root.

It starts as pressure, but quickly grows into something far more deliberate, something structured. It spreads through muscle and veins with

an increasing intensity as my body begins to change. To shift.

Without being driven by any conscious thought, my knees draw together. The bones beneath my skin begin to shift and realign, their fragile human structure collapsing inward as something stronger takes its place. The pain sharpens as the transformation continues downward, my lower legs lengthening even as the joints dissolve.

I reach for the hand of Sable's shadow as the surface comes closer.

"I am here," he says, as his fingers wrap around mine, squeezing. The voice sounds distant, muffled by the sea, but it reaches me anyway.

My legs form into something seamless and whole. The muscles along them tighten and strengthen as they fuse, forming something powerful and unmistakable. I feel its weight even through the net that binds me, feel the subtle, instinctive awareness of its presence, and though I cannot move it freely, I know it belongs to me in a way nothing ever has.

My tail.

It is beautiful.

Not in the way human things are beautiful, not fragile, but powerful and whole. Scales and muscle form a pink armor that I'm sure would help me travel far, if only I weren't captured.

A flicker of light beneath me draws my attention away from my tail. Faint at first, barely more than a thread of light, the Glim pulses weakly through the water as if it has been waiting for my shift. My chest tightens as it drifts closer, its glow strengthening with every pulse. It lingers in front of me, then flares, sudden and bright, before vanishing completely. The scales of my tail catch the remaining light filtering through the water, their surface shimmering in soft shades of pink and pearl, iridescent in a way that reminds me of the Sea of Dreams.

The net tightens as I am dragged higher, the fibers biting deeper into my skin as the surface breaks around me and cold air replaces the sea's comforting embrace.

It is only then that I realize I should've drowned. I was under the water for what felt like an eternity, and there's no way I held my breath for that long. My body convulses violently at the sudden absence of water, the air more suffocating than drowning has ever been. I open my mouth on instinct, but nothing comes. Panic surges through me.

I gasp again, my jaw straining open, but my lungs only stutter, useless. Moments ago, I was breathing without effort, and only now do I understand

that I was never holding my breath at all.

Trembling, my hands reach for the side of my throat.

My eyes widen in shock. Gills. Of course, I have gills. But do I have lungs?

“Breathe,” Sable’s shadow says, his voice insisting. “Just breathe. Slow.”

My eyes meet his as the net jerks hard, hauling me fully from the sea, the water pouring from my body in heavy streams. My chest spasms again as I try to force air into my lungs that now feel so foreign, so purposeless. The deck comes into view. With the lack of oxygen, the voices around me become distant and distorted. Violently, they drag me over the railing, my tail heavy and unresponsive beneath me as exhaustion settles into my bones.

My vision flickers, and I force my eyes open.

Sable stands near the main nest, his body held back by three men gripping his arms and shoulders as he fights against them in desperation. Blood streaks his skin, and even from here, I can see the rapid rise and fall of his heaving breaths. He shouts my name, over and over again, and my world narrows down on him.

On his grey eyes, and how they remind me of the sea before a heavy storm. On his voice, stripped of command and certainty as he fights against the men holding him back. Desperate. My gaze lingers on his face, on the strain carved into every line of it, on his dark hair that usually sits on his head like a crown, but is now flat and soaked through with blood.

They drag me away from him. Each movement sends a jolt through me, but the pain barely registers beneath the suffocating absence of the sea. His gaze never leaves mine, not even as the distance between us grows and they haul me up towards the plank that connects the two ships.

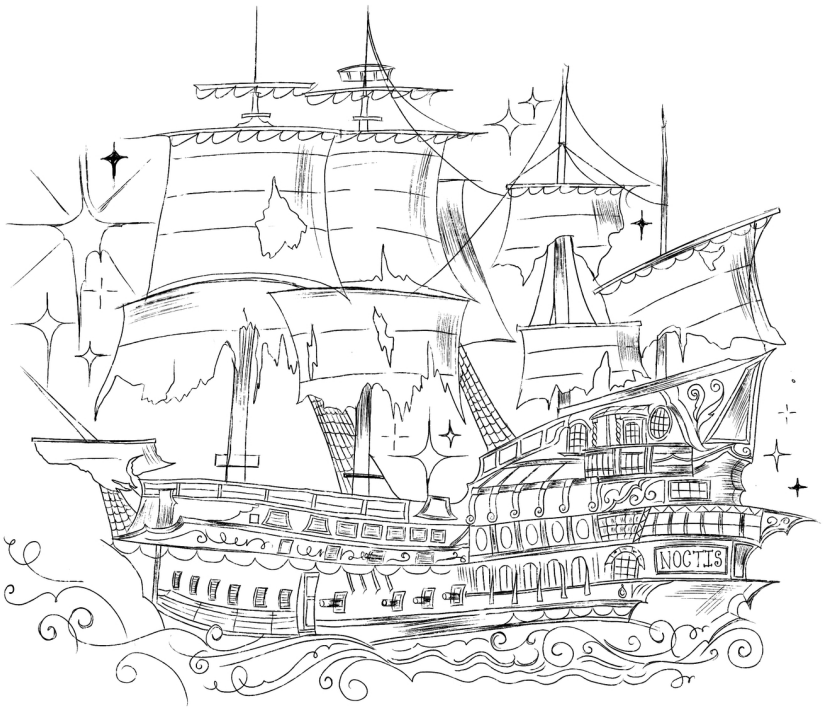
“I’ll find you!”

His voice breaks on the promise, the sound tearing through the fog closing in around my mind. His shadow presses close and sticks to my side, but as I try to reach for it, my hands do not move. Darkness creeps inward, swallowing the last fragments of light and sound.

The last thing I see is his face, not the man held back by the hunter’s hands, but the shadow that chose me, who still refuses to let me go.

With what is left of me, I scream, and the sound tears out of me, carrying a strained, almost creaking note as it echoes through the cave.

Then everything disappears.


NOCTIS

Chapter Thirty-Nine

PAIN STEALS THE BREATH from my lungs, and dryness tightens my skin, making the delicate surface of my scales stiff and aching.

I do not remember the journey here.

Only fragments remain, broken pieces without order and meaning. The air was suffocating in the hold of the ship where they kept me in a dingy cell like a helpless fish. They carelessly threw saltwater over my body now and then, barely enough to keep me alive. The moisture kept drying too quickly, and I barely escaped death a few times with the tankards' worth of water they splashed me with.

I have always imagined the day of my transformation to be the happiest day of my life, and the truth is, I never stopped clinging to that hope. Somehow, for a short moment, it was. That very first glimpse, that blissful pain, the reflection of shimmering scales felt like the beginning of my life.

But it might have been the beginning of the end instead.

As my awareness sharpens further, I become more conscious of the unnatural strain pulling from my body. Rope cuts into flesh at my wrists, making it impossible for me to move. But it is the position itself that sends waves of pain tearing through me.

I am hanging upside down. The pressure gathers immediately in my skull, and my tail bears the full weight of me where it has been secured to something above. Every small movement sends a tremor of agony through the length of it.

Voices drift through the pain, some close, others distant and muffled. Fragments of conversations reach me, discussing prices and the value of goods. I force my eyes open further and ignore the sharp protest of my dried eyelids. Deep down, I already know what awaits me. There has only ever been one ending for a siren in human hands.

The markets.

I'm back on Aurelith.

The stand across from me, like all others, is set on a wooden platform that rises on thick wooden posts. Beneath it, the sea has retreated, leaving behind a wide stretch of exposed seabed. Fish are laid out in uneven rows, their bodies split open to expose pale, bloodied flesh. Their glassy eyes stare outward without seeing, their mouths frozen in silent protest. Between them lies the tail of a siren, its torn end blackened where blood has already begun to clot.

My stomach twists violently. I gag around the cloth forced deep between my teeth, tearing open the wounds in my throat that have barely healed. I think of the siren that this tail belonged to, and if she at least found her peace in the depths of the sea before her end. My body recoils against the rope, not only because of what was done to her, but because I understand that this is what they intend for me.

A voice cuts through the fog of my thoughts.

"Well, would you look at that?"

I force my eyes to focus on the two figures in front of me, standing at the base of the stand, their boots planted wide against the damp wood. I would recognize his voice anywhere.

Grimsbane, the Rat.

He looks exactly as I remember him, like an aged, slimy eel covered in layers of worn leather. His eyes drop to meet mine, and an ugly smile spreads across his face, revealing crooked, yellow teeth.

"Took you long enough," he says, amused.

Beside him stands another hunter I know just as well, broader but just as repulsive. His gaze drifts slowly along the length of my body, pausing where the rope binds my tail.

Anger stirs beneath my skin as I curl my hands into fists. They hunted me my whole life, across this sea-cursed island, and I always managed to escape them somehow. I had plenty of practice, I guess. But now they stand

there, watching me as if I am already nothing more than scales and blood. Money.

It's strange how my siren used to be a separate, darker part of me, somewhere hidden deep inside where I once kept her contained. Now she lives in the center of me, her presence woven into every fiber of me. Most importantly, she does not recoil from the men who stand before me. I want them dead at the bottom of the sea, where their bodies will surrender to time and tide until nothing that ever touched me remains.

The hunter shifts his weight, watching the change in my expression with unease.

"We hold her until nightfall," he says, his tone turning serious. "If someone makes an offer worth taking, we sell her whole. If not…" His gaze flicks briefly toward the tail displayed across from me, then back again. "There are always other options."

The other man nods.

"Scales fetch more when they're fresh though," he mutters. "Blood too, depending on the day…"

Their conversation becomes distant as my gaze drops to their chests, where their hearts beat steadily, pumping blood. I know that with my talons, I could rip them out in one clean swipe. It wouldn't be a big effort. In my blinding anger, I might even consider eating them, like the dark water sirens do, making an exception for these disgusting excuses for men.

Beyond them, someone catches my attention.

A figure lingers next to the stand across from me, wearing a cloak that falls from her shoulders in a long, fluid waterfall of deep emerald, its fabric drinking the light instead of reflecting it. She waits, as though she understands that sudden motion would draw the wrong kind of attention. That these men are some of the most dangerous around.

Then she lifts her head.

A small gasp escapes my throat, but it is swallowed up entirely by the cloth.

Cailia.

I would know her anywhere, by those dark, knowing eyes and the way her hair clings to her like oil dripping down her shoulders.

She lifts her hand and gently presses one finger against her lips, then nods towards a beam next to her.

A sheet of parchment hangs nailed to it, the paper curled at the edges. Though they haven’t captured him correctly, I still recognize his face. I could never forget that slightly crooked nose and those dark curls, not in this lifetime anyway. Sable, sketched with coal. Beneath it, other pages overlap. Grim, and Nightglass, and all the others I have come to know and care for. Beneath each of their pictures, bold red writing that I saw plastered all over the island on these flyers growing up.

Wanted.

I blink away my tears. He cannot come here. He will not come for me. Even if this piece of paper didn’t exist and death wouldn’t await him here, the sea already has its claws in him. It had already called him home before we reached the Sea of the First Song. I failed to bring his shadow back, and with that, I sentenced him to death. He is probably back in the Sea of Bones, climbing over the railing to drown just as all the other lost souls did. And the worst part? He’ll do it all alone, because I was stupid enough to keep my promise to save his crew first.

As Cailia makes her way across the wooden bridge towards my stand, I spot the corals in the shape of her silhouette. Any passing human would not understand what lies beneath her cloak from the same of them, but if you know what to look for, they are unmistakable. She stops in front of me, and a tear falls from my eye, directly onto the dark planks beneath my head. Someone came for me. Her gaze moves over my body, tracing the length of my new form without recognition, until she reaches my face and lets her eyes rest there briefly.

“Turn her,” she says.

Grimsbane shifts his weight, suspicion raising his brow, tightening his mouth. “You’re looking to buy?”

Cailia tilts her head slightly, considering me with narrowed eyes in silence. “Depends. Not much left in this one,” she answers. “Looks half-dead already.”

The hunter snorts beside her and steps closer, his hand closing around the rope connected to my tail. “She’s worth more than you could afford, witch.”

“I want her,” she says, with no hint of submission in her voice.

He laughs and jerks the rope downward. Pain tears through my tail all the way down to my skull, and I bite down on the cloth shoved in my mouth, my scream muffled.

“For what?”

Calia’s expression doesn’t change, but I can see how her shoulders tense underneath the thick cloak.

She raises her chin. “That is nothing of your concern.”

His grip on the rope tightens as he straightens his posture, aggravated.

“I do not sell to witches,” he spits.

When Cailia does not react, the hunter turns his head when someone calls his name from behind him, his attention shifting from her. Cailia moves closer, close enough that I can see worry in her eyes.

“He is here,” she whispers, eyes darting between the hunter and me, her lips barely moving.

My breath catches as my gaze flicks past her immediately, searching for Sable in the crowds of the market that is now buzzing with life. Shouts of prices and deals fill the air, mingling with the clatter of coins and the creak of wooden carts being dragged across the docks. But there is no sign of my dark-haired pirate captain.

I quickly shake my head, meeting her eyes again. He shouldn’t be here.

Something flashes across her gaze, and one corner of her mouth lifts into a smile.

“You know how stubborn he is. Not even the sea could hold my brother back from finding you.”

The hunter turns back toward her, his face twisted into a scowl.

“I thought I told you to leave,” he says. His hand settles on the hilt of his knife, the silent warning tense in the air between them. “I won’t sell to your kind.”

Cailia studies him for a moment. She raises her head, her jaw tightening as she meets his eye. There is no fear in her eyes, just the swirling darkness of disgust. “I will give you two hundred gold sovereigns.”

Even the men on the neighboring platforms glance over at that number, their voices faltering. Gold like that can change a whole lot for a simple man like this hunter. It buys ships. It buys lives. Freedom.

Grimsbane lets out a low whistle.

“Generous,” he says, though the word carries no gratitude. His eyes flick over her again, over the clock and the faint shapes beneath it. “But not enough.”

“Three hundred,” she says as though it’s nothing.

“You don’t understand,” he replies with a nasty smirk. “I’m not selling to you.”

When I glance upward, his hand slides lower, below where the rope binds my tail, his dirty fingers reaching for my scales.

“If you lay a hand on her again,” a voice says behind him, “I will cut it off and shove it down your throat.”

The hunter freezes. He turns slowly, the muscles in his face tightening as he searches the crowd behind him.

Nothing.

But I know who that sinister voice belongs to instinctively, and let it wrap around my injured body like thick, sweet honey. With a beating heart, I let my gaze flit over the crowd, searching for the pirate stupid enough to set foot onto the human king’s territory, just for the sake of me. A doomed siren past the point of saving.

I know it’s him by the way he stands. Tall and broad-shouldered, his face hidden beneath the shadow of a cloak pulled below his dark brows.

Then he lifts his head.

Pushes the cloak from his face.

My pulse stutters.

Sable, you stupid, stupid pirate.

When Grimsbane realizes, the confidence drains from his face with his blood.

“You,” he whispers.

Sable does not answer, his gaze remains fixed on the hunter’s hand as it finds my tail, fingers tightening around it where the rope holds it up. He takes slow, deliberate steps towards me. I writhe as he nears, screaming into the cloth for him to be careful.

When the hunter digs his fingers into my flesh, and I cry out with the pain of it. All hell breaks loose. Sable throws the cloak off his body and pulls out his cutlass in one swift movement. His arm moves in a clean, decisive arc, steel flashing once in the lanternlight before cutting through flesh and bone with practiced precision. The hunter’s hand falls away from me, severed so cleanly that for a moment it does not seem to register with him that it is no longer attached.

Blood pours out of the wound in heavy gushes, delighting my siren. His scream tears through the market as he stumbles backward, alerting the men from the nearby stands. They soon surround us. When another hunter

lunges toward Sable, he closes the distance in two long strides and raises his blade again. Their weapons collide with a sharp clang, and soon the man grunts under the pressure of Sable's strength. With the twist of his wrist, he forces the hunter off balance before smacking his head with the handle, sending him crashing into the wooden posts beside the stand.

Around us, the fragile illusion of order collapses with the force of the sudden violence. More men throw back their hoods, revealing faces I know as well as my own.

I recognize Grim first, mainly because of the axe he carries. He frees it from beneath his coat and drives it into the chest of the nearest hunter, the impact forcing him backward off the platform. Nightglass emerges at his side, his blade already dripping with blood, and throws himself into combat with a nearby member of the hunter's crew.

More men of the Noctis follow, hidden moments ago among merchants and buyers, now step forward with drawn steel. I recognize Nightglass, Match, and even the cook.

They all came for me.

Cailia reaches for the rope above me now, her fingers working quickly as she loosens the knots.

"Mhh!" I shout into the cloth as figures in bright, red uniforms make their way to us from the edges of the market. A few already have their hands on their weapons, fingers curling around the hilts of their swords, though most of them carry guns. With sharp eyes, they scan the chaos, looking for whom to kill first.

Royal guards.

Cailia looks towards them once, a faint crease forming between her brows.

"Brother! Guards!" she shouts at Sable, who's engaged in a fight against a man the size of a giant. His gaze briefly flits towards them before he focuses on his attacker again. If they capture him, he'll be hanging before the day ends. The thought of them putting a rope around his neck makes me physically sick, and I gag. I refuse to believe that there is even the slightest chance this will happen.

Cailia moves toward Grimsbane, who is now lying on the ground, trying to escape death by clutching onto his arm, and reaches for the needle-thin knife that hangs on a cord around his neck. A flute. The very tool that was supposed to be the end of me is now about to cut the ropes that bind me.

“Sable!” she screams again as she yanks the cloth out of my mouth. “You’ll have to catch her! That tail looks heavy!”

Glancing down at me, she smiles wryly. “No offense.”

“None taken,” I croak, the words barely making it out of my dry throat.

The giant throws himself at Sable, his blade aiming for his ribs, but the captain turns before it can land, driving his cutlass forward and opening the man from shoulder to chest. I smile.

He is brutal. He is relentless and unfearing. And he is mine.

Suddenly, the rope gives, and I drop. For one terrifying second, there is nothing beneath me, nothing but the certainty of impact—

And then he catches me.

His arms close around me with a force that drives the remaining breath from my lungs. My tail hangs uselessly between us, my wrists still bound, my body weak, and yet, he holds me as though I weigh nothing at all.

Gently, his hand cradles the back of my head. The world around us stills. All the chaos, all the violence and pain of the moment falling away, until it is just us staring into each other’s eyes like we’d never expected to do so again. Against all odds, he is here, alive, with a beating heart. And he is holding me.

“I told you,” he says quietly, a gentle smile spreading across his face, “that I would find you, darling.”

I can offer a trembling smile in return as his words settle somewhere deep inside of me, in a place that has been hollow for so long. My fingers tighten around the stiff fabric of his coat, pulling him closer.

“I—”

The effort of speaking scrapes against the open wound of my sore throat. His hand shifts, his thumb brushing against the back of my head.

“Shh,” he whispers.

The sound is softer than anything I have ever heard from him, softer than the sea when it rests without wind. I open my mouth again.

“Don’t,” he says.

I swallow, forcing back the words. I wanted to thank him. For coming. For choosing me, even now, even here. For believing me to be worth saving.

He lowers his head slightly, his forehead almost brushing mine.

“I know,” he says.

Behind us, the sound of boots striking wood carries across the platform, followed by the unmistakable crack of gunfire as the first shot disrupts the air. Sable turns his head, his body already shifting before the next shot follows.

A red wall of bodies forces its way forward, rifles raised, smoke curling from their barrels. The crowd scatters in panic as screams erupt all around us and merchants abandon their stands.

That’s when Cailia steps forward.

She lifts her hand toward the empty seabed below us, her fingers spreading slowly as though she reaches for something buried in the depths of it. Whatever she takes from it, I cannot see, but I feel it in my bones. An ancient kind of power, the same magic that I felt in the womb of the sea. She redirects her hand towards the approaching guards, who falter at the sight of a woman stepping into their path so boldly, and into the gunfire that has now ceased.

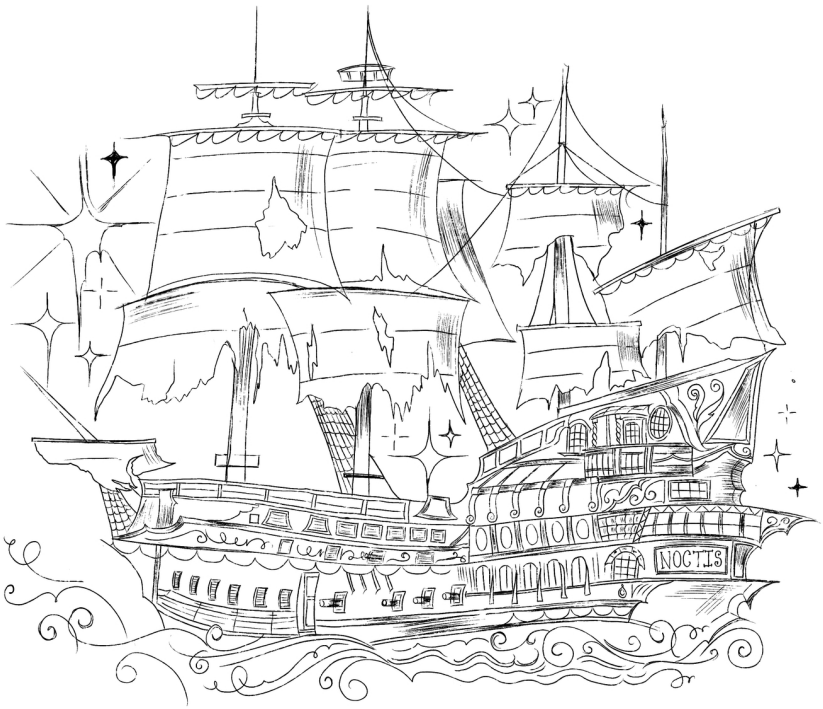
They all freeze until one of the guards steps forward, his rifle outstretched and pointed at her face.

“Shoot!” he orders. “Get the pirate—”

The rifle slips from his hold. A gasp escapes me as pale coral bursts outward beneath his uniform, forcing its way through flesh and fabric, branching out and spreading rapidly in silent defiance of the life his body once possessed. He does not scream. He stares, blank-eyed ahead of him as corals bloom within him. They soon claim his whole body and spread even further in jagged formations, creating a barrier between the guards and us.

Cailia turns her head, black-eyed and blinking.

By the way her entire body language shifts and her eyes remain dark as the abyss, it’s as if the sea itself has taken control over her being.


NOCTIS

Chapter Forty

"RUN!" SHE SCREAMS AT us, before returning her focus to the magic she is still wielding.

Sable stiffens his back. He doesn't want to leave his sister alone, and I don't want him to either.

"I'll protect her," Grim emerges from the crowd, his axe raised and ready for combat. A red haze dances across his green eyes as he gives Sable a curt nod of reassurance.

"I'll protect her with my life," he adds, and finally, Sable gives him a nod. He would trust his First Man with his life, and with his sister's life also, it seems.

As Grim turns from us, Sable rises to his feet, the muscles in his bicep straining at the unexpected weight of my tail. His grip around my tail tightens as he turns and runs through the path that the crew of the Noctis has formed for us, lifting me high enough so that my tail doesn't scrape against the splintered wood. Nightglass moves in front with his cutlass raised, ready to strike, but no one dares to attack us.

Not anymore.

The wooden platforms beneath us shudder with each step, barely audible over the beating of my heart. Gunfire cracks behind us, close enough that I can smell the gunpowder in the air, each shot barely missing us. Wood splitters all around, but Sable does not hesitate. His eyebrows are drawn tight, and even when his arms begin to shake, he doesn't slow down.

Finally, the harbor rises ahead through the fog. Dark water shifts underneath the docks, and at the sight, something in my chest lightens. A deep, instinctive pull settles there. It is so strong that it almost hurts when I draw in a breath, my lungs instead of my gills, air instead of water.

He slows his pace the moment we reach the pier, his chest rising and falling fast with his heavy breathing. Behind us, the pirates handle the remaining guards, only a few remaining. Corals and shells are glinting in the light in the distance. Cailia. I don't even have to guess.

My gaze lifts past him, towards the left of the pier.

There she is.

The Noctis, all patched up with pieces of driftwood.

The sight of her makes my heart feel full, and I realize that despite everything that has happened, she feels like home. I tighten my grip on Sable, my fingers pressing slightly into his shoulders.

With his chest rising and falling beneath his torn shirt, he carefully lowers me onto the deck. His obsidian gaze searches mine as he brushes a strand of my knotted hair from my cheek, his touch warm and rough against my dry skin.

"Are you ready?" he whispers.

Truth is, I don't know if I am. That tiny stretch of wood separates me from who I was and whom I have become, and somehow, it feels so final that it grates at me. What does this mean for us?

My hand rises before I can think about it too much, and I let my fingers thread through his dark hair until it is buried in it.

"Not yet," I whisper.

His breath catches as I lean forward and brush my lips against his. Sable deepens the kiss and lets his hand slide along my side before settling against the length of my tail, where it curves between us. His fingers spread wide there, following the shape of my scales, touching me as though this is not something strange or foreign to him.

Warmth follows the path of his touch, rising through my body in waves, and when his grip tightens, the intensity steals the breath from my lungs. We draw apart after a short moment, breathing heavily. His forehead comes to rest against mine, and I inhale his breath as if it were my own.

"You know," he whispers, "you never had to use your song on me. I was always yours. And I will always be."

"But your shadow…" I whisper, the words barely forming. "Is it—"

The sharp lines of his face soften as he begins to smile, and that faint dimple at the corner of his mouth appears.

“Look,” he says gently, and flicks his gaze past me toward the wood at his back.

I follow the movement of his eyes.

His shadow stretches across the dock behind him, bound to his body in a way that it never has been. It always flickered with a life of its own. Now it is calm, following the movement of his rising and falling chest, exactly as it should.

My breath falters. How can this possibly be, is it—

“I don’t understand,” I whisper.

His hand lifts to cup my face, his thumb brushing away a tear I had not felt falling.

“When the hunters captured you…when you screamed,” he says quietly, “it came back to me. You used your siren song, love. It hurt like hell, but it reattached. And I have never felt more whole.”

I stare at the shadow behind him as I let the words settle. The meaning of it unfolds piece by piece, until I realize what this means for him — for *us*.

He is free.

He is *whole*.

I did not fail him.

He presses his lips to my forehead. “I’ll explain everything later, but now we have to leave.”

“Sable!”

Cailia appears at the edge of the pier, making his shoulders sag in relief, and so do mine. I don’t think I could’ve lived with myself if she got hurt saving me. Her dark cloak has been shredded by her own corals, but besides that, she appears unharmed. Grim follows close behind her, slower, his posture uneven as he presses an arm against his blood-stained side.

When they reach us, she is breathing heavily, and blood begins to trickle down her nose. With the sleeve of her cloak, she quickly brushes it away, but by the way Sable tenses, I know that he saw it too.

“Cailia, are you okay?” he asks her, his body shifting as he seemingly fights the urge to get up and make sure of it himself.

His sister holds a hand up to stop him in his movement, right when Grim reaches her side.

“I’m okay, brother. Your first mate could use a little bit of stitching though, and a potion to heal him fully. Which brings me to...”

Her eyes shift from her brother toward me.

“Eryse.”

Cailia crouches down next to me, and despite the chaos, I notice that she actually used my real name. As soon as she’s turned away from Grim, her eyes darken, her expression suddenly serious.

“He will bleed out without the correct potion,” she whispers, only for me to hear. Her voice breaks toward the end, as if she were fighting tears.

My mouth opens, without anything coming out. I glance over her shoulder, toward Grim, where the blood stain has turned into something much worse. The shredded shirt reveals a large stretch of skin on the side of his stomach, where blood gushes out of a deep cut, dripping down his legs and onto the planks beneath him. So much blood.

Grim falters. Sable is at his side in no time, supporting him as he crumples to his knees, still fighting to stay upright. But the amount of blood he loses makes it impossible. With his arms underneath Grim’s, Sable helps him to lie down on the deck.

No.

Not Grim.

Not him, not here, not ever. He is the one who was always kind to me, who was the first to offer me a spot at the table. Most importantly, he is like a brother to Sable, whose face has now gone pale as he repeatedly tells him not to die, and that this is an order he better not refuse.

“What can I do?” I ask as I glance back to Cailia, who watches Grim with a deep frown line between her black eyes.

“Your scales,” she says as she turns back toward me. “I need a scale, only one, to make the potion—”

Before she finishes her sentence, I reach for the first scale I can find that looks loose, take a deep breath, and pluck it off, grimacing at the wet sound it makes. Pain shoots through me, but it is a small price to pay for Grim’s life, so I swallow it down, push it from my mind. All I want, all that counts, is for Grim to be okay.

“Here,” I hand it to her with a shaking hand. “Do you need more?”

Cailia’s eyes widen in shock as she stares at the scale for a brief moment, as though she hadn’t expected me to be so willing to part with it.

“Thank you,” she whispers, a tear slipping from the corner of her eye.

She takes the scale and curls her hand around it protectively, as if it were the most precious thing a person could touch. More crew members arrive at the pier and gather around us, cursing under their breaths and asking how they can help. Cailia orders Match to bring her saltwater, and Nightglass hurries onto the Noctis to gather more ingredients she needs for the potion.

When she has everything she needs, she gets to work.

With a stone, she grounds the scale into a fine, shimmering powder in a small wooden bowl, one of the many we have in the galley. Then she adds the salt water, seaweed, and—

She uses a knife to make a small cut in the palm of her hand, then presses her hand into a fist and lets the blood trickle into the bowl. As she is doing so, her eyes roll back, the same way they did when she used her magic on the guards earlier. I can feel it in the air, the magic, like a soft breeze against my scales, otherworldly and yet familiar, more familiar than when I felt it in her home when we first met. Cailia whispers words in an ancient language that I don't understand, the same phrase repeated over and over again, until she gasps for air, and her eyes roll forward again.

When the mixture in the bowl turns black and begins to glisten like obsidian, she sighs in relief, the tension almost fully leaving her body. She turns toward Grim, who is lying right next to her, and tears the fabric from around the wound, then lets the potion trickle onto his flesh.

"You know," she says quietly without taking her eyes off Grim, "the sea was right after all."

I frown, my gaze flicking to her face, searching for any elaboration in her face. "What do you mean?"

Her attention remains on Grim and on the wound that slowly stops bleeding. A gasp escapes my lips at the sight, and Cailia's shoulders sag in relief.

"It told me," she says after a moment, her voice softer now, "that you two would either be the beginning or the end."

My chest tightens as I remember our visit to her cottage, how defeated Sable was at the time, and now his sister gave him hope again. The sea has told her that we will either be the beginning or the end of each other.

I glance at Sable. His gaze has already lifted, fixed on me now, but he is still pale, sweat glistening on his forehead.

"There were many ways this could've gone," she continues. "If either of you had chosen not to follow the Glim, if your trust had faltered even once,

not just toward the Glim, but toward one another, you would've brought about the end of each other."

Her gaze flicks briefly to Sable, then back to me.

"But it didn't."

At that, a smile tugs at my lips, and Sable looks at me intensely with those grey eyes, as if I am his greatest treasure. I know he is mine.

Grim draws in a deep breath, his body jerking as the wound begins to close, as if drawn together by invisible stitches. He props himself up on one elbow, his other hand pressing tentatively against where the wound had been.

His gaze finds Cailia immediately, and something unspoken passes between them, making her appear softer than I have ever seen her before. She reaches out to him, steadying him as he tries to sit up.

"I'm fine," he mutters, though his voice is rough.

"You're not," she replies, just as quietly.

Sable is still next to him, color returning to his face slowly but surely, and he whispers a quick thanks to the seas. It looks like his faith in it has finally been restored.

Cailia pulls back, her expression serious again.

"You two," she says to two of the crew members, "please get him on the ship."

They step forward at once, helping Grim to his feet, one on either side of him. He does not resist as they lift him, though his gaze lingers on her for a moment longer before he lets them lead him up the plank. Cailia rises too, already turning on her heel to follow them onto the Noctis. Then she stops, glances over her shoulder, and gives me a curt nod, as if to thank me one more time.

I lift my mouth into a smile, and she leaves without another word, following them. She didn't have to thank me. She came to save me, even though I am nothing more than a stranger to her. And so did the rest of the crew, who are still standing around us in a loose circle.

I let my gaze drift through the familiar faces I have come to know.

Nightglass, the fearless father who would do anything for his son, who – despite fearing my kind– made me feel welcome. Match, the wiry young pirate who put me in my cell, but voted in my favor at the tribunal anyway. The cook, who let me earn my space amongst the crew and treated me with

respect, even let me eat while I was their captive. And even Harrow is here, though he is already boarding the ship, likely to help the wounded.

My tears begin to well at the sight of them.

“Thank you all,” I croak out, a tear slipping out of my eye. “For coming. For helping me.”

A few of them exchange glances, one of them giving a short nod.

“It’s naught,” Nightglass says and waves a hand in dismissal. He seems to be unharmed, and I am so relieved that he’ll be able to return to his wife and to Lark without so much as a scratch.

Looking around, there’s no sign of the young pirate, but I didn’t expect him to be here. They might include him in most activities, but this would’ve been far too dangerous for him. Although I’m glad he is not here, I cannot wait to see him again, to thank him personally for his kindness.

“We owed you,” Match adds, “big time. You risked your life for us.”

“Aye,” the cook agrees, and I can’t help but smile.

Suddenly, shouting erupts from afar. My gaze drifts past him, toward the edge of the market. More red coats are spilling out from the stalls now, pushing past overturned crates and scattered goods as they force their way toward the pier. They all have their muskets raised, ready to shoot. Only this time, there are way more of them. And they look angry.

“Alright,” Sable says, his voice filled with authority. “Get aboard. Make her ready.”

The change is immediate.

The circle breaks apart as they turn at once, boots striking the planks as each of them moves toward the Noctis. They begin to pull ropes free and loosen the sails, readying the ship for departure.

Sable watches them until the last of them disappears up the plank, before he turns back to me. He lowers himself to his knees right beside me, then tightens his hands around my tail carefully. This time he does not pause as he lowers me toward the impatient sea. Cold water closes over my fin first, then my tail, and finally, he lets me go. And the sea takes me.

The tension I have carried in my body my whole life unwinds at once as the salt seeps into my split skin. All the aches and dryness dissolve as my strength returns to me, more potent than ever before.

My tail moves without me consciously commanding it. The motion begins low in my spine and flows downward in one sweep, a movement

that feels both new and instinctive. Water parts around me, sliding across the curved length of my tail without resistance. Welcoming me.

Above me, Sable kneels at the edge of the pier, his gaze fixed on me without wavering.

“Are you alright?” he asks, a deep frown line settling between his eyes.

I turn slightly, letting my tail carry me closer to the surface as I look up at him.

“I think so,” I say.

“No,” I correct myself, unable to stop the smile spreading across my face. “I am way more than alright.”

Relief and pride flash across his gaze before he rises to his feet.

“Well then,” he gestures towards the open sea. “Follow the ship, little siren. We are sailing home.”

Home.

I nod, suddenly excited, and we exchange one more look before he turns and walks towards the Noctis.

“One more thing,” he says.

I tilt my head slightly, waiting for him to continue.

“I was right.”

I frown at him playfully. “Right about what?”

His mouth curves into a smirk. I know by now that this smirk means he is up to no good, and usually ends up making me blush.

“Your tail,” he says. “It is beautiful.”

I open my mouth in confusion, the heat rushing into my cheeks as if commanded. When did he ever say that to me—

Then I remember. His shadow told me many weeks ago.

I bet your tail would’ve been beautiful.

Sable winks, then boards the ship last.

“Raise anchor!” he shouts, now standing at the helm. He grips the wheel with one hand, the wind catching in his dark hair as he looks out across the open water.

The Noctis groans as the anchor is raised, and soon after, the sails catch wind.

“Set course,” he orders. "We sail for the islands!”

The hull turns and leaves the harbor of Cantora, just in time. The docks have filled with men in red, their muskets raised. While some shoot, some shout orders that scatter uselessly across the open water.

They don’t even see me lurking out of the water, just below their feet. Before going under, I glance towards the helm again.

Sable stands there, his posture relaxed, his gaze moving across the gathered guards.

Then his mouth curves.

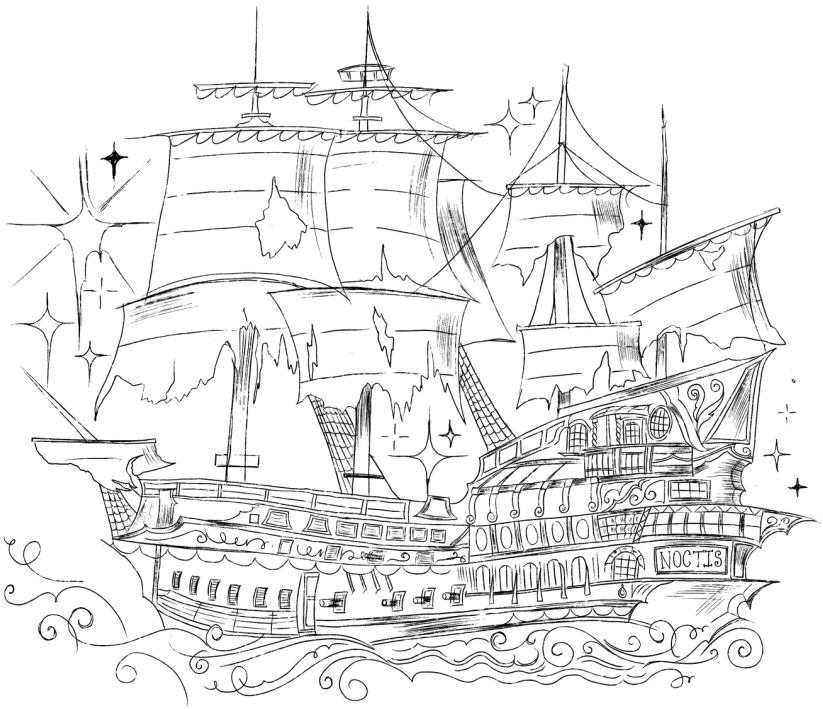
He removes his hand from the wheel and brings it slowly to his chest, before extending outward in a smooth, exaggerated sweep. At the same time, he inclines his head toward them in a shallow bow. The gesture is graceful and mocking all at once. Sable Crowe, Captain of the Noctis. In all his sarcastic glory.

The wind catches his coat as he straightens, and even from the water, the satisfied smile that settles on his face is visible. It is the last thing I see before I go under and follow the dark hull of the ship. Cantora, with all its ropes and slimy eels, becomes nothing more than a shadow dissolving in the distance as I cut through the water.

My tail moves in smooth, instinctive sweeps, each movement becoming easier than the last. Water slips through the slits at the side of my throat and moves through me in a way air never could, its salt sinking into the center of my being.

My mother was right.

Eventually, I learned how to breathe like a daughter of the sea.


NOCTIS

Epilogue

Sable

THE SAND SHIFTS UNDER my boots as I make my way across the narrow stretch of beach, the waves folding over themselves in a familiar rhythm, two screaming seagulls following me along the way. It feels good, not having to worry about the sea calling me to my wet grave anymore. Not feeling like a lost cause anymore. Instead, the sea has become something that exists alongside me, or maybe within me, but not in the way it had before. Now, I am free to roam the pirate islands without questioning how long I might be able to stay.

And it feels good to be home.

Sharp, jagged rocks rise along the shoreline, like a row of broken teeth pushing up from the earth. I pass them without slowing, though my gaze flicks toward them out of habit, just as it drifts over my shoulder a moment later, searching for something that is no longer separate from my body. My shadow stretches behind me, bound to my steps in a way that still feels new to me. It does not flicker, does not pull away.

It simply is there.

A quiet breath leaves me, something close to a laugh of disbelief. I had forgotten what it feels like to exist without that constant fracture in me, without the sense that part of me is slipping away, just beyond reach. With the burning, agonizing return of my shadow came the memories. Suddenly, I could remember giving Eryse the emerald gown. That I watched her sleep in her hammock in the orlop. How shamelessly I flirted with her, even though she was technically my captive. My shadow didn't really care; all it

wanted was to impress the pretty siren. It all came back to me, the good things and the bad. The bad things hurt way more.

I push them to the side, the memory of her threading through it all with ease. The way she looked at me when she didn't think I was looking. The way she laid a hand on my back out on that balcony, when I wasn't myself. The way she chose me, again and again, even when I told her to give me up.

She always saw right through the torment, saw the man behind the curse.

My steps slow as the docks come into view. Beyond them, the Noctis rests in the dark water, her hull swallowing what little light breaks through the low clouds above, her black, torn sails drawn tight, waiting for their next adventure.

She is still magnificent, even though the hunter bastards shot about a dozen holes in her hull. A faint smirk tugs at my mouth as I take her in, the way she sits slightly heavier on one side from the repairs that have been made. I'm sure if Saint had fixed her, she'd be perfectly even. He was the best carpenter I could have ever wished for. The thought of him pulls tight in my chest, the loss as present as it was the day he died.

I step onto the pier, the wood creaking beneath my weight, my gaze already drifting toward the helm. Lark, barely reaching over the wheel, stands there with all the confidence of someone twice his size, a hat far too large for him tilted slightly over his eyes.

My hat.

I pause for a moment, watching him, the way he grips the wheel as if he has full intentions to steer her elsewhere. I step onto the slanted gangplank and make my way aboard. By the time I reach the deck, he has already noticed me. His posture stiffens for a fraction before he straightens, as if preparing himself for a lecture.

"Sailor," I say, my voice carrying just enough to reach him without raising it. "Where did you get that hat?"

His chin lifts, almost defiant, though the way his fingers curl slightly against the wheel gives his true nervousness away.

"A lady gifted it to me," he says.

Of course she did.

I narrow my eyes slightly as I take a few steps closer, tilting my head to study him. "A generous lady, then. Which one?"

He presses his lips together, clearly considering his options, before settling on silence.

My gaze sharpens. I should’ve never let that hat out of sight.

“Does this lady,” I continue, my tone calm, “happen to have a tail?”

He bites down on his lower lip, and that is answer enough. A quiet breath escapes me, close to a laugh this time, though I shake my head as I reach down and adjust the brim of the hat where it sits far too low over his eyes.

“You’ll ruin it,” I mutter, and his expression shifts, uncertainty flickering through his eyes, as if he expects me to take it back. I catch myself before I issue any further reprimand. He’s just a boy after all, and a young pirate nonetheless.

“Keep it,” I add after a moment and offer him a smile. “You’ll grow into it.”

Lark sighs in relief and nods, his attention falling back to the wheel.

I step onto the plank and return to the pier, the sound of the crashing water growing louder as I near its edge. The tide has shifted a little, the surface darker now, the movement beneath it difficult to decipher by someone who doesn’t know what to look for.

I do.

I stop at the edge and let my gaze drift over the water, my arms crossing loosely over my chest as I tilt my head slightly.

“So,” I say, my voice carrying out over the sea, “Where is this beautiful, tailed girl who has taken it upon herself to distribute my belongings?”

There is no immediate answer. A faint ripple breaks the surface a few feet away, followed by another, and then another, each one slightly closer than the last.

“I know you’re there, little fish,” I add, softer this time.

The water stills for a moment, as if holding its breath.

Then she rises.

Only her eyes break the surface, white and foggy, fixed on me with a look I have come to know far too well. Even like this, I can see the hint of amusement in her features. The small wrinkles around her eyes give it away.

My gaze lingers on her for a moment, taking in what little of her is visible, though it is more than enough.

My vicious, sweet siren, Eryse.

“There you are,” I whisper.

Her expression does not change.

“Tell me,” I continue, my tone shifting into seriousness. “Why did you give away the hat you stole from me?”

Her brows lift, and her face emerges from the water, revealing her rosy, soft-looking lips.

“I didn’t steal it,” she replies, her voice smooth. “I found it.”

“Of course you did,” I say. “And I suppose it simply slipped off my head and into your hands by pure coincidence.”

“Exactly,” she says with a smile. “The tide brought it to me. Remember?”

I shake my head with a laugh, remembering how she refused to give me back my hat. Little did she know that I could’ve taken it from her in an instant, but I let her keep it, because I knew she’d look breathtaking in it.

“You have the looks of a siren,” I tell her, my gaze steady on hers, “but the mouth of a pirate.”

Her smirk deepens. “Well,” she says, tilting her head slightly. “I am a siren and a pirate.”

Something in my chest loosens at the ease with which she says it, as if both things can exist without contradiction. She has never really acknowledged her pirate heritage, not until now. Words cannot describe how much that means to me. For her to embrace every part of her, be it siren or pirate.

“I can see that,” I murmur, my gaze holding hers. “Though I am still deciding which part of you is more dangerous. One steals my hat, the other brings me to my knees.”

Her eyes glint.

“You already know the answer to that.”

I do. But I couldn’t care less.

My arms loosen from my chest as I take another step closer to the edge, my boots stopping just short of the drop.

“Will you come ashore,” I ask, my tone quieter now. “Or do you intend to stay out of my reach?”

Her gaze lingers on me, a playful smile spreading on her face, revealing those sharp canines that are enough to make me melt through the gaps in the planks. Or drop to my knees once again.

For a moment, I think she might answer. Instead, she dips beneath the surface.

“That’s what I get for loving a siren,” I say to myself, though I cannot fend off the smile that commands my lips.

“Coward,” I call after her and laugh.

A voice reaches me from somewhere to my left, distant but clear enough.

“Meet me by the tide pools!”

I turn without hesitation, stepping back from the edge of the dock and moving along the shoreline as I make my way toward the rocks I passed earlier. The tide has pulled back further now, leaving behind pools of water that Eryse likes to lie in during sunset. I do too, but I take in a different view than she does.

By the time I reach them, I am already loosening the strings of my shirt, my gaze sweeping the surface of the water without finding her. Ahead of me, a ripple forms, followed by the quiet break of the surface as she rises once again. She lifts herself onto the lower rocks with an ease that should not be as captivating as it is, the water slipping from her in slow lines as it drifts back into the shallow water of the pool. Her tail settles against the dark stone, the scales catching what little light remains, reflecting it in soft shades that remind me of a pearl.

“Took you long enough,” she says, and wrings her hair out, a habit that she cannot get rid of, even though she’ll get wet again anyway.

I stare at her, as I do every day, ever since returning to the islands. There are a hundred things I could say, most of them clever, most of them unnecessary, because none of them matter. I move onto the rocks, the water remaining here soaking through my boots, but I don’t care. I lower myself onto a rock beside her, close enough that I can feel the warmth of her skin where the sun touched it moments ago. My gaze drifts downward before I can stop it, tracing where the skin gives way to scales. I reach out, my fingers brushing lightly along the curve of her tail where it rests against the rock. The scales shift beneath my touch, smooth and firm at the same time.

“Still staring,” she murmurs in a low voice.

“I am allowed,” I reply, my voice quieter than I intend. “To admire my treasure.”

Her breath catches, though she doesn’t try to hide it. Not anymore.

“You are impossible,” she laughs and turns her head to watch the sunset.

“And yet, you are here.”

That draws her gaze back to mine, her eyes as white as ever, like still water reflecting the moon. Still water that I would drown in, if she asked me to. The world narrows down to the two of us and the rushing sound of the tide.

I shift my hand from her tail to her waist, steadying her as I close the distance between us. There is no hesitation, no fear of what might happen if I lose myself to it. My lips meet hers, and I immediately taste the salt on her soft lips, covering mine. She responds without pause, her hand finding its way into my hair, her grip tightening just enough to pull me closer.

It is different now.

Not only because she has changed, but because I have. Because I get to remember this.

All of it.

The way she feels, the way her tail moves. The way a little moan escapes her lips whenever I let my fingers trail over her scales.

When we part, I rest my forehead against her, my eyes closing for a brief moment as I let the quiet settle around us.

“I suppose,” I whisper, my voice breathy, “I will have to keep a closer eye on my belongings from now on.”

Her lips brush against mine again as she huffs.

“You can try,” she says. “But I make no promises.”

“I would expect nothing less.”

My hand tightens slightly at her waist, as if to make sure she doesn’t slip away into the open sea. I exhale slowly, feeling all the tension leave my chest as Eryse threads her fingers through my hair once more, which I think I enjoy even more than she does.

She leans in again, a faint smirk tugging at her lips.

“What are you thinking about, captain?”

“You,” I say without hesitation, and look into her eyes again.

“And?” she whispers, laying her hand on the side of my face gently, her teasing tone slipping away.

My gaze drifts past her for a moment, out toward the open water beyond the rocks, where the horizon blurs into something endless. Back when I was cursed, it felt like a threat. Now it feels like a possibility. A possibility to keep the promise I gave her, about sailing the seas with her, stealing dresses, gold, and whatever else she desires. To bring her men to drown, and watch her power strengthen with every one.

“The sea,” I say, my voice quieter now, though no less certain.

She follows my gaze, the movement of her head thoughtful, as if she were trying to see it the way I do.

“And what about it?” she asks, and our eyes meet again.

“I was thinking about what I promised you,” I say, my thumb brushing lightly against her side. “That I would sail the seas with you, steal whatever you desire.”

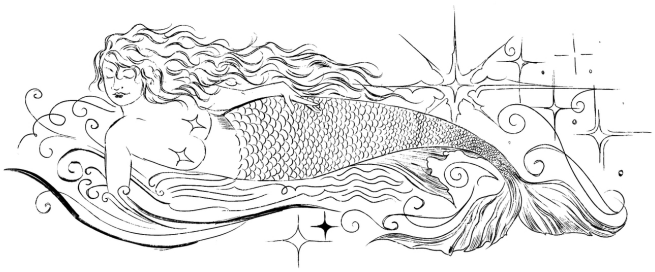
By the way she looks at me now with her eyebrows drawn into a slight frown and her mouth in a thin line, I know that she remembers. It was the night she thought she’d lose me.

“I’ll keep my promise,” I add softly. “I’ll bring you the horizon.”

And this time, I know it is a promise I can keep.

Before You Go

The sea always takes something in return. I hope this story gave you something worth keeping.



If you have a minute, leaving a short **review** helps this story find more readers. Also, come find me on Instagram **@serenrose.author** and tell me your favorite scene! I share art, scenes that didn't make it into the book, and other unhinged content there.

Acknowledgements

TO MY BELOVED DEBUT, you have cost me almost everything these past few months, and somehow gave me even more in return. I will never forget what it took to bring you into the world.

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So if you're still here, if you've made it all the way to the end, I hope you'll follow me into the next adventure.

Because there are still songs left to be sung.

And shadows that have not yet let go.

About the author



Seren Rose was born and raised in the southwest of Germany. She grew up on fairy tales, from the darker edges of Grimm to stories of magic and the sea, and has been drawn to dangerous worlds ever since. When she’s not writing her next novel, she’s walking her dog or bringing fantasy worlds to life through her art.